

Bad Faith and Antiblack Racism

Lewis R. Gordon

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HUMANITIES PRESS
NEW JERSEY

First published 1995 by Humanities Press International, Inc.,
165 First Avenue, Atlantic Highlands, NJ 07716

© Lewis R. Gordon, 1995

Library of Congress Cataloging in Publication Data

Gordon, Lewis R. (Lewis Ricardo), 1962—

Bad faith and antiblack racism / Lewis R. Gordon.

p. cm.

Includes bibliographical references and index.

ISBN 0-391-03868-0.—ISBN 0-391-03872-9 (pbk.)

1. Racism. 2. Blacks—Social conditions. 3. Sartre, Jean Paul,
1905— I. Title.

HT1521.G65 1995

305.8'96073—dc20

94-18239

CIP

A catalog record for this book is available from the British Library.

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*To Lisa and Mathieu,
and all my relatives and teachers,
who had enough sense, love, and courage to
invest in the future with respect for the past*

*We shall not always plant while others reap
The golden increment of bursting fruit,
Not always countenance, abject and mute,
That lesser men should hold their brothers cheap,
Not everlastingly while others sleep
Shall we beguile their limbs with mellow flute,
Not always bend to some more subtle brute;
We were not made eternally to weep.*

—Countee Cullen, "From the Tower of Blackness"

I live in spite of logic.

—Fyodor Dostoyevsky, *Notes from Underground*

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PREFACE

IT is truly absurd, it seems, to attempt a philosophical work on a timely topic. My purpose in writing this work is to raise the question of the questioner in the study of racism, specifically antiblack racism, and to see how the situation that constitutes antiblack racism is informative of the complexities involved in the study of human reality. Race discourse suffers from what I shall call the “blitz syndrome.” The race theorist is expected to answer everything the effect of which is to answer nothing. In this regard, a great deal of the effort to study racism is marred by the core problem of self-evasion. This is partly because the study of racism is dirty business. It unveils things about ourselves that we may prefer not to know. If racism emerges out of an evasive spirit, it is hardly the case that it would stand still and permit itself to be unmasked. Race theorists theorize in a racist world. The degree to which that world is made evident will have an impact on the question of whether the theorist not only sees, but also admits what is seen. The same applies to the society in which the theorist theorizes.

The year in which most of this work was composed was 1992. That year has left historians with much ado for time to come. The year was marked by the significance of being the five-hundredth anniversary of Columbus’s setting foot on shores whose people’s name serve as the etymological source of *cannibal*. The Caribbean, named after the Caribs, has since remained cannibal territory, but cannibalism of a special kind, given the genocide that took place there under the governorship of Columbus and the continued violence that has become an inhumanly mundane feature of some of the small nations of that region. Farther north, in the United States, 1992 was marked by another controversy. The infamous Rodney King verdict came down, and the period of rage—the riots in south-central Los Angeles—shook the nation with a foreboding sense of having traveled but a short distance since the riots of 1968. I began writing a week after the violent din. There seemed to have been something absurd about writing a philosophical

work during such troubled times. Did I really have something *important* to say? Was I “out of touch,” so to speak? What was the point of *writing* it?

Midsummer. 1:00 A.M. I stared at the first draft of four completed sections. Time to go home. I walked up one of New Haven’s lonely but major streets. A stupid thing to do. I held my draft against my chest and continued the dialogue in my head, the dialogue on racism that I have been engaged in with myself and others over the past twenty-two years. Caught in my reflections, I hardly noticed the invectives coming from a passenger in a car in the intersection I was about to cross. His cursing became loud. He was a gruff, muscular white man.

He must really be angry at someone, I thought. I looked around.

“Yes—you—*you!*” he screamed again. “I’m gonna kill your ass! Where’s my gun!” He reached to the side as if to take out a rifle.

What do you expect me to do—*run*? I thought while looking at him.

He struggled with the driver, as if to say, “Don’t hold me back, don’t hold me back!”

He aimed an imaginary gun at me while the car took off.

As I continued my way up the hill, my heart beating fiercely with anger, I found myself growing cold as I began to ask myself, What if he *did* have a gun? The headline (if there would ever have been one) became vivid. “Yale Student Killed with Bloodied Manuscript Clutched against His Chest!” And further on, “He is believed to have been a victim of racial violence. Ironically, his book was on antiblack racism.”

I recall once, when I was a child experiencing my first winter, I held my books against my chest to keep warm. A boy ran up to me and yelled, “Look at the fag—holding his books like a girl!”

My incident on that lonely New Haven street could also have been a case of homophobic violence. The year in fact came to its close with a controversy over gays in the military. The year was also marked by the enactment of antigay legislation in Colorado—a state in which I had presented sections of the third chapter of this work earlier that year.

Violent images of hate—detention centers for Haitian refugees, concentration camps in Eastern Europe, mass slaughtering in Indonesia, layers of starved, battered bodies in eastern and southern Africa—took 1992 into 1993, the thirtieth anniversary of the civil rights march on Washington, D.C., and the fiftieth anniversary of the publication of *Being and Nothingness*. By the time this book is published it will be historical knowledge that those images also close 1993 as a Ku Klux Klan march in Indianapolis, a racially divisive mayoral election in New York City, an effort on the part of the United States to erase the memory of its role in creating the Haitian situation, and a slew of situations marked by violence and poverty along racial lines worldwide bear witness.

There is, indeed, much to be done.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I SUBMIT to you, the reader, a philosophical work that is the product of much sweat, suffering, and reflection. I would not be in the position to submit it at all but for the interest, determination, concern, and love of quite a number of people. Since this is my first book, the list is unabashedly long.

The journey that led to this point has been full of great diversions and risk. As I write these words, the memory of a recent family gathering is fresh in my mind. Relatives from all over the world were present for my mother, my aunt, and one of my adopted aunt's fiftieth birthday party. The room was full of joy and ghosts. My greatgrandparents haunted the room, and my grandfather Edgar Solomon, whose tragic death led to my relatives' exodus to the United States, was present in a surrogate way through his brother. At one point during the party, one of my grandaunts took a good look at my four-year-old son and me and began to reminisce about the type of child I was. She claimed to have seen in that child the man I now am. Given the divergences I faced—not going to school for a while during my childhood, being pursued by a ferocious gang in the Bronx, becoming a jazz musician for a while without ambition of a college degree, and scores of other considerations—it is a rather remarkable *Sartrean* situation that my present comports with my childhood self so well. I wonder what other unifying interpretation would have evolved if I had not end up receiving my doctorate and teaching in a university.

I would like to thank Lisa Gordon, who has had to endure a man with a great deal of energy devoted to a variety of ongoing projects. She has shared joy and sorrow with me, and together we have helped each other grow in ways that seem almost rational—upon reflection. My son Mathieu had to deal with the fact that his father didn't always play with him over the past year. I love you, Mathieu. I would like to thank my mother, who provided moral support for my academic and artistic efforts and, above all, survival. My mother and I have shared many wonderful and horrible experiences.

But the one that will forever remain with me is the cold winter night we spent on a long line with other immigrants awaiting amnesty. We leaned on each other under stiff blankets, sharing little words, but understanding throughout that we were there, enduring the wind from the East River, the cold cement pavements—the lack of sleep, the pain from standing (since it was too cold on the pavement to sit or lie down)—we were enduring it all for something that could not at that time fully be expressed in words. We faced an open question. What were we to become? On my mother's fiftieth birthday, in the hall of extended family and friends, I saw what that was.

I would like to thank Jack Garel, who took the time to help raise three boys, who gave him hell all the way, into manhood; and my brothers Mark, Robert, and Tafari, who realized that their brother's being "here" didn't always entail his not being "there." And my aunt Lola, whose love, strength, and kindness make her not only my mother's best friend, but also my beloved aunt.

My friends: Carmen Benoit, Joelle Fishman, Randy Friedman, Jeff Harman, Jennifer Johnson, Bert Longworth, Corah Monroe, Cynthia Nieves, Michael Penzabene, Art Perlo, Tomaso Pomilio, Bill Preston, Abdullah Shabazz, Vicky Shepherd, Carrie Shaffer, Nikhil Singh, and Mark Weber for the many long conversations on matters of gender, race, and class. Thanks, Sandonna Bryant, Lina Han, and Mina Choi for watching Mathieu for me so I could work. And to my best friend at Yale, Ms. Renee White: the importance of our conversations on this topic and other social concerns is without measure.

I would like to thank my teachers in the New York public school system: Ms. Domini, who gave me my first set of encyclopedias, Mr. Cirqua, who introduced me to Hegel and Marx, Ms. Fiermann, who introduced me to Malcolm X, and the musicians/teachers Bill Seltzer, Priscilla Walker, and Eddie Locke, who introduced me to "professionalism." At Lehman College, Gary Schwartz, who has served not only as one of my best teachers, but also my closest friend. If it weren't for his playing some classic Charlie Parker recordings, I may not have stepped into his office and become a member of the Lehman Scholars Program. I would also like to thank Ann Humpherys and Carol Sicherman for their advice and help over the years. At Yale, I have benefitted from the kindness of M. Shawn Copeland, Curtis Patton, Turat Onat, John Smith, and Heinrich Von Staden, who made graduate study a sane experience by encouraging a young philosopher with those vital elements—their time, experience, and critical insights. To Angie Harder and to Anita De Palma—thanks for the extra time and extra mile.

Acknowledgments are also due to the Society for Values in Higher Education (especially the "Struggles with Religious Traditions" and "Images of Masculinity" discussion groups), the Danforth-Compton Fellowship, the Center for the Study of Race and Ethnicity at Brown University, the Yale Philoso-

phy Colloquium, the Black Graduate Network, the Yale Afro-American Cultural Center, the Sartre Circle, the Sartre Society of North America, the Radical Philosophers Association, the New Haven's People's Center, the Lehman Scholars Program, and the Purdue Women's Studies Program and African American Studies and Research Center at Purdue University, for providing me with forums in which to present and discuss these ideas. These organizations and institutions provided me with the company of people who took me to task with critical dialogues on my work in ways that were always constructive. For instance, Bob Stone of the Radical Philosophy Association and the Sartre Society initiated a correspondence with me after reviewing this work for the publisher, and his suggestions have been quite helpful and I have taken them to heart. At Yale, the work benefitted from stylistic suggestions from Kristina Chew, Stephanie Hartwell, and Mary Kay Perrotti. At Purdue, our small discussion group on gender, race, and class was a source of intellectual stimulation and support during the final revisions of the text. I'm sure the revised version benefitted from conversations with my colleagues Edith Clowes, Leonard Harris, Floyd Hayes, Patricia Huntington, Martin Matušík, William McBride, Patricia Morris, Eric Ramsey, Calvin Schrag, and Charlene Zeigfried, and my wonderful students whose enthusiasm and creativity affirmed a great number of my convictions about human potential and the importance of teaching.

Maurice Natanson, who was my principal advisor in philosophy for the doctorate degree, deserves special mention. I went to Yale with concerns in philosophical anthropology and the philosophy of education. I wanted to look into the philosophical dimensions of factors that derail the course of human potential. As things turned out, the first class I took was Natanson's *Being and Nothingness: An Intensive Reading of Jean-Paul Sartre's Ontology*. That course was my first serious encounter with existential phenomenology. It was also the beginning of a period of intensive study with Natanson on the work of Kierkegaard, Husserl, Buber, Merleau-Ponty, Fanon, Schutz, and many others. Natanson is a teacher par excellence. His wit, expertise, critical insight, intellectual integrity, and respect for human potential made it clear to me that whenever I met with him, which turned out to be almost every week, I had to give my all. Our meetings at his home, with his wonderful wife Lois Natanson, served as guiding examples of what it means to be a teacher, a scholar, and a human being. When I attended the 1992 American Philosophical Association convention, I had the opportunity to speak with a fellow searcher who wrote a book on Sartre and Nishida. When he discovered with whom I was studying, he looked at me with awe and said, "Wow, you are working with the Great Professor Natanson!" I have since thought about his remark. Wherever I go, I encounter a similar response. I did not realize the sort of relationship I had developed with this

great philosopher until I realized that I had found it difficult to see the person he was beyond the person I came to know. Natanson is a great philosopher. But unlike many people who bear that title, he is among the few who remember that philosophers are also human beings. Studying with Maurice Natanson was one of those rare moments in my life that I shall not only remember, but I shall also cherish.

Finally, I would like to make a short dedication to four people who no longer walk the earth, but whose place in my life has been such that I wish to share this moment with them. The first is a three-year-old cousin who recently died at a family gathering. I did not know him, although I lived through his death. I find the image of that child in his white coffin, brown in his skin and clothed in white, a resonating nightmare that has been a leitmotif of despair. He was but one child, but in him I saw every dead child. He was "ours." "They," all the children of the world, are also ours. The other person was my maternal grandfather Edgar Solomon, who did not live long enough to know that his daughter had a child in 1962, a child who has become known as the living embodiment of his spirit. I never met Edgar Solomon, yet I have always known him. A man of African and Jewish parents, his death away from "home" signified the two forms of diaspora that he embodied. Edgar Solomon still inspires admiration in the generation who knew him and the subsequent generations who have only heard of him. I hope this work deserves his admiration. Then there was Jack Gordon, my paternal granduncle, who took the time to teach his skinny little grandnephew who was kept out of school for over a year. Jack was painfully rotting away with diabetes and a number of other diseases, but he never felt sorry for himself. He devoted himself to helping me appreciate the joys of learning to learn. I loved him but didn't realize that I should have told him so. He died within a few months of my departure. Finally, Curtis Andino, who passed away in 1991, was my best friend of fifteen years. We taught each other jazz and regarded each other more as brothers than friends.

L. R. G.
West Lafayette, Indiana

INTRODUCTION

WHY BAD FAITH?

WHAT is the being or ontological limitation of human reality in an antiblack world? What follows is an attempt to answer this question.

Antiblack racism may embody the extreme poles of the possibility of a universal humankind; it wrenches human beings into the most extreme visual metaphors of difference: from the most light to the most dark, from the fullness of color (something) to its complete absence (nothing), from “white,” that is, to “black.” Yet there is a sense in which human beings are neither of these extremes. On the most banal phenomenological level, there are light and dark human beings. To *be* “white” and to *be* “black,” then, involve a form of not being what we are. How is this possible?

And so we begin.

Our goal is to show the relevance of what Jean-Paul Sartre calls “bad faith” to antiblack racism. No doubt there will be readers who will raise concern about my use of the term *black* instead of the supposedly more politically acceptable *African American*. My reasons are threefold. First, the recent history behind the term African American caters to concerns of the black pseudo-bourgeoisie. More than what it purports to be—an effort toward a politically acceptable nomenclature—it also serves as a way of differentiating a certain class of blacks from the dismal global situation of most blacks. I don’t meet many working-class blacks who are “African Americans.” Hence my second reason is a function of the first. Taking Frantz Fanon’s lead, a problem with the name African American is that it evades and fails to appreciate the “fact of blackness.” Fanon writes, “The few working-class people whom I had the chance to know in Paris never took it on themselves to pose the problem of the discovery of Negro past. They knew they were black, but, they told me, that made no difference in anything. In which they were absolutely right.”¹ The term *black* is also adopted by some blacks for other reasons. As one black author recently declared, “While some have recently overthrown this term [black American] in favor of African American, I have not. I find it too simplistic. I am not an African with American citizenship. Please do not misunderstand. I embrace my African

roots. However, the term African-American excludes the Native American, White Protestant, and Jewish components of my distant ancestry. And, I identify most strongly with a culture rooted in the American South. Since I have not yet thought up a term that I like better, I still call myself Black.”² This is not to say that no black person should choose to call himself African American or Africana.³ Many black people *are* of African descent. It is simply that African Americans and Africans, although included in this study, are not the major focus of it. Blackness transcends North America—and even Africa. Consider the following poem from an Australian Aborigine.⁴

When I born, I black
 When I grow up, I black
 When I go in the sun, I black
 When I cold, I black
 When I scared, I black
 When I sick, I black
 And when I die—I still black. . . .

Anti-African-American or Anti-Africana racism—if such a case is properly a case of racism instead of ethnocentrism—is therefore a subsidiary aspect of our work here. Third, the “anti” aspect of this study requires taking seriously those aspects, including words used as descriptions, of phenomena that are most hated. It may be acceptable to speak of saliva and feces, penises and vagina in scholarly discourse, but what elicit ire, disgust, and desire to conceal are their so-called vulgar alternatives. Class and professional attitudes to the use of these words make my first point all the more obvious; the black elite can now tolerate being descendants of Africans, which provides it with the illusion of being simply another ethnic group in a multiethnic society, but it can no longer tolerate the “racial” significance of also being black.

The terms “racism” and “race” will unfold in their peculiarities in the course of our investigation. Preliminary formulations of my use of these terms are as follows. By racism I mean the self-deceiving choice to believe either that one’s race is the only race qualified to be considered human or that one’s race is superior to other races. The term race is not used here solely according to the anthropological categories of caucasian, negroid, or mongoloid, since any group within these groups can be regarded as a separate race from other members of these groups in virtue of how it is treated in particular societies. This was clearly the case with Jews, for example, in Nazi Germany; although considered Caucasian, German Jews were regarded as members of a separate race from other Caucasian Germans.⁵ This is not to say that there have not been efforts to determine the “blackness” of Jews. For example, the French Comte Joseph Arthur de Gobineau (the “father” of modern racism) regarded the closeness of Israel to Africa and miscegenation

of Israelites and Africans, particularly during Hebrew enslavement in Egypt, as a ground for the inferiority of Jews.⁶ It is not clear, however, whether the blackness of Jews is a source or a function of anti-Jewish racism. As Hitler once admitted, "I know perfectly well, just as well as all these tremendously clever intellectuals, that in the scientific sense there is no such thing as race. . . . [But] I as a politician need a conception which enables the order which has hitherto existed on historic bases to be abolished and an entirely new and anti-historic order enforced and given an intellectual base."⁷ Still, Hitler's "needed conception" was received with more than sufficient zeal, and as the German-Jewish experience attests, a consequence of the choice of one's racial superiority and other races' inferiority is the view that members of other races are ultimately objects over which to exercise one's will without expecting, or claiming to expect, moral responsibility for actions considered reprehensible against human beings.

Examining racism from the standpoint of Sartrean philosophy of existence isn't a new idea. Jean-Paul Sartre has explored racial concerns in some of his work of the 1940s and early 1950s, such as *Anti-Semite and Jew*,⁸ *Notebooks for an Ethics*,⁹ *The Respectful Prostitute*,¹⁰ "Black Orpheus,"¹¹ and "Black Presence."¹² The virtues and vices of *Anti-Semite and Jew* have received study. But antiblack racism from the standpoint of bad faith has received relatively cursory and quite inadequate attention. Consider Sartre's treatments of the subject in the works listed. *The Respectful Prostitute* is a play based on the Scottsboro Nine case where nine black youths were framed in Alabama and sentenced to the electric chair for the rape of two white women.¹³ In that play, Sartre explores some forms of bad faith that emerge under *institutionalized* racism in the form of Jim Crow laws and southern mores. In *Notebooks for an Ethics*, Sartre explores how the flawed rationalization of the system of slavery literally "created" the American black—that is, a being who is supposedly a slave "by nature." And in "Black Presence," he raises the question of whether the critical and liberation efforts of black writers make sense within the confines of the language of their colonizers; but he doesn't develop an answer to this question. In "Black Orpheus," however, Sartre makes an effort to understand black particularity itself *from the inside*. He regards his project in that work as an attempt to explain the specificity of black writers to white readers under the concept of *negritude*, an expression coined by the poet Aimé Césaire.

Negritude is a supposedly intrinsic black consciousness, a form of black soul that serves as the precursor to some contemporary notions of an intrinsically black way of seeing the world. Sartre regards *negritude* as essentially that which is utterly mysterious about the black man to the white man. This stark difference is regarded by Sartre as a possibility of liberation for blacks. It is essentially an "antiracist racism" which develops the particularity

and peculiarity of blackness as a vibrant, liberating force that will provide the negative dialectical moment against antiblack racism and thereby usher in the "universal," "objective" order of a raceless working-class society.

For reasons that will become evident, I take a highly critical stand at the outset toward "Black Orpheus," despite some of its rather keen insights. First, the notion of negritude is problematic from the standpoint of freedom, for it is based on the presumption of necessary, intrinsic features of black people—the notion that black people are essentially black. Second, Sartre's analysis in that essay is full of historical falsehoods about black people that do little service to the understanding of the situation of blacks. It is historically false, for instance, that sub-Saharan African history is solely agrarian. The walls of Zimbabwe, for example, were built by black engineers before the advent of the Atlantic slave trade. Third, Sartre advances the claim, on the basis of negritude, that black people are fundamentally subjective and mysterious on the one hand, and white people are fundamentally objective and technological on the other. This claim has dangerous implications in any society that regards objectivity as more closely linked with *Truth* than subjectivity. Fourth, Sartre's romanticism of blackness and his notion of blacks being authentic in spite of their choices situate "Black Orpheus" in the camp of exoticism, a form of antiblack racism that we will discuss later on. And fifth, Sartre's main purpose in writing this famous prefatory essay was to situate black cultures as authentic foundations of *black* liberation. The project faced here is not fundamentally a search for a prescription for black liberation. Instead, it is an effort to provide a sound hermeneutic or interpretation of antiblack attitudes and their foundations, although such a study cannot avoid having some obvious implications for the question of black liberation.

We will, however, touch upon one insightful notion, the notion of antiracist racism. Antiracist racism rests on Sartre's claim that the fundamental existential project of blacks is the overcoming of antiblack racism without at the same time becoming victims of such an overcoming. Since the "racially neutral" in antiblack societies is *white*, all efforts toward purely human significations—that is, "universality"—appear to be problematic: "A man," "a woman," "a child," "one," all of these often signify "a white man," "a white woman," "a white child," "a white person." In short, absolute antiracism seems to entail discrimination *against* blacks in the form of an opaque reference to a presumed homogenous human race with white pigmentation. Sartre has thus delineated what may be the two fundamental problems faced by black particularists: First, can the struggle against racism avoid being racist? And second, can the achievement of black liberation avoid the elimination of the black race?

This last point is of course a reformulation of the famous negative movement in Sartre's articulation of the struggle against racism. The classic cri-

tique of this problem is Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks*. Fanon admitted that Sartre was correct, but with reservations. He writes, "When I read that page [of 'Black Orpheus,' where negritude is a mere moment toward a universal raceless history], I felt that I had been robbed of my last chance" (133). He "needed not to know" (135). He ultimately rejected negritude as a basis of achieving black liberation because he realized its irrelevance to the problem of the racist *Zeitgeist*: "If the question of practical solidarity with a given past ever arose for me, it did so only to the extent to which I was committed to myself and to my neighbor to fight for all my life and with all my strength so that never again would a people on the earth be subjugated. It was not the black world that laid down my course of conduct. My black skin is not the wrapping of specific values" (227).

Yet, there are values associated with having black skin that, however skewed, overdetermined, and fallacious, may be decoded to reveal dimensions of a fraudulent reality that is nevertheless "reality" and manifests itself as a form of denial of its own presence, a form of reality, that is, that refuses to speak its name. To "see" such a reality, to decode it through admitting it, calls for a variety of approaches all of which can be considered from the standpoint of one's existential situation. This was certainly a theme of Sartre's considerations on race in the works straight through to the work of the late 1950s and mid-1960s: *Search for a Method*,¹⁴ *The Critique of Dialectical Reason*,¹⁵ the unpublished 1964 Rome Lecture Notes,¹⁶ and the unpublished *Morality and History*.¹⁷

The primary method of this study is that of descriptive ontology or what is sometimes called existential phenomenology.¹⁸ It can be argued that Sartre struggled with this "method" throughout his career from his early works on imagination to his later works on dialectical reasoning. In the course of our investigations, we will see this thesis unfold as we articulate Sartre's use of the concept of bad faith throughout his opus. The core assumptions of bad faith are that human beings are aware, no matter how fugitive that awareness may be, of their freedom in their various situations, that they are free choosers of various aspects of their situations, that they are consequently responsible for their condition on some level, that they have the power to change at least themselves through coming to grips with their situations, and that there exist features of their condition which provide rich areas of interpretive investigation for the analyst or interpreter. I focus on the work of Sartre because one of his major areas of investigation has been the human project of constructing itself as a self. To determine what kind of a self a human being chooses as his project is to determine not only what kind of human being the chooser is, but also *who* the human being may be in his particularity in virtue of the choices which make his life meaningful. Hence to study an aspect of human reality under a hermeneutic model from the standpoint of

bad faith is to study the mode of *being* or ontology of that aspect of human reality itself.

Black people have the misfortune of being situated in the *what* mode of being. An existential phenomenological exploration can forge the ground for the correct bases of the *who*. Bad faith thus, from the outset, holds a unique relation to the question of antiblack racism in the following way. From the Sartrean perspective, we seek our identity by way of negating or "freezing" that of others. But in this process we lie to ourselves with the notion of being at one with our various identities. Thus, we often identify ourselves as "full" and others as "empty" or existing in the condition of lack. This condition of lack often takes on group' associations, which leads to the dichotomy of fullness and hunger having symbolic form in antiblack societies as lightness and darkness, whiteness and blackness, which in turn eventually takes on racial form as the white and the black. Bad faith can hence also be shown to be an effort to deny the blackness within by way of asserting the supremacy of whiteness. It can be regarded as an effort to purge blackness from the self and the world, symbolically and literally. Through a study of the manifestations of bad faith in various human efforts at self-evasion and self-construction, answers are proposed for the following questions: How are people able to hide from themselves? How is it possible that human beings are able to regard some members of their species as fundamentally nonhuman? Why is it bad faith to demand *others* to justify their existence?

I regard this as Sartre's fundamental insight into the human condition: that whatever we are is not always what we have to be.¹⁹ If the path taken here is a correct one, then this study provides an interpretation of antiblack racism that not only explores its subject at the level of its ontological foundations, but also aspires to an understanding of how at least one aspect of its mystification may be overcome.

PART I

Bad Faith

A "Determined" Attitude That Involves Lying to Ourselves

TO understand human reality, "it is best," writes Jean-Paul Sartre, "to choose and to examine one determined attitude which is essential to human reality and which is such that consciousness instead of directing its negation outward turns it toward itself. This attitude, it seems to me, is *bad faith* (*mauvaise foi*)."¹

An examination of bad faith puts us in touch with the "fundament" of human reality. Why is this so? Our answer depends on our interpretation of bad faith. We can tentatively define bad faith as the effort to hide from responsibility for ourselves as freedom. As a result, bad faith can also be interpreted in the following ways.

In bad faith, I flee a displeasing truth for a pleasing falsehood. I must convince myself that a falsehood is in fact true. I therefore lie to myself. This seems rather odd. For in a normal lie, there is the deceiver and the deceived. How can there be a deceiver and a deceived in a single consciousness?

We need, first, to provide an explanation of the self to whom this lie is both told and from whom this lie emanates. According to Sartre, the problem with this self is its negative mode of being. I think about who I am. I consider my name and my biography (what I have been up to this point), and I ask myself, Am I identical with these phenomena? As I reflect upon them, I am aware of them as, to some extent, out of my reach except as bits of knowledge. They appear frozen. They appear complete. Yet I wonder about what I can become, and I realize a multitude of possibilities. The choices I make from this point onward will unfold into the continuation or construction of a biography. I am an unfinished story, a story in progress, of which I am the author. I can choose an end. But I can never know the end in advance, for I could choose at the last moment to change it. Therefore when the story is complete, the writer literally disappears, and only readers and the text remain.² I can try to find myself, but I can never declare myself as having been found without making the decision continuously to preserve the version discovered. Myself will always be my responsibility.

Others can, however, share responsibility for forcing situations upon me that may limit my options.³

Implicit in having found myself is the denial of continued choice. To be at peace with myself, I will have to accept what I am, which pushes to the side the constant question of what I can be. I stand in a strange place. For what I "am" slips constantly into the past, and what I can be is always ahead of me.

From the Sartrean perspective, when I seek myself, it eludes me, it disappears. This is because there is no fixed self in Sartre's ontology. There are only semblances, chimera, social constructions, manifested wishes of definite self-hood. In short, outside of these constructions, there is no self; there is, so to speak, a perspective that is, in itself, "nothing." Facing myself as nothing, I am free to present myself under a variety of interpretations. In Sartrean language, I am a freedom.

As a freedom, I seem to have nowhere to settle down. Wherever I land is always posed as an object to me and is therefore not identical with what I am. I am like a figure attempting to stay afloat on the Arctic Ocean by hopping from ice cap to ice cap—always facing the possibility of sinking and never facing the condition of standing still. In my effort to secure my existence I confront the human condition of being like a cartoon character who tries to climb up his own body. We human beings are aware of not being identical with the objects we pursue—including ourselves.

Suppose we pursue ourselves. To "catch" ourselves we need first to make ourselves. Yet it seems that to initiate our pursuit we must already have been present. There must be a version of myself that I don't identify with myself; I must believe there is a me who stands beneath the manifested me, the me who appears to myself and others as an object. But what stands beneath that version of myself? Eventually, we have to pull the rug from underneath and realize that the liar stands on no foundation save, as it were, existence itself. The foundation of human reality is therefore its lack of foundation. We shall see that this conclusion is founded upon what Sartre calls pre-reflective consciousness. For now, we need only observe that lying to ourselves must be a case of bad faith since we must, in effect, deny having control over that of which we have control. With such an effort we attempt to give up choice in our condition. We attempt to evade the human confrontation with choice.

The Irony of Belief

IRONY can be regarded as a special kind of negation. Kierkegaard provides some insight into it:

A man protests loudly and solemnly, "This is my opinion." . . . The ironist then is on the watch . . . he of course is not looking out for what is printed in large letters . . . , but he is looking out for a little subordinate clause which escapes the gentleman's haughty attention . . . , and now he beholds with astonishment . . . that the gentleman *has not* that opinion—not that he is a hypocrite, God forbid! that is too serious a matter for an ironist—but that the good man has concentrated his force in bawling it out instead of possessing it within him. To that extent the gentleman may be right in asserting that he has that opinion which with all his vital force he persuades himself he has, he may do everything for it in the quality of talebearer, he may risk his life for it, in very much troubled times he may carry the thing so far as to lose his life for this opinion—with that, how the deuce can I doubt that the man had this opinion; and yet there may have been living contemporaneously with him an ironist who even in the hour when the unfortunate gentleman is executed cannot resist laughing, because he knows by the circumstantial evidence he has gathered that the man had never been clear about the thing himself.

An ironic man assumes a posture precisely so as not to assume it. He loves in order to hate. He hates in order to love. Whatever he claims to confront is exactly what he attempts to evade.

Belief is saturated with irony. If I am not sure about a piece of information but would like nevertheless to act upon that piece of information, I decide to act upon that which I doubt. I am acting upon that which I don't believe. But the very situation of *acting* upon my doubt reflects a form of belief. How can this be?

I think someone is upstairs. A third person knows that no one is upstairs. But I am *certain* that someone is upstairs. Do I manifest a form of belief? Our third person is compelled to say so. "He only believes," he will say of me, "that someone is upstairs."

Our ordinary understanding of belief is that to recognize belief as belief is to recognize its imperfection. Belief often falls short of knowledge. Implicit

in this recognition is the notion of ideal belief, a belief so justified that it is equivalent to knowledge (Sartre 1956, 115).⁴ But since such a belief would be knowledge, the notion of *belief* maintaining itself as belief under such a condition is problematic; it betrays the demand on belief not to be what it is. Since the criterion of evidence called for in such cases is perfection—belief on the basis of *ideal* or perfect evidence—all evidence that falls short of perfection is lumped together. No ordinary belief is regarded, by the person with such an attitude, as more acceptable than others.

Kierkegaard tells a story in which this duality between ordinary and ideal evidence opens the door to irony. A man is robbed by a bandit who wears a wig.

“Your purse!” screams the wigged bandit while holding the victim’s throat.

After the robbery, the bandit quickly discards the wig. A poor man finds the wig, puts it on, and is soon arrested for robbery. In court, the victim swears that the poor man is the robber. The actual robber appears. Kierkegaard writes,

He puts on the wig, seizes the traveller by the throat, crying, “Your purse!”—and the traveller recognizes the robber and offers to swear to it—the only trouble is that already he has taken an oath. (544)

The robber reveals himself so as to hide himself. “He only believes,” the observers may say of the traveler, “that the man with the wig is the robber.” The traveler is caught in the problem of playing a role in developing suspicion regarding his presented “true” self. He is presented as uncertain and unreliable—even when he is in fact certain of the truth since he has been certain of both what is false and what is true.

To believe—“really” to believe—is to be certain. To recognize my belief as a belief is, however, to admit a lack of certainty. Self-reflective belief is therefore problematic. Belief is, in the first person, what it is not—that is, not belief—and belief is not what it is, that is, belief. This internal calling-into-question of belief inevitably leads, as we have seen, to a demand for evidence. But if evidence is ruled outright as faulty (that is, inevitably less than ideal), the door is open for us to accept whatever we would like to count as evidence. The stage for the effort to hide from ourselves is therefore rooted in a certain attitude toward our beliefs. In bad faith we use ideal belief as our standard of belief in order to use pleasing evidence as our standard of ordinary beliefs. Sartre writes:

The ideal of good faith (to believe what one believes) is, like that of sincerity (to be what one is), an ideal of being-in-itself [that is, being a definite thing or object]. Every belief is a belief that falls short; one never wholly believes what one believes. Consequently the primitive project of bad faith is only the utilization of this self-destruction of the fact of

consciousness. If every belief in good faith is an impossible belief, then there is a place for every impossible belief. (1956, 115)

Should we choose to hide from our responsibility for our choices, we can assert that it is not that we have chosen faulty evidence but that evidence itself is faulty.

We may go further. Since we use perfect evidence as our standard, evidence that must be so true that it is free of subjectivity or perspective, then no other kind of evidence can prove us to be *really wrong* in our beliefs. Like Kierkegaard's ironist, we are able to hide from what we are on the basis of shady evidence or a wig.

Anguish

I NOW find myself in a problematic situation when I reflect upon my own beliefs as beliefs. This places me in a confrontation with myself, for only I can make myself admit to myself what I believe. There is, of course, the case of deceit by others, but in such cases my beliefs are not often recognized by me at the outset as beliefs. They are discovered to be so at the point at which I become conscious of having been fooled. In the cases where I am not deceived by another person but am aware of my beliefs as beliefs—cases of uncertainty—I face the question of whether to believe or not to believe what is brought before me. In such cases, I face a *choice* over the attitude I shall take toward my being in the world. Sartre describes this confrontation with choice as anguish, an articulation which is also adopted from Kierkegaard.

According to Kierkegaard anguish is a confrontation with the self. In anguish we face the fact that we are the ones who must make the choices that constitute our selves.

For example, I am standing on the Brooklyn Bridge. It is early Sunday morning. No one is present but myself. I fear no one jogging by and deciding to give me a little shove over the bridge down to my death in the East River. Yet there is a possibility of my plummeting down to my death. I could decide to take a dive. *I* could decide to throw myself over the rails.

What stops me?

My question is saturated with bad faith. For it suggests a “causal” factor, as though I could be desiring to throw myself to my death while being prevented from doing so by some powerful, predetermined, external force.

I face myself. Only *I* can stop myself and it is only *I* who can make the decision to throw myself off the bridge. A constant possibility from anguish, then, is suicide. For ultimately, it is always up to me to be or not to be, as it were, in relation to myself—to make the choice that will constitute “me” in the sense of my future possibilities or “me” in the sense of ending my life right now so I can be understood entirely in terms of my past realizations.

Suppose I reject suicide as a viable option. I face the question of my future possibilities. A problem emerges. For if I must choose myself, then

myself is an open possibility at the moment of my choice. In other words, the "self" that I seek is an unstable, problematic self. For suppose I choose to be a person who doesn't jump off of the Brooklyn Bridge. This doesn't mean that I *won't* do so. I could spontaneously decide to jump, despite the choice I have made up to that point not to do so.

In anguish, then, I find myself facing the situation of who and what I am. I discover that *I* constitute myself. I face my own freedom and my own responsibility for it. I face myself *as* freedom.

The situation is without comfort. Comfort implies a condition of rest, a condition of being at peace. How can I be so when I always face my own possibilities? Conditions of comfort for me are therefore illusory; they involve my convincing myself of being in a "state" of rest. Sartre identifies a state as that which "appears to reflective consciousness. The state is given to it, and is the object of a concrete intuition. . . . This state is *present* to the gaze of reflective consciousness. It is *real*."⁵ As a being whose possibilities are constantly presented to me *for me*, I can never *be* in any statelike condition. My condition of comfort must be a form of denial, ironically, a form of "comfortable untruth." Taking refuge in comfort, I flee confronting myself, I flee anguish.

Such flight reflects anguish ironically. It is an anguish-riddled-flight from anguish. It is also one of the formulations of bad faith: "We are anguish-in-order-to-flee-anguish within the unity of a single consciousness" (1956, 84).

Our formulation at this point is not, however, without problems. The question of the ontological legitimacy of the self reemerges.

The self, as we have seen, is a problematic notion. An act, Sartre declares, "is a human act only in so far as it surpasses every explanation which we can give of it, precisely because the very application of the formula 'that is' to man causes all that is designated *to have been*" (72). This is the point we have already advanced in our discussion of confronting the self as freedom. When I assert who I "am," I discover this self instantly eluding me as who I *was*. Thus the self that I face in anguish is a self that seems to be presently out of my reach. I face my future self, the self who will come about as the choice I will make. But at the moment of that choice, I will face a self that is a feature of my past. Hence any resolution or conception of myself is "*me* to the extent that I realize constantly my identity with myself across the temporal flux, but it is no longer *me*—due to the fact that it has become an object *for* my consciousness" (70).

Consciousness or human reality is always consciousness *of* something. This view of consciousness is called the intentional view of consciousness. Myself, for example, is not *I* but is an object of consciousness. But because of my presence *for me*—the presentation of myself as an object of which I am conscious—the following, seemingly contradictory formulation emerges. "I

am not *me*." Whom do I face in anguish? Sartre writes that "Anguish is the reflective apprehension of freedom by itself." In anguish, freedom faces freedom. But the freedom faced cannot be *me*. That *me* is frozen. It is an object of consciousness. The self faced in anguish must therefore be the one pursued in the effort to bridge the gap between that *me* and I—*my* possibility—in short, the self I seek when I assert that "I am I." I am I is either a pure consciousness in itself, in which case it will lack an object, or a pure object by itself, in which case it will lack a subject. In *Being and Nothingness*, both cases appear to be impossibilities, since subjects (consciousness) presuppose objects and vice versa. Hence the very effort to assert a pure, absolute *me* is a form of flight or denial, for the impossibility of such a construction lurks in the situation of each effort at self-reference. The door is open to bad faith:

If I am my anguish in order to flee it, that presupposes that I can decenter myself in relation to what I am, that I can be anguish in the form of "not being it," that I can dispose of a nihilating power at the heart of anguish itself. This nihilating power nihilates anguish in so far as I flee it and nihilates itself in so far as *I am anguish in order to flee it*. This attitude is what we call *bad faith*. (83)

I confront my "self" as a stable self. Yet such a confrontation suggests an effort to avoid the discomfort of my always being beyond myself as a stable self, a condition Sartre coins "metastability"—in a word, my own elusiveness. My only stability is my metastability. In accepting such anguish, and thereby becoming my anguish, I embody the effort to flee anguish. I manifest the attitude of bad faith.

The Elusiveness of Transcendence and the Comfort of Facticity

HUMAN reality manifests a peculiar struggle of contradiction. The human being is linked both to the free and the unfree. The latter we may call the human being's situation in the world. One definition of situations is that they are the meanings of our confrontation with those aspects of our condition over which we seem to lack some control—for example, our past biography and the freedom of others. Our situation is not, however, completely independent of the choices we make. A situation "is not a pure contingent given. Quite the contrary, it is revealed only to the extent that [consciousness] surpasses it toward itself" (1956, 409).

For example, the situation of slavery is a function of the slave's choice to assert his equality and the master's choice to deny it. A child is born on a plantation. He receives love, kindness, and nourishment from his mother. He doesn't see her for many hours during the day except when it's time to be fed. One day, when he is old enough to walk and speak, he decides to pursue his mother and discovers a peculiar point in the distance. As he attempts to reach it, he hears the crack of a whip. He attempts to continue anyway, but this time the whip lashes across his back and tears open his flesh. His situation becomes clear: *his* factual horizon—that is, where his liberty extends—is different from others' factual horizon. His horizon stops short of the point in the distance, but others roam there freely. He becomes conscious of the limitations imposed upon him. He becomes conscious of his situation as a slave. "[Human reality] constitutes itself in the flesh as the nihilation of a possibility which another human reality projects as *its* possibility. For that reason it must arise in the world as a *No*; it is as a *No* that the slave first apprehends the master, or that the prisoner who is trying to escape sees the guard who is watching him" (86–87).

Yet the slave is also simultaneously aware of not fully *being a slave*; he is, after all, *conscious of the beyond*.

The situation of the slave is that of being a slave and simultaneously not being a slave. Slavery places limitations on the options over which the slave chooses, but not over the slave's ability to choose. It is precisely the sense in which a slave is not a slave that he faces himself, every moment, as a slave who is responsible for the ways in which he deals with the fact that there is an effort to *make him*, in his entirety, into a slave. The achievement of such a totalization would be the "ideal slave." All slaves face this "ideal" as what they are not in virtue of their being human beings. All slaves are in a confrontation, as all human beings are on the existential level, with anguish.

Bad faith, or the anguish-riddled-flight from anguish, involves an effort to take advantage of the human condition as freedom and the human being as a being who lacks some control over the impact of others' freedom to affect and to effect certain aspects of its various situations. In bad faith I may assert that what I "really am" transcends my situation in the world; for example, I "am" my freedom but not my gender or biography. Or I may try to take refuge in those aspects of my situation over which I seem to lack control; I can assert that I can't help being what I am. Further, I can make an effort to be what I was or to disengage myself entirely from my past and my present by claiming only to be what I will become. Each of these cases involves taking refuge in a form of being what I "really am," as though my "real" being is as static and as complete as a stone. I can try to take refuge away from myself as a conscious being and take advantage of my situation of also being presented to others as a being subject to their interpretation of me. I can claim that other people have knowledge of a self that *is* "me" but that that self is not really me. Or I may claim that the self that is presented to others is the real me. In either case, it is another effort to take refuge in what I "really am."

I can try to be sincere. I can claim that there is a version of myself that is the real me and I am simply being myself. But even that effort is flawed; it is an effort at an attitude which manifests bad faith, for it is an effort to be for-myself what I really am. To decide to be who I really am presupposes my being determined ahead of my choices. I therefore regard myself as *compelled* to be myself, instead of submitting to a chosen conception of myself, as though even such "compulsion" were not submission and hence a form of choice. All of these cases are cases of my choosing to take refuge in a notion of myself as a reified substance. Since I am not identical with any of my objects, I must in fact be choosing whatever objects I claim to be.

Imagine a community activist. One day, he is offered the opportunity to run for a seat in city government but with the condition that he reduces his grass-roots style of political activity. He agrees, reasoning to himself that he will be able to serve his constituency better in a position of power. In city government, he is then offered the opportunity to run for a seat in the state

legislature but with the condition that he doesn't make any political waves on the municipal level. He agrees, reasoning that he will be able to serve his constituency better with the greater degree of power available to him on the state level. Eventually, a similar situation emerges and he finds himself making concessions so as to become a U.S. senator. Let us say that this period of political ascent takes a decade. He is now a senator. He is confronted one fine day on the steps of Capitol Hill by one of his old grass-roots buddies. He is called a "sell-out."

He is outraged. He defends himself right away with the claim of being a community activist who is really trying to make a difference in the community from which he has come. His accuser points out, however, that no matter what he sees himself *as he is* a politician and he has not *acted* differently from any other politician who has sold out. No matter what he may claim is his real identity and his real motives, he has made choices which have placed him in positions of power at the price of a decade's worth of legislation that could have benefitted his community. Our community activist/politician is now placed in a position of having to show that he is sincere. But how can he accomplish this without making claim either to a *real* version of himself that is not recognized by others or a *real* version of himself that will be made known to others?

Our politician/activist finds himself in anguish. For he has to make a choice either to vote upon legislation that will reveal a motive to empower his community or continue to play the game of continued-empowerment-toward-some-eventual-community-payoff. Either version of himself represents a choice of himself that he is to make; but either version doesn't necessarily support his claim to good faith, although both may support his claim to sincerity, for he could be interpreted as a sell-out who is trying not to look like a sell-out, a sell-out who has decided to make a change to appear, to his community and perhaps also to himself, like Kierkegaard's opinionated man, as sincere. From the Sartrean perspective, his immediate claim to sincerity is rotten at its core, for he treats his choice as having already been made in order to evade it. He is in bad faith.

What Am I to Me?

SARTRE regards the project of a permanent, stable self as a flawed project. This is because there is no complete *existing* self in Sartrean ontology. Hugh Silverman describes Sartre's view of the self thus: "Self-consciousness is non-self-referential. Even if language were introduced—at least a conception of language as referential (in the Fregean sense)—the self would not be characterized. Since in this sense linguistic meaning (*Sinn*) refers to some referent (*Bedeutung*), the difficulty in the case of the self is that there is a meaning (*Sinn*) but no referent (*Bedeutung*) that corresponds to the *Sinn* in question. But the self is not Pegasus, nor a unicorn. The self exists. Pegasus and unicorns do not exist, . . . For Sartre, the self *is*, but not as a referent of a cognitive or a linguistic act."⁶ Although we agree with Silverman that the self has no referent in Sartrean ontology, we suspect the rest of his interpretation to be wanting in at least one respect. Sartre claims that the true self has no essence in the phenomenological sense, which can also mean that it cannot fully be "intended" or "meant" as a *what* or a *thing* without error. Hence, although it is correct to claim that reified selves have meaning without referents, it may be incorrect to assert that the "true self" has a meaning, save the perhaps trivial fact that we can make oblique references to it in descriptions like "the true self."⁷ For Sartre, the only "complete" selves are the psychological self, the historical or biographical self, and the self as an open possibility. In *Transcendence of the Ego*, he makes the point thus: "The *I* is the ego as the unity of actions. The *me* is the ego as the unity of states and of qualities" (60). The *I* is empty and unreflective; being without content—without qualities, states, attitudes, and any of the array of intentions associated with "selves"—it eludes my every effort to grasp it. I am asked what am I doing and I answer, preoccupied, that "I am writing this book." According to Sartre, I utter these words

without ceasing to work, without ceasing to envisage actions only as done or to be done—not insofar as I am doing them. But this "I" which is here in question nevertheless is no mere syntactical form. It has a meaning; it is quite simply an empty concept which is destined to remain empty. Just as I can think of a chair in the absence of any chair merely

by a concept, I can in the same way think of the *I* in the absence of the *I*. (89)

The psychological self, the historical or biographical self, the self in process—these are what Sartre calls the *me*. They represent states and qualities. The *me* or the ego is often confused with consciousness as though there can be an ego *of* something. But the ego grasps nothing, supports nothing, nihilates nothing. Instead, the ego is the object of all these intentions; it is a possessed being. Yet the ego is no one of its manifestations.

If we take a melody, for example, it is useless to presuppose an X which would serve as a support for the different notes. The unity here comes from the absolute indissolubility of the elements which cannot be conceived as separated, save by abstraction. The subject of the predicate here will be the concrete totality, and the predicate will be a quality abstractly separated from the totality, quality which has its full meaning only if one connects it again to the totality. For these very reasons we shall not permit ourselves to see the ego as a sort of X-pole which would be the support of psychic phenomena. (74)

When the ego is regarded as an "X-pole" of psychic phenomena—that is, reduced to a single personality type or foundational point that constitutes who we are—a flight from consciousness emerges

as the order is reversed by a consciousness which imprisons itself in the world in order to flee from itself, consciousnesses are given as emanating from states, and states as produced by the ego. It follows that consciousness projects its own spontaneity into the ego-object in order to confer on the ego the creative power which is absolutely necessary to it. But this spontaneity, *represented* and *hypostatized* in an object, becomes a degraded and bastard spontaneity, which magically preserves its creative power even while becoming passive. (81)

"Creative passivity," "spontaneous objectivity"—these characterizations function as oxymoron in the Sartrean discourse. In his later essay *What Is Literature?* he observes that in the creative act of writing, the work and the writer are both *active*. They are open, they are their possibilities. But when the work is complete, the condition of substance emerges; the work is an object for the reader. A writer cannot truly be a reader, for Sartre, precisely because his work is always open; he can always change his mind and transform the work. For him to regard his work as complete without admitting the possibility of a creative act of changing it reflects a problematic stand. "Creative passivity," "spontaneous objectivity," "writing-reading" betray the condition of flight, of an effort on the part of consciousness to hide behind the ego door. The masking of consciousness' dynamism, its spontaneity in the form of articulating itself as the ego, is a form of bad faith.

In *Being and Nothingness*, the point is brought home through a theory of desire. Empty, incomplete, negative, I seek fulfillment, completeness, positivity. I desire a permanent self, an ego behind consciousness, an ego standing solid and firm behind my actions and intentions, that would have the effect of making me "full," complete. But I lack one, for implicit in desire is existing as wanting, as lacking, as incompleteness. I pursue myself like a child with a net chasing a butterfly. Yet even when the butterfly is caught, the child is aware of *it* in the net. It is other than he. To catch my ego would not entail fulfillment unless the scope of my ego is such that it would entail the end of desire as a feature of my existence. Such a desire would be for the end of desire. But how would action be any longer possible? I would no longer act because I desire to or want to; I would instead act simply because that is how I am, that is what my kind does—I would be a consequence of my ego. In such a case, *I* would be transformed from consciousness into an object—an object of my ego. The deception of creative passivity reemerges.

Sartre regards creative-passivity as an ontological feature of human reality. It is the fundamental project that constitutes the human condition as a condition constantly on the threshold of bad faith. A fundamental project is a project that constitutes the very meaning or interpretation or *raison d'être* of a human being. Implicit in desire is its own elimination. Human reality, as desire, seeks its own denial; it seeks to be a "full" consciousness. If we regard the self as a possessed object, or as Sartre prefers, a "known" object, human reality seeks to possess itself, it seeks to know itself fully while simultaneously maintaining its own awareness or pre-reflection. This ontological project Sartre considers to be *the* existential situation of the human being, which Sartre regards as the desire to be for-itself-in-itself, the desire to be a conscious substance, the desire not to be what one is and to be what one is not, the desire to be God.

Each human reality is at the same time a direct project to metamorphose its own For-itself [consciousness] into an In-itself-For-itself and a project of the appropriation of the world as a totality of being-in-itself, in the form of a fundamental quality. Every human reality is a passion in that it projects losing itself so as to found being and by the same stroke to constitute the In-itself which escapes contingency by being its own foundation, the *Ens causa sui*, which religions call God. (1956, 784)

It is out of this "anonymous" project or "original choice," the desire behind all desire, that all our particular projects emerge—the fundamental choice of a specific life and the specific choices that express our original and fundamental choices.⁸

Taking Ourselves Too Seriously

How I would like to tell him he's being deceived, that he is the butt of the important.

This man was one-ideaed. Nothing more was left in him but bones, dead flesh and Pure Right. A real case of possession, I thought. Once Right has taken hold of a man exorcism cannot drive it out. . . . It never did to make him think too much, or attract his attention to unpleasant realities, to his possible death, to the sufferings of others. Undoubtedly, on his death bed, at that moment when, ever since Socrates, it has been proper to pronounce certain elevated words, he told his wife, as one of my uncles told his, who had watched beside him for twelve nights, "I do not thank you, Thérèse; you have only done your duty." When a man gets that far, you have to take your hat off to him. (88-89)

—Antoine Roquentin

HERE Sartre's antihero Antoine Roquentin observes two serious men.⁹ The first regards himself as essential. He is situated in the irony of his own contingency. His own sense of importance is an effort to close himself off from the choices needed to make himself important, ultimately, to himself. His efforts toward self-importance in the eyes of others drop a smokescreen over himself as a source of value. The second serious man has taken a leap of faith from the realm of possibility into the realm of Full Knowledge—completeness. Like Hitler, who made every effort to believe that what is is what ought to be, he is firmly situated in a posture of Right.¹⁰ Neither evidence to the contrary nor contradictory evidence may enter. He has conquered, he thinks, his arch-nemesis—anguish. Sartre writes,

Anguish is opposed to the mind of the serious man who apprehends values in terms of the world and who resides in the reassuring, materialistic substantiation of values. In the serious mood I define myself in terms of the object by pushing aside *a priori* as impossible all enterprises in which I am not engaged at the moment; the meaning which my freedom has given to the world, I apprehend as coming from the world and constituting my obligations. In anguish I apprehend myself at once as totally free and as not being able to derive the meaning of the world except as coming from myself. (1956, 78)

In anguish I realize that I embody value and as a consequence am responsible for what I value. Human reality desires to be; therefore, the being of human reality is that of a lack of being. Consider the ethical plane. Value is often articulated in terms of the "ought" and the "should." Implicit in all oughts and shoulds is the condition of lack. What is done isn't often what should have been done. What ought to be done is often what has not yet been done. And quite often what ought to have been done isn't always (paradoxically) what ought to have been done. Take Hans, for example. Hans once warned a man of an assassination attempt on his life. He was congratulated for apparently doing what ought to have been done. Suppose the man warned were Hitler. What should Hans have done? Should Hans have done what ought to have been done—that is, prevented the murder of a human being?

Value stands in relation to itself like that of the *I* to the ego. It questions itself. Sartre concludes that value is situated on the level of pre-reflection and gains its sense of objectivity, like the ego, from reflection.

Value in its original upsurge is not *posited* by the for-itself [human reality]; it is consubstantial with it—to such a degree that there is no consciousness which is not haunted by *its* value and that human reality in the broad sense includes both the for-itself and value. . . . Value is not *known* at this stage since knowledge posits the object in the face of consciousness. Value is merely given with the non-thetic [that is, pre-reflective] translucency of the for-itself, which makes itself be as the consciousness of being. Value is everywhere and nowhere; at the heart of the nihilating relation "reflection-reflecting," it is presented and out of reach, and it is simply lived as the concrete meaning of that lack which makes my present being. (145–46)

The serious man is in bad faith because he denies his freedom. He regards his values as objects to be *known*, not constructed. He eliminates himself as a source of value and hence simultaneously hides from himself as free and hides from himself as responsible for his freedom. He regards values—including the value that constitutes himself—as transcendent, independent "givens" and desirability, including his own desirability, as a material feature of objects instead of a contingent feature of their relation to human reality. He is therefore Manichaeism in spirit, treating good and evil as material features of the world that can be encouraged or eliminated like bacteria in water.

Manichaeism is derived from the doctrine of the Persian Mani, "the apostle of God." His theology and ethics are based on a dualistic cosmogony of Form/Light/Good and Matter/Dark/Evil. According to R. McL. Wilson, "The cosmogonic myth provides the basis and substructure for the Manichaean ethics and hope of redemption. The ethics are rigorously ascetic: since procreation only prolongs the reign of the powers of darkness [by dispersing

the Light], marriage must be rejected. The Manichaeon must abstain from all 'ensouled' things and eat only vegetables, so as to avoid, as far as possible, any injury to the Light."¹¹ Manichaeon in spirit, the serious man's relation to values becomes wholly technical, a matter of following steps already laid out in their proper places.

The serious man's attitudes toward values can also be phrased in analytic terms as a play on at least what John Rawls considers to be two conceptions of rules—administrative and legislative. Roughly, the former focuses wholly on the past, whereas the latter is geared toward the future.¹² That the administrative view is situated in the past strengthens the link between a serious attitude toward values and the conception of man as substance. The legislative view is what Sartre has in mind when he criticizes the serious man. Rawls shows that the legislative view ultimately grounds the administrative view. This is what Sartre has in mind when he defends freedom as value.

At first glance, the ossification of values that marks the spirit of seriousness appears to be a form of essentialism. This assessment would, however, be an error. For essentialism involves the notion of properties without which a thing cannot be what it is. It doesn't, however, require that a thing necessarily be whatever it is. Essentialism, therefore, has room for contingency. Further, Sartre doesn't deny that when it comes to objects there is such a feature as an essential property. He concedes this in the spirit of Husserlian phenomenology,¹³ where the meaning or intention of an object is a function of that which cannot be eliminated from the object without the object ceasing to appear as what it is: "The appearance does not hide the essence, it reveals it; it *is* the essence" (Sartre 1956, 5). And finally, Sartre doesn't entirely reject the notion of essence in human reality. He simply qualifies it by arguing that essence for human beings is a feature of their past. What their lives mean is a function of what they have done.

What the spirit of seriousness involves is not only the transcendence of human values and desires, but also the *necessity* of those values and desires. The serious man who regards himself as important regards himself with an "objective" ought; one *must* revere him. The serious man who regards himself as endowed with knowledge of Right has cut off all other realms of possibility. His position crosses every possible world as a condition of action; it *must be done*.

Why is the spirit of seriousness a form of bad faith?

We have already articulated the serious man as an evader of anguish and as an individual making an effort to hide from himself as free. We also saw how in his evasion the serious man is able to take advantage of the situation of belief by precluding evidence. Let us now look closely at an example of how this breakdown of evidence can manifest itself.

John Stuart Mill once presented the following ontological-ethical argument.

That which is desirable is that which is desired by a person. Hence that which is desired by the most persons is that which is the most desirable. Happiness is desired by all people; therefore happiness is the most desirable and is in fact the summum bonum, the highest Good.¹⁴ His critics quickly attacked him for confusing human desire, which is supposedly subjective, with desirability, which is a quality and therefore supposedly objective. John Robson, for instance, writes in his introduction to a collection of Mill's works that "In trying to explain why we *should* desire the pleasurable, Mill apparently forgets what he elsewhere shows ample evidence of knowing, that there is a difference between judgements of what is and of what ought to be—that is, he is guilty of what is known as the naturalistic fallacy. . . . But the specifically moral element is here illegitimately smuggled in, for all things which are desired in fact are not (by an ethical criterion) desirable."¹⁵ (I suspect the point that Robson is trying to articulate in the last sentence should have been formulated as "not all things which are desired in fact are, by an ethical criterion, desirable.") Mill's language was confusing and equivocal, but like many such errors it was based on some insight. Quite often what we consider to be positive features of an object are manifestations of whether we desire the object or not (and also whether we enjoy or are elated by the object).¹⁶ Desire plays a central role in what objects *mean*. This relation between desire/value and meaning is a major feature of intentionality, according to Sartre's famous essay on that subject. An intended or *meant* object is understood in terms of value.¹⁷ The problem with Mill's argument, then, is that it is an ontological argument, an argument that uses human reality to prove what is expected to be independent of human reality. In *Being and Nothingness*, Sartre warns against confusing ontological with valuative concerns when he urges "the necessity of abandoning the psychology of interests along with any utilitarian interpretation of human conduct—by revealing to us the *ideal* meaning of all human attitudes" (796). Mill's argument is confusing since his humanist aims suggest that this form of objectivism—a value beyond human beings—isn't what he was even trying to accomplish.

Consider the notion of something being edible. There is a sense in which some things, like cyanide, hydrochloric acid, or molten lava, are not edible. Consuming them will kill us. But the edibility of cows, pigs, and human beings is another matter. From the standpoint of medical science, anything we can digest that enables us to sustain ourselves as biological entities is food. But from the standpoint of Hindus, Jews, Muslims, and Rastafarians, a buffet of pig flesh is hardly appetizing.

"Why are there so many starving people in India, when there are so many cows?" asks a Christian child.

The answer is often that it is because Hindus consider the eating of animal matter to be a sacrilegious act. But, we may ask, what does a sacrilegious

assessment of an object as a source of food mean? I suspect it means that the object is not regarded as food at all.

"Why do you eat pig?" I once asked a friend.

"Why do you call it *pig*? It's not pig when you eat it. It's pork," he responded.

"So what should we call fish when we eat it," I asked him—"poisson?"

It takes a great deal of self-deception to transform many objects into food. If it's the connection to life that we attempt to avoid, then we are all lost, for even the vegetarian has to eat something that was once alive. Many objects can provide us with nutrients. But it is only those that we desire that are considered food. That is what is involved for it to *mean* food; to "be" food, it must be valued as such.

Yet a transformation seems to occur in the presence of objects like food. We don't regard them as food in virtue of our desire for them. We regard them as food in virtue of what we claim they "are." Bread, for example, is no longer a baked substance. Bread is regarded, in its entirety, as food. Its meaning as food is a function of what it is: "For the spirit of seriousness . . . *bread* is desirable because it is *necessary* to live (a value written in an intelligible heaven) and because bread *is* nourishing" (706). Bread is regarded by many of us as desirable because we need it, not because we want it. We face many "inedible" objects without admitting our role in their rejection as food. We lie to ourselves.

We have seen that the desire to be God is a form of bad faith. With the spirit of seriousness, the situation is more insidious. The positing of God is also a form of bad faith. In crude form, it not only posits values outside of human reality, but it also transforms human reality into human *nature*. Its Manichaean formulations raise questions of whether human beings *are* good or *are* bad *as the types of beings they are*. As a consequence, the question of what human beings choose to be isn't important. What is important is determining the ways human beings are already predisposed to act. Hence whether the serious man regards human beings as fundamentally good or fundamentally evil doesn't matter; their goodness or evil is out of their hands—being good, evil humanity becomes illusory and a matter of subjective interpretation; being evil, good humanity becomes illusory and a matter of subjective interpretation—look deeper and evil will be discovered.

The question of the human being's relation to God brings us to the first of a number of instances in which we will delineate differences between Sartre's "system" and Hegel's "system." The tendency to interpret and criticize Sartre through Hegelian lenses has remained steadfast since Herbert Marcuse's review of *Being and Nothingness* in 1948.¹⁸ Although Sartre uses Hegelian (as well as Cartesian, Husserlian, Heideggerian, Bergsonian, and Jamesian) terminology, his purposes are often counter to Hegel's. In the

case of the spirit of seriousness, we find an ontological difference. Sartre regards the in-itself-for-itself as a futile object of desire, an intention that cannot be achieved beyond desire. Hegel, on the other hand, argues that the in-itself-for-itself—*Geist*, interpreted as Absolute Spirit—is achievable not only ontologically but historically. In his *Philosophy of History*, he writes, for example, that “the principles of the successive phases of Spirit that animate the nations in a necessitated gradation, are themselves only steps in the development of the one universal Spirit, which through them elevates and completes itself to a self-comprehending totality.”¹⁹ And in his *Phenomenology of Spirit*, “What Spirit prepares for itself in [the phenomenology of spirit], is the element of [true] knowing. In this element the moments of Spirit now spread themselves out in that *form of simplicity* which knows its object as its own self.”²⁰ He adds, “But the other side of its Becoming, *History*, is a *conscious, self-mediating* process—Spirit emptied out into Time; but this externalization, this kenosis, is equally an externalization of itself; the negative is the negative of itself” (paragraph 808, p. 492).²¹

For Sartre, God as a posited, external source of values makes serious formulations all the more easy. God knows us in our totality. A similar attitude is taken toward social systems in a serious world. In *The Respectful Prostitute*, for example, the character Fred—a racist, a quintessential serious man—looks at the bed in which he has spent the night with Lizzy, a prostitute, with disgust. It *smells*, he observes, of sin. The bed can therefore be less sinful if it were cleaned. Later on in the play, it is observed that a white man cannot be guilty. A black, a “nigger,” on the other hand, “has always done something.” The United States can therefore be without evil if it simply eliminates its black population. These themes we will develop later in our discussion of antiblack racism. For now, it is sufficient to point out that the spirit of seriousness involves the transformation of choice into a condition of human nature on the basis of either God or any substitute that determines or closes off the totality of human possibilities.

Even if we reject the notion of God’s knowing or determining us in our totality, there is still the serious matter of God as an external source of value. Should we act rightly because God commands it? By what right does God make such commands? If by virtue of full knowledge (with the virtue of consciousness of such knowledge), then God *is* the spirit of seriousness, a paradigm manifestation of bad faith.

What is our relation to a command from God? We face the question of whether simply to obey or not to obey. We evade, however, the question of determining the value of the actions ourselves. Their value is regarded as predetermined. We supposedly perform particular actions under certain circumstances simply because it is right to do them, just as our serious man regards his wife as acting *because it is her duty*, not because she *wants* to or

because she is aware of herself as a source of value in the world. The spirit of seriousness is "an ethics which is ashamed of itself and does not dare speak its name. It has obscured all its goals in order to free itself from anguish. Man pursues being blindly by hiding from himself the free project which is this pursuit. He makes himself such that he is *waited for* by all the tasks placed along his way. Objects are mute demands, and he is nothing in himself but the passive obedience to these demands" (Sartre 1956, 796).

Think of the second Genesis story of Adam and Eve's disobeying Yahweh.²² When Yahweh informs Adam and Eve not to eat of the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil, the situation of anguish emerges. In facing the possibility of obeying Yahweh, Adam and Eve become conscious of the possibility of not obeying Yahweh. They face the quintessential construction of a situation as one freedom confronting another freedom. In issuing the command, Yahweh initiates the *question* of their being. They face Yahweh as a totality that *couldn't* negate their choice. For should Yahweh make their choice for them, as it were, the "choice" would cease to be their choice and would cease to be a choice made by human beings at all, in which case the human element would remain moot in the tale. They each face Yahweh alone, in anguish. They have to make not eating the fruit a right act in virtue of their choice not to eat from it. But, as human beings, they face their ultimate desire; to gain such knowledge would, indeed, mean to be God. Needless to say, they fail, but they fail precisely because they continue to live on. For their very project, as Sartre would say, was indeed a "useless passion."

The Body in Bad Faith

A philosophy of the flesh is the condition without which psychoanalysis remains anthropology.

—Merleau-Ponty

OUR discussion thus far raised the question of the relation of freedom to situations and freedom to facticity.²³ Our account advanced to the ontological implications of desire not to desire, as desire to be as a substance that is simultaneously aware of itself. Our account then left us with a value that is ashamed of itself. Our discussion of consciousness has left us with the impression, however, of human reality as a form of “pure” consciousness. This is not the case with actual human beings. Concomitant with human reality qua consciousness is always human reality qua consciousness *embodied*. At this point, we explore some of the possibilities of bad faith raised by embodied consciousness. This discussion will prove helpful later on in our discussion of the black and the white body.

We can tentatively regard the body in bad faith as a flight from displeasing truths about the body as freely existing itself as what it is to pleasing falsehoods about the body as being unable to exist itself in ways that transcend its immediate way of existing.²⁴

We must, however, make a detour to put aside a common ground of confusion. It should be noted that Sartre’s articulation of the body stands immune to the quagmire of reductionism and the infamous mind-body problem in the history of philosophy since Descartes in an obvious way.²⁵ The traditional problem is a problem of the simultaneous extension of two different kinds of substance as one. How is it possible that mind and body, supposedly two different kinds of substance, are able to act as one? Since Sartre rejects the notion of consciousness as substance, then the presence of mind and body poses no more problem than the presence of an object of consciousness. In fact, the very problem of “mind *and* body” is an obvious form of bad faith—the reification of consciousness.

In “Casting Shadows,” Debra Bergoffen describes the reification of consciousness as “objectification.” She argues that our encounters with the Other presents the body as object and bad faith is an effort to make the self one

with such an alienated object body. Bergoffen thus describes the problem of objectification as a problem faced by a body that is different from consciousness. But even when Sartre doesn't explicitly refer to the body in his discussion of consciousness, he refers to the problem of the objectification of consciousness. Does this make consciousness in itself dualistic? Is there a consciousness/subject-consciousness/object problem of a unified self? There is one—in bad faith.²⁶

Even if we advance the notion of mind as ego, the same conclusion of bad faith emerges, but with one consideration. The ego as an object of consciousness raises the question of the body and the ego as two objects with simultaneous extensions. What, then, is the 'ego'?

We have already seen that in *Transcendence of the Ego*, the ego is the overall interpretation of actions as unified. A similar view is advanced by Calvin Schrag, when he points out that under the traditional philosophies of mind, "The mind, it is assumed, is some kind of entity to which attributes can be assigned and in which process or activities occur. . . . This picture remains suspect from a phenomenological point of view, for mind as it appears in world experience is a *developing* or *streaming* consciousness, never catching up with itself and congealing into an entity. The entitative status of mind must therefore be questioned. Correspondingly, the entitative status of the body needs to be examined."²⁷ Following Gabriel Marcel, Schrag attacks the view that mind "possesses" or "has" a body, in favor of the body as lived—that is, "The body is myself in my lived concreteness. My body is *who I am*. I exist in the world as embodied." Schrag's point is that since neither mind nor body is an entity, but mind-body problematizations refer to entities, then the human being should be regarded in neither monistic nor dualistic terms. Thus, the manifestations of action and the images anticipated hold no metaphysical problem in relation to a body: the body can have a history and, as consciousness embodied, a future, until it ceases to be a lived or conscious body. The body relates to the ego, then, as the I to the ego and as such is not identical with the ego.

Thus, we grant Bergoffen's conclusion: "Descartes' dualism is not refuted by simply affirming the embodiment of the subject." But we add: that is because a subject is an active principle analogous to but not identical with consciousness. The subject is a frozen point of reference in a situation. But consciousness defies such a reduction.²⁸

What are the ontological structures of the body? Sartre argues that there are three ontological structures of the body: (1) the body as consciousness, (2) the body as used and known by the Other, and (3) the body as a consciousness that is known as a body for the Other.

There is an obvious sense in which the body is conscious. The lights are out. I see nothing. I feel a pinch. I slap the spot and twirl the dead insect—

a mosquito—between my middle finger and my thumb. A sharp sound pierces the air like a missile toward my ear. I move my head and cover my ear, preventing a fly from entering. I stop for a moment. I have a feeling that I am not alone. I feel the warmth of an Other's presence. The body, in such instances, reveal itself as conscious flesh in the sense that its connection with its environment is immediate.

Sartre's appeal to embodied consciousness is built upon his rejection of pure knowledge—that is, disengaged knowledge, knowledge outside of a situation—and the coextension of consciousness as *lived*, apperceptive reality:

A Pure knowledge in fact would be a knowledge without a point of view; therefore a knowledge of the world but on principle located outside of the world. But this makes no sense; the knowing being would be only knowledge since he would be defined by his object and since his object would disappear in the total indistinction of reciprocal relations. Thus knowledge can be only an engaged upsurge in a determined point of view which one *is*. For human reality, to be is to-be-there. (Sartre 1956, 407)

A view from nowhere isn't a view at all. Reflective consciousness, or knowledge, requires a perspective situated in the world—a pre-reflective point of physical departure, a somewhere, a “sensible center of reference” emerges. That center is the body. A recent attack on this position is Thomas Nagel's *The View from Nowhere*.²⁹ Nagel regards perspectivity and body as accidental features of the self and hence unnecessary for viewing the world. He thus accepts the approach of regarding selves, perspectives, and bodies as different kinds of *entities*. But note, his difference with Sartre rests on his interpretation of “perspective.” Sartre's point is that consciousness is a perspective beyond which one cannot have any perspective at all and to view something is to be conscious of something. To be a view without a perspective requires the ability to be everywhere, everywhen—in short, an infinite consciousness. A consequence of this infinite consciousness is, as Merleau-Ponty once observed, a special kind of contradiction:

Our perception ends in objects, and the object once constituted appears as the reason for all the experiences of it which we have had or could have. For example, I see the next-door house from a certain angle, but it would be seen differently from the right bank of the Seine, or from the inside, or again from an aeroplane: the house *itself* is none of these appearances: it is, as Leibnitz said, the geometrized projection of these perspectives and of all possible perspectives, that is, the perspectiveless position from which all can be derived, the house seen from nowhere. But what do these words mean? Is not to see always to see from somewhere? To say that the house itself is seen from nowhere is surely to say that it is invisible!³⁰

We find ourselves facing here the Cartesian notion of reality in the calculable-invisible. Helpful though this form of invisibility may be for physics, the phenomenological question posed by Sartre and Merleau-Ponty is of a more radical sort, for it should be obvious that even in the Cartesian formulation perspectivity emerges on the level of technique and discipline, mathematical physics positing the physicist as an absent yet cogitating presence. Calvin Schrag sums up the matter this way: "It would be the unique privilege of an infinite consciousness to view the world detachedly from *nowhere*. The embarrassment of the Hegelian is occasioned by the question, 'Where does he stand when he apprehends himself under the guise of the Absolute Spirit?' Infinite Consciousness has neither standpoint nor perspective. Embodied and finite consciousness shows itself in the situationality or contextualism of standpoint and perspective, and it is this which defines its finiteness" (148). What would even mathematical physics be without the standpoint of physics? That Nagel also finds himself confronting accidental relations between the viewing self and the world is a consequence, from the standpoint of existential phenomenology, of the view's pre-reflective status. All predicates are presented to the viewing self as *objects*; thus its *modus operandi* is, as Kant pointed out in the "Transcendental Dialectic" of his *Critique of Pure Reason*, without predication. Nagel uses the term *nowhere* equivocally. Nowhere can mean consciousness is not identical with its objects, including its "place." But in this case he might as well say "nothingness," to capture the existential significance of his point. If so, all the arguments unleashed against pure transcendence—that is, that it is really the bad-faith, anonymous project to be God—applies to Nagel's argument. In fact, Nagel's is a form of ontological argument, for we can call his view from nowhere God's view on everywhere. But for the perspective to constitute knowledge, it cannot maintain anonymity; it must be a particular order, one that intends the particularity of the situation in which it finds itself. The perspective needed for me is the perspective from my body.

We sometimes regard our bodies as objects. I walk up to a mirror and mistake myself for someone else. I regard my body as an Other's. I regard myself for a moment from the Other's perspective of my being a stranger. A similar situation emerges when I see someone on the surveillance monitor in a department store. He looks sloppy and portly. "Good Lord," I whisper to myself, "some people have no shame about their appearance." Then I take a closer look. I come to realize that he is me, though not "as I see myself"—neat and thin. Such experiences are commonplace but not limited to sight. Think of hearing ourselves on tape recorders or perhaps hearing ourselves on an answering machine—the dullness or squeekiness or clumsiness, all estranged versions of our own voice. Extending my perspective can, however, go beyond that of mistaking myself for someone else. I am driving

my car. A twig from a tree falls and gently bounces off the hood of the trunk. I don't *see* the twig. But I *feel* it. In fact, I feel exactly where it lands. I even have a strong idea of what it might be. "It sounded like a twig," I might say. Or perhaps I am sitting alone in my apartment. Yet I feel someone walk through the kitchen, although I neither see nor hear the person. In both cases, my car and my apartment serve, like Lockean or Marxist conceptions of property, as extensions of the perspective that constitutes my body. Thus, according to Sartre,

My body is everywhere: the bomb which destroys *my* house also damages my body in so far as the house was already an indication of my body. This is why my body always extends across the tool which it utilizes: it is at the end of the cane on which I lean and against the earth; it is at the end of the telescope which shows me the stars; it is on the chair, in the whole house; for it is my adaptation to these tools. (1956, 428)

There is an instrumental aspect of the body that takes the form of any perspective taken for me.

But a complication emerges. Although I adapt to appendages—my crutch, my clothes, my contact lenses—as though they were my body, I am also simultaneously aware that these appendages are not me and are not my body. How do I differentiate the perspective that constitutes me in the form of my body instead of an extended perspective? How do I differentiate my eye's perspective from my contact lenses' perspective? Sartre's answer is that I am pre-reflectively aware of my body as distinct from other perspectives. To wear contact lenses, I must make myself forget that I am wearing them, else my eyes will constantly dry and the lenses will fall out. Keeping the fact that I am wearing contact lenses off my mind, my eyes water at the right amount, I feel almost no discomfort, and I am able to go about my business as if my eyes had the perspective of 20/20 vision. Eventually, the lenses seem as though they were not mere extensions on my body, but also extensions *of* my body—my body itself. Yet I am aware not only that I am wearing contact lenses, but also that my lenses are not my body. My eyes are part of me, but my lenses are *on* my eyes, on me.

Take away the perspective of my eyes and I lack sight; take away the perspective of my ears, and I hear nothing; my tongue, I taste nothing; my nose, I smell nothing; my skin, I feel nothing. My body cannot be surpassed by me. My body, as my perspective, is hence "nonpositional"; all other perspectives are positioned by it.

Objections to Sartre's discussion of the body are raised at this point by Hubert L. Dreyfus and Piotr Hoffman. They argue that Sartre's discussion of the body isn't supported by his ontology of consciousness as pure negativity. They write, "Why is the facticity of my body lived as particularly *mine*,

instead of merging with the general facticity and past of the world? If we answer that my body is distinguishable and different from the facticity of the world because it fulfills, forms, the function of 'my point of view,' then the situation becomes clearly circular; . . ."³¹ I suspect that this objection is based on a view of the body outside the sphere of action; it focuses on what the body has done. Regarded as factual and standing opposed to the self, an entitative mind-body dichotomy lurks within this challenge. The question asks for a noncircular reference to me *by me*. I can't go beyond a certain spatio-temporal point, and that is what a perspective means.³²

On the basis of the body's nonpositionality, Sartre concludes that "the body can not be for *me* transcendent and known; the spontaneous, unreflective consciousness is no longer the consciousness *of the* body. It would be best to say, using 'exist' as a transitive verb—that consciousness *exists* its body [*existe son corps*]. Thus the relation between the body-as-point-of-view and things is an *objective* relation, and the relation of consciousness to the body is an *existential* relation" (1956, 434; 1943, 378; note, the verb *exister* also means "to live").

I *exist*—live—my body as me in my various situations. In a passage illuminating our example of the slave, Sartre writes,

The body is the contingent form which is taken up by the necessity of my contingency. We can never apprehend this contingency as such in so far as our body is *for us*; for we are a choice, and for us, to be is to choose ourselves. Even this disability from which I suffer I have assumed by the very fact that I live; I surpass it toward my own projects, I make of it the necessary obstacle for my being, and I can not be crippled without choosing myself as crippled. This means that I choose the way in which I constitute my disability (as "unbearable," "humiliating," "to be hidden," "to be revealed to all," "an object of pride," "the justification for my failures," etc.). But this inapprehensible body is precisely the necessity that *there be a choice*, that I do not exist *all at once*. In this sense my finitude is the condition of my freedom, for there is no freedom without choice; and in the same way that the body conditions consciousness as pure consciousness of the world, it renders consciousness possible even in its very freedom. (1956, 432)

If Sartre's claim that one cannot be crippled without choosing oneself as crippled may seem far-fetched to some, think of the effort to transform the "handicapped" and "disabled" into "exceptional people."

The body is consciousness in the flesh or consciousness contextualized. It manifests the element of scarcity that makes our choices meaningful as individual choices. Without embodiment, we would simply manifest the anonymous existential choice of being God. Embodiment individuates us into our particular lives and is the matrix of the fundamental choice expressed in particular choices that constitute our *life*.

That the body is never a body by itself but a body living, a body acting amid things and other bodies, sets the stage for the body to be "seen" by others. It would seem that the body seen by others is seen as an object and therefore as a thing, but this is not entirely the case. A body as a thing, as pure corporeality, is lifeless; it is a corpse, in a word, pure past, pure facticity. "It doesn't look like him" is a typical declaration upon viewing the deceased in funeral parlors. Sartre would add—it *shouldn't*, for it, the corpse, is a *thing*; it never has and never will exist itself the way a human being exists his body.

We may, however, consider the following possibility. Grant that it is an error to speak of mind and body. Grant, too, that a body and a corpse are not identical. What, then, is a body? Would not all the philosophical problems posed by physicalism and other efforts to reduce mind to body emerge here since there is a refusal to reduce body to corpse?

Nagel returns. He admits, "The strange truth seems to be that certain complex, biologically generated physical systems, of which each of us is an example, have rich nonphysical properties. An integrated theory of reality must account for this, and I believe that if and when it arrives, probably not for centuries, it will alter our conception of the universe as radically as anything has to date" (51).

I find it interesting that Nagel poses this consideration of alternative points of departure, but remain embedded in analytical conceptions that persist to pose these possibilities in terms of identity relations between *entities*. The existential-phenomenological point of departure with which we are working already has at its disposal a philosophical method of free-variation which calls for the imaging and imagining of such possibilities as crucial for scientific understanding.

The strength in Nagel's position, then, is that it recognizes that "there is a danger of futile reliance on concepts designed for other purposes, and indefinite postponement of any possibility of unified understanding of mind and body" (53). The problem is that he ignores a whole area of philosophical research in that direction, namely, the tradition that grew out of the work of Husserl. That tradition places priority on the noetic dimension of any hermeneutic of the "living" body. A living body—acting upon us, speaking to us, looking back at us—is freedom. "We apprehend the Other as *free*," Sartre declares, "and . . . *freedom* is an objective quality of the Other as the unconditioned power of modifying situations" (459).

The body is always in a situation with the perspective of the Other. There are obvious cases. A couple is in one of its many sexual interludes. The situation looks right. The lights are out. One of the lovers makes his move. His beloved suddenly turns on the light, takes a long look at his lover, and resists. A mundane, sexual situation has been transformed. Now, it may be a situation of seduction. Or perhaps more severe. Now, if the

beloved is a female and the lover is a male, it may be a situation with the possibility of rape, since the definition of rape in common law and most Western statutory law is a penis entering a vagina without the vagina's—the woman's—consent.³³ Or perhaps it's a situation of embarrassment. Suppose the beloved resists his lover's advance because of a realization of how ugly his lover is. Suppose the lover realizes how he is looked upon. He realizes that he is seen-as-ugly. Perhaps he realizes that his fear of being seen—evinced by his preference for conjugal activity in the dark³⁴—has come to pass.

The ability to imagine the perspective of others leads to the third ontological dimension of the body. Our lover is now aware of himself as being seen by his beloved as ugly. This third dimension is fundamental for the development of social roles that constitute our situation. The body is seen by others as beautiful, ugly; crippled; tall, short; fat; sexy; strong, weak; or more broadly, the body of a swimmer, the body of a possible basketball player; the body of a white, the body of a black.

Bad faith should now become clear in the context of the body; it follows all the examples of transcendence and facticity. In bad faith, I deny my body as *mine* through convincing myself that my "real perspective" is my perspective *beyond* my body. We have already seen that the mind-body problem as a lived problem is a form of bad faith. Another, more popular example is Sartre's example of the approached woman. She is on a date with the supposed understanding that the date is without romantic promise. Her date makes his "move"; he holds her hand. She continues her conversation with him as though unaware of his advance; her hand remains in his hand, seemingly lifeless, seemingly without connection to the rest of her body. We can advance this example by supposing that the man places his arm over her shoulder. Suppose she continues to speak as though unaware of his advance. Suppose he kisses her, but she continues to speak as though unaware of his lips on hers. Eventually, we would conclude that the approached woman has taken transcendence to the point of disembodiment.

Of course, the man who forces such a situation on a woman is demanding her to present herself to him as a woman to be seduced. He plays the game of playing a game with her. The question is raised, Is it a form of bad faith to play along with others' bad faith? If the suitor convinces himself that his advances aren't calculated, he is surely deluding himself. What would he say, for instance, if she pulled her hand away and declared, "Now, I told you, this is not a romantic dinner!"? One can readily see how some rapists attempt to rationalize their behavior, say, in the case of a visit that is not supposed to be a romantic visit. If a touch on her hand does not mean to touch *her*, then does this also entail that to penetrate her vagina means not to penetrate *her*? The intuition behind the common law conception of rape is that rape is an act of violence because it is the woman who is penetrated and

who doesn't give consent to the act. To violate her body is to violate her.³⁵

In the case of rape, the project of disembodiment carries an obvious dimension of survival for the victim and effort toward moral purity for the rapist through the degradation of his victim. But there are also mundane situations whose dimension of disembodiment may not be as obvious. For example, the project of disembodiment is sometimes accompanied by the phenomenon of wearing cosmetics. Cosmetics cover up the body and can be presented as the body. It is the body as the body appears. A made-up body presents no flesh: hairs are covered with chemicals; skin is powdered over, or perhaps painted; clothing covers the rest. The made-up person can present himself as a smiling clown although he is conscious himself, underneath, as crying; or the made-up person can present himself as a sad face, although he is conscious of himself as laughing. These dualities in themselves aren't necessarily forms of bad faith. They could be mere modes of deceiving others. But suppose the deception is self-reflected: I am as I am made up to be. I am smiling because my face is presented as smiling. I am beautiful because my face is presented as beautiful. Or perhaps the transcendent forms pretending to be transcendental ones: I can assure myself that others don't know the "real" me in virtue of their contact with the made-up me. Such an assurance hides the fact that I may be taking refuge in this version of me precisely in order to avoid myself in the first place. The very fact of my physical transcendence from others enables me to lie to myself that I "am" transcendence, that I "am" not my body.

Another extreme effort is to steep myself completely into the notion of my body as a causal body, as facticity. Consciousness can determine itself to "exist its body differently, to make itself be clogged by its facticity" (Sartre 1956, 509). My body exists itself as passive, exists itself as "ensnared," exists itself as consciousness "engulfed in a body which is engulfed in the world" (510). My body, under such an attitude, is regarded as pure, thinglike "body," in the sense of mere body among other bodies in space, as pure causal phenomena that overcome me. I can, for example, put myself to sleep and allow myself to flatten out into my own facticity on my bed in a way that makes it difficult to rise—"My body is still asleep!" I might say. To rise, I must, often rather painfully, take hold of myself:

One *puts oneself* in bad faith as one goes to sleep and one is in bad faith as one dreams. Once this mode of being has been realized, it is as difficult to get out of it as to wake oneself up; bad faith is a type of being in the world, like waking or dreaming, which by itself tends to perpetuate itself, although its structure is of the *metastable* type. (113)

As a pure, factual, causal, thinglike body, I move as a determined being. Motion becomes ensnared by factual demands. Sartre's example of the café

waiter in bad faith is rich with descriptions of the congealment of fluid motion that characterizes the body in bad faith:

His movement is quick and forward, a little too precise, a little too rapid. He comes toward the patrons with a step a little too quick. He bends forward a little too eagerly; his voice, his eyes express an interest a little too solicitous for the order of the customer. Finally there he returns, trying to imitate in his walk the inflexible stiffness of some kind of automaton while carrying his tray with the recklessness of a tight-rope-walker by putting it in a perpetually unstable, perpetually broken equilibrium which he perpetually re-establishes by a light movement of the arm and hand. All his behavior seems to us a game. He applies himself to chaining his movements as if they were mechanisms, the one regulation the other; his gestures and even his voice seem to be mechanisms; he gives himself the quickness and pitiless rapidity of things. (101-2)

Examples of the body moving in bad faith are abundant. In the 1970s, the term for "hip" street movement was *bopping*. I once asked a friend why he chose to bop whenever women walked by. His response was that he "naturally" walked that way.

Even the body at rest can be in bad faith. Such a body sinks into its facticity; it drowns itself in a "slimy" form of existence: "The slimy seems to lend itself to me, it invites me, for a body of slime at rest is not noticeably distinct from a body of very dense liquid. But it is a trap. The sliding is *sucked* in by the sliding substance, and it leaves its traces upon me. The slime is like a liquid seen in a nightmare, where all its properties are animated by a sort of life and turn back against me. Slime is the revenge of the In-itself" (777). A slimy body is a deceiving sight: "This is because the being of the slimy is a soft clinging, there is a sly solidarity and complicity of all its leech-like parts, a vague, soft effort made by each to individualize itself, followed by a falling back and flattening out that is emptied of the individual, sucked in on all sides by the substance. A consciousness which became slimy would be transformed by the thick stickiness of its ideas" (778). Such a body pretends to exist by itself, pretends to lay at rest alone, but it is a body that is not only existing itself in a slow, deceptive slide into itself, but also a body in the midst of drawing others into itself. There are many examples of this form of body—the addicted body, the "overweight" body.

Thus Sartre's three ontological descriptions of the body and their connection to his articulation of a *situation* result in the expression of bad faith also as a form of flight from a situation of the body; it is a self-deceiving choice to deny our situation as consciousness-in-the-flesh caught in the gaze of others in the world.

Think again of our two lovers. Suppose the repulsed lover, the beloved, grabs his partner and passionately makes love to what he regards as his lover's

ugly body with the lights on. What are the possible meanings of this situation?

The ugly lover?—"I was mistaken, he doesn't find me ugly."

His beloved—"I do love him, even though he is so damn ugly. I must, for I still desire him. I make love to him."

The ugly lover is aware of the look he saw on his beloved's face. The love-making confirms something, but certainly not the beauty of his body. His situation is denied as what it is, a situation of evasion.

The beloved attempts to flee himself. He posits his desire as a given instead of a choice. Thus it is not, he thinks, that he has chosen to make love to his ugly lover despite his revulsion of him, but that his desire overcomes his revulsion. He is, he might reason, simply in love. Yet even this situation of being "overcome by love" may be flawed, for the sexual act in this instance may be more than it appears to be; it may be the effort to appear overcome by love in order to be loved all the more by his lover. This point is developed in one of the most provocative sections of *Being and Nothingness*: "Concrete Relations With Others."

Sartre categorizes human relations according to three concrete modes of existing: love/masochism, indifference/desire/hate/sadism, and being-with/"we" relationships. All of these, he argues, exist in a circle of bad faith. We have already seen this with desire. Desire militates against a human reality yet paradoxically manifests human reality in so doing. To desire to be is to desire to be a thing; to be a thing is no longer to be a human being; to be a thing for-oneself is also to present oneself as no longer being a human being, but instead God; hence, implicit in all desire is misanthropy—the desire for the destruction of human reality. Since Sartre regards sadism/hate as closely linked to desire, let us begin there.

The road to sadism begins with an indifferent attitude to other human beings as human beings; it is an attitude that regards other human beings as mere objects among other objects in the world. With such an attitude, I become, as it were, the sole consciousness in town. I become either idealist or solipsist.

This comprehension [the Other is a freedom capable of looking back at me] is simply what I myself determine to hide from myself. I practice then a sort of factual solipsism; others are those forms which pass by in the street, those magic objects which are capable of acting at a distance upon which I can act by means of determined conduct. I scarcely notice them; I act as if I were alone in the world. I brush against "people" as I brush against a wall; I avoid them as I avoid obstacles. Their freedom-as-object is for me only their "coefficient of adversity." I do not even imagine that they can *look at me*. Of course they have some knowledge of me, but this knowledge does not touch me. It is a question of pure modifications of their being which do not pass from them to me and which are tainted

with what we call a "suffered-subjectivity" or "subjectivity-as-object"; that is, they express what they are, not what I am, and they are the effect of my action upon them. (495)

The relation to others that emerges is that of master to slave, exploiter to exploited, subject to thing.

Those "people" are functions: the ticket-collector is only the function of collecting tickets; the café waiter is nothing but the function of serving the patrons. In this capacity they will be most useful if I know their *keys* and those "master-words" which can release their mechanisms.

Think of the misogynous notion of "the line." The man who regards women as mere things often seeks the magical words that would *make them* respond to his sexual approach in the form of effect to cause. Yet simultaneously such a man is aware that women are not mere things and, as such, are regarded as *giving themselves* to him in submission to these magical words. He sees himself as the unique cause of their response, but he sees them, perhaps with contempt, as responsible for their response. "She wants me," he might say of a woman who responds to his advance, but he would hold her in contempt for being the kind of woman who would respond to such a proposition. He finds himself manifesting the old Groucho Marx joke of not wanting to belong to a club that would have a guy like him as a member. The mixture of desire and disgust "turns" him on. For the misogynist doesn't seek mere sexual release—otherwise, a plastic sex doll or his own hands would do—but instead seeks a *woman* to dominate. He seeks to force a freedom to submit to a specific mode of being, in this case his interpretation of the "feminine" one that he has chosen for her. "The freedom is there in the flesh; it is freedom which is this flesh since there is a facticity of the Other. It is therefore freedom which the sadist tries to appropriate" (522).

Hence the sadist seeks more than to torture physically the Other. He seeks also the Other's humiliation. The sadist "does not seek to suppress the freedom of the one whom he tortures but to force this freedom freely to identify itself with the tortured flesh. This is why the moment of pleasure for the torturer is that in which the victim betrays or humiliates himself" (523). The sadist takes advantage of the situation of being-for-others as a confrontation of freedoms: "No matter what resistance the victim has offered, no matter how long he has waited before begging for mercy, he would have been able despite all to wait ten minutes, one minute, one second longer. He has *determined* the moment at which the pain became unbearable. The proof of this is the fact that he will later live out his abjuration in remorse and shame. Thus he is entirely responsible for it. On the other hand the sadist for his part considers himself entirely the cause of it." Yet it is the freedom that the sadist seeks to enslave that holds the key

to the sadist's project as a project doomed to failure. In the movie *Blue Velvet*, for example, the sadist Frank kidnaps a woman's husband and child, cuts off the husband's ear, and uses the possibility of further butchery on her loved ones as a means of gaining her submission to him and his degradation of her. Clad in a sparkling blue dress, she sings "Blue Velvet" all night to him in a nightclub. He regularly bursts into her apartment and violently mounts her, grunting, spitting, humping away as hard as he can. Occasionally, she looks at him. He slaps her and screams, "Don't look at me!" The failure of sadism is sadism itself. The sadist must hide from that of which he is aware; in hiding from the Other's freedom, he hides from his own. It takes only the look of the Other to drag his bad faith into betraying the "troubled" consciousness that it is. "Thus this explosion of the Other's look in the world of the sadist causes the meaning and goal of sadism to collapse. The sadist discovers that it was *that freedom* which he wished to enslave, and at the same time he realizes the futility of his efforts" (527).

Whereas the sadist seeks to escape his facticity, the masochist embraces it. The masochist seeks to be a mere object among other objects. He seeks this, paradoxically, because he seeks also to *be* in the fullest sense of being. In seeking his triviality he ironically seeks his importance. Consciousness is always consciousness of something. To be conscious of himself as something, the masochist seeks the eyes of others, or more precisely the Other. To be an eternal object, the masochist needs an eternal gaze from, ultimately, an eternal Other. He learns who he is negatively through the eyes and admission of who he is not. Yet merely to be seen by the Other doesn't constitute masochism. If the situation disgusts me, I can try to escape it—run, close my eyes, or better: *look back*—"Why are you looking at me? What's your problem? Mind your own business!" To "be" a masochist requires the constitution of oneself as masochistic. It requires the choice of masochism. Hence, masochism "is an attempt not to fascinate the Other by means of my objectivity but to cause myself to be fascinated by my objectivity-for-others; to cause myself to be constituted as an object by the Other in such a way that I non-thetically apprehend my subjectivity as a *nothing* in the presence of the in-itself which I represent to the Other's eyes. Masochism is characterized as a species of vertigo, vertigo not before a precipice of rock and earth but before the abyss of the Other's subjectivity" (492).

The masochist confronts the choice, literally, to throw himself completely into the freedom, the nothingness, of the Other. That he confronts choice, his project of giving himself to the Other as a thing is doomed to failure; it requires the masochist's transcendence, his freedom.

It is useless for the masochist to get down on his knees, to show himself in ridiculous positions, to cause himself to be used as a simple lifeless

instrument. It is *for the Other* that he will be obscene or simply passive, for the Other that he will *undergo* these postures; for himself he is forever condemned to *give them to himself*. It is in and through his transcendence that the masochist disposes of himself as a being to be transcended. (493)

The masochist ends up using the sadist as an instrument for his own desire to be an instrument. "Thus in every way the masochist's objectivity escapes him, and it can even happen—in fact usually does happen—that in seeking to apprehend his own objectivity he finds the Other's objectivity, which in spite of himself frees his own subjectivity."

Thus the masochist seeks to be pure flesh and the sadist seeks to be pure consciousness. These attitudes serve as extremes of two other attitudes toward others: love and hate. Love, Sartre argues, is the desire to possess a freedom as a freedom in a special way: for the freedom to choose to possess the lover yet simultaneously cannot help but desire to possess the lover. "In love it is not a determinism of the passions which we desire in the Other nor a freedom beyond reach; it is a freedom which *plays the role of* a determinism of the passions and which is caught in its own role. For himself the lover does not demand that he be the *cause* of this radical modification of freedom but that he be the unique and privileged occasion of it" (479). Thus: "It is in the capacity of an end already chosen that the lover wishes to be chosen as an end." Hence, "to want to be loved is to invest the Other with one's own facticity; it is to wish to compel him to re-create you perpetually as the condition of a freedom which submits itself and which is engaged; it is to wish both that freedom found fact and that fact have pre-eminence over freedom" (480). This desire to be perpetually re-created inflates the conception of facticity of the lover and the beloved. Both are expected to become the world for each other. They become the objective condition of each other's value. "[To] want to be loved is to want to be placed beyond the whole system of values posited by the Other and to be the condition of all valorization and the objective foundation of all values" (481).

Consider some clichés of love. "You mean the world to me"; "Do you love me as much as I love you?"; "I would die without you"; "You don't really love me, or else you would have made the sacrifice of———"; "You don't really love me, or else you would not expect me to make the sacrifice of ———," which amounts to, "You don't really love me, or else you would have made the sacrifice of not expecting me to make the sacrifice of ———"; etc. A lover says, "I love you." He invariably expects an answer. "I love you, too." All open declarations of love are pleas for assurance, pleas that betray a hope to subject the beloved to the lover's freedom. The beloved could respond, "No, I don't love you"; "I love you . . . but not in that way, not in the way you love me"; or, "I love you, too." It is the desire to be loved, the desire to be desired. Love is ultimately the

desire to be protected by way of subjecting ourselves to the possibility of being harmed. In love, we freeze ourselves under the gaze of an Other so as to make ourselves of paramount importance, of seemingly absolute, "objective" value.

With such sacrifice, we reap, according to Sartre, rather exquisite, though futile, rewards:

I can no longer be *looked* at as ugly, as small, as cowardly. . . . My existence is because it is *given a name*. I am because I give myself away. These beloved veins on my hands exist—beneficently. How good I am to have eyes, hair, eyebrows and lavish them away tirelessly [*de les prodiquer inlassablement*] in an overflow of generosity to this tireless desire which the Other freely makes himself be. Whereas before being loved we were uneasy about that unjustified, unjustifiable protuberance which was our existence, whereas we felt ourselves "*de trop*," we now feel that our existence is taken up and willed even in its tiniest details by an absolute freedom which at the same time our existence conditions and which we ourselves will with our freedom. This is the basis for the joy of love when there is joy, we feel that our existence is justified. (482–84; 1943, 420)

It is no accident that God or the Absolute is often equated, by at least Jews, Christians, and Muslims, with love. He wants to be loved by humanity, thereby establishing the relation of love to humanity and the exaltation of the value of human value. Humanity wants to be loved by the Absolute, thereby receiving the gift of absolute importance. The failure and bad faith of the situation rest on its being an extension of masochism—the giving of oneself as an object for the Other in the hope, ultimately, to *be*. The silliness of the project is similar to the silliness of the Absolute's "needing" humanity in the first place. Such need depends on a mode of being that constitutes its transcendence.

Hate is the desire to suppress other freedoms. It is misanthropic. It is an effort, ultimately, to be alone in the world. "The Other whom I hate actually represents all Others. My project of suppressing him is a project of suppressing others in general; that is, of recapturing my non-substantial freedom as for-itself" (533). Like masochism, it is an effort to be protected, but instead of an effort to be protected by way of becoming the world, it is an effort to be protected by way of denying being subject to the world as situation, by way of wiping away the possibility of being seen. The irony of hate is that to suppress others consciousnesses, to deny their freedom, requires the recognition of them as consciousnesses. The failure of hate is that the fact of the Other as a consciousness who looks back at the hater lurks within its very denial.

It is at this point that the role of the body can be more clearly stated. The body is the matrix through which consciousness deludes itself as having an outside and having an inside—the matrix through which consciousness

deludes itself by taking advantage of the dimensions of seeing and being seen.³⁶ Bad faith emerges as the forms of denial that constitute those inherently doomed ways of seeing and being seen as demarcated in our discussion of sadism/hate and masochism/love. It is the evasion of human beings in the flesh.

“Strong” and “Weak” Bad Faith

ON the basis of our discussion of the body, bad faith is an effort on the part of consciousness in the flesh to hide from the anguish of its living as desire, as an unfulfilled, empty being, as a being subject to continuous confrontation with freedom. From the discussion thus far “strong” and “weak” senses of bad faith emerge. Strong bad faith signifies an individual hiding from his own freedom. Weak bad faith signifies the web of beliefs and artifices that constitute the general spirit of seriousness that enables the individual to hide from his and others’ freedom with great facility; it infects the realm of the social by congealing human reality with a prevailing, institutional condition of unfreedom, of the self-denial and discouragement of freedom. Hence we shall also call this “institutional bad faith.”

The institutional dimensions of bad faith, where sociality is infected with a perverse ossification, receive extensive treatments in Sartre’s *Saint Genet: Actor & Martyr*,³⁷ his *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, and his unpublished 1964 *Rome Lecture Notes*. It can be argued, however, that the matrix of bad faith—the situation—makes *Being and Nothingness* a suitable source for our analysis of the institutional dimensions of bad faith.³⁸ Since our concerns are ontological and phenomenological, in the sense of trying to describe the phenomenon of antiblack racism from the standpoint of bad faith, *Being and Nothingness* will remain our primary source. It should be borne in mind, however, that the concept of bad faith plays a fundamental role in Sartre’s work straight through to his tome on Flaubert.

Institutional bad faith locates itself in the collective attitudes built upon the ontological foundations of masochism and sadism—the “us” and the “we.” The us is ultimately a consequence of what Sartre calls the “Third.” Us emerges at the most basic level when two freedoms are aware of themselves as seen by an Other. The “we,” on the other hand, is a function of being the Third. The we is a point of view by which the Other is seen; it is consciousness of others. On the ontological level, both these attitudes suffer from the same problems as masochism/love and sadism/hate, but with a twist.

Those who assume an us as their totality accept their own objectification and hence hide from their freedom. Sartre writes that “The person who says

'Us' then reassumes in the heart of the crowd the original project of love, but it is no longer on his own account; he asks a Third to save the whole collective in its very object-state so that he may sacrifice his freedom to it" (1956, 546). Just as love is an effort to secure oneself from anguish by becoming objective value as an eternal object for another, so too is the motivation for losing oneself in the security of the crowd. In the words of Elias Canetti,

It is only in a crowd that man can become free of [the] fear of being touched. That is the only situation in which fear changes into its opposite. The crowd he needs is the dense crowd, in which body is pressed to body; a crowd, too, whose psychical constitution is also dense, or compact, so that he no longer notices who it is that presses against him. As soon as a man has surrendered himself to the crowd, he ceases to fear its touch. Ideally, all are equal there; no distinctions count, not even that of sex. The man pressed against him is the same as himself. He feels him as he feels himself. Suddenly it is as though everything were happening in one and the same body. This is perhaps one of the reasons why a crowd seeks to close in on itself: it wants to rid each individual as completely as possible of the fear of being touched.³⁹

In offering myself to the crowd, I allow myself to be touched in order to protect myself from being touched. I rid myself of others' "otherness" so as to delude myself of being a body without an outside, a body incapable of being seen. I offer myself masochistically to realize my sadism—my desire for a world without others.

The problem with the we is that the we constitutes consciousness of "me and others"—in a word, *us*. For "we" to be, we must also be *us*. To get out of this circle seems to require being consciousness without an object, a mode of being rejected outright in our ontological framework. The we reflects a desire to be an impartial Third, ultimately a view without a point of reference that can be seen, a view without a body or, better, bodies—a view from nowhere. The we is "anarchic" at its core, unstructured, without bounds—the desire to be without being transcended as an *us* (Sartre 1956, 545; see also 1963, 9). "It is therefore useless," concludes Sartre, "for human-reality to seek to get out of this dilemma, one must either transcend the Other or allow oneself to be transcended by him. The essence of the relations between consciousness is not the *Mitsein*; it is conflict" (555).

Of course, there seem to be exceptions. I sit at a bar. I look across the room and see another patron. I look at him. I want to meet him. I stare at him in the hope that he will stare back. He does. He sees me looking at him. I question him with my eyes—"I am interested. Are you?" He *acknowledges*, simultaneously, that he is aware of my interest and also that he is interested—by a slight movement of his eye-lids, by an inviting raise of his eyebrows, a tilt of his head. We both nod—

"Yes . . .?"

Acknowledgments are variations of team playing. Players nod to each other in basketball games, soldiers nod to each other on the battlefield, couples "nod" to each other to enter the conflict that constitutes "relationships." Yet even this notion of the nod fails. Nodding to another falls under the category of communication and language. But Sartre writes, "Language is not a phenomenon added on to being-for-others. It is originally being-for-others; that is, it is the fact that a subjectivity experiences itself as an object for the Other. In a universe of pure objects language could under no circumstances have been 'invented' since it presupposes an original relation to another subject. In the intersubjectivity of the for-others, it is not necessary to invent language because it is already given in the recognition of the Other" (485).

Although I have offered or thrown myself to the man across from me by way of a nod, that he has accepted or "caught me," so to speak, depends upon him. Even our simultaneous nods of acknowledgment are ultimately in his hands. "As soon as I express myself, I can only guess at the meaning of what I express—i.e., the meaning of what I am—since in this perspective to express and to be are one. The Other is always there, present and experienced as the one who gives to language its meaning. Each expression, each gesture, each word is on my side a concrete proof of the alienating reality of the Other" (487).⁴⁰ The situation of the pick-up, the approach, the exchange, is sado masochistic. I offer myself to the Other. My effort to make my acknowledgment *our* acknowledgment masks the situation of the acknowledgment as a "yes" being out of my hands.

Why do we call institutional bad faith weak? We call it a weak form of bad faith simply because it expresses itself in the system of beliefs manifested by people in their everyday activities, their folkways and mores, and because such a system's maintenance and perpetuation depend on a collectivity of choices that may or may not be efforts to hide from responsibility. It is the solvable presented as unsolvable and the dissolvable presented as undissolvable. For example, Paul Robeson once observed that "In a baseball game, an umpire's decision may be based upon some prejudice *in his mind*, but a state law that makes it a crime for Negroes to play baseball with whites is a statute *on the books*."⁴¹ A white umpire who doesn't want to face his attitude toward blacks in the face of a black who wishes to play can, instead, face his attitude toward law and custom—that he is "compelled" to obey the laws and customs of the land. Under such a circumstance, the umpire may deny that he, as a white, is in a special position to do something about the laws and customs with perhaps less risk than the black who is asking to play. The umpire may claim that he is not individually responsible for the exclusion of blacks from baseball, and that he, although white, is not responsible for *whites*. Sartre has a stinging response to such appeals:

The weakness of the oppressing class lies in the fact that although it has at its disposal precise and rigorous means of coercion, it is within itself profoundly anarchistic. The "bourgeois" [for example] is not only defined as a certain *homo oeconomicus* disposing of a precise power and privilege in the heart of a society of a certain type; he is described inwardly as a consciousness which does not recognize its belonging to a class. . . . It is only when the oppressed class by revolution or by a sudden increase of its power posits itself as "they-who-look-at" in the face of members of the oppressing class, it is only then that the oppressors experience themselves as "Us." But this will be in fear and shame and as an Us-object. (1956, 554-55)

In sum, weak bad faith is a convenient context—group denial—for individuals to hide from themselves. "There is no white-man conspiracy in the United States," a white man may declare. But as we shall see, a black man can respond, "True. But that doesn't mean that antiblack racism is an *accidental* feature of the United States."

"Strong" bad faith is strong precisely because the decision to hide behind the array of bad social beliefs is the responsibility of not only the collective of individuals, but also each individual. Although power is located in weak bad faith, in virtue of the limited options it imposes upon individuals, the inescapability of having to make choices over options solidifies the role of strong, situation-based bad faith.

Some Critical Remarks

THUS far we have explored a number of formulations of bad faith. Our discussion of what bad faith is cannot, however, stop here. A number of important questions emerge.

First, Sartre argues that human reality is freedom. He also argues that human reality as consciousness is always consciousness of something. Is the something of which there is consciousness a determination of consciousness? Would that entail consciousness' no longer being free but instead determined? How does this notion of consciousness comport with Sartre's advancement of the body as a form of consciousness?

Second, how is bad faith possible? A lie to others, as we have seen, has at least the duality of the deceiver and the deceived. The deceiver knows the truth or at least believes something to be the case and is hence not fooling himself. The deceived is simply fooled by another. But in the case of bad faith the deceiver and the deceived are the same person. The duality therefore disappears. Since there is no other person who functions as deceiver, the source of deception must be the deceived. How can this be? The very notion of conscious self-deception seems to go against the grain of common sense.

Third, the notion of human reality as an existential project of desire to be God raises the question of whether it is possible for a human being ever to act in good faith or at least not act in bad faith. How pervasive is the relationship of bad faith to human reality?

How Is Bad Faith Possible?

SARTRE rejects the notion of the “true” self as an ego.⁴² This is because the ego, he argues, is an object of reflection. The “I,” in the sense of consciousness, must therefore “be,” as it were, in the form of pre-reflection. To fool myself, then, would be to place a cloud over consciousness as pre-reflective consciousness. I would have to block the role of pre-reflection in my act of reflecting.

Sartre has argued that in every act of consciousness there is a simultaneous pre-reflective consciousness. This is because reflective consciousness implies self-consciousness. If I am conscious of a table, then the basic requirement of consciousness—being conscious of something—has been met. But suppose I am not aware of being conscious of the table, or anything at all. Sartre’s claim is that I would not be conscious at all. I would be an unconscious consciousness, which is not only a contradiction of terms, but also an experience of not being conscious at all—a freedom without freedom. It is on this basis that Sartre rejects, for example, the classical psychoanalytic notion of the unconscious. The unconscious should not be conscious at all, yet, as he sees it, rooted in the id, it nevertheless resists revelation by the therapist. This is Sartre’s description of the classical psychoanalytic model. His version is obviously simplistic and not representative of Freud’s work on the subject. Like Husserl, Freud was constantly redeveloping his theories.⁴³ Our concern here is not whether Sartre was correct in his interpretation of Freud. Our concern is whether Sartre, within the confines of his system, can show how bad faith is possible.

How is it possible that the unconscious doesn’t resist the decision to go to the therapist but resists the decision to let flow the array of instincts and childhood experiences that constitute its being?

Sartre’s response is that the unconscious must be conscious on some level of what it must resist. An appeal to the unconscious is in effect an appeal to a phenomenon of *two* consciousnesses in a single individual—one, the ego who seeks therapy, and the other, the unconscious who resists it. But this phenomenon doesn’t resolve the questions raised by the concept of bad faith, for we may now simply ask whether the unconscious as a form of

consciousness is conscious of itself and both goes for and resists therapy in bad faith, and whether the ego as a form of consciousness also demands and resists therapy in bad faith. The *patient* must be aware, however subtle this awareness may be, of his situation enough to resist aspects of it. The problem of self-consciousness is, however, more acute.

Let us return to our example of being conscious of a table. If I am aware of being conscious of the table, isn't the consciousness of which I am aware now also an object, just like the table is an object of consciousness? Here lies the possibility of deception. For I and the consciousness of which I am aware are a unity, yet it can be articulated as though I were a plurality. It is the table that constitutes the object sufficient to establish there being consciousness of something. The relation of awareness to reflection is therefore translucent. Awareness or pre-reflection receives its object straight through reflection. I am simultaneously reflecting on the table and aware of being conscious of the table. Sartre expresses the translucency of consciousness by using a parenthetical "of" in his formulation of self-consciousness; one is, for example, conscious (of) being conscious of the table. The "consciousness (of)" is a way of formulating pre-reflective consciousness. The structure of pre-reflective consciousness reflecting on something presents itself as other than itself, as the reflecting side of a two-way mirror, while hiding the perspective that it considers to be its "inside."

Pre-reflectively, I am not anything but pure existence. Yet this condition of lack entails my seeking to be something. Hence, although pre-reflectively I am pure existence or "nothing," I nevertheless formulate my self in the form of being something. This something is a mediation of how I immediately exist.⁴⁴ It is paradoxical in the sense that, as mediated, "I" am reflected as an object to me and am, as we have seen, coextensive with me in the sense of two forms of consciousness' being one. The question of possibility can be reformulated as a question of mediation: how is it possible for me to suppress my awareness of mediating between pure existence and reflection?

The possibility of being both pre-reflective and reflective is not necessarily an ontological problem. Sartre often formulates consciousness or human reality as that which is what it is not and is not what it is. Human reality is built upon contradiction. Hence, trivially, the contradiction implicit in lying to oneself can be conceded as ontologically unproblematic. Contradiction is not a problem for a being whose ontological structure is contradictory. But this position on the problem of lying to oneself doesn't help us much by way of understanding how bad faith is possible because it simply amounts to saying that a contradictory being is contradictory. What it does help us to understand is that a viable description of the possibility of bad faith cannot be one that fails to capture the contradiction of human reality, for in effect it would be the advancement of a being that is different from a human

being. The answer must bring out the clarity of the contradiction itself; it must show how the breakdown of the effort to *be* entails the self-deception of *being* as such.

Human reality cannot be what it is and not be what it is not since only substance can be pure positivity—can be at one with itself. Human reality, however, is always at a distance from itself; human reality is pre-reflectively here but reflectively *there*, however subtle the separation, in its past or its future. Human reality can be pre-reflectively here because “here” carries no mediation; it is not a realm of knowledge but is instead pure existence. The moment I reflect upon “here,” I transcend here because here is also a “now,” which at the point of reflection becomes a “then.” To be *here*, I have to be here *now*. I cannot thus be here upon reflection but instead without reflection.

The immediacy of pre-reflection suggests the following. First, pre-reflection may sometimes lack the distinctness of reflection. Pre-reflective consciousness of an object often brings us in touch with a cognitive encounter with a “somewhat” instead of a “what.” To be in touch with an object on an immediate or existential level connects us with aspects of what the object is not. I look out the window and glance at a man from behind whom I think is Sartre’s famous absent friend Pierre. The man turns around and I realize that he isn’t Pierre. I realize that the man is somewhat like Pierre. In effect, at the moment of my initial glance, what I was immediately aware of was “somewhat-like-Pierre.” My decision that he was Pierre was a reflective one. Awareness can be indistinct.

Second, the immediacy of pre-reflection raises the possibility of pure negativity. Somewhat-like-Pierre is a formulation of the possibility of Pierre and not-Pierre. For human reality this negativity is positive; it is what makes us distinct—that we are not, as we have seen, any of the objects of which we are conscious. Yet somewhat-like-Pierre is not an empty concept; in fact, although not empty, it is not a concept at all in the sense of a mode of reflection. It is an ontological category that Sartre refers to, in his early works *Imagination*⁴⁵ and *The Psychology of Imagination*,⁴⁶ as an *image*, a category that is, in fact, a necessary condition of human reality as freedom. For at this point, we can return to the question of freedom. If consciousness is always consciousness of something, how is it that consciousness isn’t simply behavioristic like a salivating Pavlovian dog? The answer is that although consciousness always requires an object of consciousness, there is an endless array of imaginative (and emotive) attitudes toward the object. These imaginative attitudes come about through the many manifestations of negating—questioning, erroring, hating, fearing, interpreting.

To make an error, I have to be able to regard the object as what it is not. To hate the object, I have to be able also to hope for its disappearance or annihilation. To fear the object, I may hope either for its disappearance or

its transformation into a state of impotence in regards to me or my loved ones. And finally to interpret it, I have to be able to advance its possibilities. Without these possibilities in my relation to the object, I would not only never make false, hateful, or fearful judgments regarding the object, but I would also never be able to *choose* how I look at the object or whether I would look at the object at all.

Pure immediacy seems to be without any object and seems therefore to “be” nothing. But human reality is not, as we have seen, situated in an object-less world. Immediacy is always in touch with the existence and meaningful features of the world in terms of what the world is not. What happens, however, when human reality regards itself imaginatively?

In the imaginative act the world is displaced. For unlike perception, where consciousness encounters the object and is regarded by Sartre as being in a passive condition, the image is *presented* in the imaginative act by consciousness. It is an active mode of being. Hence, when human reality regards itself imaginatively, it is in the process of exploring its possibilities in at least the form of images. Images of the self are images of our situations, images of ourselves as tall, beautiful, sexy, nice, or whatever interpretation of ourselves that we may like as seen by others.

But now we return to our question of the mediation of self-reflection with an added dimension. Are images of the self the result of acts of reflection? Our answer depends on what exactly are the ontological structures of images.

Images, according to Sartre, are not objects in the world. They are not “things,” nor are they “thinglike.” In *Psychology of Imagination*, the example he uses is that of looking at a thing, for example, a chair. When I close my eyes and imagine a chair, I am aware of the image’s not being an actual chair. Failure to appreciate this awareness has been a source of confusion among philosophers, particularly phenomenologists. According to Sartre, the error of phenomenologist philosophers—like Berkeley and Hume—rests on their confusing images with objects in the world. If an image were an object, the question of how I perceive *that* object would emerge. If the answer is that I have an image of that image, the series follows *ad infinitum*. What Sartre doesn’t say in *Psychology of Imagination*, but what is implicit in his claim that we are pre-reflectively aware of images as images, is the conclusion that the phenomenologist may be a figure in bad faith. He denies what he does and experiences, which are that he doesn’t, for example, “see” an image—he *makes one*.

An image in the Sartrean sense is therefore a choice. Its “source” must be spontaneous, for it cannot exist prior to its presentation. Since the image cannot be before it is presented, its ontological station must be that of existence or pre-reflection as well. Yet, an image is not a choice alone, for it is also a choice of what to present. An image cannot be a pure nothing.⁴⁷ In

the image, we have pre-reflection with *form*—we have the “somewhat” of which we have spoken earlier.

The ontological extension of the image, as an act of consciousness, is what Sartre calls the “unreal,” which we can also call nothingness. It is consciousness intending consciousness purely, or consciousness taking flight from the world of objects. Objects are practically “suspended” in such an act. Think, for example, of the activity of composing a story. At first, the room or garden or café in which we compose this story is there, all around us, in its fullness. As we become more involved in the act of composition, more involved in the creative process, aspects of the room seem to slip away into a sort of vagueness. Sounds become less distinct, geometric features lose their sharpness, and colors seem to mesh. At the same time, the world of the story becomes more distinct, yet never completely so. We do not confuse the story’s world with reality. Yet as we become almost completely involved, we seem to lose track of everything around us. Suppose we are interrupted. The distinctiveness of the world returns with abrupt vengeance. We thought ourselves to have been involved in the act of composition for a few moments but we realize that we have been involved in it for quite some time, say, a few hours.

Suppose we are asked by our intruder what we are doing. We explain that we are composing a short story and as it turns out are doing so by way of writing it down on paper. We show our work thus far to our intruding friend, who is marvelled by our originality and who asks,

“Where did you get such an idea?”

What sort of an answer can we provide that would constitute an accurate description of the source of our story in progress? He demands a causal explanation. But would it be accurate to say that the story came to us? Is it that we simply detach ourselves from our surroundings and wait for stories to “leap into our heads,” as it were? Such formulations are ruled out of the philosophy of existence that we have assumed here. Consider them in the context of desire. Sartre writes that “for the For-itself, to be is to choose its way of being on the ground of the absolute contingency of its being-there. Desire therefore does not *come to* consciousness as heat *comes to* the piece of iron which I hold near the flame. Consciousness chooses itself as desire” (1956, 508). If we concede that what we envisage and imagine are what we desire, we can conclude that consciousness imagines itself as imaginary. Thus, the story emanates from us. It emanates spontaneously in the act of creating it. Consider this act of creating. Creating is an effort toward something. At the moment of assuming its being, the presentation, the image, fakes its past. It becomes in its assumed structure over a period of time, however small, not only a thing in the sense of being-in-the-past but also a lie in terms of having-been-as-a-thing in the past:

Motive is raised in terms of the past, and consciousness, by *turning back upon* it, confers on the motive its weight and its value. There is therefore no difference between the choice of the motive of the desire and the meaning of the upsurge—in the three ekstatic dimensions of duration [past, present, and future]—of a consciousness which makes itself desiring. This desire—like *emotions* or the *imagining attitude* or in general all the attitudes of [consciousness]—*has a meaning which constitutes it and surpasses it.* (508; emphasis added)

What imagination and imagining suggest is that there is no complete elimination of the “what” aspect of human reality. We are always aware, albeit on an indistinct level, of some feature of the relationship between existence and phenomena—in short, the world in terms of what it is not and what it is, what it may not be and what it may be. Edward Casey affirms our point in his suggestions for improvements on Sartre’s position. An image, argues Casey, cannot be a nothing precisely because it has meaning and is therefore to some degree connected to phenomena or objects. But to imagine needn’t involve visual imagery. “For example,” he writes, “in imagining *that something is the case*, we need not clothe the projected state of affairs in any specific imagery of a visual, aural, or kinesthetic sort” (163). In an act of imagining, we can take the standpoint of imagining negative attitudes—for example, *how* we are, or *that* we are—without imagining the exact contents of such acts, that is, imagine without visual, aural, or kinesthetic images. The same applies to the emotions. We can “realize affectively certain emotions without feeling them concretely” (Sartre 1956, 435). Such acts, being without appearance, being spontaneous, have the mode of not-being at all. They are, in other words, deceptive.

As an act of consciousness, imagining (and emoting) the self is spontaneous and deceptive. The ego, as we have seen, is regarded by Sartre as an object in the world, as an object of consciousness. People are acquainted with our ego in our many actions that constitute their knowledge of us. The spontaneity of imagining, however, enables us to play with the interpretations of our ego over time at any given moment. We may know our situation as part of the crowd rooting for the home team, but in our cheering we can block everything out but the game—block out our later appointments, block out our overdue bills, block out the drink that spilled on us earlier, block out the terrible domestic dispute that started off the day. We can also simultaneously imagine ourselves as the home team although we are looking at the team. We throw the ball as the player throws the ball and together *we* land the hoop, we make the play, we win the game. We can deceive ourselves because we exist deceptively. Or as Klaus Hartmann puts it, “I am courageous and not courageous, I am any concrete determination and not it, my ideal is the totality of any concrete determination, etc. It is existence,

not essence, which is dialectical" (135). Simone de Beauvoir expresses this phenomenon, the dialectical irony of human reality, thus: "The original scheme of man is ambiguous: he wants to be, and to the extent that he coincides with this wish, he fails."⁴⁸ The leap from pre-reflection to reflection is, in some cases, over a sufficiently short period of time to present the illusion, or perhaps delusion, of simultaneity. Hence, we exist ourselves under the self-imposed illusion of pre-reflective and reflective ossification. I am thus able to "freeze" or "bewitch" myself, so to speak, by existing myself purely in the present by not thinking about my past and evading my future, by transcending my facticity and transcending my transcendence as the approached woman transcends herself so as to hide from the choices she has to make in her situation.

One can thus be in bad faith because of coextensive ironic and ontological considerations. As we have seen in our discussion of belief, human reality exists on an ironic fine line. It can "be what it is not" precisely in order not to be what it is. One can believe in order not to believe, love in order to hate, try to succeed in order to fail, and so forth. Thus, in order to be true to oneself, one also has to be able to lie to oneself; in order to choose one's freedom, one has to be able to deny one's freedom. This ironic stand demands a formulation of good faith.

Sartre advances two forms of good faith. The first, we shall call *ignorant good faith*. It involves believing what one believes, in short, belief without awareness of the belief as a belief. Its form, like sincerity, is that of being-in-itself: "The ideal of good faith (to believe what one believes) is, like that of sincerity (to be what one is), an ideal of being-in-itself" (1956, 115). This form of good faith carries the threat of bad faith since to remain believing what one believes, to remain presenting belief with the posture of knowledge, requires closing off the possibility of questioning one's belief as belief. To *remain* in good faith requires realizing the possibility of being in bad faith. The second form of good faith we shall call *authentic good faith*. This form of good faith requires recognizing one's situation as what it is. It is an attitude toward evidence. Writes Sartre, "Bad faith does not hold *the norms and criteria of truth* as they are accepted by the critical thought of good faith" (113; emphasis added). A similar appeal has been made even from the standpoint of W. V. Quine: "Grant that a knowledge of the appropriate stimulatory conditions of a sentence does not settle how to construe the sentences in terms of existence of objects. Still, it does tend to settle what is to count as empirical evidence for or against the truth of the sentence."⁴⁹ This form of good faith involves making the choice to oneself to treat evidence in appropriate ways conducive to the admission and self-admission of the situation of truth. It is the stand toward evidence that Husserl illustrates in his *Cartesian Meditations* when he writes:

Any evidence is a grasping of something itself that is, or is thus, a grasping in the mode "it itself," with full certainty of its being, a certainty that accordingly excludes every doubt. But it does not follow that full certainty excludes the conceivability that what is evident could subsequently become doubtful, or the conceivability that being could prove to be illusion—indeed, sensuous experience furnishes us with cases where that happens. Moreover, this open possibility of becoming doubtful, or of non-being, *in spite of evidence*, can always be recognized in advance by critical reflection on what the evidence in question does.⁵⁰

From this passage it is easy to see why Simone de Beauvoir argues in her *Ethics* that there is a strong relationship between "existential conversion"—authentic good faith—and phenomenological reduction, since both demand a (reflective) "bracketing" of the spirit of seriousness/natural attitude (14; 1947, 19). In bad faith, one makes the effort to hide from the anguish of authentic good faith by taking an attitude toward evidence that enables one to act as though it were impossible not to have any other form of good faith but ignorant good faith: one is in good faith about what one does not know. In bad faith, then, one pretends to be in good faith about being in bad faith by lying to oneself about being ignorant of one's bad faith. To be ignorant is not identical with being unaware. One can be aware of what one does not know.

The foundation of bad faith, then, is good faith, good faith as a possibility to which one takes an ironic stand, a negative attitude, as a primary mode of being. Maintaining the contradiction, bad faith's ultimate foundation is the posture of good faith in order to deny what it is—that is, bad faith. Likewise, the foundation of good faith is the possibility of its becoming bad. Ontologically, bad faith's possibility rests on the possibility of mediation presenting itself as immediacy. Perhaps some words on what is involved in confusing the mediate with the immediate is in order. Consider temporal analyses, which are correlated with mediacy and immediacy. Part of the problem we have with temporal analyses is our tendency to look at temporal dimensions in terms of spatial ones. The future is regarded as a nontemporal "space," not a time. Thus Sartre's point about living immediacy may seem difficult since we imagine ourselves seeing the other temporal ekstases in their different "spaces." In this respect, our pointing out that bad faith is possible by way of taking advantage of the temporal dimension of human reality is founded, also, on Henri Bergson's observation that we tend to look at time in terms of space—an observation that also has an earlier variation in, of all works, Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit*.⁵¹ Alfred Schutz elucidates Bergson's view with the distinction between the experience of duration (*durée*) and the persistence over physical time that is the hallmark of substance: "While the duration of physical objects is no *durée* at all, but its

exact opposite, persisting over a period of objective time," he says, "you and I, on the other hand, have a genuine *durée* which experiences itself, which is continuous, which is manifold, and which is irreversible."⁵²

Sartre speaks of dialectical immediation and mediation of consciousness as one: consciousness (114). Dialectical mediation is the nothingness, for example, that is neither contained "within" nor "outside" of being. It is the contradiction of being-in-itself. Thus, it is not that the future "is" elsewhere, nor that the past "is" elsewhere, nor even that the present "is" here. If it is an error to regard time in terms of space, it is also a categorial error to regard being in terms of time. We can distort being in terms of time and time in terms of being. Time is a dimension of what being is not. We thus find another formulation of bad faith here—temporal immediation and mediation in the service of evading dialectical immediation and mediation. One can literally live one's imagined self as though living in the present; without the reflection and relation of past to present and without accepting the array of possibilities that can be chosen as one's future, a person in bad faith focuses himself, as it were, on immediacy to the point of attempting to substantiate temporal immediacy, to the point of living, as if in a dream, the unreal.

The Question of Authenticity

Is there not at the base of all decision a decision to decide?

—Maurice Natanson

HUMAN reality chooses itself.⁵³ The essence of human reality—in the sense of human reality being a definite, unchanging thing—is a function of its past. Existence therefore precedes essence; human reality *exists* prior to its “nature.” Yet Sartre has declared that bad faith is an essential attitude to human reality.⁵⁴ How, then, can a human being not be in bad faith? The situation appears moribund, especially given Sartre’s tendency to speak as though human reality doesn’t only face the attitude of bad faith, but also embodies it in the sense of *being* bad faith: “It is very true that bad faith does not succeed in believing what it wishes to believe. But it is precisely as the acceptance of not believing what it believes that it is bad faith. . . . The first act of bad faith is to flee what it can not flee, to flee what it is” (1956, 115). Yet, bad faith’s being identical with human reality cannot be the case, for an identity relation between bad faith and human reality would entail the impossibility of responsibility for beliefs; it would have the same consequence as the demand for ideal belief by making good-faith beliefs impossible beliefs—to accept this notion would be an act of bad faith.

We have already advanced two formulations of good faith. The first one is unreflective belief. The second, authentic form of good faith is the choice of a certain attitude toward beliefs, that beliefs must be subject to some criteria of evidence or, in phenomenological terms, that beliefs must be made evident. What happens, however, when the sort of evidence or “evidencing” sought has to do with an interpretation of my relationship to one of my attitudes? If I recognize my choices as choices, does this mean that I, in effect, choose to choose? If so, what is the relationship of my choosing the choice of choosing? Is the relation of choice to choosing similar to that of reflective consciousness to pre-reflective consciousness?

Although we have been using the prosaic word *choice*, it should be noted that the discussion is also a variation of the phenomenological problem of constitution, and in many respects substitution of the term *constitution* will preserve the points we have been making. A discussion of the phenomenological

concept and problem of constitution calls for a separate work, especially since the concept is understood in terms of the problem. In brief, the problem of constitution is the problem of whether consciousness has a passive relation to a meant object or an active relation to the object's meaning; in other words, whether consciousness is constituted by the meant-object or constitutes the meant-object. Since we are discussing the human being's relation to choice, we can phrase this problem as whether the human being constitutes choice or is constituted by choice. Our discussion focused on the constituting of choice/constitution. We can see straightaway that Sartre's conception of choice differs from colloquial associations of choice with deliberation.⁵⁵

Sartre's position seems to entail the view that to choose is to choose to choose in virtue of my pre-reflective awareness of doing so. But it should be noted that this does not mean that, in choosing, I choose the situation of having limited options available to me. Instead, it simply means that I am aware that I must choose in a given situation and when I actually choose, the choice of not choosing is a self-contradictory option that conceals the act of choosing. Such an effort is a form of bad faith. To recognize my choice to choose implicit in both my option of choosing and my option of trying not to choose is therefore an effort to look my ontological condition straight in the eye, as it were, instead of hiding from it.

But now the question emerges, If human reality weren't fleeing itself, would it still be human?

The answer is negative, for if human reality weren't in flight, it would congeal, become, as Sartre observes, "slimy." It would be a living lie. Although I recognize my choice to choose, it cannot be a recognition that I regard as a once-and-for-all choice. I face a futile situation, for the only once-and-for-all choice I can make without becoming a congealed, slimy, living lie is suicide. Good faith cannot, as a consequence, be a permanent condition. This is the reason why Sartre focuses on bad faith as a means of unfolding his ontological description of human reality.

All human beings face the ironic situation of human reality. To avoid bad faith is to be in bad faith; to cling to good faith is to be in bad faith; to flee oneself is a form of flight; to accept oneself as a being who flees himself is also a form of flight. What can one do?

Our discussion shifts to the question of authenticity. Regarding authenticity, Sartre writes,

If it is indifferent whether one is in good or in bad faith, because bad faith reapprehends good faith and slides to the very origin of the project of good faith, that does not mean that we can not radically escape bad faith. But this supposes a self-recovery of being which was previously corrupted. This self-recovery we shall call authenticity, the description of which has no place here. (116n)

Authenticity is a form of "self-recovery of being which was previously corrupted." It is a form of taking hold of existence from a choice of bad faith. In this formulation Sartre is in keeping with most articulations of authenticity as a demand born from human reality instead of a demand on human reality. On the basis of our discussion of bad faith thus far, this articulation suggests the following. In its most concrete form, authenticity opposes the spirit of seriousness. Recall that the spirit of seriousness involves an attitude toward values as demands on human reality instead of demands from human reality. To provide a theory of authenticity therefore requires a prescription of "therapy" for the serious man. Sartre's response is straightforward. Reveal to the serious man the problems with the attitude he has chosen, and this revelation can be accomplished by way of existential psychoanalysis. The results are three levels of analysis: ontology, existential psychoanalysis, and existential psychoanalytic interpretations of specific actions. Correlated to each of these are the three articulations of human reality as built upon existential choice, fundamental choice, and specific choices.

Existential or original choice is the desire to be God. It is a doomed project founded on the spirit of seriousness. At its core is the very desire to be. The cure for that project is ontology. Ontology "must reveal to the moral agent that he is *the being by whom values exist*" (797). Human reality must be shown that by virtue of its ironic condition it is a choice to be precisely because it lacks being and cannot ever *be* except in the sense of its past, in the sense of having *been*.

Fundamental choice is the choice that manifests itself in a particular life. It is rooted in the situation of consciousness in the flesh and a social world. Using many of the interpretive tools of classical psychoanalysis while substituting bad faith for the Freudian unconscious, the job of existential psychoanalysis is to describe how the choice "to be" manifests itself in one's life. The choice to be may, for example, be the choice to be superior precisely because one finds oneself to be inferior. The project is therefore to hide from one's inferiority through asserting one's superiority. Like existential or original choice, choices of this kind are doomed to failure. They unfold on themselves with vicious irony; in asserting one's superiority, one lays bare one's inferiority.

Specific choices reveal fundamental choice. Existential hermeneutics, which are no more than existential psychoanalyses of a particular action, reveal the fundamental choice operating at this level. For example, Peter "must" go to Yale or Harvard. He applies five times. Finally, he is admitted to one of these institutions on a conditional basis—say, that he does "satisfactory work" after two semesters of study. He doesn't study. He takes a leave of absence. Why? Let us say he goes to Harvard. He reasons thus: he goes to Harvard; therefore he must be superior. But if he has to work hard at his studies, he

must not be equal to superior people who go to Harvard. Superior people supposedly find challenging academic work easy. So he doesn't study. He may claim that the courses don't interest him. Or perhaps he would claim that Harvard hasn't turned out to be as challenging as he had hoped it would be and he has, as a consequence, lost interest. Or he may claim that the courses offered were not the ones he is good at. Why doesn't he leave Harvard? Why does he take a leave of absence? A leave of absence enables him to "be" a Harvard student while not taking courses at Harvard. He reasons that he is a superior student because he goes to Harvard. But what he does not admit to himself is that his leave of absence enables him to avoid being judged as an inferior, average, or superior student. He claims he has a "natural" aversion for those subjects. Eventually, it becomes clear that this person desires to be superior precisely because he is hiding from his own sense of inferiority. He has made a fundamental choice to *be* superior, so he takes advantage of institutional forms of bad faith mentioned in our discussion of weak bad faith in order to hide from his choice in strong bad faith.

Authenticity requires the existential psychoanalytic realization that our values are chosen moment by moment, and all of them reflect some desire to be.

Can we ever *be* authentic?

Perhaps. It is clear that on the existential level we must first exorcise the desire to be God without rejecting desire. On that level, it is impossible to exorcise this desire without contradiction; therefore, we must exorcise this desire in an ironic way. There must be a way to reject existential desire by way of desire. The way out seems to be situated on the level of specific choices. Rejecting existential desire by way of desire must be done on the most concrete level of immediacy—the *moment* of choice. Authenticity awaits us, then, in a godless universe. To achieve authentic moments, we must become either atheists on a pre-reflective level or simply be indifferent to the Absolute on a pre-reflective level.

Overcoming the spirit of seriousness, and as a consequence at least one form of bad faith, involves recognizing our values as chosen. This recognition poses a number of problems. For wouldn't such a realization have an evanescent effect upon the very values chosen? In his *Notebooks for an Ethics*, Sartre has written that "if you seek authenticity for authenticity's sake, you are no longer authentic" (4). Aren't values-realized-as-chosen similar, in effect, to beliefs-realized-as-beliefs? In the case of beliefs, the criterion of perfection crumbles belief into bad faith. What, however, would be an ideal value? Sartre has a bitter answer: "[It] is an ethics which is ashamed of itself and does not dare speak its name. It has obscured all its goals in order to free itself from anguish" (1956, 796). An ideal value has no exceptions—that is, it has the form of a Kantian categorical duty—but in human reality, the

only condition without exception is the condemnation to choose. Hence choice itself turns out to be the ideal value; but, being chosen, it is regarded by the chooser as less than ideal. It is empty and runs the risk of triviality. The irony of value is the fact that its foundation is shunned. Hence to take an authentic stand toward values requires, ironically, not taking our values *too* seriously.

Authenticity requires recognizing that we must choose, but *that* choice-in-itself is vacuous. A "substantialized choice," a choice that is an object of consciousness, has no value-in-itself, since it would be like pre-reflective consciousness' relating to reflective-consciousness *without an object*. Choice-in-itself is always, by itself, less than ideal.

Meaningful choices must therefore be anchored in the situations that constitute our being in the world. But to be authentic they must not be determined by those situations alone. As Charles Taylor puts it, "We need relationships to fulfill, but not to define, ourselves."⁵⁶

PART II

Logic of Racism, Racist Logic

A RECENT THEORY

"IF the people I talk to and the newspapers I read are representative and reliable," writes Anthony Appiah, "there is a good deal of racism about."¹

It would appear that Appiah would be headed in the direction of a structuralist argument, or perhaps an argument which reveals the phenomenological features of what is clearly more than an aggregate of natural or ordinary attitudes. But this is not the case. His approach is an analytical breakdown of the consistent and inconsistent use of various racial terms and their relevance to the autonomy of a rational agent—an agent who makes an effort to eschew contradictory beliefs. In the spirit of his analytical philosophical point of departure, since most people apparently don't know what they are talking about when they talk about race and racism, Appiah hopes to make clear some of the crucial concepts of such discourse. He suggests that "what we call 'racism' involves both propositions and dispositions" (15).

Appiah's project is, in our judgment, a rather limited and limiting approach. He is attempting to chisel through ossified human reality with the wrong tool. We shall examine his theory, however, since it reflects a general misconception of racism that may be posed as a response to our position that racism is a form of bad faith, and that general misconception is that, ultimately, no one chooses to be a racist.

Racialism, Racism, Racialists, and Racists

Whose recovery is more doubtful, that of him who does not see or of him who sees and still does not see? Which deception is more difficult, to awaken one who sleeps or to awaken one who, awake, dreams that he is awake?

—Kierkegaard

APPIAH advances two forms of attitude toward race: racialism and racism. The former is merely an identification of people under racial categories. This identification he regards as fairly harmless, since, he thinks, it is a mere matter of fact: either people are of certain races or they are not. The latter attitude, racism, is more complex and its pernicious possibilities are well known. Racism is not a mere matter of fact but is instead a value. Correlated with each attitude are two forms of individuals, the racialist and the racist.

Racism is broken down into two forms. There is *extrinsic* racism, where people of different races are regarded as having certain features that warrant character judgments of them. Then there is *intrinsic* racism, which involves a form of group loyalty. Extrinsic racism is a form of essentialism where there is room for some level of rational discourse. Intrinsic racism, on the other hand, apparently has no rational basis. The intrinsic racist considers himself obligated to members of his group regardless of their moral character. Thus one should be able to dissuade the extrinsic racist by exposing the falsity of his beliefs—that many characteristics of other races aren't essential characteristics. But the intrinsic racist may not be dissuadable, since there is no counterexample that can be presented against such loyalty. If, for example, bad character among members of his group is acceptable, then even other members' disloyalty against him would not count as reason against such a racist's loyalty.

Appiah objects to both forms of racism on Kantian grounds:

If two people share all the properties morally relevant to some action we ought to do, it will be an error—a failure to apply the Kantian injunction

to universalize our moral judgments—to use the facts of race as the basis of treating them differently. (12; 1992, 18)

It is not clear what these properties are that are “morally relevant to some action we ought to do.” If being a member of the kingdom of Kantian rational beings is one of them, the following passage from Fanon’s *Black Skin, White Masks* may be instructive here:

The psychoanalysts say that nothing is more traumatizing for the young child than his encounters with what is rational. I would personally say that for a man whose only weapon is reason there is nothing more neurotic than contact with unreason. I felt knife blades open within me. I resolved to defend myself. As a good tactician, I intended to rationalize the world and to show the white man that he was mistaken. . . . After much reluctance, the scientists had conceded that the Negro was a human being. . . . Reason was confident of victory on every level. . . . [But] that victory played cat and mouse; it made a fool of me. As the other put it, when I was present, it was not; when it was there, I was no longer. (118–20)

A straightforward problem is Kant’s requirement that in order to respect human beings we must look beyond human beings to abstract versions of them as rational beings.² The whole point of antiracism is, however, to demand that members of the disrespected race be respected as they “are,” in the flesh, so to speak. Sartre first introduced this requirement in his 1948 discussion on Jewish recognition when he wrote, “When it is a question of the legal rights of the Jew, and of the more obscure but equally indispensable rights that are not inscribed in any code, he must enjoy those rights not as a potential Christian but precisely as a French Jew. It is with his character, his customs, his physical traits that we *must* accept him” (147).³ This difference with Kant ultimately rests on the question of the “place” of philosophical anthropology in the philosophical study of morality, a difference located in the conception of the human being—consciousness in the flesh—that we have defended earlier.⁴ It challenges the dualism that enabled Kant to separate moral philosophy from moral anthropology. Kant can, for instance, have a moral misanthrope who can hate humanity to his heart’s content as long as he acts fundamentally from duty-in-itself. That is because the moral law ultimately stands above, in the sense of having priority of value over, human beings. For the humanist who wishes to remain Kantian, the only way out is to situate humanity on a meta-ethical level above the moral law as its constituter, which defeats the whole point of its categorical formulation. It wouldn’t even work to make this meta-ethical level an identity-relation between humanity and the Moral Law, for then humanity would have to be shown to be essentially constituted in virtue of its form, a task

that would be destined to fail in any encounter with embodiments of rationality that are regarded as contingent.⁵ One would have to argue not only that there is a human nature, but also that rationality is identical with that nature; in other words, not only that human being "is" rational being, but also that rational being *is* human being, a conclusion that Kant clearly rejects. In a sense, then, the problem Appiah sees with racism, that it fails to respect the abstract feature of a human being, misses the point about racism that involves hating others in the flesh, which is a failure to respect important, supposedly contingent features of human beings. Rationality is a relation in this scheme from "above" to "below." The racist has no problem with abstract humanity, which he both regards as "above" and concedes is already manifested by himself and his group. We find a similar concern in Fanon's criticism of Dominique O. Mannoni's *Prospero and Caliban*.⁶

He [Mannoni] speaks of phenomenology, of psychoanalysis, of human brotherhood, but we should be happier if these terms had taken on a more concrete quality for him. . . . When one tries to examine the structure of this or that form of exploitation, from an abstract point of view, one simply turns one's back on the major, basic problem, which is that of restoring man to his proper place. (1967, 88)

But Appiah's appeal is to Kant's condition of universality, his second formulation of the philosophical basis of morality. Appiah's appeal to this Kantian injunction is an example of the now commonplace use of Kant as the philosopher of choice in the effort to found a theory of rights that addresses the positive dimension of the moral treatment of persons and, as such, serves as a viable philosophical route for attacking racism. It is ironic in this regard that Kant is a good example of an extrinsic racist, and perhaps even an intrinsic racist.⁷ Kant's racism was evidently based on the physical anthropology of his day. Kant attributed physiological deficiencies to blacks on the basis of the warmer climates in which they lived. It should be noted, however, that implicit in Kant's view is a form of intrinsic racist presumption of *other races*' "abnormalities." The cold climates in which Europeans live are presumed to benefit them. In what sense? Apparently, in making them white.⁸ Thus, Kant was able to spend his eighty years thinking about and developing ideas of universal humankind and at the same time deny full human membership to particular groups of human beings—that is, he objected to membership in practice although he was willing to accept membership in principle, which amounts to saying that he chose to believe pleasing falsehoods that militated against *de facto* universality.

Kant exhibited a sort of passion that suggests he felt that "evidence" of black (and female) inferiority "must be" correct. The inferiority of black people was a living reality for him. This was the case even though there

were blacks in Germany who, albeit few in number, participated in Germany's intellectual and political development. For example, there was Anton-Wilhelm Amo, whose work, *Dissertatio inauguralis de jure Maurorum in Europa* (1729), *Dissertatio de humanae mentis apatheia* (1734), *Tractatus de arte sobrie et accurate philosophandi* (1738), enabled him to teach at the University of Wittenberg, the University of Halle, and the University of Jena.⁹ Whether Kant considered the significance of Amo is a matter for speculation. Given the concerns with racial differences in the scientific and philosophical literature of the period, the existence of a black philosopher, who completed not only dissertations in law and medicine, but also lectured on philosophers about whom Kant shared interest—Leibniz and Christian Wolff—and who played a role in the development of the Wolfian movement to make philosophy more rigorous, a movement Kant paid close attention to, it would be very unlikely that Kant was not familiar with Amo's work, or at least Amo. Knowledge of blacks who contradicted his negative conception of blacks required him to retreat to the racist appeal to exceptional cases or that the information presented must have been false (West 1982, 63). Our discussion of bad-faith attitudes toward evidence applies here: logic stops, so to speak, where contradictions to black inferiority are a concern.¹⁰ It is wise to conclude, then, that the problem of rationality and the problem of universality go deeper than Appiah, and perhaps most philosophers, may be willing to admit.

The problem of racist philosophers is a thorny one, full of complexity, in virtue of the constant demand against prejudice in the practice of philosophy, which often blurs philosophers' memory of the fact that philosophers are human beings. The persistence of racist attitudes among philosophers seems incredulous to those who may regard the discipline as being, in some way, innocent. Consider Michael Dummett's remarks on this problem in the preface of his study on Frege:

There is some irony for me in the fact that the man about whose philosophical views I have devoted, over years, a great deal of time to thinking, was, at least at the end of his life, a virulent racist, specifically an anti-semite. This fact is revealed by a fragment of a diary which survives among Frege's Nachlass, but which was not published with the rest by Professor Hans Hermes in *Frege's nachgelassene Schriften*. The diary shows Frege to have been a man of extreme right-wing political opinions, bitterly opposed to the parliamentary system, democrats, liberals, Catholics, the French and, above all, Jews, who he thought ought to be deprived of political rights and, preferably, expelled from Germany. When I first read that diary, many years ago, I was deeply shocked, because I had revered Frege as an absolutely rational man, if, perhaps, not a very likeable one. I regret that the editors of Frege's Nachlass chose to suppress that particular

item. From it I learned something about human beings which I should be sorry not to know; perhaps something about Europe, also.¹¹

Dummett discovered that the dimensions of people are such that rationality may have dimensions that some of us may consider to be quite nonrational, if not irrational. Black philosophers' experiences of racism in philosophy substantiate Dummett's realization.¹² Consider John Pittman's dialogue in his introduction to a volume of essays by black philosophers, "'Yes, admittedly, philosophers may have been susceptible to the sort of dangers implicit in the practices you have indicated. But this is not distinctive of philosophy; it is rather a general problem of the culture that has been formed by centuries of European and Anglo-American development.' My first reaction to such a response is, admittedly, a mere reflex: 'Where was your absolute standpoint then, when you needed it most?'" (5–6). As Fanon noted in his speech before the First Congress of Negro Writers and Artists in 1956, "Race prejudice in fact obeys a flawless logic. A country that lives, draws its substance from the exploitation of other peoples, makes those peoples inferior. Race prejudice applied to those peoples is normal."¹³ Sartre makes a similar point in his 1964 *Rome Lecture Notes* when he declares that "The colonizer is a moral agent."¹⁴

Although Appiah notes that racist beliefs don't come out of thin air, as it were, Appiah doesn't explore the possibility of racists' voluntarily adopting these beliefs and their doing so with an emotional sense of urgency. Kant, for example, was deeply entrenched in a social and private project; although stated as the scope of reason, it was also the desire for God and a certain kind of humanity.¹⁵ This desire later found expression in the work of Hegel, and then it found its theological and political affirmation in Kierkegaard, its theological rejection but political affirmation in Marx and Nietzsche, and its theological and to some extent political rejection in Sartre. The adoption of stubborn racist beliefs cannot simply be cast off as "irrational," as Appiah suggests when he writes that "Real live racists, then, exhibit a systematically distorted rationality" (8; see also 1992, 14–15). He faces the problem Merleau-Ponty identifies with neo-Kantian and analytical approaches to descriptions of Otherness: "They have validity rather than existence" (1962, xii).

There are already problems associated with the notion of systematically distorted rationality. Where can one go if one's rationality is *systematically* distorted? How do we account for individuals who are *not* distorted? What is the standpoint from which we determine that a form of rationality is distorted *systematically*? Is it that those of us who raise the question already stand outside of a distorted system?

Appiah's position becomes clear with elaboration. He writes, "It is hardly necessary to raise objections to what I am calling 'racial prejudice'; someone who exhibits such deformations of rationality is plainly in trouble" (8). And

later, to the extent that their prejudices are really not subject to any kind of rational control, we may wonder whether it is right to treat such people as morally responsible for the acts their racial prejudice motivates, or morally reprehensible for holding the views to which their prejudice leads them. It is a bad thing that such people exist; they are, in a certain sense, bad people. But it is not clear to me that they are responsible for the fact that they are bad. Racial prejudice, like prejudice generally, may threaten an agent's autonomy, making it appropriate to treat or train rather than to reason with them. (9)

Appiah recognizes that there are people whose racial attitudes may not be changeable by way of rational persuasion. He regards such people as fundamentally distorted—sick—in a way that can perhaps best be categorized as psychopathological. We here bear in mind Fanon's insistence that "The habit of considering racism as a mental quirk, as a psychological flaw, must be abandoned" (1967a, 38). In *Black Skin, White Masks* (11), he urges a *sociogenic* approach, which he regards as recognizing the convergence of the existential situation of an individual amid social forces that may "overdetermine" his significance. The task, in short, is to address the problems between society and the self, the problem of socially situated existence under the force of institutional sites of power or terror. This is precisely the point of examining racism from the standpoint of bad faith: one must address the transcendent and factual dimensions of human reality as a situated reality. Let us, then, raise some considerations in light of our observation that human reality is founded on contradiction, irony, ambiguity, and paradox.¹⁶

Appiah's analysis of the stubborn racist is saturated with psychological assumptions that lead to the call for causal explanations through the question, What causes a racist to have racist beliefs? This is primarily because he examines the stubborn racist in the language of incapacities. Somehow, the stubborn racist seems unable to do something about his situation. His attitudes are regarded as effects of causes that are beyond his control. Here, Appiah's position enters troubled waters.

First, the mere use or expression of racist discourse reflects some form of capacity. But the issue at hand goes beyond the use of racist discourse. We are also concerned with whether one has the ability to stop using racist discourse or not—in short, the ability to change oneself from a racist into a nonracist or even an antiracist—which would raise the question of one's "commitment" to such discourse. Appiah's position on stubborn racism as a form of distorted rationality leads to the rather queer conclusion that rational people are not people who choose or try to adopt unreasonable beliefs. For Appiah, it seems, no rational man could, for instance, embody Kierkegaard's articulation of faith in *Fear and Trembling*, where the paradox of Abraham is his both believing that Yahweh will make him the father of

the Jews through Isaac *and* that he “must” obey Yahweh’s command to offer Isaac as a sacrifice to Yahweh.¹⁷ From Appiah’s perspective, Abraham would be more than faithful. He would also be irrational.¹⁸ Irony, paradox, and contradiction would lose their place in nonpathological human reality. The tragic would condescend to the foolish. As Natanson once observed,

The question at issue, then, is not, Why did an individual do something rather than nothing? but rather, In doing something or nothing what order of commitment is at the basis of decision? . . . The moral issue arises only when the individual is himself confronted in his actual existence with the reality of radical choice. Choosing a life which presupposes the validity of knowledge [or faith] presents the person with the universal [or absolute] image hidden within his individual act: he has chosen to become that being who deems knowledge and reason intrinsically valuable. . . . Furthermore, the very act of existential decision throws into relief the particularity of concrete existence, which otherwise remains taken for granted in the course of both daily life and much scientific investigation. (1963, 22; brackets mine)

Second, Appiah’s view of extrinsic racism as a more rational though limited position than intrinsic racism is also problematic. It doesn’t seem to hold, at least in practice, that an attachment to evidence-in-itself necessarily breeds any more rationality than an attachment to loyalty, especially since loyalty can be advanced as a form of evidence of rationality.¹⁹ It could be argued, for instance, that to be loyal to those who are most like me is no more than a function of the duty to be loyal to or to love myself.

Suppose, however, we advance the following schema. There can be racism by ignorance and racism by choice. Racism by ignorance conforms to a great deal of Appiah’s analysis of extrinsic racism. We expect such a figure to respond with either “I didn’t realize . . .” or “I should have realized . . .” One cannot conclude off hand that such a figure is a “real” racist until that person is given an opportunity to act upon correct information. But as Appiah has observed, there are individuals who resist accepting correct information. No exception to their rule compels them to reject their rule. Does this situation automatically entail distorted rationality, or, if you will, a form of psychopathology?

I once taught a student who worked in a sanitarium. Often, he observed, when white patients were brought in at the point just before “complete break-down,” they would, upon realizing that he is black, unleash a barrage of racial invectives against him. The reason for this, the student suggested, was that they desperately needed to cling to some notion of not being “really at the bottom.” To remind themselves, and their caretakers, that the black worker was the real bottom enabled them to delude themselves about their condition—“No,” they seemed to say, “I am not *that* bad!” What the student’s example also reveals is a dimension of institutional bad faith, that

institutional bad faith makes it all the more easy to hide from choice. The social pariah enables the psychotic pariah to deny his situation. It is unclear whether the patients actually hate black people. Antiblack racism seems to express itself through such people. It is clear that such patients expect "normal people" to do so. Thus their hatred, whether of themselves or others, may take antiblack symbolic form.²⁰ To be abnormal may mean to be black. Thus, "No, I am not *that* bad," could mean, "No, I am not black. I am normal."

The attitude that Appiah speaks of—stubborn racism—isn't limited to psychopathological people like those in the student's example. Stubborn racists are often very "normal" people. Take, for instance, the following two very "ordinary" people, a "mother of five" and a "weary cabdriver":

Maybe it's not really me saying this. I don't want to be that type of person. It makes me less a good human being. A good human being is rational, sensible, and kind. Maybe layers and layers of prejudice has [*sic*] finally got to me. I have such a mixed bag of feelings. I'm always fighting myself. One part of my brain sees all these things and is fighting the other part, which is my real deep, deep-down feeling.

When traffic's beginning to close in on me and I'm behind in my money, I'm really uptight. There's a black driver in front of me, the word "nigger" will come into my head. No matter how much education you may have had, the prejudices you were taught come out. These sinister forces are buried deep inside you.²¹

In the 1970s whole North American neighborhoods—moms, dads, grandmoms, granddads, children, friends, neighbors—came out to throw stones at buses that brought little black children into their neighborhoods to study with their little white children. Today, those same people attend their children's graduations, go to church, go on picnics, and engage in any number of the ordinary activities that constitute North American folkways. Some of them find themselves sending their children off to integrated colleges and their grandchildren to mixed public schools, although many of them have abandoned the now majority-minority public school systems. Had black children not been bused to their neighborhoods, it is possible that many of those people would not have found themselves screaming "nigger!" at anybody, or at least children. The presence of black children in neighborhoods those people came to consider as *white* developed the situation that Sartre regards as the *NO* that forged their identities as advantaged oppressors in this case against the disadvantaged or oppressed, despite their claims to the contrary. Of course, like the individual who cries "reverse discrimination!" the articulation of their situation was twisted. *They* were being oppressed by black progress, or they couldn't help themselves. They saw themselves, in effect, like innocent folk, potential victims in covered wagons surrounded by a

threatening onslaught of "savage" colored presence holding them responsible for past injustices.

We respond to the distorted-rationality description of the stubborn racist the same way Sartre responds to the classical psychoanalytic notion of the unconscious. How do we account for the stubborn racist's ability to be stubborn in a way that enables him to resist particular types of evidence? The stubborn racist who is not psychopathological betrays his ability to recognize the right kind of evidence by resisting them. He is a figure in bad faith. (We may also wonder about the patient's ability to maintain certain norms. Shouldn't the psychotic klansman now embrace blacks?) The stubborn racist is a figure who deceives himself not only about other groups and his membership in his own group, but also about the meaning of his relationship to these identities. These identities are values that close off who he is. He is thus caught in the anguish of constantly choosing his identity by negating his and all others', by psychologically purging himself of his possibilities. The woman who posed the question of whether *she* was "really" thinking racist thoughts faced the ironic situation of not wanting to admit how she felt, or perhaps feels, despite her apparent admission of it—even to herself.

Under the model of bad faith, the stubborn racist has made a choice not to admit certain uncomfortable truths about his group and chooses not to challenge certain comfortable falsehoods about other people. The stubborn racist can be regarded as having made the self-deceiving choice either to believe in his own group's superiority, and therefore his own superiority, the way our serious man of superiority believes in his, or he has made the decision to believe in other groups' inferiority, ostensibly for the same reason. Since he has made this choice, he will resist whatever threatens it—even under the guise of threatening this attitude himself. ("I don't want to be that type of person.") In short, it's not that he isn't "persuaded" by the *logic* of counterexamples; it is that he is unwilling to accept what ordinarily count as counter-examples where questions of race are concerned. He has decided to resist persuasion.

Sartre has pointed out that "With bad faith . . . a peculiar type of evidence appears: *non-persuasive evidence*. Bad faith apprehends evidence but it is resigned in advance to not being fulfilled by this evidence, to not being transformed into good faith" (1956, 113). Consider the case of the Baldus Statistics, statistics that pointed out the racist practices of the Georgia criminal justice system in regards to death penalty sentencing. In discussing the use of the statistics in *McCleskey v. Kemp*, Henry Louis Gates, Jr., sums up what we have been describing as a bad faith attitude toward evidence and the *logic* of counterexamples. He points out that Federal District Court Judge Owen Forrester's

basic objection to the Baldus statistic was that the information it collected “could not capture every nuance of every case.” This is true enough. On the other hand, as an appeals brief noted, “[b]y insisting on a standard of ‘absolute knowledge’ about every single case, [Judge Forrester] implicitly rejected the value of all applied statistical analysis.” Obviously you wouldn’t need these statistics under conditions of perfect knowledge. *Pace* Judge Forrester, the higher courts each accepted the internal validity of the Baldus statistics—or affected to [sic]. The issue became one of its judicial relevance.²²

Other examples of this aspect of racist behavior abound. Fanon identifies it throughout *Black Skin, White Masks*. For the racist, the point is not only that other races are inferior, but also that they *must be* inferior. He is caught up in the *must be* aspect of the serious attitude. He has chosen to be unreasonable. Hence evidence of racial equality must be ideal evidence—absolute, immutable, perfect—which amounts to saying that every single member of the condemned race must be without fault. The requirement is an improbable goal to achieve.

In a synthesis of Appiah’s and Sartre’s language, extrinsic racism is a form of bad faith because it is a demand for ideal evidence where questions regarding the equality and rights of other racial groups are concerned. But extrinsic racism ultimately rests on intrinsic foundations, for when challenged, the extrinsic racist may ultimately have to admit that what he regards as a problem with other racial groups is that they are not members of his group in the first place. This last resort is not as irrational as Appiah may think. We have already pointed out that the intrinsic racist can be a person who regards the basic unit of self-reference to be groups instead of individuals. The self or the *I* as far as he is concerned is his group. To harm them is to harm him, and to harm him is to harm them as well. If this is the case, then he places group loyalty upon the same level as self-preservation. It *is* self-preservation. “One cannot with impunity require of a man that he be against ‘the prejudices of his group,’” says Fanon (1967a, 40). His loyalty to his group stands, then, as a point of self-justified departure. Yet, even this last resort is not immune to bad faith. For even if we assume that one’s racial group is the basic unit of value, it doesn’t follow that the basic unit of value is immune to irresponsibility, error, or blame. Just as an individual’s character can be flawed, so too can a group’s actions. In short, the racist can be in bad faith in virtue of his use of extrinsic racism to conceal his intrinsic racist commitments. He may demand others to provide evidence for their right to exist when all along he has assumed that the problem of their existence is that they are not members of his self-justified group. Appiah’s schema is therefore helpful, but it requires the added dimension of bad faith to articulate a coherent theory of “ordinary”—that is, nonpsychotic—racism.

A similar conclusion is made by Stephen Nathanson.²³ Nathanson points

out that whereas racism is an extreme attitude akin to extreme patriotism, racial loyalty may be similar to patriotic affection. Racial loyalty and patriotic affection don't exclude *other* groups. Since racism is an extreme (calling for the exclusion of other groups), Appiah's analytic breakdown is problematic. He needn't resort to the "truth" of extrinsic racism or "intrinsic" racism.²⁴ As forms of racism, they are already extreme. And how can one reason with an extreme, whether intrinsic or extrinsic? Our conception of bad faith offers a different approach—identifying and demystifying the commitment involved in the racist's resorting to an extreme in the first place.

Yet, even if we were to assume Appiah's view that rational people don't stubbornly cling to unreasonable beliefs, there would still be room for an interpretation of the stubborn racist as a figure in bad faith. We now turn to that interpretation.

Affective Dimensions of Racism and Race

Color prejudice springs not from the stereotype alone, but from an internal psychological state; not from misinformation alone, but from an inner need to believe. It thrives not only, on the obscene witch-doctoring of men like Jimmy Byrnes and Malan, but upon an inner craving for symbolic magic. . . . Hence whatever else the Negro stereotype might be as a social instrumentality, it is also a key figure in a magic rite by which the white American seeks to resolve the dilemma arising between his democratic beliefs and certain antidemocratic practices, between his acceptance of the sacred democratic belief that all men are created equal and his treatment of every tenth man as though he were not.

—Ralph Ellison

APPIAH's analysis of the encounter of race and unreason suggests that we have to be rational in order to be responsible. Thus he refers to the stubborn racist as rationally deformed, in need of help, and probably lacking in moral autonomy. But, we ask, why not simply refer to the stubborn racist as a person who chooses a certain emotional or affective self-presentation to hide from that of which he is simultaneously ignorant yet aware?

It is difficult to imagine a racist who is without some form of emotional or affective response in the presence of the people whom he regards as his racial inferiors. There is, after all, the sense of revulsion or perhaps the sense of being ill-at-eased that the anti-Semite experiences in the presence of a Jew, Israeli, or Arab, or the antiblack racist in the presence of a black, or the homophobe in the presence of a homosexual. For the homophobe, there is the imagined penetration. For example, homophobes often guard their buttocks in the presence of homosexuals. This behavior is rich with meaning. Do homosexuals only penetrate other men? I suspect this behavior to be a gestural version of "Everybody—note: *I am not a homosexual! I don't have homosexual urges!*" One can hardly substantiate the second claim by guarding one's penis. Yet there is an emotional discomfort exhibited in such behavior, a tension in the air. There is a sense in which these men *believe*

themselves threatened by such an Other's presence. The presence of homosexuals seems to awaken these men to the reality of their penetrability. We will take up this matter of the self-denial of penetrability later on.²⁵

Emotionally detached racism or racism without affect seems rather odd, perhaps even pathological. It fits, at best, the sociopath, the type of being who has only an abstract attitude toward other races—"They *are*, simply, inferior," he might say. But such a figure easily falls under Appiah's description of the extrinsic racist. Show him evidence to the contrary. Yet being by definition pathological in the example, he may have no more interest in one piece of evidence than another. A "normal" person may develop the sentiment or passion of concern when evidence begins to peel away the significance of his indifference. So again, why not refer to the nonpathological stubborn racist as affectively self-distorted?

Appiah considers "dispositions." A racist disposition is "a tendency to assent to false propositions, both moral and theoretical, about races—propositions that support policies or beliefs that are to the disadvantage of some race (or races) as opposed to others, and to do so even in the face of evidence and argument that should appropriately lead to giving those propositions up" (15–16). Appiah's use of the term *dispositions*, I suspect, is based on the effort to look at race in terms of natural scientific norms of truth. A metastable consciousness is difficult to grasp, since its goals are irritatingly elusive.

The term *disposition* is loaded with equivocations. This is so because there are many *kinds* of disposition. The term can refer to inclinations to do something, attitudes toward something, or willingness to do something. One can be disposed to act in a certain way in virtue of being willing to do so. Or one can be disposed to do something in virtue of being so constructed; one can supposedly be genetically disposed, for instance, toward violence. A disposition may or may not be a choice. Dispositions may be attitudes that are situated in favor of certain activities. Dispositions also take on various descriptions. They can be emotional, rational, calm, nervous—all of the features that apply to general descriptions of our behavior. Now, we ask, are dispositions suffered or are they chosen? Can they be both? Do dispositions stand before us as proclivities, as the ego, with its set of possibilities, stands before consciousness? Or do dispositions relate to us in such a way that we can act in any way other than those in virtue of which we are disposed, or perhaps predisposed? If there is a true distinction between dispositions and predispositions, how does responsibility figure in terms of either? Am I more responsible for what I am disposed toward doing than what I am predisposed toward doing? If so, what can be said about the initial situation of that manifested predisposition? Is there no such situation? Am I predisposed to do certain things from birth, as in the case of instinct?

Here we have a loaded problem. For the philosophical paradigm in which

Appiah is working is one which situates choice—being the source of action upon an option versus other options of which one is aware—in the realm of the *rational*. He regards choice as solely reflective. Choice is thus linked to truth-seeking activity and reflective consciousness. The stubborn racist's rejection of truth-seeking activity—what we have been calling the norms of evidence and truth—makes him appear to be a figure whose capacity to make choices has been impaired. He is not disposed toward rational assessments of other races.

Is this an accurate model of the relation between human reality and choice—between human reality and itself?

Only, I suspect, if human reality were solely Cartesian, where mind and will are reflective. But even Descartes can be shown to have a more complex theory of the mind and will, as can be seen in his *Passions of the Soul*.²⁶ Although Descartes analyzes the passions in causal terms (see particularly article 45, pp. 300–301), his conclusion is ambiguous. He agrees that the soul can be re-directed from submission to the passions, the proof of which is the fact that animals can be trained to restrain from acting on their inclinations (article 50, p. 305). On this basis he concludes that “Even those who have the weakest souls can acquire a very absolute empire over all their passions, provided they employ sufficient skill in the management and guidance of them.” It is unclear whether the patient in this case decides to seek and to accept the therapy or disciplining that will result in his control of his passions, or simply that the decision is made *ex nihilo* to implement therapy by an anonymous therapist. In either event, Descartes's argument still leaves room for the agent to stand in a free relation to his passions: he may not have “caused” them, but he is certainly responsible for them in virtue of his ability, with effort, to control them. Sartre's argument goes further. Sartre argues that the agent is not only responsible for his passions in the sense of being able to overcome them, but he is also responsible for them in virtue of being their ultimate source. Sartre thus offers a theory that identifies *who* implements the therapeutic process. Since a major aspect of the Sartrean project is to situate both choice and existence on the pre-reflective level, the Sartrean perspective holds the key to an analysis of racism on the existential or pre-reflective level that advances the discussion. If our thesis that the stubborn racist is in bad faith is correct, we should be able to show *how* the stubborn racist is in fact lying to himself about his racist beliefs. How is it that he gets himself to believe such falsehoods, and how is it that he is able to make such choices pre-reflectively?

We will seek our answer in Sartre's view of being in bad faith toward imaginary and emotional presentations. There, it is argued that we can be responsible even when we are not rational. An image, we have shown, is *presented* by consciousness and is therefore a choice. We made cursory sug-

gestions of emotions to be the same. At this point, it will be fruitful to elaborate on the latter.

Sartre has a criticism of classical psychology. The problem with classical psychology is that it treats consciousness as a mere being among other beings, as physics does atomic particles among atomic particles, as being-in-itself.²⁷ Francis Jeanson, in his commentary *Sartre and the Problem of Morality*, elucidates the error: "Under these conditions psychology becomes mental physics."²⁸ Determinism seeps in. Consciousness becomes affected by phenomena the way one being is affected by others in the realm of Newtonian physics. The relationship of emotions to the world is therefore, from such a standpoint, effects to causes.

Another way of looking at the problem with classical psychology is that it is an extensional view of human reality; but human reality, in virtue of its intentional activity, requires also an intensional language for accurate description. This intensional language is the intentional approach of phenomenology.

For the psychologist emotion signifies nothing because he studies it as a fact. . . . Therefore, it will be non-significative from its beginning; but if every human fact is really significative, the emotion studied by the psychologist is, by its nature, dead, non-psychic, inhuman. If, in the manner of the phenomenologist, we wish to make of emotion a true phenomenon of consciousness, it will, on the contrary, be necessary to consider it as significative from the first. (Sartre 1948a, 16–17)²⁹

The psychologist who conflates his subject with physics is charged with the same error as the physiologist who claims to be studying the body. The field of such inquiry is the realm of the dead. Just as the physiologist translates the body into a corpse so as to study it in natural scientific terms, the classical psychologist translates emotions into "facts." This is not to say that there is no legitimacy in studying human beings scientifically. "Predications about human behavior in which man functions as a logical and empirical object are unavoidable in the scientific enterprise. This type of objectification is authentic and is not at issue in the elucidation of alienation. The objectification which produces alienation is of a metaphysical sort, geared to a transformation of incarnated consciousness into a reality other than itself" (Schrag 1969, 146; see also Sartre 1956, 115).

Commitment to an extensional language fails to account for the fact that two different phenomena with different meanings can have the same extension. The classical statement of this view is Gottlob Frege's "On Sense and Reference."³⁰ Although Quine argues that reference/extension requires a language and that the rules of interpreting/translating that language have to be, perhaps even arbitrarily, although preferably pragmatically, chosen, for our purposes the difference between Frege and Quine isn't essential, since

(1) Frege's model helps our view, and (2) so does Quine's since our point is that the extensions don't have to entail particular meanings of phenomena. We differ with Quine on the interpretation of ontology, however. Quine regards ontology as situated in extensional language, whereas from the Sartrean perspective, ontology also involves the study of phenomena that may not have extensions. Ontology has more to offer for the study of such phenomena than the nominalism of their exclusion from reality. This is Sartre's point with regards to the nihilating aspect of intentionality. Quine's focus on extensions leads him to such reductions as "With Dewey I hold that knowledge, mind, and meaning are part of the same world that they have to do with, and that they are to be studied in the same empirical spirit that animates natural sciences. There is no place for a prior philosophy" (26). This is not the place to explain why Quine's interpretation of Dewey is inaccurate.³¹ What is important for our work here is that although Quine's negative criticism of extension suits our project, his constructive project suits us with reservations. Since his concerns with knowledge, mind, and meaning can be studied in terms of their intentions as objects of consciousness, Sartre would have little problem with Quine's scientism. Sartre's point is that certain reductions are necessary for certain kinds of inquiries. But there is place for a prior philosophy in Sartre's work in virtue of his raising the question of how the act of reducing phenomena is possible. Ontology considers not only that phenomena can be reduced to other phenomena, but also what kind of being is both necessary and sufficient for such a reduction to take place and be meaningful. Sartre's answer has been the theme of our work—a being for whom bad faith is a constant possibility. In this sense, Sartre's ontology is richer than the Occam-mania of Quine's. For Sartre recognizes the negative side of knowledge, mind, and meaning as well. In short, science has its own ontological concerns, but ontology itself requires a richer formulation than, What is there? It also asks, among other questions, To what extent is "What is there?" a function of what there is not? How is nothingness possible? What kind of being can formulate the question of existence itself? Why is the relation of a human being to being-in-itself a contradictory matter versus a matter of contraries?³²

The view that emotions are effects of causes in the world requires a change in the world that correlates with each emotion. But, in emotional experiences, the world often remains the same. It is the agent who changes. He has not changed in the sense that one should say that "brain activity" has changed. For even brain activities can each be an extension of a multitude of meanings. What is not captured in the extensional view of emotions is the significative aspect of emotions. Significative phenomena are representative; they point beyond themselves to presentations. "Signification" is sometimes regarded by phenomenologists as "meaning."³³ Schutz sums up signification

when he argues that "A sign is by its very nature something used by a person to express a subjective experience. Since, therefore, the sign always refers back to an act of choice on the part of a rational being—a choice of this particular sign—the sign is also an indication of an event in the mind of the sign-user" (1967, 119). It should be noted that although only beings who are capable of understanding meanings can coherently be called "choosers," it doesn't follow that such beings no longer make choices when they are not rational. Thus Schutz's reference to a rational being states a potential feature of a being that is not at every moment actualized. The extensional view thus fails to appreciate that it is the agent whose emotions are different attitudes toward the world; sometimes these attitudes are efforts of evading the agent's situations and embodying a way of living himself as self-evasion. "We know," writes Sartre, "what the thing signified is from its origin: the emotion signifies, *in its own way*, the whole of consciousness or, if we put ourselves on the existential level, of human reality. . . . It has its essence, its particular structures, its laws of appearing, and its signification. It cannot come to human reality *from the outside*. On the contrary, it is man who *assumes* his emotion, and consequently emotion is an organized form of human existence" (1948a, 17–18). If we correlate emotions with desire, the following passage from *Being and Nothingness* concludes our point:

[The] desire to be by no means exists *first* in order to cause itself to be expressed subsequently by desires *a posteriori*. There is nothing outside of the symbolic expression which it finds in concrete desires. There is not first a single desire of being, then a thousand particular feelings, but the desire to be exists and manifests itself only in and through jealousy, greed, love of art, cowardice, courage, and a thousand contingent, empirical expressions which always cause human reality to appear to us only as *manifested* by a particular man, by a specific person. (722–23)

Consider some examples of being "overcome" by emotions: fainting in distress, panicking in the face of burdensome responsibility, or simply displaying joy in the presence of a visiting friend.³⁴ What these three examples have in common is that they enable the agent to switch the point on which choice is focused in these situations. Instead of handling the problem in a distressing situation, the agent opts for being incapacitated. Instead of assuming a weighty responsibility, the situation becomes a matter of an authority figure showing compassion for a panicking subject—a subject overcome by tears, a fit of hysteria, or nervousness. Even displaying joy may be a form of evasion—perhaps evasion from the possibility of the relationship with a friend now being different from it was in the past or the overwhelming sense of too many decisions to be made upon being reacquainted; a moment's respite is taken in which to think. Joy could also be a declaration to the Other that

one would like to continue where one has left off—a form of “I love you!” which calls for the desire to be, in fact, desired.

It should be noted here that Sartre’s point isn’t reductive. It is true that by appealing to the significative aspect of emotions, Sartre is saying that emotions can be forms of evasion. But this is not all they are. Sartre isn’t trying to claim, for instance, that to be in good faith means to be without emotions. Just as authentic good faith involves recognizing one’s responsibility for one’s attitude toward good faith, an authentic attitude toward one’s emotions involves recognizing one’s relationship to them. It involves recognizing one’s role in one’s emotional activity. There is a world of difference between the declarations “I don’t want to face my future” and “I am unable to face my future.”

Emotion can freeze the present; it can be an effort to delay choice. Emotion can also be an effort to avoid anguish and can be, as such, a form of bad faith. Ironically, as an effort to delay choice it is also a choice, and it thus makes the chosen aspect of bad faith all the more evident. We therefore try to evade our situation by emoting or choosing a version of ourselves that freezes the situation. “Since the subject feels it is impossible to transform the world,” writes Jeanson, “he transforms his own manner of being present to the world. . . . The body’s action ensures our belief either by giving us a new situation or, in the extreme case, by suppressing all situations (fainting)” (1980, 28). Emotion is an effort to transform the world through a transformation of the self. Sartre writes that “It seeks by itself to confer upon the object, and without modifying it in its actual structure, another quality, a lesser existence, or a lesser presence (or a greater existence, etc.). In short, in emotion it is the body which, directed by consciousness, changes its relations with the world in order that the world may change its qualities” (Sartre 1948a, 60–61).

There are many ways to suppress situations, besides fainting. We can choose an identity that is, in appearance, unchosen. Our identity thus becomes one that “happens” to us as wind happens to blow leaves off of trees in the fall. Jeanson suggests the verb “impassioned” (*passionné*) to describe this attitude; he suggests that we impassion ourselves (*l’on se passionné*) for someone or something (1980, 31).³⁵ The impassioned person in bad faith throws himself into an emotional fit in order to take on an identity that enables him to evade himself. He manifests himself excessively as what he is in order ironically to evade what he is. Jeanson speaks of a man who throws himself into water in order to avoid getting damp. We have spoken of the various ironic ways in which we evade situations by seeming to face them. Calling such a phenomenon *metaphysical hypocrisy*, which is tantamount to bad faith, Merleau-Ponty writes that it

is a self-deception by means of generality; it may thereby lead ultimately to a state or a situation which is not inevitable, but which also has not been posited and willed as such. It is even found in the "sincere" or "genuine" person whenever he pretends to be whatever he is without qualification. It constitutes a part of the human condition. When the hysterical fit reaches its climax—even if the subject may have pursued that climax in order to escape an embarrassing situation, plunging into it as into a shelter—he hears *almost* nothing, he sees *almost* nothing, he has *almost* become this spastic, breathless being who flounders on a bed. (1962, 162–63)

Merleau-Ponty provides an accurate description of the stubborn racist whom we and Appiah have been trying to describe. The stubborn racist has placed himself in a general attitude toward members of the race he regards as inferior. His reaction to them is sometimes visceral. Members of other races "cause" certain effects in him. Evidence to the contrary is ignored, though not ignored so far as to make the racist's behavior seem pathological. He needs to seem sufficiently rational to bring across the general differences between himself and "them." He at first regards himself as a system fortified against incompleteness, yet he may also retreat to assessments of incompleteness ultimately to safeguard his position as a self-contained *opinion*. If he were to let rationality too far into the door—the norms of truth beyond himself or his group—then all would be lost, even to himself. He would be susceptible to some form of universality which would require the transition toward inclusion, toward making "them" part of "us."

Thus Appiah is half correct when he describes the stubborn racist as a being who is in some sense distorted. But the distortion is a function of his choice of self-presentation. He betrays a form of maladaptation to a situation by way of being unwilling to face the situation. There is his refusal to face the situation of contacting the Other of another race. The retreat is to the *inferior* mode of being. Sartre concludes that "it is we who put ourselves into a state of complete inferiority, because on this very low level our needs are fewer; we are satisfied, and with less expense. Being unable, in the state of high tension, to find the delicate and precise solution of a problem we act upon ourselves, we lower ourselves, and we transform ourselves into the kind of being who is satisfied with crude and less well adapted solutions (for example, tearing up the paper which gives the statement of the problem)" (1948a, 37). W. E. B. Du Bois has identified this dimension of racist behavior in the United States. Instead of addressing the promethean task of the problems faced by black folk, there is the response of interpreting black folk as the problems themselves.³⁶ Don't support his right to vote; he is a "nigger." Don't deal with your own lack of skills; "they" are stealing your job. Don't (if you are black) deal with the difficult problem of combating racism in the

United States; attack *other* minorities who, you are somehow convinced, are more privileged than your minority group. Do all this (whether you are white, brown, or black) with an angry, self-righteous sense of what "they" are doing to *you*. Low responses to the Other call for lower needs. Thus racism involves a form of moral laziness in the face of institutions that encourage such laziness. In this sense the racist is sometimes regarded as an "unenlightened" individual. Kant, to his credit, writes that "*Enlightenment is man's emergence from self-incurred immaturity.*"³⁷ He adds, "Laziness and cowardice are the reasons why such a large portion of men . . . gladly remain immature for life. . . . It is so convenient to be immature!" Kant's conception of "self-incurred immaturity" is similar to Sartre's conception of bad faith—self-incurred unfreedom. Observe Sartre's description of the anti-Semite in *Anti-Semite and Jew* as "a man who is afraid. Not of the Jews, to be sure, but of himself, of his own consciousness, of his liberty, of his instincts, of his responsibilities, of solitariness, of change, of society, and the world—of everything except the Jews. He is a coward who does not want to admit his cowardice to himself" (53). Both Kant and Sartre are urging humanity to grow up. It is this aspect of Sartre's thought that locates him outside of what has become known as the "postmodern" camp, although there are aspects of modernity that he rejects.³⁸ It is far more difficult to respect—try to know on an equal footing—the Other. One transforms oneself into seeing the Other as unworthy of respect.

But how do we account for the anxiety that may be met by the mere presence of the racially different Other? What produces the "high tension" that invites evasion?

The situation of race is part of a wider situation of racial ideology—what we have been calling institutional bad faith. Thus the Other's "meaning" in racist situations—a social inferior—serves as a ready-made outlet for deeper, immediate efforts at self-evasion. Consider the emotion of anger in the presence of a black. Anger is an emotion that may not at first signify escape. Sometimes it immediately signifies sadism (Sartre 1948a, 44). Suppose the racist in this instance angrily screams "nigger!" He has made his racism known. But note, he makes his racism known, at first glance, precisely in order to make the Other anxious, to place him in a situation of realizing a form of facticity—the institutional meanings imposed upon him, the spirit of seriousness that Sartre calls "practico-inertia" in *Critique of Dialectical Reason*. In this instance, the racist functions much like both the suitor in *Being and Nothingness* who "makes his move" on the date and the antagonist who demands the homosexual to admit that he *is* a pederast; he is forcing a situation that transforms the mode of being under the Look—the mode of being seen—to the Other. In shouting "nigger!" the antiblack racist in this case makes himself seen in order not to be seen, for the "object" present is

the black. Thus the black Other's facticity enables the sadist/racist to fancy himself an evader of anguish precisely by giving the Other a pejorative name which in turn gives the antiblack racist a factual meaning. "I am a racist who shouts 'nigger!'" is just as much a form of flight as the desire for facticity implicit in saying to the Other, "You are a nigger!" It reminds the Other of this: "I, the one who calls you 'nigger,' am not a nigger and am therefore superior to you." The behavior one is expected to live by as a racist is far easier than the behavior one is expected to live by as a human being.

The more the racist plays the game of evasion, the more estranged he will make himself from his "inferiors" and the more he will sink into the world that is required to maintain this evasion. His response to people of other races can increasingly take on, in Sartrean terms, a "magical" evasion. This is because in bad faith there is the affective assumption of a correlative magical world. Jeanson explains, "Corresponding to each emotion there is a world: a world of the horrible, a world of the gloomy, of the 'shifty,' of the disturbing, of the intimidating, etc." (33). And in Sartre's own words,

Thus, man is always a wizard to man, and the social world is at first magical. . . . What happens, then, when the superstructures laboriously built by reason cave in and man finds himself once again abruptly plunged into the original magic? It is easy to guess; consciousness seizes upon the magical as magical; it forcibly lives it as such. The categories of "suspicious," of "alarming," designate the magical insofar as it is lived by consciousness, insofar as it urges consciousness to live it. The abrupt passage from a rational apprehension of the world to a perception of the same world as magical, if it is motivated by the object itself and if it is accompanied by a disagreeable element, is horror; if it is accompanied by an agreeable element it is wonder. (1948a, 84-85)

Just as the imaginary has the correlative unreal world, emotional activity has the correlative "magical" world. Adds Jeanson, "All behavior indicates two perspectives: an act of consciousness and a corresponding world in which that act unfolds and to which it gives meaning. The magical appeals only to the extent it is lived as such, that is, only where there is magical activity of consciousness" (33). In short, consciousness is able to take advantage of the fact that there are many ways to see the world, many ways to live it. In a passage from *The Emotions* that is reminiscent of our discussion of the body, Sartre concludes,

In order to understand clearly the emotional process with consciousness as the point of departure, it is necessary to bear in mind the twofold character of the body, which is, on the one hand, an object in the world and, on the other, something directly *lived* by consciousness. We can then grasp the essential point: emotion is a phenomenon of belief. Consciousness does not limit itself to projecting affective signification upon the

world around it. It *lives* the new world which it has just established. It lives it directly; it is interested in it; it endures the qualities which behavior has set up. . . . In other words, consciousness changes the body, or, if you like, the body—as a point of view on the universe immediately inherent in consciousness—puts itself on the level of behavior. (75–76)

The problem, then, is that what may be an initial evasion can transform itself into an ongoing, lived reality. In this respect, racism bears the typical marks of abusive relationships.³⁹ For example, citing his colleague Marilyn Crist's pedagogical approach, Henry Parker identifies the following characteristics of abusers. Their main defense is denial, they have low self-esteem, they are brutal yet self-righteous, they are "serpent-like" underneath, and they are influential in the sense of wielding power in abusive situations.

Racism, just like all other abusive relationships, is *lived* by its participants. The racist can sink into his emotions under the guise of his facticity; he can live himself as a being determined by them. He lives his attitude as belief.

The agreeableness [or disagreeableness] of the object which was just given to me exists as an exigence much more than as a reality; it has a sort of parasitic and tributary reality which I strongly feel. . . . True emotion is . . . accompanied by belief. The qualities conferred upon objects are taken as true qualities. Exactly what is meant by that? Roughly this: the emotion is undergone. One cannot abandon it at will; it exhausts itself, but we cannot stop it. (Sartre 1948a, 73)

Like sleep, once "undergone" as a mode of living, emotional fits ensnare us in a "condition" from which it is difficult to ascend. It has to take its course unless an external force "snaps" us out of it. But for the *general* attitude of racism, the emotional evasion is left on reserve for the moment of contact with the object that is regarded as a cause of exigency.

Perhaps an illustration will bring the point home. Racist appeals can come to the surface in rhetoric as well as bodily displays. We have already seen the housewife whose affective response to the type of person she would like to be shifts the question from her attitude toward blacks to her attitude toward herself as almost incapable of thinking otherwise—as a victim, that is, of racist attitudes. When it comes to the rhetoric of race, some writers shift to more emotional rhetorical devices whenever members of the disdained race are mentioned. For instance, in her polemic on the violent antics of the New Left, Hannah Arendt's style and penchant for hard evidence shift quite a bit whenever her discussion focuses on blacks:

In America, the student movement has been seriously radicalized wherever police and police brutality intervened in essentially nonviolent demonstrations: occupations of administration buildings, sit-ins, et cetera. Serious

violence entered the scene only with the appearance of the Black Power movement on the campuses. Negro students, the majority of them admitted without academic qualification, regarded and organized themselves as an interest group, the representatives of the black community. Their interest was to lower academic standards. They were more cautious than the white rebels, but it was clear from the beginning (even before the incidents at Cornell University and City College in New York) that violence with them was not a matter of theory and rhetoric. Moreover, while the student rebelling in Western countries can nowhere count on popular support outside the universities and as a rule encounters open hostility the moment it uses violent means, there stands a large minority of the Negro community behind the verbal or actual violence of the black students. Black violence in America can indeed be understood in analogy to the labor violence in America a generation ago; and although . . . only Staughton Lynd has drawn the analogy between labor riots and student rebellion explicitly, it seems that the academic establishment, in its curious tendency to yield more to Negro demands, even if they are clearly silly and outrageous, than to the disinterested and usually highly moral claims of the white rebels, also thinks in these terms and feels more comfortable when confronted with interests plus violence than when it is a matter of nonviolent "participatory democracy."⁴⁰

And there we have it. "Violent," "unqualified," "standards-lowering" blacks versus "disinterested" "white rebels" with "usually highly moral claims." For our purposes the falseness of Arendt's position isn't the point; it is her choice of terms that betrays her attitude/emotions. Arendt's attitude toward blacks in her other works, particularly her work on totalitarianism, has left me with the impression that she regards blacks as a cancerous threat, a form of pollution to white civilization, whose presence nauseated her. It should be noted that I am not interested in hurling any charges of racism against Arendt generally. Her published work reflect only a portion of her life. However Arendt may have regarded blacks outside of her published work is another matter; my point here is only that in her public work, she betrays herself as a rather high-cultured, intellectually gifted, stubborn racist.⁴¹

Appiah's position is thus limited in either direction, for the racist retreats into bad faith and is therefore responsible, under both rational and passionate self-presentations. What Appiah fails to notice is that it is at this point of emotional breakdown—the hysterical frenzy of lynch mobs, rioters, witch hunters, and other forms of displaced mania—that the kinds of interventions he writes of, interventions designed for the "sick," are clearly relevant. In such cases force/treatment is necessary for people who have gone or are about to go "too far." In terms of racist people's general attitude toward other races, the intervention needed is more of the existential "sociogenic" sort, which requires recognizing their role, their responsibility, in the

perpetuation of their attitude on the one hand and also recognizing the institutions designed to encourage such self-deception on the other. Granting their responsibility for their attitude, practical efforts of prevention can be implemented without the constraints upon actions designed for pathologies. "Sick" people cover a narrower parameter than ordinary people; the majority of "ordinary" people can be held accountable, from an existential psychoanalytic standpoint, for the preservation of situations that serve as opportunities for attempts at dehumanization. The reason why those whites who protested against bussing in their neighborhoods were responsible for the education of black children as well as their own is not because of "past" racial injustice but because of their role in maintaining those injustices and their role in setting the stage for future injustices. The current segregated, unjust distribution of resources in the U.S. public school systems substantiates our point.

Fanon has written that

The black man's alienation is not an individual question. Beside phylogeny and ontogeny stands sociogeny. . . . Let us say that this is a question of sociodiagnostic. . . . Man is what brings society into being. The prognosis is in the hands of those who are willing to get rid of the worm-eaten roots of the structure. . . . Any unilateral liberation is incomplete, and the gravest mistake would be to believe in their [individual and social] automatic interdependence. (1967, 11)

Fanon later adds, "A Given Society is racist or it is not" (85). In this sense, Fanon would agree with John Rawls that the subject of justice and (racist) injustice is the basic structure of the society itself.⁴² So, in regards to Appiah's relegation of racism to less-rational souls, it pays to note that this does not make them less responsible. But even in regards to Appiah's, Kant's, and even Rawls's rational souls, we should also note Sartre's observation that "Our worthiest souls contain racial prejudice."⁴³

How do we respond to the claim that racialism is fairly harmless?

In our introduction we pointed out that broader conceptions of race are needed than the traditional anthropological categories of caucasian, negroid, and mongoloid. This is because in practice races are *constructed*.⁴⁴ For example, there are multitudes of white races. The recognition of various groups of whites as "different races" often rests on political foundations, and the degree to which racialism reflects a purely descriptive concern—whether there "are" different races or not—stands on shaky foundations. If we take seriously the notion of difference as a criterion for race, we would soon discover ourselves on the metaphysically problematic road of singular essences. Each of us would embody our own race, and the number of human races would be identical to the number of past and present human beings—a conception of "race" that is, if not self-contradictory, at least incoherent.

What racialism hides is the fact that we *value* these differences as differences, a conclusion for which Appiah provides some examples of support (1992, 14). To understand racialism, we need also to investigate the passionate motivations behind constructing races.

Consider the racial extremes of our study: blacks and whites. There are no *black* people in the sense of people who are the *color* black. What does it mean to argue that people are black? Their blackness is built upon the presupposition of whiteness. But the same goes for whites. There are no people—even albinos—who are *white*. Black and white are, in fact, one step away from the ontological extremes of the relatives dark and light. The actual extreme of both is the same: blankness or nothingness. Dark and light are most likely phenomenologically apparent; to admit what we see when it comes to these “races” often involves seeing brown and pink—to “see” black and white requires an embellishment of reality that constitutes regarding it in the mode of the unreal. It is an act of magic. In the context of blacks and whites, at least, the racial categories are functions of the racism.

Our Sartrean position is on the other pole of Appiah’s. Appiah writes, “So far as theory is concerned I believe racialism to be false: since theoretical racism of both kinds presupposes racialism, I could not logically support racism of either variety” (1990, 16). Appiah rejects racism because he thinks it depends on a false concept—racialism. The logical form of his argument is the classic *modus tollens* argument in formal logic. In effect, he says, “If *p*, then *q*; not-*q*; therefore not-*p*,” where *p* stands for both forms of racism and *q* stands for racialism. We have been arguing that it is the other way around; racialism depends on racism. Appealing to the same formal logic, we say that *p* stands for racialism, but *q* stands for racism. Thus to reject *p* does not logically entail the rejection of *q*. And the rejection of *q*? Such logicism surely violates the spirit of a Sartrean look at our subject.⁴⁵ The resolution of our logical face-off with Appiah depends upon a deeper theory of what is going on with racialist theories.

Our position is that racialism also accompanies the search for biological moral difference. The order isn’t temporal; it isn’t that one succeeds the other. It is that one is a function of the other. It is the existence of one that calls for the logic of the other. Thus one can attack racialism and preserve the desire to differentiate groups in such a way that turns out to be racist; with time the condemned group will be given a name. In Richard Rorty’s words, “Concepts do not kill anything, even themselves; people kill concepts.”⁴⁶ It is *people’s* attack on racism that may loosen the logic of racialism.

Our difference with Appiah thus takes the form of Sartre’s classic response to traditional philosophical anthropology.⁴⁷ Whereas traditional philosophical anthropology seeks man in his definition, Sartre’s philosophical anthropology reminds us that man’s existence precedes his definition. By treating his

definition as preceding his existence the racist is, in effect, a serious man. What is implicit in Appiah's use of the oblique term *belief* is that he ultimately regards racialist definitions as leading to the existence of certain values toward certain differences; that may be the reason why he ultimately rejects racialism. Like Appiah's view, the Sartrean view regards both extrinsic and intrinsic racisms, as well as racialisms, to be problematic—but for different reasons. The Sartrean position raises the question of racism as a form of bad faith since it is a form of evasion of human reality. Although racialism is a function of racism, it does not follow that there cannot be authentic recognition of the institutional fact of these categories.⁴⁸ Their reality, however ontologically suspect, and perhaps even embarrassing, is a function of that which is significative; thus they hold a tale that is rich with ambiguity. Despite the falsehood of racialism, Appiah's philosophical anthropology arrives at its limitations in its failure to articulate the authentic contexts in which such falsehoods acquire some sense of legitimacy. One can authentically say, "There goes a black man," especially when the context is, say, a heated discussion over whether such men are now extinct.

PART III

Antiblack Racism

RACISM AND ANTIBLACK RACISM

WE now look at antiblack racism from the standpoint of Sartrean bad faith. Bad faith is the effort to hide from human reality, the effort to hide from ourselves. From the standpoint of bad faith, racism is the ossification of human reality into a monadic entity identical with any one aspect of its assumed duality. The racist is a figure who hides from himself by taking false or evasive attitudes toward people of other races. The antiblack racist is a person who holds these attitudes toward black people. What is the nature of these attitudes? The answer to this question will afford us a hermeneutic of antiblack racism.

We have pointed out that racialism is a form of value built upon racism. We therefore assert that one of the attitudes of an antiblack world is that white people and black people are essentially white and black. People in between are sometimes regarded as either more black or less white, though such subtlety of difference seems to be present only in "black" societies. For the most part, whiteness is pure, and all others are colored down the line to the blackest. The initial encounter with this attitude does not automatically entail one's being in bad faith. But the preservation of this attitude is a form of bad faith. A child may be shown that one person is white and another is black. But for the child to live with this distinction requires an uncritical attitude toward these distinctions that can transform his attitude, as he goes on in years, into bad faith. This is because the distinctions themselves cannot sustain the force of existential criticism. The adult who introduces racist notions may be a figure in bad faith.

We have already noted that there is a sense in which there are no black bodies or white bodies. There are dark and light ones. I remember a toddler running up to me one time in terror: "Help!" he said, "There are black people in my room!" As it turned out, he inferred that black people—those people about whom he had apparently heard so many negative things—were shadow people. He caught a glimpse of shadows in his room. I explained

to him that I am black and that he is black too, but he pointed to a pair of black shoes and alerted me to my error.

Thus already we can reassert that blackness and whiteness are projections. But eventually, blackness and whiteness take on certain meanings that apply to certain groups of people in such a way that makes it difficult not to think of those people without certain affectively charged associations. Their blackness and their whiteness become regarded, by people who take their associations too seriously, as their essential features—as, in fact, material features of their being. We have seen that taking values as material features of the world is an example of the spirit of seriousness.

There are obvious problems with the “logic” of racial difference. If one group of people is determined by its difference from another group of people, what characteristics count as major differences versus minor differences become a matter of valuative determinations. “Brown people,” for example, can be people who are more dark or less white. Minor differences among a number of groups can become major differences between pairs of groups. Problems emerge when the logic is based upon difference-in-itself. We have seen that the process of elimination would continue until eventually the criterion of similarity becomes singular essence, where similarity is based upon the principle of identity, and where an individual would only be similar to (because identical with) himself.¹

It should be noted at this point, then, that black people and white people needn't have been the historical black and white people. As long as a group defines itself as white in such a way that it becomes the standpoint from which other races are judged on the basis of the degree to which they are less white, a slippery slope downward begins until the unreal figure of blackness looms at the point beyond which there is only nothing. Since, however, there is also a point beyond whiteness which is also nothingness, the ascription of whiteness also becomes unstable. The result is that there may very well have been black people even if there were no Africans. Antiblack racism exists against Australian aborigines, for example. It is useless to point out the *genetic* differences between aborigines and Africans, for the hereditary interest is a function of the racism, not the other way around. Some Europeans are, for instance, more genetically close to Africans than to other Europeans. Our point needn't be limited to aborigines. “I have mentioned the fact that mixed-blood Indians in areas where they hardly ever see Negroes refer to their full-blood brothers as ‘niggers,’” observes Erik Erikson, “thus indicating the power of the dominant national imagery which serves to counterpoint the ideal and the evil images in the inventory of available prototypes.”² It is no accident that nineteenth-century photographs of American Indians betray darker people than those of today. Miscegenation with whites was encouraged among Native Americans, primarily for reasons of survival since they were

marked for extinction by the European settlers. Miscegenation also occurred between Indians and black former slaves. Miscegenation offered a way for Indians not to be seen at all. From the antiblack standpoint, Indians mixed with blacks are simply black and those mixed with whites are simply "less colored." Rejecting Jung's notion of the archetypal primitive black in every man, Fanon, in concert with Erikson, writes, "I think Jung has deceived himself. Moreover, all the peoples that he has known—whether the Pueblo Indians of Arizona or the Negroes of Kenya in British East Africa—have had more or less traumatic contacts with the white man" (1967, 187). Readers in doubt of Fanon's claim need simply consult Tzvetan Todorov's *The Conquest of the Americas* for a detailed, gory history of the European confrontation with Native Americans.³ The contingency of the African situation is also argued for in Eulalio Baltazar's analysis of the fusion of economics, religion, and race in *The Dark Center*.⁴ Jan Pieterse's *White on Black* offers a discussion of the British view of East Indians and the Portuguese view of the Japanese as "niggers." Apparently with British rule, all of native India was provided the Third who enabled them to gain the perspective of the "dark" Shudras (Untouchables).⁵ For our purposes, what counts is the association of *darkness* with lowly and dark people with lowliness. Whether spiritual, moral, or material, the consequence is the Dark Other. This conclusion even applies to cases where it would seem that there was no color at all—blindness. The notion of presence-hot-whiteness and absence-cold-blackness applies. There are, as Stevie Wonder attests in his description of his childhood memories, "white sounds" and "black sounds."⁶ For our purpose, what matters is that in all these cases there is the notion of being colored, being dark, as a mark of inferiority.

There may, then, very well have been white people even if there were no Europeans. And there may very well have been black and white people even if there were no people who resemble (morphologically) the people whom we now recognize as black and white people. This suggests that black people and white people are contingent realities of our world, which reinforces our view that the notion of their "naturalness" is a form of spirit of seriousness.

As a form of racism, the first premiss of the antiblack world is that white people are superior to black people. Such an assumption has an impact on the integrity of interpretations of the black body and the white body.

White and Black Bodies in Bad Faith

RECALL our discussion of bodies in bad faith. The body has at least three characteristics. It is the perspective of consciousness. It is seen by Others. It is consciousness' perspective of being seen by Others. Correlated to these three characteristics are two dimensions of bad faith. There is the form of bad faith that affirms the first characteristic of perspectivity but denies the other two. This is what Sartre means by sadism and hate—consciousness' denial of being body. Then there is the affirmation of the second and third characteristics, but denial of the first. This is consciousness' denying transcendence, consciousness' claiming to be only an object for Others. This is what Sartre means by masochism and love. We can call these bad-faith attitudes toward the body, respectively, bad faith against facticity and transcendence, *Presence* and *Absence*.

What happens when the human species is split into a duality of white and black?

The result is a Manichaeian world of the comfortable untruth of material goodness and evil embodied in people who are respectively the lightest and the darkest. This untruth is comfortable because of its simplicity; one can approach evil as one can approach the problem of cleaning bacteria from water. A masked effort of denial is required to preserve such duality, since the duality is a projection onto the human species which calls for human beings to be what they are not. This masked effort also requires the motivation of a passion or interest in preserving the duality. This passion develops into all of what William James calls the "sentiments" of truth and rationality.⁷ James points out that there is a sort of feeling of truth and reason that accompany arguments and other forms of "rational" activity. Our point is that we can also develop this feeling in bad faith. The untruth of race is a lived reality precisely because many of us have learned to live it, passionately, as true. In our discussion of the relationship between racism and racialism, we pointed out that this passion is racism itself.

The point at which the value "superior" is attributed to one and the

value "inferior" to another is the point at which each group becomes a deep or ontological denial of human reality. For one group would receive whatever value is placed upon the factual dimension (Presence) of human reality, and the other group would receive the value of transcendence (Absence).

It would seem at first that the dominant group would choose the value of Absence in such a distribution of value, since it may wish to maximize its freedom. But this doesn't seem to be the case in antiblack situations. Quite often, although dominant groups may wish to maximize their liberty, they may also wish to deny their responsibility in the face of such liberty. The duality is therefore more complex in a way that makes Presence become absence and Absence become presence. Let us consider some illustrations.

Let us assume that black people receive the value of Absence. Their mode of being becomes existence *manqué*—existence gone wrong. Their mode of being becomes the being of the NO. Consider the following passage from Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man*:

I am an invisible man. No, I am not a spook like those who haunted Edgar Allan Poe; nor am I one of your Hollywood-movie ectoplasm. I am bone, fiber and liquids—and I might even be said to possess a mind. I am invisible, understand, simply because people refuse to see me. Like the bodiless heads you see sometimes in circus sideshows, it is as though I have been surrounded by mirrors of hard, distorting glass. When they approach me they see only my surroundings, themselves, or figments of their imagination—indeed, everything and anything except me.⁸

Here Ellison's protagonist describes the black experience of absence, the sense that Fanon describes of there being something absent whenever blacks are present. The more *present* a black is, the more absent is this "something." And the more absent a black is, the more *present* is this something. Ellison's description is much like Sartre's description of the sadist walking among others as mere beings in the world, others being no different from mere physical objects—except that Ellison's description is from the standpoint of the people ignored in such denial. Invisibility is part of the traditional chattel roles of blacks in slavery and blacks in colonial societies. Blacks, in this formulation, are regarded by antiblack racists as mere objects of the environment, mere things among things. The Invisible Man's invisibility comes about in virtue of the denial, by virtue of the pervading norms of black inferiority in Western societies, of his humanity. In this formulation, then, the black's absence fails to translate into his *human* presence.

Now let us look at another experience, one that may on the surface seem to be different:

"Dirty nigger!" Or simply, "Look, a Negro!"

I came into the world imbued with the will to find a meaning in

things, my spirit filled with the desire to attain to the source of the world, and then I found that I was an object in the midst of other objects. (Fanon 1967: 109)

Fanon's problem seems to be a problem of his presence. He is *seen*. Wherever he goes, he is seen by everyone, including himself, when he catches himself, as a black. An oddity. A danger. He is congealed into the "fact of blackness":

"Look, a Negro!" The circle was drawing a bit tighter. I made no secret of my amusement.

"Mama, see the Negro! I'm frightened!" Frightened! Now they were beginning to be afraid of me. I made up my mind to laugh myself to tears, but laughter had become impossible. . . .

Then, assailed at various points, the corporeal schema crumbled, its place taken by a racial epidermal schema. In the train it was no longer a question of being aware of my body in the third person but in a triple person. . . .

I was responsible at the same time for my body, for my race, for my ancestors. I subjected myself to an objective examination, I discovered my blackness, my ethnic characteristics; and I was battered down by tom-toms, cannibalism, intellectual deficiency, fetichism, racial defects, slave-ships, and above all else, above all "Sho good eatin.'" (112)

We may note Fanon's declaration of making up his mind to laugh himself to tears. He was caught in the realization of the futility of his option to choose an emotional response as a form of evasion. Laughter had indeed become impossible—as "genuine" laughter.

Fanon's situation is ironic. He is seen in a way that *Frantz Fanon* is not seen.⁹ He is evaded. Missed. He is not seen in his individuality. To see him as black is to see enough. Hence to see him as black is not to see *him* at all. His presence is a form of absence. Like Ellison's *Invisible Man*, the more present he is, the more he is absent. Fanon and the *Invisible Man* both suffer, then, from being Absence; they seem to suck presence into themselves as a black hole, pretty much like the astrophysical phenomenon that bears that name.

As a destruction of presence, he is even a language-eater: "The Negro arriving in France will react against the myth of the R-eating man from Martinique. He will become aware of it, and he will really go to war against it. . . . A Martinique Negro landed at Le Havre and went into a bar. With the utmost self-confidence he called, 'Waiterrr! Bing me a beeya'" (21).

Large-scale symbols of blackness, for example, the "Dark Continent," suffer the same: "A great many countries have been present in their time at the heart of our concerns," writes Sartre. "But Africa, for many of us, is only an absence; and this great hole in the map of the world lets us keep our conscience clean" (Sartre 1974a, 187).

The black body lives as Absence.

Since we are working in a duality of Presence and Absence, the white body is presumed to live itself as Presence. But does this mean that the white body cannot also be transformed into Absence?

We return to our first premiss of antiblack racism: the white is superior to the black. What this premiss suggests is that the white's existence is justified, whereas the black's existence needs justification. The black's existence lacks something. This entails whites being, ironically, full presence *and* the standpoint from which others (non-whites) are seen. In Sartrean language, this would mean that whites are, in an antiblack world, the in-itself-for-itself. Whites are Freud's "prosthetic God."¹⁰

The result would be that when a white is absent, something is absent. There would be a lacuna in being. But when he is present, his presence would be felt by Others. Unlike the Invisible Man, his body lives as *his* body. He can become known *in-himself* (as human being). His facticity is not masochistic. Although he is *Presence*, he is not an object. How is this possible?

The response is that there has been a coordination between individual bad faith and institutional bad faith. There is institutional affirmation of what whites claim to be and institutional denial of what blacks deny being. Thus the white's facticity becomes his transcendence, and the black's transcendence becomes his facticity.

This usurpation of transcendence and facticity, absence and presence, in individual human beings has unusual implications for the Sartrean categories of concrete relations with others.

Recall that love, for example, is the desire to be desired. If whites are in-itself-for-itself, then to be white means to be simultaneously the object of one's own desire. Whites are therefore already desired by whom they desire. Blacks, on the other hand, being Absence, being pure lack, become raw desire.

It would seem that, being raw desire, blacks should be the source of value in an antiblack world. But this possibility is usurped by the presence of an "objective value"—*the white is superior to the black*. The black finds himself situated in a serious world. To be valued means to *receive* value outside of blackness. It means to be valued by a white.

A strange hierarchy of values emerges. Antiblack societies are also patriarchal societies.¹¹ To be most valued means to be valued by someone who is both white and a "man." (We use *man* instead of *male* since man has a broader meaning. One can stand for a man, as do some females in patriarchal roles.) To be less valued is to be valued by someone who is white and a woman. To be even less valued is to be valued by someone who is black and a man. And to be least valued is to be valued by someone who is both black and a woman. The categories of brown fall along similar lines from the lightest male to the darkest female.

At this point, it may seem that we agree with Calvin Hernton's suggestion that the black man's maleness and the white woman's whiteness are two levels of existence that balance each other out onto an egalitarian plane.¹² We reject this view, however, primarily because of the considerations we will pose later on in our discussion of blackness and effeminacy. No matter how much the black man chooses to be a man, an antiblack world may still refuse to recognize him as such. But although a white woman may be denied recognition as a male, she faces a different situation when she demands recognition as white—particularly if the circumstance is against a black male. Black males and white females do not, therefore, stand on equal planes in an antiblack world.

To be desired by a black woman is denigrated as a presumed desire. But to be rejected by her is the ultimate insult in an antiblack world. Hence blacks desire to be desired by whites, and they desire not to be rejected by blacks.

The ossified duality requires that the black body is Absence (of human substance) and the white body is Presence (of human substance). Hence to look at a black body is to look at a mere being-among-beings. The black body is, as Fanon observes, "*overdetermined* from without." The black body lives as a form of human deficiency.

The white body, being human (Presence), doesn't live as mere being-among-beings. It lives with the potential to be a being that stands out from mere beings. Its being-in-itself ironically enables it to be a being-for-itself. The worlds of the black and the white become worlds separated by Absence leading to "fate" on the one hand and Presence leading to "freedom" on the other. Put differently, the former lives in the world of the WHEN and the latter lives in the world of the WHETHER.

The black body: when will I make a mistake? When will my wrongness come to fruition?

Fred, the antiblack racist in *The Respectful Prostitute*, has already declared the thesis of the dialectic: "A nigger has always done something."

The fallacy is set in motion. Commenting on the lynch mob's pursuit of The Negro in that play, Fanon declares the fallacy's conclusion:

"A feeling of inferiority? No, a feeling of nonexistence. Sin is Negro as virtue is white. All those white men in a group, guns in their hands, cannot be wrong. I am guilty. I do not know of what, but I know that I am no good" (139).

I am black. I have therefore committed a crime. I am black. I know what is the problem with my black body. It exists.¹³ I therefore "am" a crime.

"As a sentencing factor, race ranks with prior conviction for rape, armed robbery, and even murder. The race factor here isn't merely statistically significant, it is, as you might think, downright determinative" (Gates 1992, 333).

The black accused needs only to be “seen” to be guilty of a prior offense. His color is the evidence. He is guilty of blackness.

The black child learns what to do *when* he is approached for shoplifting, *when* he is approached for assaulting another, *when* he threatens the welfare of white children, *when* he is stopped by the police. This moment of being stopped by the police, this (it seems) inevitable moment, stands waiting out there like fate.¹⁴ For the black adult, this *when* is transformed into DON'T. DON'T jog, for he might be mistaken for a criminal in flight; DON'T walk through areas that appear affluent, for he might be mistaken for a burglar; DON'T shop with his hands in his pockets, for he might be presumed shoplifting or, worse, concealing a weapon; DON'T drive an expensive automobile, for he might be presumed to have stolen it; DON'T even consider behaving ambiguously in public with a white spouse.

Black bodies have an array of expressions predicated upon white views of blackness and black interpretations of white views of blackness. The ones predicated on whiteness range from what black folk call “too, too black” to those referred to, among blacks, as “acting white.” Black views of blackness have a multitude of expression according to black cultures. What is important about these two forms, however, is their being firmly rooted in the second and third descriptions of the body: both of which are rooted in the body as seen. The problem is that the third, the body known as seen by others, is linked to the first, the perspective of the body. Hence what antiblack racism demands of the black body is for it to live as its second ontological characteristic at the expense of the first and the third—to be a body without a perspective.

From such a standpoint, physical or mechanistic explanations are standard procedure. The familiar litany of biological explanations of black behavior substantiates this point: the black athlete is good *because* he is black and therefore genetically designed for extraordinary physical feats—feats that are at least extraordinary for normal human beings. The black's supposed sexual prowess is a matter of his biological structure—his penis and his animal passion, for instance. Being a body that desires to be seen, the black body lives on a fine line between Absence and orchestrated Presence. It disciplines itself to be *incognito*, to blend in with its environment on the one hand, and at other times it grins, dances, leaps, twirls; it exaggerates itself. Its existence is always superfluous. Since its problem is that it exists, its efforts to justify its existence always miss their mark.

And what does antiblack racism demand of the white body?

The white body is expected not to be looked at by black bodies.¹⁵ This is because the black body's situation of being-without-a-perspective cannot be maintained if blacks are able to unleash the Look.

There was a period in the American South when, for blacks, looking a white in the eye carried the risk of being lynched. Calvin Hernton reports,

for example, an infamous case of rape by “reckless eyeballing” that occurred in Mississippi in the 1950s: “The Negro was on one side of the street and the woman was on the other side. She screamed. What happened? ‘That “nigger” tried to attack me.’ ‘But he’s way over there across the street going in the opposite direction!’ ‘Why he *looked* at me as if he were going to attack me.’ The Negro was arrested, tried, and sentenced!” (27). As absurd as this case may be, the white woman in the example exemplifies a point: The Look is sadistic. Thus the Negro had, indeed, attacked her, apparently, simply by looking at her. That this case represents a form of distorted rationality under other interpretations (for example, Appiah’s) shows the limitation of excluding the evasive aspects of affect from interpretations of human reality. Sartre’s conception of the Look and his analysis of efforts to evade the Look bring out the deeper meaning of such encounters—particularly in an antiblack racist one of rape by “reckless eyeballing.” Even if the Freudian angle of the woman taking advantage of the situation of racism for the sake of being “rescued” by the community were taken, Sartre’s point is that the evasion itself relied on a logic that legitimated the rescue—again, that the Negro overstepped his bounds simply by looking at her.

Although the white body is regarded as Presence, it lives the mode of Absence, and it offers, instead, its perspective as Presence. In other words, the white body is expected to be seen by others without seeing itself being seen. Its presence is therefore its perspectivity. Its mode of being, being self-justified, is never superfluous. Unlike the black, whose transformation from Absence to Presence poses a threat to the precarious balance of reality, the white is already Presence and therefore poses no such threat—except, perhaps, in his absence. This is because, as once pointed out by William James, there is no more reality than what there is.¹⁶ The conclusion, then, is that reality is threatened by the *inclusion* of blacks, whereas reality is jeopardized by the *exclusion* or *diminution* of white presence.

The obvious flaw in this logic built upon an identity relation between whiteness and Presence is that all human beings are present and, being human, are also beings to whom and in virtue of whom the world is presented. They are also simultaneously absent. The ontological situation of humanity hasn’t changed under the interpretation of blacks as Absence and whites as Presence. What happens here is an affective appeal to an imaginary, “magical” version of the world that suits the desired duality. This magical appeal is antiblack racism.

Black Antiblackness in an Antiblack World

FROM the premiss that in an antiblack world the white is superior to the black, we went to our second premiss, that whiteness must be regarded as self-justified in such a world. This leads to the corollary that blackness must be unjustified. If blackness cannot support its own existence, then we ask, What happens when blackness reflects upon itself? What happens when Absence reflects upon Absence?

The general problem of bad faith is raised by Sartre when he considers the possibility of consciousness reflecting its negation upon itself. If consciousness is a function of nihilating objects, then the possibility of consciousness' attempting to nihilate itself is raised. Is there a similar situation when blackness reflects its blackness as Absence upon itself?

Consider the black use of the word *nigger*. The *Dictionary of Afro-American Slang* offers a definition of the term and a theory of what is going on when blacks use the term:

Nigger: (possibly from the French *nègre*) when used by a white person in addressing a black person usually it is offensive and disparaging; used by black people among themselves, it is a racial term with undertones of warmth and good will—reflecting, aside from irony, a tragicomic sensibility that is aware of black history.¹⁷

There are many apologists for the word *nigger*. Yet the situation seems clear: if it is offensive when whites use it, how can it not be so when blacks do?

The *Dictionary of Afro-American Slang* seems to have taken the apologist's position, that there is something "tragicomic"—nay, even noble ("a tragicomic sensibility")—in black people's use of this term. Their absence status cancels negative apperception.

From the racist standpoint, the black body as embodied lack is a body of raw desire emanating away from itself. Since non-blackness is the aim of such desire—given that desire seeks to be something and blackness is presumed

here to be a form of nothing—then blackness is regarded, even by the black, as the antithesis of fulfillment in an antiblack world. For the black to seek himself as a black seems to be a warped desire to frustrate desire. The result, as one might imagine, is that some blacks would regard themselves as the epitome of ugliness, horror, and malevolence: “Sin is Negro as virtue is white.” The black who regards his body as a black body, as a repulsive body, as, ultimately, *pure, unformed matter*, has taken a transcendent position toward his body. His body is frozen under the force of the Look, the force by which his body ends up standing in relation to itself as the Other. The point of perspective becomes separated from itself; the perspective gained in the flight from the black body is the assumption of non-blackness. The black, in such an instance, is able to exist as denial, is able to regard his body as not “really” his.

Being ultimately regarded by black and antiblack racists as a body without a perspective, the black body is invited to live in such a way that there is no distinction between *a* particular black body and *black bodies*. Every black person becomes a limb of an enormous black body: THE BLACK BODY. A special form of negation emerges. Liberation from the black body becomes liberation from blackness. There is already a form of frustration in concrete sexual relations. Desire from the white body—“love” in the Sartrean sense—does not redeem the black body. No body can be redeemed, if by redemption is meant an existential conversion of recognizing oneself as a human being and human reality as a source of value, by way of flight to a serious world. Another possibility is to take the pseudo-authentic line of “awareness.” Call a spade a spade and take advantage of the duality of the black body as a construction of institutional bad faith and the black body as a situation faced by every black person. Like the man who throws himself into water in order not to get damp, the black can throw himself into blackness in order to evade whatever features of his blackness that he most fears. One form of emersion is language.

“Nigger” points to the fatalism of the *ultimate Other*. “Niggerness” is the lowest denominator; it robs itself of most human possibilities—freedom, value, self-awareness. The very act of *saying* nigger reflects a consciousness which distances the ascription of “niggerness” to the speaker—even when he uses the term as a self-referential term. “I am a nigger!” simultaneously declares, “I must not really be a nigger precisely because I am aware of myself as a nigger *in the eyes of everyone*—as a nigger *out there*, in the world, not *here*, in my soul!” “Nigger” is forever situated in the third person; *they* are “niggers,” *he* acts like a *nigger*; I can act like a *nigger*—which is an Other -- but I can never *be* “nigger” or “niggerness,” only “a nigger.” “Niggerness” emerges as a universal category that alleviates responsibility. “Niggerizing” the world hides one’s shame for one’s own “niggerness.” Thus, even referring to whites

as “niggers” is a form of bad faith. It is the effort to universalize “niggriness” to the point of not being uniquely the meaning of it. If everyone can be a “nigger,” then there is nothing particularly degrading about my being one. A black who unleashes the term “nigger” is saying to himself, “I am not a nigger.” Or, since the image of a “nigger” is a black—even when the term is hurled at a white, which amounts to saying that such a white is too black for his own good—the black who uses it can also be interpreted as saying this to himself, “I am not *that* kind of black, I am not a nigger” or “I am not a typical black, I am not a nigger” or “I am not one of *those* blacks, I am not a nigger.” No one is pro “nigger.”

Such a black is mired in self-denial. He knows who “niggers” are. Geneva Smitherman has argued, from the standpoint of semantic linguistics, that in black English, “nigguh” is correctly understood as “both black and white, male and female, or any group whose labour is exploited.”¹⁸ Smitherman shares Fanon’s and our view of the exploited dimension of the fact of blackness. Yet, her appeal to black English has a number of serious flaws. We have already seen some of the flaws in identifying whites as “nigguhs.” But more, Smitherman’s conception of black English rests on the shared understanding of black English among blacks across class and ethnic lines. Black English is thus regarded as a monolithic conception of blacks that makes them one with a particular cultural identity. Aside from the multitude of black cultural identities across the language spectrum of English, Spanish, and French—even within the territorial boundaries of the United States—there are also the varieties of English among blacks as well as among whites. Even though it is not Smitherman’s logic, such a conception of language would hardly have a viable response against a *genetic* determination of black discourse. But even if we focus on the social determination of black discourse in terms of her claims on the *use* of “nigguh,” an ironic aspect of its conflation is missed. “Nigguh” doesn’t really mean *any* exploited individual. The application of “nigger”/“nigguh” to exploited individuals signifies their being treated *like* the group toward whom exploitation is considered justified. And who might that group be? If other folks are black when they are exploited, who are blacks when blacks are “superexploited,” since to be exploited is a presumed mark of blackness? And when do blacks appear not to be an immediate situation of exploitation? Blackness and exploitation are far more complex phenomena.¹⁹

Implicit in taking this “nigger”-signifying attitude is a slide down a very slippery slope into the illusion of extreme non-blackness. Since the black who unleashes the word “nigger” against other blacks has adopted an antiblack standpoint on human reality, the human vantage point available to him from which to deprecate the “nigger” is “non-blackness,” which turns out to be whiteness since he lives in a world troubled by a false dilemma: one is ultimately either white or black. On one level, his response appears unreflective.

Only for the white man The Other is perceived on the level of the body image, absolutely as the not-self—that is, the unidentifiable, the inassimilable. For the black man . . . historical and economic realities come into the picture. . . . [When I think of myself as positive, it] is not I as a Negro who acts, thinks, and is praised to the skies. . . . I suggest that those who are interested in such questions read some of the compositions written in French by Antillean children between the ages of ten and fourteen. Given as a theme “My Feelings Before I Went on Vacation,” they reacted like real little Parisians and produced such things as, “I like vacation because then I run through the fields, breathe fresh air, and come home with *rosy* cheeks.” It is apparent that one would hardly be mistaken in saying that the Antillean does not altogether apprehend the fact of his being a Negro. . . . It may perhaps be objected that if the white man is subject to the elaboration of the *imago* of his peer, an analogous phenomenon should occur in the Antillean, visual perception being the sketch for such an elaboration. But to say this is to forget that in the Antilles perception always occurs on the level of the imaginary. It is in white terms that one perceives one’s fellows. (Fanon 1967, 161–63, n. 25)

Fanon’s example of Antillean children’s writing reveals a facet of the relationship between universality and imaginary worlds. The counterfactual aspect of imagination enables one to live one’s delusions through suspending time perception.²⁰ Yet certain norms of validity are chosen—in this case, the notion of white people being the embodiment of positivity. But human reality is also *negative*. Thus in phenomenological terms what Fanon’s example reveals about the Antillean situation, considered as the situation of blacks in an antiblack world, is that human being *intended* is white. But man is pre-reflectively nothing. The intention, posed as a definition of what it means to be human, is a denial of the ontological significance of pre-reflection. It is a form of bad faith.

Fanon has unmasked the reasoning. The world has a duality of good and evil that eventually situates itself as powerful and weak, oppressor and oppressed. It defies “nature” to place power in the hands of evil; therefore those with power, those who oppress, must not really be evil. Those who are oppressed must be evil; on some level, they must *deserve* their oppression. Harold Cruse provides a stinging commentary on this form of reasoning in *The Crisis of the Negro Intellectual*.²¹ He observes that lurking within many forms of black nationalism, which he thinks is particularly acute between African Americans and African–West Indians, is a form of blame-the-victim antiblackness. These groups avoid self-criticism by attributing conformism and prostration to “*other* blacks.”²² From the standpoint of this form of reasoning, to avoid being evil, being weak, being oppressed, I must commit the positive act of identifying those who deserve to be punished, those who are evil, those who are weak, those who ultimately choose their oppression. The relation becomes like

that of sadist to masochist, with the only perspective, of course, being the sadist's.

The black who calls blacks "niggers" assumes the self-deceiving stance of a white foundational ego behind consciousness—an ego which he regards as *de facto* Presence. "Moral consciousness implies a kind of scission, a fracture of consciousness into a bright part and an opposing black part. In order to achieve morality, it is essential that the black, the dark, the Negro vanish from consciousness. Hence a Negro is forever in combat with his own image" (Fanon 1967, 194). We can add, in order to see his image as an object, he sometimes presumes a non-black, supposedly pre-reflective stand. If this is so, then it is not, as Jung thought, that every man is black on the inside, but that every man is, when he cleanses himself of prejudice as best he can, white. But the effect here is to make the notion of "man" a notion whose core is saturated with bad faith. The "nigger"—signifying black becomes like the "Indian serfs and African slaves and mulattos who prayed to white saints to show that they belonged to the race of the masters" (Baltazar, 1973, 34). He doesn't want to be oppressed, so he plays the role of an oppressor in the hope of becoming an oppressor—which holds the delusion of not being the oppressed—a role that, in the antiblack perspective that dominates his world, is best suited for a white man. He reasons, in virtue of his assumed role, that deep down inside he is white—white in his teeth, white in his bones, white in his soul. But the role is a troubled role, for he *knows* he is not white. It is through "magic" that he has betrayed blackness by rooting, as it were, for white forces, by imagining himself as a white soldier in the battle of the races. The irony of his situation is that the very effort to transcend his blackness makes him "blacker" than ever. Assuming an antiblack stand makes blackness low, how low can he step beyond betraying himself by supporting that which militates against his humanity? "Nigger!" preserves the racism which he hopes to evade by reenforcing it. His sadistic effort to deny his body makes *his* body, a black body, more apparent. He steepes himself in his own facticity.

Yet the black who uses "nigger" isn't all that ironic. His blackness permeates him to the point of his having no excuse; he doesn't seriously maintain the position that he is not black. His situation falls from the ironic, from even the tragic, to the pathetic.

A white man enters an elevator and discovers that he stands as the only white amid a dense forest of blacks. "Gee," he says, "I didn't realize that there were so many blacks working here."

His comment may puzzle the others in the elevator. Hasn't he been among blacks before?

Suppose instead the lone white man had rather stupidly said, "Gee, I didn't realize there were so many niggers working here." Why would this declaration be offensive?

The offense of a white using the term "nigger" in the presence of blacks rests upon what such a situation manifests—an acknowledged state of war against blacks. It is no accident, for instance, that "nigger" is shouted during racial attacks, during efforts to *degrade* the black, to "let him know his place," to torture him, to kill him. Since the black who uses the term "nigger" has appropriated what he thinks is a white consciousness of himself, he too has taken an acknowledged state of war against blacks in his situation—including himself. What are the antiblack manifestations of this stance?

The following letter was written, purportedly by an anonymous klansman, to a black inmate in Chicago:

The Ku Klux Klan would like to take this time to salute and congratulate all *Gang Bangers*, all *Alcohol Drinking Abusers*, and all *Drug Users* for the slaughter of over 4,000 black people since 1975. You are doing a marvelous job. Keep killing each other for nothing, the streets are still not yours . . . it is ours. You are killing each other for our property. You are killing what could be future black doctors, lawyers, and businessmen that we won't have to compete with. And the good thing about it is that you are killing the youth. So we won't have to worry about you niggers in generations to come. We would further like to thank all the judges who have oversentenced those niggers to prison.

We are winning again. Pretty soon, we will be able to go back to raping your women because all the men will be gone.

So you *Gang Bangers*, *Alcohol Drinking Abusers* and *Drug Users* . . . keep up the good work. We love to read about drive-by shootings. We love to hear how many niggers get killed over the weekends. We can tolerate the niggers with jungle fever (for now). . . . Because that further breaks down the race.

To all *Gang Bangers*, *Alcohol Drinking Abusers* and *Drug Users* across the world: We don't love you niggers, but we can appreciate you. You are doing a wonderful job in eliminating the black race. Without the men. . . . your women cannot reproduce. . . . Unless of course, we [do] it for them. Then we will have successfully eliminate[d] a race, thanks to your help and commitment to killing each other.

If most of you nigger *Gang Bangers*, *Alcohol Drinking Abusers* & *Drug Users* cannot read this letter, it is OK. Go pull a trigger and kill a nigger.

Thank you.²³

An assumption of antiblack racism is a metaphysical state of war between whiteness and blackness, which is in fact an appropriation of the Manichean notion of a metaphysical war between Good and Evil. The situation is regarded as one of opportunity costs: what benefits any member of one harms all members of the other. The letter from the klansman sums up a great deal of this antiblack attitude. It has also highlighted the implications of blacks assuming an antiblack consciousness: black fratricide.

Blacks are now besieged by the situation of so-called "black-on-black crimes" in our antiblack world. Blacks are the most victimized group, and a great deal of their physical victimization in urban centers is dished out by other blacks.²⁴ The tendency on the part of blacks to unleash punishment on blacks more than to any other group is well known. Most black rebellions have resulted in higher black casualties than any other group. Mau Mau in Kenya took many black lives.²⁵ A great number of African National Congress supporters were killed in South Africa by black rivals, albeit by the instigation of the white South African government. In Zimbabwe the situation was similar.²⁶ Why is this so?

We can attempt an Hegelian answer. In the *Phenomenology of Spirit*, Hegel argues that the struggle for self-recognition as a human being, as a specific embodiment of *Geist*, involves the submission of the Other and the elevation of the self in a life and death struggle for recognition the result of which is the relation of lord to bondsman. The lord gains leisure time in virtue of the material labor needed to satisfy his needs being located in the activity of the bondsman. The bondsman, on the other hand, develops the will to assert his freedom, and hence self-recognition, through his ongoing experience of transforming nature. All human beings desire, that is, to become lords or masters. If we add the premiss that blacks are regarded as unnatural human beings in virtue of their being regarded as too deeply situated in "nature," then the relation of blacks to each other can be like bondsmen not only to other bondsmen, but bondsmen to nature. To "work" on nature in the sense of freely exercising one's will over it leads to the conclusion that some of the blacks in the previous examples develop self-consciousness through the oppression of other, "lower" blacks who are closer to things of nature than the blacks who dominate them. This internal domination within a wider, Western milieu results in a Western self-consciousness that makes it more difficult for white Westerners to maintain a lordship role to such blacks—particularly in colonial environments.²⁷

We can also reassert our thesis on the word *nigger*, that the use of the term suggests a matrix of oppressor and oppressed that requires a pathological view of liberation: one liberates oneself sadistically since all consciousness is oppressive consciousness. The mere emotional response that accompanies the use of the term lays bare to consciousness who *they*—the oppressed, the low—are.

The Hegelian interpretation, although similar to our Sartrean model of the oppressed playing the role of oppressors, has a few limitations. It suggests the possibility of a special form of mediation. Eventually, lords and servants will disappear in a condition of pure, egalitarian freedom commensurate with the Truth of Absolute Self-Knowledge—in this case, as it turns out, Western culture, although Hegel simply says Self-Recognition or *Geist*. From

the standpoint of an antiblack world this simply means that blackness will disappear under the cultural situation of universal whiteness. Although this is a desirable possibility from the standpoint of antiblackness, it fails to account for the peculiar biologism in antiblack attitudes. "What is important to us here is to show that with the Negro the cycle of the *biological* begins" (Fanon 1967, 160; see also his long footnote 25 on 161–64). The biologism rejects the relativity of blackness. Could the black ever *be* white enough in a cultural environment that militates against not only his skin, but also his genes?

Hegel's limitation goes further. Sartre has criticized Hegel for failing to appreciate the concrete individuality of consciousnesses (1956, 322–23). In concert with Sartre, our analysis suggests that on the basic level of which we are speaking—*particular* blacks versus *particular* other blacks—the Hegelian, mediating resolution of conflict misses the mark by covering too broad a field. It is a cannonball aimed at a dart's bull's eye. Hegel claims that human beings desire mastery. We add that this is a function of the fact that human beings also do not wish to be slaves and often conceive of no other alternative than to become masters. Although Hegel argues that implicit in this desire is the desire to be recognized by an Other, he fails to account for the individuating question of *which* Other. The black who unleashes his rage on blacks in particular may either be displacing his anger toward whites—he may be hiding from his own desire for white recognition, which substantiates our thesis of bad faith—or he may be avoiding the unbearable sense of humiliation of not being recognized by even the lowest denominator. Although both cases seem to substantiate the Hegelian thesis of recognition, the *kinds* of recognition sought in both cases differ. In both cases the black wants to be recognized by whites, but in the second case the black feels he *must be* recognized by blacks. The Sartrean perspective offers an individuating factor on the basis of the body as the perspective from which one is *seen* by others; self-recognition is not only that one is seen by others, but also *how* one is seen by others. A sticky feature of bad faith in an antiblack world is the situation of blackness; only a black can be regarded as the inferior of another black. Thus, to be seen as superior requires, from this distorted perspective, *black* suffering.

The "other black" must be punished at all cost because he carries in his gaze a powerful truth. A lone black in a room of whites *sees* only white people. He is able to live deluded in the belief that if he cannot see his black skin then it is no longer black but transformed and coordinated with his white mask. He is *seduced* by the situation. He lives a deluded "we."

"I was stupefied, as an adolescent, when a girl who knew me quite well jumped up in anger because I had said to her, in a situation where the word was not only appropriate but the one word that suited the occasion:

'You, as a Negress—.' 'Me? A Negress? Can't you see I'm practically white? I despise Negroes. Niggers stink. They're dirty and lazy. Don't ever mention niggers to me.'" I knew another black girl who kept a list of Parisian dance-halls "where-there-was-no-chance-of-running-into-niggers." (Fanon 1967, 50)

Jean Baudrillard has written that at the moment of seduction, "*'I'll be your mirror'* does not signify 'I'll be your reflection' but 'I'll be your deception.'" ²⁸ He goes on to say that "*To seduce is to die as reality and reconstitute oneself as illusion. . . .* Narcissus too loses himself in his own illusory image; that is why he turns from his truth, and by his example turns others from their truth." One wonders what truth such blacks are 'turned from when they enter rooms where-there-are-no-niggers. They are seduced by the situation. White eyes, behaving in their mundanity, seem to see nothing wrong. The interplay of illusion—the black's presence indulges white denial of racism ("This is how I behave with other whites as well"); the lack of other blacks' presence indulges black denial of there being black presence at all ("No white is *saying* or *acting* as though I'm not one of them; therefore I must *be* one of them"). Black eyes—awful, truthful eyes—stop, gaze, *acknowledge*: *You* are one of *us*. There it is. In the flesh. The *mirror* image.

The situation of whiteness as far as the eye can see: "I'll be your mirror." The reality, the fact of blackness, gazing back: "I *am* your mirror."

Whereas the white who screams, "Look, a Negro!" may overdetermine the black, may present an alienated identity to the black, the other black who simply acknowledges black presence commits the crime of asserting a recognized identity.

The white man: "You are not me."

The black man: "You are me."

The-black-who-hopes-to-become-white: (to whites) "I am really you and so long as you don't assert that I am not you, there is no disputing the fact that I am you." The same black: (to another black) "I cannot be you. Why are you claiming to be me? Why are you dragging me into your infernal existence? Away with you!"

Such a black concedes reality to Hegel's master. Hegel's master seeks and eventually finds himself through the slave's struggle to find himself as a being who is not identical with the natural environment that he modifies. But the introduction of bad faith suggests that the master and the slave are in fact deceiving themselves in such declarations. For how can the slaves' labor bring about their own self-consciousness which eventually results in the social situation of Self-Conscious Spirit (equal freedom) commensurate with *Geist* if "self-consciousness" is that which the master embodied all along? ²⁹

The Sartrean view of sadism doesn't hold such hope. The Hegelian situation

of struggle has a polarity of oppressor and oppressed that makes sense from the Sartrean perspective, but the resolution which amounts to either consciousness without an object or an in-itself-for-itself has been rendered impossible in the Sartrean system.³⁰ This is because, as Sartre himself points out, the *ontological* significance of consciousness precedes the epistemological question of self-recognition (1956, 322–26); reflective consciousness requires pre-reflective consciousnesses to begin with. Hegel adds to the discussion when he raises the question of recognition, and Sartre deepens the dimensions of the lord-bondsman relationship by expressing its role as a *situation*—two or more freedoms encountering each other. As we have seen, in such encounter sadism is not only an attitude with a concealed mediation, but it is also an attitude doomed to failure; the sadistic path is enmeshed in a web of bad faith in the form of denying the Other as a freedom with the possibility of looking back, of appropriating a sadistic relation to the sadist.

Finally, if we take seriously Hegel's notion of the unfolding of self-recognition in history as the body of *Geist*, blacks are, as Hegel himself declares in his *Philosophy of History*, anachronistic. Where there are blacks, there is no history and hence no spirit. Hegel treats the view of blacks being ontologically Absence as a legitimate position. Without the charge of bad faith—that is, seeing blacks but denying their presence—the Hegelian interpretation of blacks lacking historicity would be ontologically conclusive. If we wish to impose some reservations on Hegel's assessment and claim that some level of spirit is embodied in blacks, our embellished Hegelian interpretation could be that blacks are lost in some past stage of development tantamount to that of the first stages of self-consciousness—concrete situations of violence. Hence, to study the stage of *Geist* as the highest contemporary stage of self-consciousness in the human species requires looking at the White Man.³¹ Although blacks would then have a form of primitive historicity, the freedom of blacks would still be denied by wiping away their actual history, their contemporary (nonprimitive) historicity, and their individuality.

A conclusion from these Hegelian possibilities is that the dynamics between individual and group assessments of blacks are not considered. That urban situations are violent ones isn't considered in the equation; that colonial situations, as Fanon has observed, are built upon violence isn't taken seriously. The standpoint of bad faith calls for the consideration that blacks who are violent toward blacks may choose to do so for a variety of reasons. The notion of black-on-black crime fails for reasons dependent on a simple logic. Blacks often live in segregated "communities." The odds of victims of black violence being otherwise are very slim. After all, whites are the primary killers of whites for the same reason: who else would be most likely to inflict violence on whites in segregated white suburbs? Thus the mere advancement of black-on-black crime as an unusual category represents a

failure to stand in good faith toward the norms of evidence. The antiblack perspective of blacks is presumed in the formulation. For example, *Pacific News* ran a story on a Somalian relief worker who was fired for her critical views of Operation Restore Hope.³² The worker was critical of the American and European presentations of the Somalian situation. White American and European physicians, relief workers, educators, and soldiers were the only ones shown assisting Somalians and combatting Somalian thugs. The many Somalian physicians, relief workers, and community defense teams remained invisible. Worse, that the thugs have been taken seriously by the foreign forces as liaisons to the people reenforces the image of violent black rulers. There were other, legitimate groups available to assist in the mediation of the Somalian situation. In Kierkegaardian terms, what these phenomena show is that blackness is trapped in a skewed relation to the ethical universal. There is a double-bind, for we have already pointed out on the other hand that to situate blacks in the universal, from the antiblack standpoint conceived here, would mean to take the blackness out of them.

The notion of black-on-black crime supports the very world it rejects. Should blacks be attacking whites? Are such blacks simply stupid soldiers who are shooting their own men in a state of war? Why isn't white-on-white crime a *race* problem?

"Why do so many blacks kill each other?" a host once threw out for discussion at a dinner party.

"Why are most serial killers white?" responded a black guest.

"That doesn't answer the question," added the host.

"But it does in its own way," retorted the black. "You are asking a question which seeks an explanation—perhaps one in the form of the *nature* of blacks—on the basis of demographics that highlight blacks. I am simply asking you whether you would use the same criterion for whites. Are you willing to say that whites are predisposed by nature to be serial killers? Maybe a lot of blacks are killed by blacks because, through political and economic segregation, those are the demographics of killers in their neighborhoods. Or perhaps many blacks are killed by blacks because many blacks have adopted this society's attitude toward black life. What do you think?"

A black gang chases some members of another black gang who have made the mistake of crossing its "turf." One of the other's members is caught by the home-turf gang. The home-turf gang ties him up and ties an M-80 firecracker around his genitals and lights it. The scene concludes with a red explosion that permanently disfigures the trespasser's body and his propensity to contribute to the genetic pool of the human species. On another occasion, a victim is soaked live in gasoline and lit afire. The stories go on and on.³³ The style of these acts of sadism bear close similarity to southern lynchings. The victim is anonymous except insofar as he can be identified as a member

of a hated *group*, and his body is either disfigured but living or disfigured to the point of death. These situations' racial dimensions are revealed, but if our analysis is correct, these situations reflect ritualistic behavior that transforms the participants, through the magic of bad faith, into white figures in pursuit of the antiblack world's embodiment of weakness and evil—the black, the dark, the *nigger*.

Blackness emerges as a consequence of *white identity*. Blacks who appropriate “nigger” into their language have declared a state of war on blacks by way of magically appropriating a white foundational ego on the basis of an antiblack superego. Then there are blacks who take on a white identity by virtue of engaging in the collective act of “lynching” blacks. The lynching phenomenon carries the internal negation of failure in virtue of the fact that such blacks exemplify the klansman's attitude (quoted above) toward blacks in general. Their effort to escape their blackness exemplifies it. Hence, although such blacks would deny that they are making the effort to appropriate whiteness into their actions, like Kierkegaard's ironist who would die to prove he holds an opinion that he doesn't hold, they too punish blacks in order to deny their own desire to be white. This form of black antiblackness encourages an absolute negation of whiteness; blacks become absolute non-whites. Manichaeism reemerges; blacks are regarded as the opposite of whites. Additional weird negations emerge.

Whites are good, blacks are bad. But whites are the enemy; therefore they are bad, so blacks are good. Hence goodness must be articulated in terms of opposition to whiteness. “As I begin to recognize that the Negro is the symbol of sin, I catch myself hating the Negro. But then I recognize that I am a Negro. There are two ways out of this conflict. Either I ask others to pay no attention to my skin, or else I want them to be aware of it. I try then to find value for what is bad—since I have unthinkingly conceded that the black is the color of evil” (Fanon 1967, 197). To be bad therefore becomes good. The problem is obvious: in such a situation, whiteness holds all the cards; black positivity becomes derivative and dependent upon white *decision*. The role of blacks among each other becomes that of putting those who go astray back into “their place”—the realm of the “us.” Such a role is sadistic since it is an effort to submerge other blacks into their facticity under the gaze of the Third: whites. The impact of such an antiblack attitude is devastating: it shifts antiblack racism away from a white racist pilot to the illusion or self-bewitchment of automatic pilot.

Although there is a “fact of blackness” in the sense that blacks are *seen* as blacks, like the plantation slave, the colonial native, the Invisible Man, and Frantz Fanon, all blacks face the question of how to face that situation. For the black to *accept* the values of that situation as objective values—“Blacks simply *are not* capable of achievements considered positive by anyone”—is

to hide from himself as a source of value which includes the value of accepting such values. To live under what whites expect of blacks is to live only as a body seen and a body known as seen. It is an evasion of whether blacks can live otherwise.

There are many ways to hide from the acceptance of "white values" of blacks under the guise of black pride. For example, I once saw two black crack dealers clad in Malcolm X t-shirts while selling their illicit items. The logic? I sell crack, therefore I am black; white people are afraid of me, therefore I am black; white people were afraid of Malcolm X, therefore he was black; white people are afraid of me and I wear a Malcolm X t-shirt, therefore I am *very* black.

Of course, there is this possibility: Malcolm X is in style; therefore I wear Malcolm X t-shirts. The crack dealers I saw were all wearing such shirts, so they may have also decided to wear the t-shirts as their gang uniform. The question is then raised, what kind of reasoning may have gone into that group's decision?

Consciousness emerges as a negation of an object of consciousness. But consciousness requires pre-reflective consciousness. In other words, to be conscious we must simultaneously be aware that we are not identical with the objects of which we are conscious. Thus it can be argued that few studies of black people in an antiblack world tell us anything significant about black people. They tell us much about how a white-dominated culture regards black people. Black antiblack attitudes tell us the same. Black antiblack perspectives are pseudo-white egos behind "black" reflective consciousnesses. And unlike the Hegelian view which argues that a slave consciousness emerges as the dialectical transformation of the master into dependency, we instead claim that the slave finds himself nihilating himself to become himself as seen by the master. He "is" only the black-body-as-seen-by-others. There is no *black* consciousness from the standpoint of an antiblack world.

Exoticism: Antiblackness Under the Guise of Love

In the struggles between generations, children and old people often join forces: the former pronounce the oracles; the latter puzzle them out. Nature speaks, and experience translates: adults have only to keep their traps shut. Failing a child, one can take a poodle: last year, at the dogs' cemetery, I recognized my grandfather's maxims in the trembling discourse that runs from grave to grave: dogs know how to love; they are gentler than human beings, more faithful; they have tact, a flawless instinct that enables them to recognize Good, to distinguish the good from the wicked. "Polonius," said one unconsolated mistress, "you are better than I. You would not have survived me. I survive you." An American friend was with me. With a burst of indignation, he kicked a cement dog and broke its ear. He was right: when one loves children and animals *too much*, one loves them against human beings.

—Sartre

HATE can be concealed in many ways.³⁴ A lover of animals looks into eyes that want, eyes that are forever grateful for what they receive, eyes that can never judge. Such a figure can ultimately be a sadist, a misanthrope, in that his perfect world is a world without other human beings. Everything that animals do is glorified precisely because it represents such an animal lover's ideal for Others: consciousness without judgment.

In our discussion of the emotions, we pointed out that one can throw oneself into an emotional fit in order to evade responsibility for a situation. Our discussion of black antiblackness suggested that some blacks exoticize blackness—they throw themselves into blackness so as to evade responsibility for themselves as people who have to make choices in an antiblack world. This immersion into blackness for the purpose of evasion is a possibility of everyone in an antiblack world.

There is something odd about saying, "I just *love* black people." Why black people? Why a people who, by virtue of the situation of the speaker,

must be in a significant sense different from him? Wouldn't such a speaker find himself in the situation of the black who uses "nigger"? Wouldn't his ability to stand outside of blackness, as it were, so as to see blackness, represent a form of nihilating assumption of regarding himself from the outside?

To love black people *because they are black* betrays the desire to be loved by blacks. On its surface, such desire deceptively appears as a form of antiwhiteness. "Whites are so boring. We can't dance, we can't sing, we can't play good basketball or break track records. Look at our skin—no color. Boring. And worse, we aren't even good in bed. Who wants to be purely cerebral anyway?"

One can always take a poodle.

"The white American regards his darker brother," writes James Baldwin, "through the distorting screen created by a lifetime of conditioning. He is accustomed to regard him either as a needy and deserving martyr or as the soul of rhythm."³⁵

If sin is indeed Negro as virtue is white, and the socratic dictum still maintains that we don't wish to embrace evil, then the heart of antiblackness is the desire to be protected from the black. There is therefore a special kind of evasion that occurs in the exotic attitude: the exoticist throws himself into blackness in order to protect himself from blackness. To throw himself into blackness requires, however, the presentation of himself as factual—as an object-for-blackness. This would seem at first to be an act of masochism, but the act is loaded with equivocation.

There is a sense in which the immersion into blackness is the desire to be protected *from human beings*. For black eyes represent a form of absence of human presence in antiblack situations. The eyes that are evaded are the eyes that matter, the eyes that judge; like Freud's notion of the patriarchal beard, white flesh becomes the point of view that determines authority and reality. Whoever desires to be protected from these eyes accepts the core assumption of antiblackness—the supremacy of whiteness. Such a figure experiences vertigo in the presence of whites; whites become the bottomless subjectivities at the edge of which, the body of which, there is the threat of slipping into facticity, slipping into being seen by "truly human" eyes. The exoticist is therefore not a masochist, for as it turns out he doesn't want to be *seen*. He wants to stand before innocent eyes, eyes incapable of understanding what stands before them, eyes that can look without seeing.

The exoticist commits a double sin. He wishes to place a veil over the eyes of humanity and he assumes humanity as white humanity. He is both a misanthrope and a patron of white supremacy. Blacks are here mere instruments as are all objects of sadism; they stand as figures of wonder like poodles jumping through hoops.

Being a form of sadism, the exoticist's attitude is ultimately built upon

hate. He claims to hate whites, but since the attitude of hate requires universal hatred, the exoticist brings a two-edged sword to the black whom he claims to love. He loves the black purportedly in order to hate the white, but in using the black to express this hatred, he exemplifies antiblackness, the denial of black humanity as human. His expression of love for blacks is therefore rotten at its core.

"The black man insists," declares Baldwin, "by whatever means he finds at his disposal, that the white man cease to regard him as an exotic rarity and recognize him as a human being" (166).

"Don't treat me as an exotic rarity!"

Translation: "Your point of view constitutes *the* point of view. Make it one I would like."

The effort to hide from themselves their desire for white recognition by rejecting white recognition was borne out in the history of the major spokesmen of negritude. Most of them became well-paid puppet statesmen of neocolonial regimes (Caute, chap. 5). Sartre's assessment that negritude was merely a moment in the historical development of global liberation was thus proven correct. But his thesis that it was liberating was proven false. Had he recognized it as a form of bad faith, a reflection of the desire to evade the eyes of the white man through a self-deluding, exoticized black consciousness, he would not have committed such an error.

It appears pointless to respond to sado-exoticism with the plea for human recognition. In Sartrean terms, the best response in the presence of such an attitude, eyes that insist on being the perspective from which being-seen is manifested, may either be indifference or *to unleash the Look*, which amounts to revenge.

"Look how handsome that Negro is! . . ."

"Kiss the handsome Negro's ass, madame!"

Shame flooded her face. At last I was set free from my rumination. At the same time I accomplished two things: I identified my enemies and I made a scene. A grand slam. Now one would be able to laugh. (Fanon 1967, 114)

Yet there are more sophisticated ways to achieve a "grand slam."

"Who do you write for when you write?" a white writer asks a black writer.

"Well," responds the black writer, "I write to black people."

"How can you do that—are you saying that I don't have a right to read what you write, or that I *can't* understand it? Aren't you being racist?" charges the white.

"No. Since you seem to feel that *you* have the right to identify racist activities on the part of blacks, then I needn't worry. As far as you are concerned there is a universal mankind. So as long as I write to blacks, I am writing, however subtle, to Man—no?"

"But you are *focusing* on blacks, which at least reveals the effort to shut me out—a white who holds no hostility to blacks."

"And what would you say is going on right now when you challenge my efforts to communicate to black people? Where was your concern for universality when white writers said things like, 'The area is uncivilized, no white man has ever visited there,' or 'When the Zulus produce a Tolstoy we will read them'? Aren't these codes that point to the reader, the one who determines the value of the text, as a white reader? Yet I, a black reader, can nevertheless read the 'universal truths,' however subtle, among their pages. Since your white writers have more power in the dissemination and presentation of knowledge, I wonder why do you even *bother* with me? Wouldn't your self-righteousness be more productive elsewhere? You remind me of those folks who waste their energy attacking afrocentricity—as if afrocentricity seriously has the political organizing elements of a *Wretched of the Earth* or *Black Jacobins*. Look, I'm not saying that whites *shouldn't* read my work. I'm simply saying that it makes no difference to me whether they do or not."³⁶

The white, in this instance, could point out that such a black may be in bad faith. It is possible that he has made himself indifferent to white judgment to buffer himself against being judged negatively by whites.

Whether indifference or a direct act of revenge, there is failure, for the stand of sadism is a form of bad faith. The exoticist who is informed of black indifference is tortured; he faces the *human* possibility of the black becoming the eyes through which he is *seen* for what he is.

In this battle of the eyes, there is, however, a third alternative. The black can realize that he is seen, which is in effect a form of looking, though not looking-back. But if he says nothing, if he simply realizes it and goes on, he has issued a form of indifference to the white, which provides him with revenge, so he might as well say something, if revenge is not his intent. Suppose our black in the above conversation said this:

"Why do you want to be so important? Why does it bother you so much whom I write for? Do you ask whites this question? And if you do normally ask whites this question, do you mean it at this moment in the same way? Are you asking me whether I write to myself, my students, my colleagues, my nation, my race? Whom? What?"

Yet even in this case, as in Sartre's analysis of language, there is a sado-masochistic dimension—is our black using words as a whip with which to lash the sadistic white consciousness in the flesh before him by posing the possibility of his transformation into white masochistic consciousness in the flesh? As long as the black avoids being an object by not yielding to what the white wants to hear, it seems that his only option is revenge.

Yet there are two modes of revenge here—revenge relished and ironic revenge. Castigating the white would be the former; mere indifference would

be the latter. The irony is not only the fact that he achieves his revenge even by not intending it, but also that his indifference to having accomplished his revenge makes it more profoundly sadistic. This is because the ultimate fear of the exoticist is that of his irrelevance. Not only does a lack of response to the white have no value to such a black, but also that this lack of response accomplishes revenge without his aiming for revenge doesn't matter either. It is to regard the white as being as close as possible to an actual *thing*—the ultimate fear of the exoticist.

When a Frenchman, for example, says to other Frenchmen, "The country is done for" . . . it is emotional talk; burning with love and fury, the speaker includes himself with his fellow-countrymen. And then, he adds, "Unless. . . ." . . . In short, it is a threat followed by a piece of advice and these remarks are so much the less shocking in that they spring from a national intersubjectivity. But on the contrary, when Fanon says of Europe that she is rushing to her doom, far from sounding the alarm he is merely setting out a diagnosis. . . . He certifies that she is dying, on external evidence, founded on symptoms that he can observe. As to curing her, no; he has other things to think about; he does not give a damn whether she lives or dies. Because of this, his book is scandalous. And if you murmur, jokingly embarrassed, "He has it in for us!" the true nature of the scandal escapes you; for Fanon has nothing in for you at all; his work—red-hot for some—in what concerns you is as cold as ice; he speaks of you often, never to you. . . . What does Fanon care whether you read his work or not? (Sartre 1963a, 10–12)

The exotic attitude is what Sartre would call a "slimy" attitude; the exotic attitude manifests itself in a "soft," "gentle," placing of the hands on the dark Other, as if to assure, as if to share the condition of blackness in the delight of being on its side. It is no accident that exoticism manifests itself as antivalue, as the desire for "forbidden fruit," as it were; such antivalue is a function of its sliminess; "[sliminess] is a type of being not realized but threatening which will perpetually haunt consciousness as the constant danger which it is fleeing, and hence will suddenly transform the project of appropriation into a project of flight" (1956, 778–79). Being slimy, the exoticist "clings" to the black, "stains" him in the situation of either becoming equally slimy or issuing revenge; being sticky, slimy, the exoticist's project of transcendence falls apart in the face of any black who acknowledges, commits revenge upon, whether by way of indifference or word, the exoticist's bad faith, the exoticist's sliminess.

The exoticist tries to hide from his situation of being the Third, the sadist. He reasons a different kind of "third," that he stands between oppressive whites and oppressed blacks as a third figure, a white who doesn't oppress blacks. Yet such is the case of dominant groups; as variations of the anarchic

consciousness, it is their luxury to deny their role.³⁷ What the exoticist often fails to mention is institutional support of his presumption of *having a right to everything*; like a diner who doesn't question his right to pluck any delectable item from the tropical buffet, the exoticist sees blackness as there for the taking—how wonderful he is to be an enlightened white who bestows value upon blackness by virtue of appreciating it. Observes Taylor, "For real judgments of worth suppose a fused horizon of standards. . . . A favorable judgment made prematurely would be not only condescending but ethnocentric. It would praise the other for being like us" (1992, 70–71).

Behold: "In fact you are like us—you are 'us.' Your thoughts are ours. You behave as we behave, as we would behave. You think of yourself—others think of you—as a Negro? Utterly mistaken! You merely look like one. As for everything else, you think as a European."³⁸

Still, there is the reality of the situation of language and power. We have already explored in our discussion of the black use of "nigger" and black English some of the bad-faith dimensions of trying to make the Other like oneself, which amounts to the way "we" see "him" or "her." As Fanon remarks,

If a man [of authority] who speaks pidgin to a man of color or an Arab does not see anything wrong or evil in such behavior, it is because he has never stopped to think. . . . What an idealist, people will say. Not at all: It is just that the others are scum. I make it a point always to talk to the so-called *bicots* [pejorative term for Arabs], and I have always been understood. They answer me as well as their varying means permit; but I will not allow myself to resort to paternalistic 'understanding.'" (1967: 32–33)

The exoticist is "turned on" by blackness. Blackness frees him. Hazel V. Carby strips bare a sinister dimension of this "freedom" when she writes,

Certainly, we can see how the black female subject has become very profitable for the culture industry. . . . We need to ask why black women, or other women who are non-white, are needed as cultural and political icons by the white middle class at this particular moment? What cultural and political need is being expressed, and what role is the black female subject being reduced to play? I would argue that it is necessary to recognize the contradictions between elevating the black female subject to the status of major text within multiculturalism and failing to lead students toward an integrated society, between making the black female a subject in the classroom and failing to integrate university student and faculty bodies on a national scale. Instead of recognizing the contradictions, the black female subject is frequently the means by which many middle-class white students and faculty cleanse their souls and rid themselves of the guilt of living in a society that is still rigidly segregated.³⁹

Carby is right. Black females are exotic symbols in the academy and popular

culture. Their glorification is a convenient smokescreen from the institutional dimensions of racial responsibility and racist terror. A black-female-over-coming-adversity novel on the bookshelf is no doubt worth far more its price in the release of guilt than dollars. This was certainly the case in Fanon's time, and the tradition continues.

Blackness enables the exoticist to stick a middle finger up at all that whiteness that shackles him with its judgmental eyes. The more outrage whites show toward his actions, the more he can gloat at their myopia, the more he can relish in the freedom of his own form of revenge, his own desire to make what he regards as truly human eyes, white eyes, slip into oblivion.

"To us," writes Fanon, "the man who adores the Negro is as 'sick' as the man who abominates him" (1967, 8).

We conclude that the "sickness" of which Fanon speaks is the comfort of nonhuman relationships; the "blacker" the Other, the more self-deceiving the exoticist's sense of escaping the judgmental eyes of human subjects. The reduction of self as lover of blackness and the black as a paradigm object of desire situates such attitudes in the Manichaeian camp of the spirit of seriousness. They are forms of bad faith.

Effeminacy: The Quality of Black Beings

OUR descriptions of sexuality in an antiblack world pose a gender problem. From the standpoint of an antiblack world, black men are nonmen—nonwomen, and black women are nonwomen—nonmen. This conclusion is based on our premiss of whites—white men and white women—being both human, being both Presence, and our premiss of blacks, both black men and women, being situated in the condition of the “hole,” being both Absence. This dichotomy poses a gender question concerning black men and a metaphysical one concerning black women. Blackness is regarded as a hole in being. Black men are hence penises that are holes; and black women are vaginas that are holes—holes that are holes. If blackness is a hole, and women are holes, what are white women, and what are black men in an antiblack world?

The question brings us to an infamous passage in *Being and Nothingness*:

The obscenity of the feminine sex is that of everything which “gapes open.” It is an *appeal to being* as all holes are. In herself woman appeals to a strange flesh which is to transform her into a fullness of being by penetration and dissolution. Conversely woman senses her condition as an appeal precisely because she is “in the form of a hole.” This is the true origin of Adler’s complex. Beyond any doubt her sex is a mouth and a voracious mouth which devours the penis—a fact which can easily lead to the idea of castration. The amorous act is the castration of the man; but this is above all because sex is a hole. We have to do here with a *pre-sexual* contribution which will become one of the components of sexuality as an empirical, complex, human attitude but which far from deriving its origin from the sexed being has nothing in common with basic sexuality. . . . Nevertheless the experience with the hole, when the infant sees the reality, includes the ontological presentiment of sexual experience in general; it is with his flesh that the child stops up the hole and the hole, before all sexual specification, is an obscene expectation, an appeal to the flesh. (782)⁴⁰

Given the assumptions thus far of antiblack and misogynous worlds’ being coextensive, the obvious sexist hermeneutics from this passage are more in-

structive than limiting.⁴¹ For we face the hermeneutical problem of the symbols of masculinity and femininity from the standpoint of bad-faith institutions regarding gender identification. If Sartre is conducting an existential psychoanalysis of the quality of being from the standpoint of potency and impotency, what other matrices are available in the West, and for the most part even “beyond” the West, if we tentatively grant such a standpoint today? His critical ontology makes them problematic features of any particular human being, but the situation of his inquiry, an examination of human reality from the standpoint of bad faith, regards them as essential forms of reality. The interpretive problem cannot be resolved simply by calling Sartre a sexist, no more than our concerns with antiblack racism can be resolved by calling him an exoticist. If instead of using gender descriptions of the relation of being-for-itself to being-in-itself he had simply raised the question of qualities that emerge from the contradiction of being-in-itself, the question remains whether the context of the inquiry, a society that places activity on masculinity and ambiguous passivity (“aggressive passivity”) on femininity, would not have enabled others to draw out similar conclusions as Sartre’s? An alternative may be the history of feminist presentations of women, but hasn’t a dimension of that discourse rested on at least the recognition of the identification of women as a passivity to be overcome as passivity? “Yes, men have a penis and women don’t,” says Drucilla Cornell, “but it is the meaning given to the fact within the system of the gender hierarchy that continually re-inscribes the de-valuation of women as the castrated other.”⁴² And she is correct. But isn’t it the case also that women *have* vaginas and men *don’t*? The historical fact of the matter is political priority on the penis as an organ of control and the vagina as an organ to be controlled, but the point of our analysis thus far is that that is precisely what is involved in institutionalized forms of bad faith. Gender identity is ambiguous, and as such it is sometimes both equivocal and unequivocal—given the context. In a language where the feminine “means” soft and the masculine “means” hard, application to human beings in the flesh creates the “trouble” of contradiction. The subject of formulating a feminist point of departure has received much study in this regard.⁴³ For our purposes, what is significant about Sartre’s descriptions of a convergence of ontology and gender is their serving as a summation of many of the themes we have been dealing with—sexuality/castration, protection (from the obscene), and internal negation (black antiblackness/holes that are anti-holes). The “essence” of blackness from the standpoint of the antiblack racist is, if you will, the hole, and the hole is the institutional bad-faith mode of the feminine. Antiblack racism is therefore intimately connected to misogyny.⁴⁴

Hence the white woman should not be regarded as the jewel of the antiblack racist. For hidden in her whiteness—like the secret blackness of

milk, the secret abundance of blackness, the fertility that so outrages Manichaeism with its propensity to split apart and weaken the Light—is the antiblack racist's suspicion of her blackness. She stands as a white blackness, as a living contradiction of white supremacy. Out of her comes every white, placing a question mark on the notion of the purity of whiteness in the flesh. Unlike the black woman, out of whom only black children can be born, she can bear *both* white and black children. Because of this, the white woman ultimately stands on the same ontological level as slime in an antiblack world. She is regarded as a frightening substance that simultaneously attracts and repels.

Comparing consciousness to water, Sartre writes,

Slime is the agony of water. It presents itself as a phenomenon in process of becoming; it does not have the permanence within change that water has but on the contrary represents an accomplished break in a change of state. This fixed instability in the slimy discourages possession. . . . The slimy flees with a heavy flight which has the same relation to water as the unwieldy earthbound flight of the chicken as to that of the hawk. Even this flight can not be possessed because it denies itself as flight. It is already almost a solid permanence. Nothing testifies more clearly to its ambiguous character as a "substance in between two states" than the slowness with which the slimy melts into itself. (774)

Being linked to the slimy in an antiblack world and thereby being able to stand as a "substance between two states" situates the white woman as an attracting being—like the simultaneous stickiness and slipperiness of slime—whose "nature" stands below the psychic and above nature:

What comes back to us then as an objective quality [in our contact with slime] is a new *nature* which is neither material (and physical) nor psychic, but which transcends the opposition of the psychic and the physical, by revealing itself to us as the ontological expression of the entire world; that is, which offers itself as a rubric for classifying all the "thises" in the world, so that we have to deal with the material organizations or transcended transcendence. This means that the apprehension of the slimy as such has, by the same stroke, created for the in-itself of the world a particular mode of giving itself. (772)

The entire web of legal structures built around the protection of the white woman amid the simultaneous deprecation and violation of her by "men" in the antiblack world is built upon her displacement.⁴⁵ She both attracts and nauseates the antiblack with the "obscenity," under his gaze, of being a white hole. The antiblack glorifies the white woman because he distrusts her; he entombs her in an edifice of serious value so as to hide, even from herself, her propensity to make choices.

The "place" and "attitude" imposed upon the white woman are therefore

the realm of the exoticist's. She becomes the primary matrix of "affection" toward blackness. Her "feminine" mode of being puts her in solidarity with blackness, but her connection to whiteness maintains the ever present possibility of her option of betrayal. Betrayal becomes the avenue of asserting her freedom in the antiblack situation; to choose her blackness is a betrayal of whiteness; to choose her whiteness is a betrayal of blackness.⁴⁶ In either variation, she would be taking advantage of her ambiguity and betraying herself. It is an error, then, to claim that the Sartrean description is one about *woman* in general. It is about white women in particular.

What do we make of black men at this point? How does a hole with a penis work in this situation?

Consider a white man. Being pure Presence, he is equated with manliness *in toto*. The manly, or masculine, is in fact a figure of denial, a being who attempts to close all its holes and become pure, sealed flesh in search of holes. From the perspective of such a being, all holes are elsewhere; he doesn't even have an anus; when he kisses, nothing enters his mouth—he enters the Other's. In his presence, the black becomes a chasm to *fill*. But the black "man" is a *hole*. Could such a figure seriously accomplish denial by a decision to interpret himself as completely "closed"? Let us look at his primary claim to maleness, if not manhood: his penis.

A penis is an ambiguous organ. It protrudes. It pretends not to be a hole, but instead a filler-of-holes. Yet its tip reveals its ambiguity, for its ability to ejaculate, to "spit" semen—slime—depends upon an aspect of it rarely seen by any but those who take a hygienic, scientific, or sexual role toward the organ: its *hole*. Masculinity, in such instances, is revealed to be an embodied lie, a denial of its own duplicity, its own darkness at the tip of its means of penetration. Complete masculinity is like complete whiteness; it is a chosen falsehood, a form of denial. As pure Presence, masculinity is an ideal form of whiteness with its own gradations; the less of a hole one "is," the more masculine one is; the less dark, the more white. The black man would therefore have the propensity to become slimy if it were not for the fact that he embodies femininity even more than the white woman. His skin, his eyes, his nose, his ears, his mouth, his anus, his penis ooze out his femininity like blood from a splattered body. He faces the possibility of denying his feminine situation: a black man in the presence of whiteness stands as a hole to be filled; he stands to the white man in a homoerotic situation and to the white woman in a heterosexual erotic situation with a homoerotic twist; she becomes the white/male that fills his blackness/femininity.

The reader may wonder whether this analysis fails in the case of a black man raping a white woman. There are obvious problems with this appeal. We might as well ask whether the analysis fails in the case of a black man sodomizing a white man. What both cases pose is a problem of physical

strength. But we *know* that the wider framework of antiblack racism in collision with sexism makes the black man who rapes a white woman stand in a clear legal hermeneutic of himself as rapist even before he rapes. He "is" guilty whether the white woman is raped and is therefore telling the truth or is not raped and is therefore lying. A more disturbing possibility is raised. The "phallus," against which and upon which gender analyses often focus, needn't be and possibly no longer is a penis.⁴⁷ In an antiblack world, the phallus is white skin. On this matter I urge the reader to consider some of the rich examples in the popular film *The Crying Game* (1992). A white female Irish terrorist is pitted against a black, working-class transvestite who has become the lover of one of the former male Irish terrorists. The symbolism of a white woman in black leather with a black gun and a black transvestite in a white cricket outfit with a black gun is psychoanalytically rich enough, and the "manliness" of the white female terrorist at this point is obvious. But consider this. Could the significance of the transvestite's character have been maintained if s/he were not a person of color? When the black transvestite faces the white terrorist, where stands the phallus?

The black man is caught. He cannot reject his femininity without simultaneously rejecting his blackness, for his femininity stands as a consequence of his blackness and vice versa. Standing in front of a white wall, he appears as a hole, as a gaping, feminine symbol to be filled, closed up, by the being who has being. His mode of betrayal is thus set on a different level from the white woman's; he has a connection to the black woman in virtue of his blackness, but he can deny who he is by asserting what limited connection to maleness he may have. Yet, even this concession is suspect, for the black man's duality is not always phenomenologically apparent; for whereas one may always "see" white skin, one rarely sees a penis. His assertion of a duality is therefore always questionable—an act of faith, as it were.

Antiblack racism's quality of being is therefore differentiated between the hard and the soft, the bland and the sweet, the sealed and the torn. When soft becomes softer, it becomes a sucking presence; when the sweet becomes sweeter it eventually takes on the nauseating feature of rancid fruit; when the sealed is torn open, it betrays its horrid inside as a wound, a gaping hole with slimy crevices. The hard and the bland, whenever harder or blander, amount to safety: neither penetrable nor noticeable, they regard other substances as objects to be affected by human presence. A dimension of antiblack racism that emerges at this point is the effort to clog the universe. Where does this leave the black woman?

The black woman stands as the reality of sweet, seductive, open femininity in our antiblack, and at this point we might as well say misogynous, world. A black female christologist has argued that if the Christian God were to walk the planet today, "he" would be a black woman (Grant, 220). We say

that this interpretation is possible because the antiblack symbolism and antifeminine attitudes of Middle Eastern and southern Mediterranean society entailed a conflated attitude against such a messianic figure's femininity, against his ultimate black-womanness. The whole homoerotic ritual of the crucifixion can be seen as a consequence of the "brotherly love" of a life that shared the agony of women, men, and a colonized people. The black woman emerges, then, as Carby observed, as an exotic figure of solution. We will speak more on black women in our discussion of God in an antiblack world.

Antiblack Racism and Ontology

WE have now covered sufficient ground to state the importance of an ontological description of antiblack racism. Sartrean ontology poses the question of the significance of a contingent relationship between the self and the Other. As we have seen, this is a relationship of conflict in the sense that relationships aren't established simply by the basic situation of two freedoms attempting to face each Other, but also by the effort of the chosen, ongoing project of making those relationships. On this score, Fanon identifies three limitations of Sartre's ontology—one dealing with his treatment of the Other and the other two dealing with the role of ontology in the study of the black situation. In regard to the first, Fanon writes:

Though Sartre's speculations on the existence of The Other may be correct (to the extent, we must remember, to which *Being and Nothingness* describes an alienated consciousness), their application to a black consciousness proves fallacious. That is because the white man is not only The Other but also the master, whether real or imaginary. (1967, 138 n. 24)

The second limitation is located in Fanon's assessment of the relationship between the historical situation of colonialism and antiblack racism:

In the *Weltanschauung* of a colonized people there is an impurity, a flaw that outlaws any ontological explanation. . . . Ontology—once it is finally admitted as leaving existence by the wayside—does not permit us to understand the being of the black man. For not only must the black man be black; he must be black in relation to the white man. . . . The black man has no ontological resistance in the eyes of the white man. (109–10)

In criticizing Alioune Diop's assessment of the Reverend Placide Tempels's effort to state a Bantu ontology,⁴⁸ Fanon formulates the third limitation:

Be careful! It is not a matter of finding being in Bantu thought, when Bantu existence subsists on the level of thought, when Bantu existence subsists on the level of nonbeing, of the imponderable. It is quite true that Bantu philosophy is not going to open itself to understanding through a revolutionary will: But it is precisely in that degree in which Bantu society, being a closed society, does not contain that substitution of the

exploiter for the ontological relations of Forces. Now we know that Bantu society no longer exists. And there is nothing ontological about segregation. Enough of this rubbish. (185–86)

We will begin with the first.

Fanon reminds us that the social world—the world of Absence confronted by the presence of Others—is rich with meanings that articulate the confrontation of freedoms. How can the black be a freedom if his confrontation with the white is never, at least institutionally, that of master over the Other in a situation? Does this mean that the black can never be master in and over his situation? Or more abstractly, does this mean that the black can never be a subject? This is how things appear when Fanon writes, “The Martinican does not compare himself with the white man qua father, leader, God, he compares himself with his fellow against the pattern of the white man” (215).

Insofar as the black can only achieve equality among blacks in an antiblack world, we agree with Fanon. The ruling principle of such a world is “separate but equal”—equality among like kinds. This conclusion is obvious from our analysis of blackness as a mode of being beneath the scheme of whiteness in an antiblack world. Yet a conclusion of a Sartrean analysis is that antiblack racism is a contingent (though not accidental) feature of our world. There could very well have been an interpretation of blackness as fullness and whiteness as the emptiness that threatens it. For example, the expression “colored” suggests an alternative group who exists without color. But even this example is susceptible to an obvious problem: would not the “white” in this case really be the black? Fanon refers to a *black* consciousness. Isn’t such a notion a form of bad faith, the spirit of seriousness, on its face?

It is—to the extent that there is no, at the basic ontological level of consciousness of transphenomenal Being, black nor white consciousness. But “what” kind of consciousness is there? We face a qualitative and quantitative concern.

Qualitative: Since there are reflective white and black consciousnesses—that is, knowledge of each consciousness’ situation in a given society—is there a qualitative distinction between white and black pre-reflective consciousnesses? Does it make sense to speak of such consciousnesses?

Quantitative: Does it make sense to speak of more than one pre-reflective consciousness?⁴⁹

Perhaps we should work backward. Pre-reflective consciousness is “empty.” It seems to function at first glance, I venture to say, like Schopenhauer’s notion of Will. Being ontological, there is no principle of individuation located in its domain. “It is true we see the individual come into being and pass away,” says Schopenhauer, “but the individual is only phenomenal, exists only for the knowledge which is bound to the principle of sufficient

reason, to the *principio individuationis*. Certainly, for this kind of knowledge, the individual receives his life as a gift, rises out of nothing, then suffers the loss of this gift through death, and returns again to nothing."⁵⁰ There are deterministic elements in Schopenhauer that differentiate him from Sartre and provide a rich response to Sartre's notion of the situation. For example,

We find that although the will may, in itself and apart from the phenomenon, be called free and even omnipotent, yet in its particular phenomena enlightened by knowledge, as in men and brutes, it is determined by motives to which the special character regularly and necessarily responds, and always in the same way. We see that because of the possession on his part of abstract rational knowledge, man, as distinguished from the brutes, has a *choice*, which only makes him the scene of the conflict of his motives, without withdrawing him from their control. This choice is therefore certainly the condition of the possibility of the individual character, but is by no means to be regarded as freedom of the particular volition, *i.e.*, independence of the law of causality, the necessity of which extends to man as to every other phenomenon. (388)

But in the main, the basic units of their thought are pre-reflective and ontological. Like, albeit not identical with, the for-itself, "The will, which, considered purely in itself, is without knowledge, and is merely a blind incessant impulse, as we see it appear in unorganized and vegetable part of our own life, receives through the addition of the world as idea, which is developed in subjection to it, the knowledge of its own willing and of what it is that it wills. And this is nothing else than the world as idea, life, precisely as it exists" (354). Pre-reflective consciousness functions like an empty set in formal logic; all derivations can flow from it. This consequence poses no special problem, given our articulation of human reality as contradictory, paradoxical, and ironic; its emptiness is a precondition of its freedom. Qualitatively, then, no human being is distinct beyond the fact of his perspective on the world.

One may hasten to impute a form of universalism here, but this would be an error since, being empty, such universality is meaningless. For meaning, we have to step outside of the pre-reflective level by-itself, for such an in-itself formulation would be in bad faith in the first place, and consider what we have interpreted Sartre to be arguing for in his description of the body as a pre-reflective *perspective*; an appreciation of the context of choice, what we have called the residue of mediation, or the interplay between pre-reflection and reflection, awareness and knowledge, seeing and being seen. Put differently, we face the question of what is imposed upon a situation. Every individual faces a situation not only as a freedom, but also as a freedom facing a collectivity of freedoms, a freedom with a perspective (the body) facing a collectivity of perspectives. The Other, in this case, is more than a

concrete individual Other. The Other is ALL. The Other is tantamount to the Freudian notion of the super ego. Although it may be problematic to speak of a plurality of pre-reflective consciousnesses, it certainly makes sense to speak of a plurality of perspectives. The question is whether pre-reflective consciousness calls for a perspective other than these plurality of perspectives to constitute the *I*. Phyllis Sutton Morris has argued that the body fulfills all the conditions of the *I* qua perspective of consciousness.⁵¹ Morris seems to be correct, insofar as her point pertains to the first ontological description of the body (the body as consciousness). I cannot see as an object my body as I live it, just as *I* am not identical with *me*. In the presence of the Other as the Other who, as the Third, looks back at us, there is a minimum of three perspectives: *his* and ours.

Our analysis of antiblack racism rests upon the notion of the Third's being The Antiblack Racist—a figure treated as a fundamental perspective of the antiblack world. The consequence of such an institutional or cultural imposition is the reality, as pointed out by Fanon, of our various social roles in an antiblack world. The type of being we meet the Other as is already situated for most of us. We must choose, but what we must choose *as* is already set for us. Try as I may, whenever I choose, no matter what I choose to choose *as*—what I choose to “be”—the fact of the matter is that it always turns out to be a black man who chooses.⁵²

So it would seem that we agree with Fanon. Let us see.

Ontology can be regarded not only as a study of what “is” the case, but also a study of *what is treated as being the case* and *what is realized as the contradiction of being the case*. By following the path of articulating what is treated as being the case, by appealing to interpretations of reality in the given social situations that serve as matrices of choice, and by emphasizing the importance of negativity, of Absence, in critical ontology we have been able to raise the question of whether all ontologies are ultimately “distorted” ontologies. This is the case because, by way of their commitment to identity relations between meanings and being, human being and essence, ontologies often ascribe necessity instead of contingency to being. In short, all ontologies asserted as ONTOLOGY may carry residues of the spirit of seriousness; they may fall into the error of treating ontology as solely the study of Presence, and they may regard Absence on the level of an in-itself, abstract universalism. We have seen many instances of the perils of committing ourselves to what *must be the case* as far as existence is concerned. We lose sight of the contingency of being when we fail to appreciate that what is the case doesn't always have to be the case. No black has to be black. No white has to be white. But we must also stand back and add—provided we remember that the wider situation upon which these interpretations are based is itself contingent, although not necessarily “accidental.” For example, the feminist effort to

establish a policy of nonsexist language “has derived some strength and, I suppose, plausibility, in the eyes of philosophical practitioners because of one simple fact: until quite recently, those engaged in philosophical reflection in the western academy *have been* white men. This fact is as much a result of the presumption as it is a determinant of it. We can say of this fact, however contingent, that ‘it is no accident.’ Though it could not be ‘rationalized’ by all the philosophy in the world, it is of a piece with the entire history of the United States, and for what is still called ‘western civilization’” (Pittman 1992–93, 5). Blacks *are* black and whites *are* white in an antiblack world.

So we return to Fanon’s view that whites cannot be the Other to blacks. Is a black in bad faith when he says, “I *am* the Other if the Other means inferior object in the presence of a white,” in an antiblack world?

Well, first, such a black isn’t a figure in bad faith primarily because he is recognizing his *situation*, if he means by the expression that the Other means he who is Absence. This does not mean that he is not recognizing his freedom. Knowing his situation makes his options, however poverty stricken, clear, which in turn brings him face to face with his role in the matter—the anguish of his choice. To exist himself—to live—in an antiblack world as though he were not seen as black, an Other, would be sheer self-denial.

But, we ask, How meaningful is any of his actions in changing his situation?

Our formal goal is an ontological one. Since we reject the notion of a “pure,” unmediated ontology in itself as opposed to a mediated or interpreted ontology,⁵³ our discussion of existence should not stand as a discussion of what “is” without presenting interpretations of the positive dimensions of what it means “to be.” We suggest that “to be” is to be-as-at-least-one-situation-or-another. This is not identical with being-at-least-one-situation-or-another. Yet description of an antiblack ontology as a distorted ontology—an ontology *in* bad faith instead of one perpetually threatened by bad faith—suggests an ontological perspective that is not distorted. Such an ontological perspective stands true without mediation. This suggestion interestingly brings us back to the liberation question, for this undistorted ontology seems to depend on a rejection of the “must be” attitude. It calls for a recognition of contingency “in-itself.” To liberate ourselves from an ontological perspective of pure presence (and the attitudes that accompany it), we need to admit, at bottom, that our situation doesn’t have to be as it is. We need to embrace the negative aspects of existence in the form of existential or radical conversions hinted at in *Being and Nothingness*. Thus, although the bad-faith situation of institutional bad faith puts the black in conflict with the white subject as his Other, it doesn’t follow that part of that conflict cannot mean the black’s effort to transform that relationship. The whole point of the black’s being able to recognize there being something wrong with the relationship of his objectification rests on his awareness of

the possibility of an alternative situation—that he has a perspective on the world, that he is a human being. It is this awareness that makes the type of revenge situations described earlier possible. In his treatment of the situation of slaves and masters in the slave colony of San Domingo, C. L. R. James provides support for our view of human awareness:

The difficulty was that though one could trap them like animals, transport them in pens, work them alongside an ass or a horse and beat both with the same stick, stable them and starve them, they remained, despite their black skins and curly hair, quite invincibly human beings; with the intelligence and resentments of human beings. To cow them into the necessary docility and acceptance necessitated a régime of calculated brutality and terrorism, and it is this that explains the unusual spectacle of property-owners apparently careless of preserving their property: they had first to ensure their own safety.⁵⁴

The fundamental problem with Fanon's rejection of a possible ontological description of that situation is that it fails to appreciate the *existential* dimensions of the black situation. This is probably the reason for Fanon's proviso "once [such an ontology] is admitted as leaving existence by the wayside." The ontology he is criticizing is the form that demands ontology to look at the black from the "outside." Yet his own experience of being the black man seen as being seen—"Look, Negro!"—can only be understood as a realization of perspectivity, as an existential situation. His analysis calls for, and in fact is, an appreciation of the body as an ontological figure constantly confronted by the possibility of a bad-faith reduction of itself, a reduction into pure Presence or pure Absence. That the black body is interpreted as a black body by way of the two dimensions of being-seen and seen-as-being-seen calls for an assessment of such interpretations. This assessment we have already made: that such assessments call for an analysis from the critical standpoint of bad faith. Sartrean ontology is such a critical ontology.

To an extent, then, we have already described antiblack racism in a way that reveals its critical ontological or, better, existential dimensions. What is existential about racism is that it is a form of bad faith, which is a phenomenological ontological or existential phenomenological concept. The ethnophilosophical aims of Tempels, against which Fanon was arguing, are different from ours.⁵⁵ It is in recognition of the limitations of the ontological scope of ethnic categories that we have from the outset rejected the prefix "African" as in African-American, as the focus of our study. When Fanon writes, "What use are reflections on Bantu ontology when one reads elsewhere [of Apartheid in South Africa]?" we respond that ontology, understood from the standpoint of bad faith, offers basic reasons for the failure of *Bantu* ontology. Such an ontology isn't basic; it attempts to formulate human reality not

only in terms of a specific form of human reality—specifically Baluba society (see Mbiti, 1970, 14)—but also in terms of a metaphysics of *presence*, that is, forms of being-in-itself. Ontology, properly understood, reveals that human being can only be positively universalized in bad faith precisely because human being also *lives* as a negative, nihilating being. Apartheid, for example, was an effort to ossify man.

Antiblack racism is a form of bad faith because it is an effort to evade facing human beings in their ambiguity or, as we prefer, in the flesh. This means that antiblack racism is ontologically significant since bad faith is an ontological category. That antiblack racism is politically significant is already conceded by Sartre and Fanon. The relationship between bad faith and antiblack racism results in the following remarkable conclusion: not only does it challenge Fanon's death sentence on ontological studies of race, but it also challenges the view that existential ontology, as developed in *Being and Nothingness*, is without political distinction.

These considerations bring us to a matter in which the relationship between bad faith and antiblack racism is of great importance: the problem of legitimacy in the human sciences. How can there be a science of human beings, the challenge goes, if there were no ontological dimension of human beings? Similarly, how can one study antiblack racism and black people when there are already problems involved in studying people? A clue rests in what is at bottom required of the interpreter of human phenomena. Husserl's discussion of the body is helpful here. He writes, "If we stick to our *de facto* experience of someone else as it comes to pass at any time, we find that actually the *sensuously seen body* is experienced forthwith as *the body of someone else* and not as merely an indication of someone else" (Husserl 1960, sec. 55, p. 121). The demand then becomes an admission of what we see: "What I actually see is not a sign and not a mere analogue, a depiction in any natural sense of the word; on the contrary, it is someone else" (124). To *see* human beings requires an admission of the ontological challenge of human encounter. The critical ontological role of the concept of bad faith in the study of human phenomena is that of a hermeneutical scheme in which to understand human *beings* in the face of the rejection of human *nature* and a reductive view of history. Fanon's "sociogenic" approach, which employs the methodological tools available to the situation under concern, is an effort toward such an analysis. This method is demonstrated in the entire Fanon corpus as a form of critical existential phenomenological description of the relationship between social-scientific "data" and the human effort to be made evident, to be seen as human, amid the data. That is why Fanon's "subjects" always at some point "speak," come through, in his work. Human beings, he suggests, require case-study analyses to be understood. This is not to disregard physiological and macro data. It is instead to offer considerations

from which the data can contribute to descriptions of actual human beings.

What existential phenomenology has to offer anyone concerned with the study of race, then, are explanations of three aspects of antiblack racism. The first is that the concept of bad faith hits the core of the existential situation of blacks by providing an account of why black men and women feel responsible for their condition. They are oppressed by a sadist's realization of both his anonymity and their freedom. At the end of *Black Skin, White Masks*, Fanon prays, "O my body, make of me always a man who questions!" But he knows that as a black man he *lives* the question—Why? Why *us*? Why *me*? Some years later, this questioning led to a realization similar to our own:

I shall be found to use terms like "metaphysical guilt," or "obsession with purity." I shall ask the reader not to be surprised: these will be accurate to the extent to which it is understood that since what is important cannot be attained, or more precisely, since what is important is not really sought after, one falls back on what is contingent. This is one of the laws of recrimination and of bad faith. The urgent thing is to rediscover what is important beneath what is contingent. (1967a, 18)

The second insight is the self-reflective dimension of examining the world from the standpoint of bad faith. The only privilege the inquirer into antiblack racist phenomena has is his situation as a human being, a situation that leaves him constantly in the face of a possible slide into bad faith. His inquiry, like all "good" inquiry, must be a critical inquiry.

The third insight is that, just as in the wake of God's devastation man is born, so too in man's devastation racism is born. In Fanon's own words, "The disaster and the inhumanity of the white man lie in the fact that somewhere he has killed man" (1967, 231). One fights against racism to liberate human beings. It is with this assessment of the implications of antiblack racism that we now begin an exploration of "God" in an antiblack world.

PART IV

“God” in an Antiblack World

AN ANTIBLACK COSMOGONY

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness *was* upon the face of the deep. And the spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.

And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.

And God saw the light, that *it was* good; and God divided the light from the darkness.

And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.

—Genesis 1:1–5

In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

The same was in the beginning with God.

All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made.

In him was life; and the life was the light of men.

And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not. . . .

And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.

—John 1:1–14

Now as Adam was white, Abraham white and our Savior white, did he enter heaven when he arose from the dead as a white man or as a negro? If as a white man, then the negro is left out; if as a negro then the white man is left out. As Adam was the Son of God and as God is light (white) and in Him is no darkness (black) at all, how could God then be the father of the negro, as like begets like? And if God could not be the father of the blacks because He was white, how could our Savior, "being the express image of God's person," as asserted by St. Paul, carry such a damned color into heaven, where all are white, much less to the throne?

—Reverend Buchner Payne

I was even lonelier and more vulnerable than I had been before. And the blood of the Lamb had not cleansed me in any way whatever. I was just as black as I had been the day that I was born. . . . "The white man's Heaven," sings a Black Muslim minister, "is the black man's Hell." . . . The Africans put it another way: When the white man came to Africa, the white man had the Bible and the African had the land, but now it is the white man who is being, reluctantly and bloodily, separated from the land, and the African who is still attempting to digest or to vomit up the Bible. . . . If the concept of God has any validity or any use, it can only be to make us larger, freer, and more loving. If God cannot do this, then it is time we got rid of Him.

—James Baldwin

WE have now come to the most literal meaning of bad faith as faith that has gone bad or perhaps faith that was never good in the first place. There is already a great corpus of literature on the theology of God in an antiblack world.¹ That discussion is situated in the historical context of the three prominent Western religions: Judaism, Christianity, and Islam. It has also received some treatment in its variations of Buddhism, as well as Obeah, Yoruba, and other traditional African religions. Since contemporary blacks are situated under and subject to the most forceful concerns of the major three, primarily because most black people today are either Christian, Muslim, or Jewish, and the people who dominate black people today are primarily members of at least the first two, I will use the symbols of the major three as the context for the rest of our discussion. I should like here to make it explicit that my aims are not theological but philosophical. Thus my interpretations are based, with few exceptions, on the theological standpoints of philosophers, and my interpretations are constrained by the domain in which my analysis is situated: a universe hostile to black presence.

“Is God a White Racist?”

GOD in an antiblack world has already been articulated in 1973 in the most provocative text in black theology, which continues to be a source of concern and dread by black theologians and religious philosophers: William Jones's *Is God a White Racist?* The general claim for rejecting this work is that its focus on theodicy doesn't adequately capture the black religious experience as an experience of liberation. Since our concern in this study isn't primarily one of liberation, this claim doesn't pertain to us. In our project of exploring the spirit of seriousness or Manichaeism of antiblack racism, theodicy is an extremely important concern. And that even the most prominent black theologian, James Cone, has admitted that he has not been able adequately to answer Jones's challenge of a black theodicy emphasizes the importance of that work toward the understanding of antiblackness. In Cone's words,

No one has provided a deeper challenge to Black Theology than has the philosophical critique of William Jones. His book, *Is God a White Racist?* (1973), shook Black theologians out of their "liberation complacency" and forced them to deal with the problem of theodicy at a deeper level. If God is liberating the Black poor from oppression, as Black theologians say, where is the liberation event that can serve as evidence of that fact? The question has not been answered to anyone's satisfaction, and thus continues to serve as a check against the tendency of substituting liberation rhetoric for actual events of freedom. (197)

Jones poses W. E. B. Du Bois's famous question, "What meaneth black suffering?" (xiii).² The meaning of this question in an antiblack world is obvious: to purify the world of blackness. Since Jones's concerns are more theological than ontological, he explores this question of the meaning of black suffering in the historical theistic situation of black, specifically black American, theological scholarship. He points out, however, that the meaning of black suffering seems to be linked, at least philosophically, to the question of God's intentions.

To paraphrase Kant's admonition, my objective is to force the black theo-

logians and their readers to pause a moment and, neglecting all that they have said and done, to reconsider their conclusions in the light of another question: Is God a white racist? (xiii)

Jones explores this question under the conceptual scheme of "Divine Racism." Divine racism is characterized by (1) the basic presupposition of mankind as a "two-category system" of an "in" and an "out" group, (2) the two-category system's being correlated with an imbalance of suffering for the "out" group and less suffering (if suffering at all) for the "in" group, (3) God's being responsible for the imbalance of suffering for the "out" group, (4) God's favor or disfavor being associated with God's racial preference, and (5) God's being a member of the "in" group (3-5). Antiblack divine racism suggests that God is part of the "in" group (whites) and blacks are part of the "out" group.

The efforts to rationalize black suffering as part of a divine theological plan are flawed, argues Jones, because of an unwillingness to regard the multi-evidentiality of suffering and the historical situation of black people—in our terms, because of bad faith toward evidence. In terms of suffering, Jones writes that "a demonic deity is a possible deduction—I do not say the only one—from every event asserting God's benevolence. And the step is indeed a short one from a demonic deity to a divine racist" (9). God can be interpreted as setting in place a divine plan for a moral of liberation through black people, or God can simply be a sadist having fun. Can the latter disjunct seriously be disputed without a straight-out circular appeal to God's being good? How can we step out of this stalemate of evidence?

Jones suggests an existential path of regarding God, like man, as the sum total of his acts (10). God "is" what God does. It is tempting to think that this ascription of God is Hegelian, but this would not be the case, since Hegel's Geist is a being whose embodiment is rational necessity. Jones's existential God faces his possibilities—he *could* have not been an antiblack racist—but Hegel's Geist could not have been otherwise and cannot be otherwise than what he will be in accordance with history's eventual culmination of self-consciousness.³ With this active, existential interpretation of God, Jones avers that the history of black people suggests that God is either (1) able to prevent black suffering but refuses to, or (2) wants to prevent black suffering but is unable to (12). Those who take the view of God as "benevolent" are inclined to assert the first conjunct of (2), that He wants to prevent black suffering. But the problem with (2) is that its second conjunct requires the rejection of God as omnipotent; God can, after all, do whatever God wants. The absurdity of (2) leads us to (1). But (1) suggests that God is a sadist. Since there is no point in rejecting God's omnipotence, at least from the standpoint of true believers, (1) seems to be a likely conclusion.

Even if we respond that black suffering is but a minute period of God's plans, the problem, from the existential perspective of *actions*, is that we have no more reason to believe that God will help black people than that God will continue to be indifferent to, or perhaps even relish, black suffering. Verification for that question can only be sought under some circumstance that will itself be subject to multievidential interpretation. What God seems to mean *yesterday* and *today* is black suffering.

It should be noted that a presupposition of racism is a state of war between superior and inferior races. Thus, as contended by Reverend Payne, whatever benefits one race hurts the other. Hence Jesus' historical choice of being white, from the antiblack perspective, entails the rejection of blackness. This rejection is borne out, from such a perspective, as historical fact. God is not, as thought by black theologians, in those who suffer. God is in those who benefit from the world God has created for them.

Jones then issues an immanent critique of black theologians' efforts to articulate their suffering as an example of God's liberating plan and offers, in their place, what we may call a form of authenticity which requires that "Man must act *as if* he were the ultimate valuator or the ultimate agent in human history or both" (xxii; see also part 3). This is the best way, he argues, either to reduce or to eliminate God's responsibility for the black condition and the white role in it. We can call this conclusion a variation of the classic Augustinian view that God is not the cause of sin by virtue of human freedom. It is not God but we who sin.

What does the black have to lose? If he accepts God, he suffers. If he rejects God, he suffers. This two-fold path of suffering suggests only one perspective of God (should the black not regard himself as "deserving" his suffering): that if benevolence is an essential property, if you will, of God, then, for the black, God must not exist, for God has not manifested himself as a benevolent being in the concrete reality of black experience (32-33). This is clearly the view of James Baldwin, at least as regards the conventional conceptions of God as Good, White, and Beyond. "White people hold the power," writes Baldwin, "which means that they are superior to blacks (intrinsically, that is: God decreed it so), and the world has innumerable ways of making this difference known and felt and feared" (1962, 40).

Baldwin is aware of a pervasive condition of bad faith regarding God. He is aware that from the antiblack standpoint, God's whiteness isn't an issue. It is a presumption. But from the black standpoint, God's whiteness is a problem that gnaws at the pre-reflective consciousness of every black; he knows that it takes an act of reflection, perhaps in bad faith as well, on his part to make God non-white just as much as it does on the part of a white to make God non-white. Baldwin then goes to the heart of the matter. "But God—and I felt this even then, so long ago, on that tremendous [church]

floor, unwillingly—is white. And if His love was so great, and if He loved all His children, why were we, the blacks, cast down so far? Why?" (46).

What concerns us is not simply that there is suffering, but that *blacks* suffer. Why blacks? Our answer is ultimately like that of our answer to the question of black presence. The answer requires an antiblack world in which blackness/womanness is ultimate Otherness. But if blackness is ultimate Otherness, then is blackness also ultimate Otherness even to God? From the standpoint of antiblack racism, the answer is clear: yes.

The White God and the Black Sufferer

BLACKNESS is trouble. Blackness is Absence. Blackness is a hole. Blackness is *that which has gone wrong*. "Let there be light!" The cry is taken as literal in an antiblack world. The antimiscegenation law is ontological in its purpose—to protect the light from darkness. Power and Will channel themselves toward light. The Hebrew God, like most gods, is paradoxical. He said, "Let there be light," so we ask, Was He then situated in darkness?

There is hardly any point in pursuing the details of the classical theodicy implicit here. The Persian apostle Mani was, after all, demanding consistency. God is either all white and good or not good at all and hence all black.

From the standpoint of the black who has rejected God, an awful lot of black people seem to be quite misguided. They embrace myths which on the deepest level regard them as obscene. From the standpoint of these myths black people don't even *suffer*. How can black suffering be taken seriously if blacks are not even regarded as members of the universal, as members of humanity?

But as Kierkegaard has observed, the law of noncontradiction has no home in the Kingdom of God. The most faithful is he who can embrace a spiritual paradox (1983, esp. 70–71). So an awful lot of black people are faithful and quite paradoxical. They are aware of who God is, and they worship Him anyway.

Yet, there are blacks who have said good-bye to "God." Sickened by the sight of many a black folk kneeling in front of Michelangelo's models and William Blake's *Ancient Days*, they have become aware of the historical "bleaching" of divine figures. As Eulalio Baltazar puts it in *The Dark Center*,

An even more significant influence of the color symbolism was the operative process of deliberately whitening or bleaching the center of the Christian Faith, namely, Jesus Christ, from a Semitic to an Aryan person to which the entire history of Western painting bears witness. Both Aryans and Gentiles, even the most anti-Semitic, worship their God incarnated in a Jewish body. But, as Bastide observes, "this Jewish body was not white

enough for them." As a result "the dark hair that Christ was thought to have had came to be rendered as very light-colored, and his big dark eyes as blue." The bleaching process in which Christ's hair and beard assume the color of sunshine, symbolizing the brightness of the light above, and his eyes, the color of the sky from which he descended and to which he returned marked the entire history of Western painting. Bastide rightly notes that "the progressive Aryanization of Christ is in strict accordance with theology of the color symbolism," namely, that "it was necessary that this man, the incarnation of God, be as far removed as possible from everything that could suggest darkness or blackness, even indirectly." (32)

There are blacks who have begun to realize that learning how to live without the white God also entails realizing that they don't need to be "saved." Even if God's membership in the "in" group is rejected, God's "behavior" would still appear an awful lot like a black who shouts "nigger!"

"Jesus was black, you know?" I have heard for some time now. With the recent attacks on afrocentricity, the declaration has gained some reservations:

"Well . . . it's not that he was black, in the sense of negroid, but that he was colored—like the Palestinians of today, you know, dark, with curly hair, tanned, 'olive'-skinned."

"Well, in our case," interrupts a Black Muslim, "Allah is undoubtedly black."

Or a Rastafarian, "No, we're not into that white Jesus nonsense. It has been prophesied that the Messiah will be a descendant of David, and His Majesty Haile Selassie was such a descendent."

What we have here is a certain attitude toward evidence. Evidence is presented for the fulfillment of desire. We know that it doesn't matter what the historic prophets actually looked like. It also doesn't matter what Jesus actually looked like. Even if he were what *we* may call black, the point is that he may not have known this and that in order to "be" God in the flesh he may have been caught in a situation similar to that of all black figures who become "authority"—he may have had to see himself as white. What is the point of being black if he and the others with whom he had contact were not aware of it? In an antiblack world, the issue is what divinity *must be*.

Blacks and whites are caught in a futile situation in an antiblack world. The black is always *too black*. The white, on the other hand, is *never white enough*—except from the standpoint of the black. For the black, to be white enough is to be a human being and hence one step closer to God. But since such a goal is out of his reach, he might as well regard whiteness as divine. If the black *is* human, and whiteness is above blackness, then to be white is tantamount to being a god. The white is aware of this ideal. But every white is simultaneously aware of not being this ideal. To *be* white requires the choice of whiteness as a project. There are people who would be considered white in some societies but for the fact that they live themselves as

non-white. Think of some Caucasian ethnics in the United States and some Caucasian social pariah in parts of the world where there are ethnic problems in the face of a powerful governmental force associated with whiteness—for instance, England's relation to Ireland or Russia's previous relation to much of Eastern Europe, or even the case of some mulattoes in countries like Martinique and Haiti. That whiteness is a project—an ongoing choice of identity—makes whiteness a goal of the white in an antiblack world. The problem, however, is that whiteness cannot be a project at all without a given condition of blackness. It is the realization of the blackness, or potential blackness, in every white that makes his whiteness an object of his own desire.

Picture a world without blackness *in toto*. No darkness—no sleep, no shades or lines by which to make objects distinct, no dark frame of reference. The situation becomes clear. Complete whiteness results in nothingness just as much as complete darkness. The original situation of bad faith, as we have seen, rests in a confrontation with a hole in being. It is in virtue of the hole that negativity is realized. It is in contact with the hole *within* that the vertigo experience of anguish emerges; it is in the decision to take flight from the hole—to plug it up, to pretend it isn't there—that bad faith is chosen as an original project.

The white is pre-reflectively aware that he can be no more white than he can be completely "full." His whiteness is in the class of what Sartre calls "unrealizables," those exteriorities which remain exteriorities despite our attempts to interiorize them. To seek to be full in an antiblack world is to seek to be the unrealizable ideal of being completely white.

So what, then, is God? Is Jones's argument correct? Is it the case that since the historical world is a Manichaeian dualism of good whiteness and wretched blackness, we cannot rule out the possibility that historical antiblackness suggests that God is not only white, but also a white racist?

If we recall the assumption that whatever benefits the white must harm the black and vice versa, the situation is moribund. If God is white, then the situation of blackness becomes that of eternal damnation. It would mean that the Eternal Eyes that constitute the Eternal Third from whose perspective black bodies are seen as what they are would be an antiblack perspective. Antiblackness would literally become *the natural condition*; it would be *the way things are* and *the way things will be*. Blacks would be essentially damned.

Ultimate Desire and Authenticity in an Antiblack World

Shame. Shame and self-contempt. Nausea. When people like me, they tell me it is in spite of my color. When they dislike me, they point out that it is not because of my color. Either way, I am locked into the infernal circle.

—Fanon (1967, 116)

FROM the Sartrean perspective, God is a desire for the ideal, not an achievement. From the standpoint of being *in* bad faith, especially in the form of the spirit of seriousness, God is “out there” with his arms held open, waiting to embrace us. From the standpoint of the black in an antiblack world, God is a desire that can never truly be satisfied—the desire to be white. From the standpoint of the white in an antiblack world, God is the hoped-for “we” upon whom the white assumption of being God can be deferred. Since whiteness is the ideal, the white man is either God or as close to God as anyone can be on earth. Therefore he needs a transcendent God simultaneously to deny his hubris and affirm his whiteness. Can he, as it were, have his cake and eat it too?

We have pointed out that even a black has to go through an act of reflection in order not to imagine God as white. This poses an ontological problem. If the level of pre-reflection, of awareness, is existential, does this mean that God really is white? The answer is negative. Imagining seeps form into pre-reflection in a way that clouds it. There is no *pure* pre-reflection save existence itself.⁴ Pure pre-reflection is merely an ontological awareness on the basis of the path of pre-reflecting, which is a nihilating path away from objects as well as toward them. It is the “away” aspect of pre-reflection that bounces consciousness into the abyss of existence—that nothingness that nauseates human reality with its unique “taste,” that freedom in the face of which the human being experiences vertigo. The reflective act is therefore an effort to undermine the pre-reflective choice not only of a god, but also of the kind that is most desired in an antiblack world: a white one.

The black and the white desire a white god on a pre-reflective level primarily

because God *means* whiteness. The point at which meaning permeates the specificity of God is the point of a residue effect similar to the residue effect of indistinction; the reason God seems to be pre-reflectively white is that the expression "somewhat-like-God" carries a white residue, a ray of light through the darkness. Somewhat-like-God is associated with lightness, not darkness, despite the effort to articulate God's invisibility. Hence only the white can reflect upon himself as being pre-reflectively linked to God in his essential feature of value: his whiteness.

What happens to God?

Our first conclusion must be that God *as a nonracial object of desire* is dead in an antiblack world. This is because the white man, as God in the flesh, becomes a subject to overcome. He is not God, but he serves *as God*, for the white in such a world is the subject-object of desire—the Man, so to speak, the way to be: "But the being toward which human reality surpasses itself is not a transcendent God; it is at the heart of human reality; it is only human reality itself as totality" (Sartre 1956, 139). God is the Impossible Man. If we reject whiteness in an antiblack world, it must be because we seek humanity.

Hence neither the black man nor the white man is truly human in an antiblack world. This is because to be human, at least from the Sartrean perspective, is to desire to be God. Another of Sartre's departures from Hegel emerges. Whereas Hegel's work culminates in a conception of Geist as necessary, Sartre's work culminates in a view of God as futile. Whereas the primary figure in Hegel's philosophy is Geist, since the history of man ultimately expresses Geist, the primary figure in Sartre's philosophy is human reality, since the unrealizability of becoming God informs us of what it means to be human. The desire to be God establishes human reality; whereas for Hegel, human reality—history—confirms Geist. For Sartre, there is no establishment of God; there is only the fact of an impossible *intention*. But this original choice, this impossible intention, has been sabotaged in an antiblack world. What is instead desired is a certain type of Man, a man above all men. Authenticity in this world becomes a peculiar demand: that the white man abandons being God and the black man rejects not being a man; the former must step down to humanity, which amounts to stepping up to authenticity, and the latter should step up to humanity, which amounts to stepping up to authenticity as well. The result is an egalitarian goal of human reality. Authenticity in an antiblack world is the realization that human reality is itself a project.

This conclusion is not, however, without problems.

First, Sartre claims that "the passion of man is the reverse of that of Christ, for man loses himself as man in order that God may be born" (784). So it would seem that if man were to reclaim himself as man, God will die.

But if humanity then becomes an ideal,⁵ and humanity is the desire to be God, does humanity also become impossible in virtue of the satisfaction of its ultimate desire?

Second, the goal of wiping whiteness and blackness away in favor of humanity carries the infamous assimilation aporia.⁶ In *Anti-Semite and Jew*, Sartre poses the problem:

The Jews have one friend, however, the democrat. But he is a feeble protector. No doubt he proclaims that all men have equal rights; no doubt he has founded the League for the Rights of Man; but his own declarations show the weakness of his position . . . , there may not be so much difference between the anti-Semite and the democrat. The former wishes to destroy [the Jew] as a man and leave nothing in him but the Jew, the pariah, the untouchable; the latter wishes to destroy him as a Jew and leave nothing in him but the man, the abstract and universal subject of the rights of man and the rights of the citizen. Thus there may be detected in the most liberal democrat a tinge of anti-Semitism; he is hostile to the Jew to the extent that the latter thinks of himself as a Jew. . . . Between his enemy and his defender, the Jew is in a difficult situation: apparently he can do no more than choose the sauce with which he will be devoured. (55–58).⁷

The assimilation argument is ultimately an argument built upon the perspective of the Third. The Third seeks humanity in a redundant way, for he knows that *he* is regarded as humanity, as the universal. What he wishes to destroy is the perspective from which he is seen as oppressive. But in the process, he embodies a misanthropic consciousness toward the oppressed by wishing, in the end, that they would simply disappear. This argument applies not only to Jews, but also, as Sartre observes in “Black Orpheus,” to blacks; the fundamental project of blacks is the overcoming of racism—enter the supposedly ethical plane of the universal—without at the same time becoming victims of such an overcoming. Since the matrices of ultimate Otherness in an antiblack world are the coextensive binary basics of gender and the quality/color extremes of white and black, the consequence is another formulation of this aporia: How can oppressed groups become subjects instead of objects without loss of their identity?

At first glance, this formulation may seem like a form of bad faith. Recall that “Bad faith seeks to affirm their identity while preserving their differences. It must affirm facticity as *being* transcendence and transcendence as *being* facticity, in such a way that at the instant when a person apprehends the one he can find himself abruptly faced with the other” (1956, 98). A black who denies the fact of his blackness but also denies the implications of his “humanness” would fall under this description. Opposed to this formulation is a black who recognizes the fact of his blackness and calls for an

admission of his role as a *subject*—that is, a human being. Charles Taylor discusses this problem as one faced by proponents of the "politics of difference," proponents who face the possibility of being in bad faith by both denying and preserving the dualities of their existence. Taylor points out that one form of good faith in this situation is the recognition of the *survival* element of difference politics (1992, 40–41). What is at stake is the existence of the group deemed "different." We have already shown that mere universality evades the question of difference to begin with.⁸

In answer to the first aporia, it seems that regarding humanity, and hence freedom, as the fundamental object of desire poses no real problem. Such a goal can be regarded as a factual aspect of the situation of antiblackness as a form of humanity that has been lost. To seek humanity isn't a problem. But it can also be argued that since God is also lost, and since God is a fundamental feature of human desire, to regain humanity, we must seek God, but we must do so in the form of God being the rejection of whiteness. Yet this route seems to be flawed, for to introduce God again requires putting to the side humanity as a project.

Our second aporia requires addressing the supposed internal contradiction of an appeal to humanity in the face of difference. Although racism precedes Descartes, this response to racism seems to have a peculiar Cartesian quality to it. The "in" race is analogous to the Cartesian *Cogito* and the "out" race is analogous to the Cartesian notion of extended substance. The problem, from this perspective, becomes that of regarding the "out" group as "in," of transforming it from extended substance to *Cogito* and, hence, human substance. Sartre's admonishment of this solution to the situation of antiblackness and anti-Semitism requires a critique of the notion of Other as extended *substance* to begin with. Implicit in Sartre's objection is the delineation of two distorted objectives, both of which flow out of the assumption of human reality as a form of substance.

First, why not shift from the Other as problem and instead focus on the problematic *Cogito* to begin with? Put differently, why not simply shift to an "antiracist racism," which requires throwing the white man and the white God "out" as primary substances instead of bringing black people "in"? As Fanon argued, there is supposedly no white Other when a white encounters a black in an antiblack world; the white *is* the subject/master. Blacks only meet *others* in the absence of whites. Hence the white God is the rug that needs to be pulled from under the white man.

Second, and perhaps more central to our discussion, why should difference be a problem to begin with? The problem *of* the Other's difference is an evasion of the problem faced *by* the Other who is different. Yet, the first objective is problematic in the sense that it requires an act of hatred, an act which, as we have argued so far, reeks of misanthropy. Is it our ironic

historical situation that we cannot seriously throw the white God out without hating the white man?

The second objective identifies the problem with the assimilationist's argument, that it is also in the same category of hatred. It manifests a desire to eliminate the Other *as* Other—in other words, to create a world of only one *kind* of human being who stands in relation to others roughly as consciousness in denial of itself as body. It takes a minor step in reasoning to realize that such a deduction will never cease except in a world of only one individual who is left incapable of seeing himself since he will lack others as those in virtue of whom he can regard himself as not only being conscious but also as being-in-situation, as being seen as a human Other. The result is misanthropy to the greatest degree.⁹

That misanthropy is a consequence of desire in an antiblack world is not surprising.¹⁰ The additional conclusion is that the rejection of racist categories in an antiblack world doesn't necessarily lead to a nonracist human condition. This is because antiblack racism places a "limit" on human reality that calls for an ethics that is not built upon the presumption of similarity, but is instead built upon the presumption of difference—an ethics of Otherness. The blackness in all "Others" stands as a negation to the white subject; Others ultimately stand as holes that are not filled by whiteness. This ethics of Otherness accepts the role of the universal as a pole from which the particular can be understood as the kind of situation it is. If Sartre is correct that being-in-itself is the universal whose contradiction "is" being-for-itself, then this ethics of Otherness is the authentic relation between being-in-itself and being-for-itself. Such an ethics also paradoxically regards the universal as a *limited*, bounded ethical category.

Is such an ethics possible?

I suspect the answer to this question rests on the root question of suicide and the black/feminine response to this question.

"Why don't black people kill themselves?" is a remark often raised by antiblack racists. The question betrays the sense of the black condition as a sort of perseverance in the face of a logic calling for the contrary. Like Dostoyevsky's *Underground Man*, blacks seem to live in spite of logic. From the standpoint of an antiblack world, blacks should not exist, so a live black has a lot of explaining to do. This demand for explanation is a core feature of racism, that others' existence isn't justified. But since the questioner's is self-justified, the questioner has provided himself with the privileged position of playing God. The suicidal query can thus be reformulated, "Why don't black people kill the ultimate object of their ire?" After all, the root alienation of themselves beyond themselves seems to be ultimately out of their reach. From the antiblack perspective, eliminating the aspect of themselves that is alienating—their blackness—seems to be the rational alternative.

The road out of misanthropy is a road that leads to the appreciation of the importance of difference. Let us take seriously the view that blacks/women aren't ignorant, that they know that the object of their reverence is a white man, and a sadistic one at that. They seem somehow to love "Him" anyway. They seem somehow to appreciate Him, this perspective from which they are so oppositional, so distanced, that *they* are the ultimate embodied Other. If this is so—that they don't worship God under the presumption of themselves being white, of themselves having *some* whiteness within—then their faith stands like Kierkegaard's notion, in his *Works of Love*, of loving the dead:

In order properly to test whether or not love is faithful, one eliminates everything whereby the object could in some way aid him in being faithful. But all this is absent in the relationship to one who is dead, one who is not an *actual* object. If love still abides, it is most faithful. (325)

Like the dead, God is forever out of the reach of black people in an antiblack world. Yet it is precisely this impossibility of salvation that sets the context for an ethics—or perhaps better, a faith—of difference. It signals the paradox of faith that emerges between all black/feminine-white/masculine relations.

I walk down the street, mumbling to myself, I see an elderly black woman toting two heavy bags. She's finished a day's work at the white lady's house. She is weary, frowning. I say, as a matter of course, "How's it goin'?" she looks up. Her face brightens. "Fine. And you?"

Three young black kids are swaggering along. As they come toward me, I say, "How's it goin'?" The tall one in the middle is startled. "Fine. And you?" (Terkel, 42)

There are some obvious power elements to be considered in this Studs Terkel's example. He is a white man. He faces the "white problem." The white problem is similar to the problem that Sartre faces when he attempts to come to grips with his bourgeois status in a world in which, at least morally, losers win.¹¹ Only the oppressed, it seems, can have salvation. Sartre understood that although each individual bourgeois cannot change the relation of the bourgeoisie to the proletariat, each individual bourgeois is nevertheless responsible for such a relationship. He faces a multitude of choices in his situation—whether to betray his class, whether to fight against the proletariat, whether to deny any responsibility for the whole situation, or whether simply to stand out of the proletariat's way. But in either circumstance his project is bankrupt in virtue of the fact that the revolution is not for him. Similarly, there are whites who may fight on behalf of racial justice, and they may even deploy interesting argument on the basis of self-interest, but in the end, there is the gnawing feeling that racial justice is not

for whites. To be black may mean to dream of liberation, but to be white means to face moral condemnation. This is the insight Sartre develops in *Notebooks for an Ethics* when he observes that the "kind" master is regarded by the slaves as more responsible and hence morally reprehensible, since by treating the slaves humanely he admits that they are human beings and should not be slaves.¹² Ethical action for the white man takes on a meaning that carries a genuine Kantian problematic: he literally has nothing to gain, for Salvation for him would have to be a matter of Kierkegaardian faith. Yet Studs Terkel recognizes that, despite the absurdity of his action, he must make the move toward contact with the Other. If blacks are the Other in the presence of whites, the ethics of difference among humanity falls upon whites as an existential situation in an antiblack world. The white or black who extends a hand to make contact with the Other has done so as a paradoxical act of faith by attempting the impossible, for no black can be equal to a white in an antiblack world, but from the standpoint of acts like that of loving the dead, such an impossibility doesn't matter. The act itself "is" its own freedom, its own authentic upsurge, that transforms the impossible into the ironic. It is the absurdity of the act that makes it possible.

To Be Black, Faithful, and Suffering

THE concept of God in itself is a paradigm case of bad faith from the standpoint of Sartrean ontology. Hence, there is no reason why the notion of a white God should fare any better. Of interest, however, is the implication of God in an *antiblack world*. The dualism of an antiblack world is analogous to the distorted presentation of transcendence and facticity as a dualism, a distorted presentation that makes not only bad faith possible, but also human reality possible. But in the antiblack world, each pole of the dualism is jelled, slimed into the pretense of a *de facto* dualism. For the white attempts to be the purity that he is not, and the black attempts the same. The ontological extremes of this purity are the quality of God as white and masculine and His opposite as black and feminine. Since only the white man can be like the first pair, he stands in the antiblack world as godlike in his particularity and, like the Christian man-god, God in the flesh in his form. The problem faced is that the white man would have to be coincident with his ideal at this point, which amounts to saying that the transcendent God has disappeared. The only alternatives are that whiteness or God itself is so ideal that no actual white man can ever achieve an identity relation with it, or that God or whiteness must be rejected, which makes humanity—Freedom—the ideal toward whom both whites and blacks aim. This freedom must, however, be approached through love, not hate, which requires respect for this freedom as Other.

We cannot, then, settle with our discussion of black female worship of the White God, for although the black/woman may be in touch with this Otherness, it doesn't help matters much if this Other is the white man. This Other must be so Other that his ideal becomes an impossibility even for the white man. This Other must be a God in front of whom the white man becomes Other without the hope of equality. The link between God and lightness must be broken.

To be liberated from the racism of a black-white world—to transform an antiblack world into a world in which there are people who can embrace

valued aspects of their particularity—requires an Impossible God. It requires not a Good God who is impossible, but instead a God whom all would be willing to reject if all were to continue to stand committed to antiblackness, a God that is neither white nor black, man nor woman, a God that, from such a perspective, doesn't exist.¹³ If man is “a useless passion” as Sartre insists, we can respond at this point that it is because “God,” the impossible, self-contradictory in-itself-for-itself, is such a useful one.¹⁴



PART V

Critical Encounters

“I-Thou”

TO examine critically the implications of applying bad faith to the study of antiblack racism, it will be fruitful to examine some of the usual stock of criticisms of Sartre's ontology.

The Sartre of *Being and Nothingness* is primarily concerned with questions of the confrontation of beings. What is the relationship, he asks, between consciousness (nothingness) and being-in-itself? From this standpoint, he launches existential ontology as a study of the disclosure of beings and the study of the revelation of the world as an ontology of being and nothingness. His description culminates in the question of the ontological status of the self and the Other—the problem of other selves. This problem has a great deal of limitation in the formulation, How is it possible that I am able to make contact with *the* Other? What happens to the idiosyncracies and peculiarities of *others*?¹

Sartre's discussion of the body provides an immediate response to these questions: to fail to see others as they live, as consciousnesses in the flesh engaged in varieties of situations, is to fail to see them in their existential, contradictory dimension. The body lives “in situation.” Thus Sartre's basic descriptions of subject-object conflicts should be regarded as frozen structures, as analyses of frozen aspects of human reality, as analyses of concrete relations with others *from the standpoint of bad faith*. The peculiarities of others provide context to the meanings of situations. To understand such encounters requires, ultimately, critical good faith toward the evidence presented in situations.²

Recall that the sadist is in bad faith because he denies not only the Other's transcendence, the Other's freedom, but also his own facticity. Likewise, the masochist denies not only his own transcendence, but also the Other's facticity. The sadist presents himself as subject and the masochist presents himself as object. But these isolated presentations are skewed reductions. That these are instances of bad faith suggests the possibility of alternative examples in good faith—just as good faith serves as a foundation of bad faith.³ Recall that bad faith is a choice. If we were not able to choose good faith in good faith, then we would cease to be responsible for our bad faith.

Thus if it is a form of bad faith to deny human reality, to attempt not to face human beings, then the alternative, good-faith situation must be one that involves the appreciation of the contradictions of human reality. Both the sadist and the masochist are demanded to face the human beings they encounter, which involves emancipating their presented identities from their presented reductions. Sartre thus appears to face a *reductio ad absurdum* against his formulation of human relationships in *Being and Nothingness*. If relationships that embrace the contradictions of human reality weren't possible, then bad faith would also not be possible in such relationships. There would be a case of evading freedom without being in bad faith. There is thus a form of transcendental argument here. Bad faith situations with others presuppose the possibility of our ability to make contact with each other, however tendentious, fragile, or fleeting such contact may be. We don't reach out to others in vain. Like authenticity, such contact is chosen, but only momentarily realized. Sartre's analysis can therefore be strengthened by pointing out that *Being and Nothingness*, if regarded from the standpoint of bad faith, reveals the potentials that thwart relationships—one of which is the presupposition that relationships can be established without effort and can be maintained on the level of the in-itself. This is obvious since the dyadic and triadic relationships that Sartre examines are forms of faulty reductions; they are reductions of human reality to transcendence or human reality to facticity. They are instances of the body in bad faith.

This observation on the importance of good-faith relationships with others as a foundation of bad-faith relationships with others provides us with an additional considerations against Fanon's death sentence on ontology. Fanon's argument relies on a stratified bad-faith relationship as a function of the historical weight of antiblack racism. But if this were so, then antiblack racism wouldn't be a form of bad faith. It would neither be wrong nor right, false nor true, deceptive nor authentic. It would simply "be." Antiblack racism would simply be a feature of the world as the Ice Age was a period of earth's geological history. To establish the *existential* problem of a man who asks, as Fanon does when he prays, "O my body, make of me always a man who questions!" Fanon needs the possibility of good faith. We needn't reiterate the formal significance of this possibility.

Our position on the problem of sociality may leave some of Sartre's critics unsatisfied—particularly those who require that good-faith situations take the form of what is described in the English translation of *Being and Nothingness* as "we" relationships—that is, subject-subject relationships. Most of Sartre's critics consider his attack on such relationships as simply a glaring contradiction of experience. In Buberian terms, he fails to account for the fact of I-Thou encounters. Structurally, this is because Sartre's analysis is supposedly ultimately built in the third person; he seems to be asking, "How

does he (the subject) account for *him* (the object)?" when he should be asking, "How do I account for the fact that I 'meet' *You*?"

Although the standard view is to treat Buber's categories as fundamentally different from Sartre's, it can be argued that Buber's view and Sartre's view aren't mutually exclusive except for their theological commitments. There is Buber's problematic theism versus Sartre's religious atheism. But, we ask, How would Sartre's formulations work in relation to his *readers*? There, he is in a relationship that at least requires the first person and the second person who, although susceptible to object formulations, can also be directly contacted. All writers and readers relate to each other as Thou.

The notion of there being a problem if any objectification occurs is based on the immediate reduction of the human being to the subject in the same manner that the human being is often reduced to "mind." For Sartre, neither mind alone nor subject alone constitutes human reality. Embodiment is the contradiction of such reductions. *I am conscious of You*. A part of *you* is negative, transcendent. But a part of you is that you stand individuated from *me*. The fact of embodiment makes you and I possible. That I make "contact" with you or Thou does not mean that I do not simultaneously commit an act of objectification in virtue of my being conscious of you.⁴

There are, however, some deeper concerns. All of our descriptions of bad-faith situations depended on our pointing out the contingency of situations deemed necessary. Our ontological perspective is therefore built upon contingency itself. This raises the following problem. Is an ontology built upon contingency a distorted ontology? Is an ontology that calls for contingency an ontology that is itself without contingency?

Sartre has presented a fundamental insight into all ontological questions when he advances the notion of nothingness as a central feature of human reality. In our discussion of antiblack racism, we pointed out that human ambiguity is presented as absent in the form of the comfortable untruth of complete, closed, full, white presence and incomplete, open, empty, black absence. When an individual is ossified with a white or black identity as his complete identity, he is in bad faith primarily because of his denial of his own nothingness—his own potential to be not wholly what he "is." Bad faith emerges in these color symbols as an effort to wipe out the contingency of the significance of these symbols. At bottom these symbols are really signs; they point beyond the freedoms that embody them. The freedoms are a special kind of "limit." It does not make sense to ask what is beyond the beyond, what is beyond nothing. A contingent ontology is thus neither necessary nor contingent beyond itself; it lacks a context, a perspective, beyond itself to make sense of either necessity or contingency.

Ethical Concerns

WE have now come to perhaps the major concern with embracing Sartre's critical ontology. We, provided we are neither sadistic nor oppressive, don't want to say that it isn't necessary to change an oppressive situation. We want to say that we *ought* to change it. We want prescription for change, not a description of the fact of choice. This is the standpoint of the usual stock of criticisms against Sartrean ontology. Perhaps a brief adumbration of them is in order.

Sartre focuses too much on absolute or radical freedom, it is said, which leaves him with an impoverished view of actual choices. "Real" choice is based, it is claimed, on factors like the chooser's character.⁵ Second, the notion that radical freedom serves as a foundation of value suffers from the flaw of vacuity. Choice-in-itself is empty. Sartre tells us that we must do "something," but this something is so anonymous that its significance becomes pointless or trivial.⁶ Writes one critic, "I want to decide freely, but not by chance. I cannot be trapped in an ethics of indifference where the exercise of freedom is equivalent to tossing a coin. Chance is no foundation for moral action. I must base my decisions on facts and reasons" (Fronidizi, 389-90).

The appeal to "character" is not without its own flaws. It is much like the chicken-or-the-egg debate. Sartre's point is that even if we have a sense of ourselves that we call our "character," we have to choose among or between options that conform to, and hence confirm, that character. We face the anguish of the possibility of choosing to act "out of character." This very possibility makes acting "in" character a self-deceiving form of necessity.⁷

Sartre doesn't stand particularly opposed to the second criticism. This is because he not only uses it against hyper-freedom or what he calls the "anarchic" consciousness, but he also presupposes it throughout *Being and Nothingness* and his subsequent work.⁸ The purpose of Sartre's discussion of the body and what it means to be in-situation concedes the limitations of anonymous choice. One takes flight to radical freedom only by denying one's situations, just as one takes flight to complete facticity by denying one's ontological situation of anguish.⁹

Yet these two forms of criticism address an important limitation of Sartre's ontological analysis of freedom, albeit in a misguided way. Sartre doesn't provide us with what we ought to do, only that we are lying to ourselves when we claim that we are not responsible for what we do. But the concern for a form of prescriptive ethics on the basis of Sartrean ontology reflects a mistaken view of the Sartrean project, at least in *Being and Nothingness*, since the role of the philosopher, from the Sartrean perspective, is not to be our shepherd. The philosopher is not here with the Word. Save that for the Serious Man of Right.

For the study of antiblack racism, these objections to Sartre prove unhelpful primarily because they lead inevitably to the conclusion that antiblack racism reflects a form of "bad character." All we are left with is a world in which a great deal of people are apparently "bad." This is a comforting appeal for people who would like to believe that they are "good." Such a stand is not only Manichaeian, but it encourages the sort of distorting picture of racial matters that closes off the wider sense of responsibility for a racist society. How can one be responsible for others' character if we defer prescription to the Serious Man of Right?

Our question is a serious question and it brings us to another moralist attack on Sartre—the infamous deconstructionist attack, although the stance of moralism is one that deconstructionists may vehemently deny.

Deconstruction

An ill-tempered speaker might say: I don't see the connection [between deconstruction and justice], no rhetoric could bend itself to such an exercise. . . . Such a speaker wouldn't merely be in a bad temper, he'd be in bad faith. . . . The "sufferance" of deconstruction, what makes it suffer and what makes those it torments suffer, is perhaps the absence of rules, of norms, and definitive criteria that would allow one to distinguish unequivocally between *droit* and justice.

—Jacques Derrida

THE purpose of the deconstructionist attack on the subject is an effort to free us from the "tyranny" of the dominating impact of mastery/substance/presence in Western metaphysics and consequently Western culture.¹⁰ This approach fails as a criticism against Sartre in obvious ways. The first and perhaps most obvious problem posed by a deconstructive critique of Sartre's ontology is the problem of common "suffering." Both deconstruction and Sartrean ontology face the "ill-tempered speaker," for both offer a critique of rules, norms, and definitive criteria for human reality—in both, that is, there is a critique of traditional ontological conceptions of philosophical anthropology by the revelation of such values as constructions.¹¹ But this shared "path" is more an intersection of different roads than a shared route on a common highway. Maurice Natanson once posed the following consideration, "If the existential commitment to reason is possible, why not an equivalent commitment to unreason? Is it possible to have an existential nihilism?" His response is illuminating.

It is the affirming act which distinguishes the rationalist from the nihilist, not a disposition to optimism. More cautiously stated, nihilism can be defined as the refusal of existential commitment and the consistent nihilist can offer neither explanations for his choices nor reasons for his decisions. A rationale of nihilism at this fundamental level (and obviously we are not discussing political positions of the sort that have sometimes been called "nihilist") is a contradiction in terms. If one insists on speaking of a "commitment" to nihilism, it is an order of commitment which transcends explication as well as justification. It follows that the "decision to decide" is implicitly a celebration of the rationality of man and his determination to persist in trying to understand a reality that in itself offers little in the way of philosophical encouragement. At the same time, existential

commitment illuminates the relationship between the concrete individual's life and the style of existence he has chosen. In the interplay between the concrete and the universal there arises a sense of social reality as the most matter of fact and yet the most remarkable of all things. (1963, 22–23)

If existential phenomenology poses an affirmative dimension of the “decision to decide,” the question is raised, What kind of dimension would follow from a rejection of existential phenomenology, here represented by Sartre's ontology? Our response warrants some recapitulation.

Recall that Sartre rejects the notion of a substantial self. Although he retains the subject (a dreaded point of departure in deconstruction) his subject is non-egological. Sartre is able to accomplish this, we have been arguing throughout, by way of his treatment of the body as an existential ontological figure that defies the traditional ontological category of “presence.” Sartre's treatment of the body thus resists some of the typical tropes of deconstruction—if by deconstruction is understood the unmasking of the metaphysics of Presence in philosophy and the seductive comfort that accompanies such metaphysics—by revealing the consequences of deconstructing *perspectivity*. One can deconstruct perspectivity to reveal it or to unmask it, and one can deconstruct perspectivity to destroy it.¹² The problem with the approach of destroying it is that such an approach manifests two forms of bad faith: the evasion of the body as seen and the evasion of the body as consciousness/freedom in the flesh. In this sense, then, even the positive project of deconstruction—*de*-constructing, re-building an interpretation from a de-centered world view, from the “margins,” after revealing its faulty, centric foundations—would be rather limited without consideration that no one is marginalized without the perspective, in the flesh, of marginality. Pure Absence, Absence without a point of view, is a form of bad faith that turns out to be the form of consciousness that it condemns. If the hope of deconstruction is the destruction of the notion of perspectivity as subject, there nevertheless remains the Manichaeian question of the “purity” of its point of departure—deconstruction-itself—which is no less than a perspective.¹³

A response could be that a move can be made toward the interpretive dimension of language itself, and the problem considered can be formulated in a language that poses no question of a perspective itself, a writing that poses no question of authorship itself, in virtue of its rejection of both dualistic and monistic dimensions, dimensions that inevitably situate power and privilege “somewhere.” Yet, something can be said about the linguistic-prelinguistic duality that emerges as the focus of such a deconstructive appeal to language itself. Consider the following observation:

If both the transcendental subject and the empirical subject are dissolved, the epistemic spaces which define the transcendental and the empirical

are displaced, and a new *epistēmē* is allowed to appear. This new *epistēmē* emerges after the "death of man" and appears in the guise of the "being of language." . . . The undergirding philosophical matrix of this linguistic framework . . . is the distinction between synchrony and diachrony. Indeed, in effect, in structuralist analysis the synchrony-diachrony doublet replaces the transcendental-empirical doublet. But instead of constituting an advance, this replacement represents a retrogression. . . . The sought after *archē*, which Foucault and the structuralists so diligently pursue, is positioned outside of time in a nonhistorical being of language.¹⁴

The appeal to (if not "centering" of) discourse in-itself becomes subject to the same kind of criticism that Kierkegaard issued against Hegel's System, but I would reformulate it thus: Why should the marginalized be interested in a language that is neither inhabited nor utilized by human beings?¹⁵

I have been defending the view of a critical good-faith relation to, as well as a critical good-faith recognition of, human beings in the flesh. This led to the theory of the body as perspective. What can deconstruction say about the body as perspective, as point of departure, at this point other than the body's being a perspectival fact or a fact of perspectivity—provided, of course, that "facts" are permitted to emerge in discourse at all? Can one deconstruct away the body without falling into bad faith?

If deconstruction retreats to the negativity of its "critical" project of unmasking presuppositions of the metaphysics of substance, then it has accomplished a reformulation of Sartre's claim that to state the negative, to lay bare the illusion of the self as a form of substance, is an existential phenomenological project. For example, Henry Louis Gates, Jr.'s "deconstruction" of the attitudes toward statistics taken by eminent judges and legal theorists appears indistinguishable from the project of showing that they are in bad faith where matters of race are concerned. Gates describes their bad faith, but he refuses, in at least "Statistical Stigmata," to give their attitude a name. I don't see why *racist* wouldn't suffice. But note, whereas Gates has a certain interest in deconstructing legal efforts toward evading evidence of racial discrimination where blacks are concerned, it doesn't follow that his work is an example of deconstruction. Although Gates's analysis fits into our conception of a hermeneutical critique from the standpoint of bad faith, it doesn't follow that the Sartrean standpoint and deconstruction are "really" one. It is not our interest here to place deconstruction in William James's third classic stage of a theory, where a theory is "seen to be so important that its adversaries claim that they themselves discovered it" (1975, 95). That the deconstructionist may recognize the possibility of bad faith, as we have seen in Derrida's remarks on the ill-tempered speaker, does not mean that deconstruction is in agreement with the Sartrean conception of bad faith. The deconstructionist may reject the view that bad faith is *chosen*, since

choice may smell of agency. If so, Gates's commitment to the spirit of deconstruction may be the reason for his reluctance to spell out the judges' and legal theorists' *choice* of rejecting or evading evidence that substantiates black claims while embracing "evidence" that substantiates white claims. If such reluctance, or perhaps indecision, is a hallmark of deconstructive "praxis," then deconstruction has not escaped existential phenomenological traps any more than any other anti-ontology. Indecision is also an effort to evade decision. It masks its own decision to decide not to decide.

This indecision which is also a decision may escape, if not bad faith, at least a nihilism by claiming that it is effected for the sake of an "opening" of new terrain, for the sake of breaking down the boundaries or the "limits" of the "margins" or the "marginalized." But to accomplish this aim, a move may be called for in which even the margins and the marginalized aren't named for the sake of their marginality. What, then, is involved in this rejection of presence that dares not speak its name? What does it mean to argue that there is a "place" left open for new, fresh discourse?

A possible response is to reiterate that the whole purpose of a deconstructive project, if any deconstructive effort can be properly considered a "project," is to perform a rejection or an unmasking or a demystification, a deconstruction, that is *not* in the name of anything—a form of refusal of engagement in engagement, which is one of the intuitions behind Derrida's term *différance*.¹⁶ Is this a form of escape by way of introducing a neologism? Rorty thinks so (1989, 124, n. 6). I am inclined to agree with him, but with reservations. It seems to me that there is a hierarchy of language that takes the form of a command. Authority and information are presumed to come from the "top," but not from the "bottom" or, as deconstructionists prefer, the margins. In the United States, for instance, there are at least three major types of English: the white English of the power élite ("standard English"), white working-class English, and black English (Smitherman, 1991, 73). The consequence is that all those designated "below" or "bottom" must understand what comes from "above," but from the standpoint of "above," all that comes from "below" is incoherent, gibberish, incorrect, or worse, invisible. "Below" seems to function like *différance*. In a white world, or at least an antiblack one, black people are to be *translated*. The translation "smells," however, of a form of assimilation, which is also a threat for the antiblack racist since "they" are to be put into his, which is the presumed universal "our," terms. Translation is thus constructed as a threat to the black. The consequence is that the antiblack racist fears yet revels in the miscegenous dimension of translation, and the black faces necromancy through being translated into a form of living dead. The Orphic dimensions of this turn have already been discussed by both Sartre and Fanon. What should be considered here, instead, are the historical messages to be learned from translating black reality.

Necromancy has certainly been the case with the political economy of black aesthetics (for example, "making a Lady out of Jazz," "king of swing," "white gospel," "rock," "whiggers") and the political economy of black identity as a form of liberation praxis (white appropriation of structural or metaphorical blackness to justify their praxis—"reverse discrimination").

The intuition behind *différance*, then, is instructive. Irreducibility, metastability, or fleeting translatability is more valuable than we may realize. But when we transform that intuition to the level of method, where deconstruction would function as *différance* in-itself, as a form of refused engagement with whomever "we" are, we face a different kind of problem. The rejection that is not in the name of anything would be a lot like a choice from the standpoint of radical freedom, a freedom in the name of nothing—perhaps not even freedom. Consider how the term *radical* betrays its own ambiguity when conjoined with "freedom." From *radicalis*, which means having roots, radical can mean both the foundations or roots as well as the extremes (given that the roots are as "deep" as one may go and still remain focused on, say, the plant). Radical freedom can therefore mean root-freedom or the foundations of freedom or extreme freedom, freedom that has gone against itself and, consequently, has gone "too far." Sartre is in favor of the former, primordial freedom, since he ultimately argues that the root of freedom is human being in the flesh. But he rejects the latter, extreme (ultimately escapist) freedom, which we have been arguing denies not only facticity, but also embodiment. Sartre is not advocating a freedom which Fanon describes in *The Wretched of the Earth* as occurring between 9:30 P.M. and 6:30 A.M. Ironically, the possibility of deconstruction's being a form of freedom-in-the-name-of-nothing puts deconstruction in the camp of the anarchic consciousness, a form of consciousness attributed to Sartre's philosophy. His philosophy, understood as a critique of human reality from the standpoint of bad faith, is compelled to reject this form of consciousness in virtue of the evasion of one's facticity being a form of bad faith.

There is, however, another dimension of deconstructive praxis to consider: the ways in which language can be used as a liberating praxis, as deconstruction of the construction of, in a word, "style-centrism." In this regard, deconstruction's formulation of the primacy of language (for Derrida, writing) and its appropriation of terminologies designed to irritate the comfortable complacency of dominant-cultural norms of expression and interpretation are worth consideration. Style can be liberating insofar as it can be a demonstration that an expression can be "expressed" in different ways. But can the appeal to style also be a form of evasion? Sartre has criticized the conflation of language analyses in his discussion of masochism precisely because he regards them as the reduction of human reality to facticity—the metaphysics of presence that deconstruction condemns. Yet, there is a peculiar

existential dimension to style. One's style can cut through the clothing of dense, anal-retentive prose, or "rape" the author with "penetrating" analysis; or perhaps one's style may exemplify a willingness for dialogical engagement, a call for gentility, a call for mutual respect; and then again one's style can cast a magical spell that makes the "substance" of the matter irrelevant. We find ourselves again in the world of magic or the magical world of affect. Value-neutral language is a self-deceptive ideal. But this doesn't mean that anything goes as far as affective prose is concerned. We needn't consider limitations here in terms of the obvious reductionism of transcendence; the political claim to praxis, with "style," is sufficient. Terrorizing language may be irritating, perhaps even frightening, but the social costs and levels of courage they demand may represent a form of bad faith on the level of delusions of grandeur and self-importance. Just as there were natives who were free in their dreams between 9:30 P.M. and 6:30 A.M., deconstructing natives may only be free in their free, albeit stylish, interpretations.

The written language of the West and its alphabetical systems betray an economy of power. So the native may seek a form of liberating writing. True enough. But should we draw out a dialectical response here by not writing in the forms of the West or, even more locally, the forms of the variety of groups to which we may belong? That I am *writing* this work in English and in a Western university already places constraints on my response. Someone would benefit if people of color were to abandon the dominant language and its political economy of disseminating knowledge, but I am not entirely convinced that that someone would be a person of color. The klansman whom we quoted earlier concluded his invectives with the remark that "If most of you . . . cannot read this letter, it is OK." I suspect that he would be comforted by the thought of growing numbers of black folk hard at work constructing a world in which one day none of them will be able to write a response.

It could be argued that the only qualification that should be placed on blacks' written response is that it is identified by blacks as writing—with a form of black style to boot—not by whites or the West. But we've encountered this version of mysterious blackness locked in its own monadic reality before. Given the existential phenomenological implications of sadism, completely sealing off recognition of the Other from the sadist intensifies his own delusions of sadism qua reality. I am not interested in doing the klansman's work for him.

Deconstruction's attack on the comfortable world of Western metaphysics, a world that needs to be shaken up by Johannes Climacus's life project, raises the question of whether it is, as situated in our historic moment, a bad-faith attack on bad faith. It is important to address the degree to which language and a perverse metaphysics function oppressively in a given society,

but this important task can slip into the comfort of the attack itself instead of the realization of its limitations in dealing with the more troubling responsibilities involved in dealing with oppression, an unsettling feature of which is the possibility of being judged negatively by the oppressed one seeks to liberate. If such judgment is undermined, the consequence is a world dominated by commitment (by way of a rejection of commitment) against a reality capable of making judgments at all; a consequence of the supposed "death of the subject" is the comfortable elimination of judgment and consequently the case of certain subjects who judge. A similar concern is voiced by Henry Louis Gates, Jr.:

The constitution of the Western male subject, after all, has enjoyed quite a different history from that of its racial or sexual others. Consider the irony: precisely when those "others" gain the complex wherewithal to define a countervailing subjectivity in the republic of Western culture, our theoretic colleagues declare the subject to be mere mystification. It is hard not to see this as the critical version of the grandfather clause, the double privileging of categories that happen to be, as it were, preconstituted, a position that seems to leave us nowhere, invisible and voiceless. (1990, 323–24).¹⁷

In the effort to kill the Western metaphysical judge, a simultaneous mutilation of the oppressed's judgmental vocal chords lurks as the hidden catch. After all, power relations exist not only in the fact that oppressed peoples often express themselves in colonial languages, but also in the fact that language is a special form of offering of the self. All languages are received and given away; they "live" as a form of anguish at the heart of intentionality. The writer looks at his writing and experiences his alienation. He stands as a Frankenstein with his monstrous offspring crying out, "Why was I born if I am doomed to be rejected for not being you?" The embellishments on the national language by "minority" groups place the dominant culture in promethean anxiety; dialects are not only given languages but also languages utilized for the needs of communities beyond those who introduced them. In this regard, it is surprising that we find the following supposedly deconstructive remarks by Robert Denoon Cumming on Sartre's use of the term *human reality*:

Since Derrida is wrapping up in order to advance to his own philosophy of language, he focuses on a particular word, stigmatizing as "monstrous" the "translation," which we have seen Sartre had accepted from Corbin, of Heidegger's *Dasein* ("being-there") as *réalité humaine*. That "this translation," comments Derrida, "dominated *via* [*à travers de*] the authority of Sartre—this gives much to think about regarding the reading or not reading of Heidegger during this epoch."¹⁸

By analogy, the appropriation of colonial and predecessors' tongues would also have a "monstrous" implication. This monstrosity Cumming characterizes as vulgarization. Derrida uses the term in the sense of the ordinary when he writes, "The contact of the concept of *vulgarity* or ordinariness in the expression the 'ordinary concept of time' with the stated point of departure of the Aristotelian interpretation."¹⁹ His purpose in doing so is to show how the conflation of being into the temporal dimension of "presence" has become so matter-of-fact that it is treated as our "ordinary," that is, natural, ontology. Yet, there is an elitism explicit in the deprecation of a phenomenon as vulgar, and Cumming's deprecation of Sartre as a popularization of Heidegger suggests this latter, pejorative usage. Even if Cumming were correct that human reality is a mistranslation of *Dasein*, the very ascription of vulgarization—transforming it into the appreciably human under one interpretation, making it less valuable under another—betrays the misunderstanding of philosophical novelty that may come out of initial misunderstandings. Sartre's indebtedness to Descartes, Hegel, and Kierkegaard requires an interpretation of his philosophy that calls for similar criticisms against forced reductions as those we have pointed out in the case of regarding Sartre as no more than vulgar, unoriginal Hegelianism. Vulgar Cartesianism, vulgar Kierkegaardianism, vulgar Bergsonianism, vulgar Heideggerianism, what next—vulgar Sartreanism? From the standpoint of philosophical "purists," our engagement with Sartre on antiblack racism is a condescension of philosophy, to whom the question can be addressed: Should we then call for philosophy to lose the dialectical fashion of its history? The affirmative answer in deconstruction—"the End of Philosophy"—doesn't seem to meet its own practice. Worse, the call for "complete originality," at least on the part of Cumming, suggests a similar form of bad faith as the call for "perfect belief" and "perfect evidence." Sartre's originality doesn't lay claim to his predecessor's terminology but his novel uses (and for some of his critics, like Heidegger and Derrida, abuses) of such terminology.

So we find ourselves in the midst of problems raised by the search for "clean" language. In the struggle for domination-free language, everyone seems to be reduced to an "oppressor" of future generations—unless, of course, there is the effort to face humanity across the ages as a perspective of value. All new, liberating languages require some foundation on which to stand, and all too often they are foundations that carry the sentiment of shame. To evade *that* calls for a bad-faith stand toward the normative. As Rorty observes, "Flowers could not sprout from the dialectical vine unless there were an edifice into whose chinks it could insert its tendrils. No constructors, no deconstructors. No norms, no perversions" (1982, 108). And another internal-critic, or, yet, an *Other*: "And while the so-called death of the subject may be a theoretical triviality, its rhetorical deployment is

more problematic. Starting with the recognition that the 'reflexive actor' is not simply a given, a subjectivity existing prior to and independently from language, we too quickly decided that its factitious pedigree made it an effect of linguistic determination. But that did not quite follow. . . . The familiar Wittgensteinian point is that you cannot simply opt out of a form of life, and you cannot *mean* outside one, either" (Gates 1990, 324).

What would constitute vulgar (Alain) Lockeanism, vulgar Fanonism, vulgar (C. L. R.) Jamesianism, vulgar (Paulo) Freireanism? Vulgar Marxism? Vulgar Feminism?

Drucilla Cornell has considered whether deconstruction, which she refers to as the Philosophy of the Limit, is "the 'discourse' of the outside observer." "Maybe so; but, as a woman," she concludes, "I am thankful for a 'discourse'" (1992a, 87). Cornell's appeal is ironically existential. Her decision to decide rests on her situation "as a woman." This is not a deconstructive move. Her deconstructive move is the "discourse" for which she is "thankful." For this aspect of her situation to extend into a philosophy of the Limit calls for a special concern. Philosophy of woman is not identical with philosophy of the Other, since the Other may be a broader category than the situation that Cornell might mean by "woman." When conjoined with deconstruction, we find ourselves thrown here into the Manichaeism of the *source*. The source of deconstruction or its "origins" cannot be evaded as White Male (Heidegger, Paul De Man, Derrida, Foucault, etc.) without a conception of deconstruction as independent of white males. If this independence is the appeal to the Limit or the Other "herself," then we must claim that *any* work *from* the Other "is" deconstructive. Our work here would be a work of deconstruction in virtue of my being a man of color. Of course, there could be an addendum—provided that the work from the person of color exemplifies the voice of the Other, is a philosophy of the Other/Limit. But then an insidious form of oppression emerges: the Other is spoken *for* without having spoken. To remedy the situation, the speaker finds his or herself searching for legitimacy of voice. It should be clear by now that no individual Other *is* the voice for *all* Others except from the standpoint of those who militate against the Other's existence. One can only represent the Other in her absence.

The appeal to exemplification of otherness is the familiar appeal to the oppressed as the loci of liberation praxis. Given the existence of white female members of the Ku Klux Klan and neo-Nazis terrorist groups—terrorist groups who because of their white platform have never been officially regarded as terrorist groups in the United States—and the history of white female participation in the construction, in the judicial system, the academy, and popular culture, of the black male as Rapist, I find this appeal to an ideal source as the location of liberating praxis to be in serious need of

critical evaluation. And from the colored spectrum, a recent example comes to mind: given their track records as guardians of civil rights during the Reagan administration, could we seriously locate Clarence Thomas and Anita Hill as exemplars of the Limit? The exoticization of otherness leads to a slippery slope, for the oppressed would then face the perilous degeneration into a bad-faith search for "ideal" oppression ("which Other is the most oppressed?"), the consequence of which would be victimization and violation as marks of innocence. Like the racist Fred, we would find ourselves constantly sniffing beds in search of clean sheets.

We face, then, in deconstruction's purported alliance with the excluded, the marginalized, the limited, the oppressed, the explicit question of deconstruction's involvement in the interpretation of varieties of black situation. In its alliance with the situation of black folk, deconstruction proves limited, and perhaps limiting, in its declaration *not really to be doing anything*. The declaration is a form of attack on all seriousness. Here, deconstruction parts company with Sartre. Sartre's concern with the serious man, for instance, is about when he has become "so serious" that he has gone too far—when he has lost himself in a quicksand of seriousness, seriality, or practico-inertia.²⁰ Sartre concedes that some seriousness is needed for us to realize not only our projects, but the heart of our decision to decide, which is ultimately a form of affirmative, world-engagement. For blacks/women, I suspect a little more is needed than freedom-in-the-name-of-nothing-except-the-voice-from-the-margins in virtue of the consequences of living in a serious world, an antiblack world, which is exactly how some black/women deconstructionists see themselves.²¹ As a perspective that can *afford* triviality, deconstruction becomes the mark of a peculiar dominant-cultural perspective. Black deconstructionists deconstruct, that is, a little too seriously. This is because they cannot afford to be trivial in an antiblack world.

In the quest to appropriate Kierkegaard's effort to make the System tremble, deconstruction *as a philosophy* has thus betrayed its own effort to evade the very bodies of flesh and bone who suffer, shudder, and shriek, like Shylock in the Venetian court, that they, too, have their bond.²²

It should be noted, however, that deconstructionists' effort to forge a *postracist* and postcolonial discourse instead of maintaining the conservatism of a *neoracist* and neocolonial one strikes at least one important chord on racial concerns. Eventually, we should move forward on such matters. Part of such a goal involves the realization of constructions as constructions and challenging, in the spirit of Marx's eleventh thesis on Feuerbach, the bases of the resistance to change—including the passionate aspects of such resistance. On this matter, I think Sartre would be in total agreement given not only his written work, but also his actual various excursions into activism beyond the sphere of the pen, activism which supported antiracist and

anticolonial struggles often in the face of serious death threats and assassination attempts.²³ "Sartreanism" is ironically unable to avoid this path in good faith in virtue of its antipathy to ineluctability.

From the Sartrean perspective, the philosopher, qua ontologist and "writer," is our bad conscience.²⁴ He is saying that of which we are aware but refuse to admit. This does not mean that the philosopher is our surrogate conscience. Instead, it means that the philosopher is in situation, as all human beings are. If he is asked to "tell it like it is," he reminds us that his response involves also telling us what "it" is not.²⁵

It is bad faith to attempt commitment to social concerns while denying that we—each of us—actually do so. The aspects of an antiblack world that concerns existential phenomenology are the ways in which we try to evade ourselves by situating blackness and whiteness in either an eternal realm of Presence or a flight to Absence.

An implication of our intersection with deconstruction should at this point be made explicit. Our quarrel with Kant rested on the question of philosophical anthropology. Our view is a rejection of human nature, but at the same time an embracing of philosophical anthropology as the location of questions of value. Our quarrel with deconstruction is the other extreme. There we find an encounter with a rejection of both the Kantian place of philosophical anthropology and philosophical anthropology itself. The End of Man thesis (in its negative connotation of rejecting the question of "man") is also an attack on philosophical anthropology. The surest way to evade human reality is to pretend that the human being doesn't exist. Such a rejection is a form of bad faith.

We now depart from our intersection with deconstruction and consider, in terms of Sartre's critics, the one who was perhaps his worst and most unreliable critic of his ontology, and that one is the "later" Sartre himself.

Marxism

The bad faith of our Marxists consists in bringing two concepts into play at the same time so as to preserve the benefit of a teleological interpretation while concealing the abundant, highhanded use which they make of the explanation by finality. They employ the second concept to make it appear to everyone that there is a mechanistic interpretation of History—ends have disappeared. At the same time they make use of the first so as surreptitiously to transform into real objectives of a human activity the necessary but unforeseeable consequences which this activity entails.

—Sartre, *Search for a Method* (48)

SARTRE eventually succumbed to the criticisms against the “social limitations” of his early philosophy and supposedly made his effort to enter sociality and history in *Search for a Method*, *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, his unpublished 1964 Rome Lecture Notes, and his unpublished 1965 Cornell lecture *Morality and History*. He utilized the concept of bad faith in various forms throughout these works. I suspect that there may have been a special kind of struggle going on beyond the challenge of becoming the engaged writer during at least the period of *Search for a Method* and the *Critique*: his conservative bourgeois critics on the one hand and French Marxist critics on the other hoped that Sartre would abandon not only certain technical features of his philosophy, but also the spirit of his philosophy. He was simultaneously too Marxist and not Marxist enough. I suspect this was because he lived in a world in which Marxism and its enemies presented themselves, and their loci of liberation (or, as in the case of the conservatives, retrenchment) as ideals. His attack on both transcendence and facticity offended the individualists, the traditionalists, and the collectivists. For the traditionalists and the collectivists, “the social” functioned like a talisman for political commitment, as if a work dedicated to the social automatically entailed political commitment. Had there not been an effort simply to step into the social by way of submitting to the ready-made, historical philosophical presentation of it—in Sartre’s case, this demanded an engagement with the dialectical method and “historicity”—I suspect that Sartre would not have claimed to have abandoned the existential phenomenological approach to sociality in *Being and Nothingness*. Even if we were to conclude that he did in fact abandon such a project by the time of *Search for a Method*, we would still be left with the question of what kind of social theory would

have emerged if he were to have returned to it. I suspect that such a theory would not have been radically different from the effort he in fact made in *Search for a Method*, the *Critique* and the unpublished 1964 *Rome Lecture Notes*, given his preservation of the concepts of bad faith and Manichaeism and his revolutionary humanistic defense of need as an ethical dimension of human reality in those works.

Racism is discussed in those works, but we shall here consider his treatment in the *Critique* (714–34).²⁶ He discusses racism in the *Critique* as a feature of imperialism or, as he prefers, superexploitation. If there is a major limitation of this work in regards to our concerns of antiblack racism, it is Sartre's failure to articulate the uniqueness of various forms of racism. He issues the Fanonian line of treating all forms of exploitation as part of the same, concrete, coextensive reality. As a result, his case study, the French-Algerian situation, treats Algerians as one race. It is not a matter of whether Algerians are more or less exploited than any other oppressed group. That they are being exploited at all is a sufficient ground for liberating praxis, and in that regard I am in agreement with Sartre and Fanon. But the interpretation of the people must not be such that they are reduced to a unified ideal. As Sartre himself warned in *Search for a Method*,

Marxist formalism is a project of elimination. The method is identical with Terror in its inflexible refusal to *differentiate*; its goal is total assimilation at the least possible effort. The aim is not to integrate what is different as such, while preserving for it a relative autonomy, but rather to suppress it. (48)

There were, and still are, serious racial attitudes *among* Algerians, attitudes discussed by Fanon in *Black Skin, White Masks* and *Wretched of the Earth*.²⁷ Are all forms of domination and exploitation racist? If so, what are we to make of this passage from *The Wretched of the Earth*:

It must in any case be remembered that a colonized people is not only simply a dominated people. Under the German occupation the French remained men; under the French occupation, the Germans remained men. In Algeria there is not simply the domination but the decision to the letter not to occupy anything more than the sum total of the land. The Algerians, the veiled women, the palm trees and the camels make up the landscape, the *natural* background to the human presence of the French. (250)

Are all forms of colonialism racist? If so, should we conclude that there is no difference between British colonialism in Ireland and its activities (past and present) in the Caribbean and Southern Africa? If we grant that colonial conditions are racist ones, how does that help us to understand or to explain the "internal" racism of Nazi Germany? The United States? Brazil (despite

Brazilian denial of such)? China? Japan? How do we explain ethnic cleansing? Pogroms? These may be too many standpoints for one text to address. So, let us return to at least the colonial one.

Sartre describes racism in the Algerian context as "*Other-Thought (Pensée-Autre)* produced objectively by the colonial system and by super-exploitation" (1991, 714). This is the institutional bad faith of which we have been speaking, a form of infection of the social sphere with ready-made meanings that encourage self-evasion. But the uniqueness of the meanings needs further development: Manichaeism does, after all, have a peculiar antiblack symbolic presentation. That symbolic presentation has been the matrix of our study thus far.

Another concern is that Sartre's efforts focus on the role that capitalism plays in facilitating a racist environment. On this score, he is entirely correct. Accompanying superexploitation is always the quest for profits. But there is another fact to contend with. Racism, particularly antiblack racism, has existed and continues to exist in socialist environments, or at least settings that claim to be socialist, too. Thus, for blacks the question appears to be similar to the one he posed for Jews (and especially black Jews) in *Anti-Semite and Jew*. Which hell? Blacks who embrace socialism in an antiblack world do so for obvious reasons: Hell with social benefits and the spirit of equality is better than hell without—especially if capitalist hell calls for a poor who are accepted as "naturally low," that is, blacks. I don't think that blacks believe that socialism creates a magical transformation in over three hundred years of racial hatred, any more than they expect a free market to transform the attitudes of white merchants. What socialism has to offer is its stand on the liberal tension between liberty and equality—that everyone is entitled to certain goods, which amounts to the spirit of equality. A white socialist may be in principle compelled to share the goods with his black brothers and sisters—even if he regards them, albeit with contradiction, as his inferior.²⁸ This is because, as Sartre argues in the 1964 *Rome Lecture Notes*, socialism, even in a racist world, is compelled at least to recognize the black person's needs.²⁹

We do not find here a rejection of Marxism. That Marxism cannot properly capture the dimensions of race and racism is hardly a criticism against Marxism since such a project is not one for which Marxist social theory may have been designed to address in the first place. Such a "rejection" would be similar to the stupid line of reasoning involved in responding to the question of Duke Ellington's life achievements with the phrase, "But then, he was no Mozart." Black liberation may be a function of considerations that need to be addressed on their own terms. They may relate to other forms of praxis—just as African-American classical music relates to eighteenth-century European classical music in virtue of their both being music—even though

the comparative point of departure, antiblack racism, persists *in spite of logic*.

Still, in the face of this persistence I continue to dream everyday of a classless society, of a day when a decision not to concern myself with whether I am bottom, middle, or top—am among the haves or the have-nots, am a controller of the means of production or am controlled by the means of production—is a function of a critically good-faith relation to reality instead of a possible form of self-evasion. But I do not long for the day in which I can look myself in the mirror and discover that I am no longer there. I do not wish to extend my hand before me and not recognize what I see. This is neither narcissism nor grandiose location of my “self” as the center. I am just admitting the implications of recognizing blackness as a construction that imposes a special form of anguish. I once bought a button that announced, “Black by Nature, Proud by Choice.” It can be rephrased, “Black by Construction, Proud by Choice.” I live the anguish of how I constitute my relation to my constitution in a world that is constituted by myself and others. But this anguish is historically situated. I don’t fight my invisibility for the sake of becoming invisible. Fanon once claimed that he would like to walk out into a crowd and experience the sheer mundaneness of melting into it. I am *aware* that white people experience this, and experience it mundanely too, but I must confess that I don’t *know* what it is in the sense of fully understanding what it would mean for *me*. I am too deeply situated in the reality of blackness, which is in this historical moment the reality of antiblackness, which constantly advances the anthropological question of the strangeness of such mundanity for a black person.

The persistence of racism affects the race/class dynamic in peculiar ways. There has been a traditional progressive argument against racism, that racism divides the working class. This argument presupposes, however, that race solidarity is an evil. Yet, among blacks, it can be argued that the problem with class is that it wrecks black solidarity. A wealthy or even middle-class black can be deluded by the lure of class and lie to himself that money and “status” transcend racial boundaries, to which we need only remind him that there are countless cases of white entrepreneurs who would rather not make a sale than sell to blacks and that there are white exclusive clubs that would rather not receive black financial endowment than to include black membership. That the United States’ civil rights struggle also consisted of black patrons attempting to force white entrepreneurs to profit from their business raises serious questions on the economic dimension of the etiology of race exploitation. As much as the black middle and upper classes may try to identify with being the bourgeoisie, their situation of being overdetermined from the outside confronts them every day: department store monitors, police officers who stop them for driving too slow, frightened white colleagues in elevators, white control over key segments of the private sector, purported

acceptance "in spite of their color," "exceptionalism" in terms of their race, and so on. What should such black folk admit about the dimensions of race and class? There is a black and a white working class, but an antiblack world reminds the white that at least he is not a "nigger." He stares class in the face as a social construction to be overcome. What should the black do in the face of an identity that simultaneously militates against him but on the other hand is the very premiss by which he exists? Should the black be asked to wipe himself out of existence in order to found himself?

Fanon claimed that he wants to save the Negro from himself. But the Negro also lives in the world, in the flesh. He faces the question of simultaneously hating and loving himself. He faces the problem of how to live with others in a world that ranks with such an odor of self-denial that an authentic demand he can make short of a Bigger-Thomas explosion of violence amounts to the call for a breath of fresh air. He faces the struggle of overcoming his overdetermination. He faces a struggle on four fronts: himself, his gender, his race, and his relation to the social world.

Bad faith applied radically requires the possibility of good-faith relations *with others*. The rejection of the social world is a form of bad faith. One has to be able to stand authentically in relation to the natural attitude just as one must be able to stand authentically in relation to whatever reductions one makes of such an attitude, whether in the form of phenomenological reductions or existential conversions. Although I may radically convert my attitudes toward racialism and racism, I must also make a radical conversion of that radical conversion into an authentic stand on the implications of human evasion. The problems of political justice can be formulated among a group of people in a racist situation—the very act of *posing* the problem to each other demands an egalitarian situation since it is a form of bad faith to presume self-justified presence on the part of the questioners but not the questioned—but the deeper problem is whether even the possibility of entering such a dialogue exists in racially hostile environments. Fanon described the problem well in 1956 when he wrote in his resignation letter from l'Hôpital Psychiatrique de Blida-Joinville that

Madness is one of the means man has of losing his freedom. . . . If psychiatry is the medical technique that aims to enable man no longer to be a stranger to his environment, I owe it to myself to affirm that the Arab, permanently an alien in his own country, lives in a state of absolute depersonalization. What is Algeria? A systematized de-humanization. (1967a, 53)

Fanon took a stand that constituted the recognition of his historical situation and the role he could have played but chose not to play in the colonial effort to discourage human contact with the colonized, the effort to make the Arab no longer a stranger to his environment, the effort to create

the Happy Slave. The identification of bad faith, radically applied, calls for the recognition of the possibility of human contact, albeit recognized with a critical eye. It ultimately calls for an existential phenomenological communicative praxis, an existential phenomenological admission of what is involved in *acting* authentically.³⁰ To act inauthentically is to act as though the world were devoid of human beings.

THE LIVING DEAD

A FINAL concern. The reader may wonder, if the existential phenomenologist only admits the "truth" about antiblack racism—that antiblack racism is a form of bad faith—what would be the point in cases of absolute stubbornness, of a person who insists on antiblackness all the way to his grave? What can be said about those who die in bad faith?

There is a consequentialist response. Racist people affect others with their attitude. Thus we should be concerned with what such people do to others. Who cares about victimizers when the life of their victims is a living hell? There is a sense in which our answer to the question of someone who has died in bad faith requires our looking at someone who *might* die in bad faith. This is because even if we appeal to the cliché that there is no sense crying over spilt milk, the problem calls for an appeal to the performative aspect of the question; what would we say if we faced the problem of a person as an eternal present—as someone whose "meaning" is a matter of *intervention*, on our part, at any moment—even after his death?

Let us assume that there is a man who secretly harbors antiblack sentiments, but is fortunate, as far as he is concerned, that he has never had to communicate it to anyone, since where he lives, he never has to encounter a black person in the flesh. What can we say about such a man and people similar to him who live out their lives with such attitudes? There is a sense in which such people suffer from the fate of having never truly lived. If our antiblack racist has victimized anyone, it seems to have been himself. Our question therefore raises a special problem of value, for what else can be stated about such people except the importance of that which they have lost?

We find ourselves again in Kierkegaardian territory:

Which sight is more sorrowful, that which immediately and unrestrainedly moves to tears, like the sight of one unhappily deceived in love, or that which in a certain sense could tempt laughter, the sight of one who is

self-deceived, whose foolish conceit of not being deceived is ludicrous, something to be laughed at, if its ludicrousness were not a still stronger expression for horror by signifying that he is not worth a tear? (1962, 23)

To have lived in bad faith is to have evaded recognition of oneself as a human being. It is to have lived a fugitive existence. "To cheat oneself out of love," continues Kierkegaard, "is the most terrible deception; it is an eternal loss for which there is no reparation, either in time or in eternity. . . . There is also talk about being deceived by life or in life; but he who self-deceptively cheated himself out of living—his loss is irredeemable." By love, Kierkegaard doesn't mean simply the desire to be desired, but the desire to stand truthfully before God. He means by it the desire to be worthy of desire. In this formulation, seeking God is not only a search for value by choosing value, but also an admission of truth by symbolically revealing oneself to all over the ages. We can regard this ironically in the Kantian form that we spoke critically of earlier.³¹ Imagine oneself being desired without exception, valued without exception, by consciousness itself eternally. The presentation of a false self for eternity is to close oneself off from moral consideration by oneself and Others. One's "life" becomes simply a form of "I was not." Wherever truth was, I was not there. To die in bad faith, then, is tantamount to having never lived. It is the "preconclusion" of ultimate comfort.

Yet perhaps this response isn't enough. There is a sense in which it too succumbs to a form of trap. For to ask about those who die in bad faith is to ask whether being critically in good faith matters beyond the human recognition of its value. Are we willing to be that serious? The response requires a call from the inwardness of humanity. If by the question is asked, Is dying in bad faith a profound human loss? A life of having never trembled? One might as well return to the old adage that the tragedy of the man is that he was once a child. Never to have matured? Never to have grown up? Never to have risked Fear and Trembling? To be *that* serious? Perhaps the best response is simply that that level of seriousness has a project of suicide at its core. It demands serious values in order not to be a source of value, in order not to be human. To accept racism to the grave is to capitulate to others' dehumanization and one's own. Such a project of regarding others—implicit in the attack on particular others—as pure, dehumanized objects cannot be done in critical good faith. But then the question returns full circle, does that matter? If *we* are to answer that question, then we are caught, for the question demands a truthful answer, an answer that cannot be the affirmation of bad faith.

I close with an observation by Alfred Schutz. Schutz notes that the social world is built upon our ability to reach others. The social implication of

antiblack racism as a form of bad faith is therefore obvious: lurking within such an attitude is the total elimination of the social world. It is a consciousness that seeks the dissolution of the framework of being contacted by others. It is a consciousness that truly accepts the dictum, "Hell is other people." This is because antiblack racism, however casually accepted, is a descent into the choice of a misanthropic consciousness.

NOTES

INTRODUCTION

1. See Frantz Fanon, *Black Skin, White Masks*, trans. Charles Lamm Markmann (New York: Grove Press, 1967), 224. Hereafter cited as Fanon 1967.
2. Victoria Holloway, "President's Message," *The Drum: The SNMA-Yale Chapter Newsletter* (October 1991): 1.
3. The reader may be concerned about my use of the pronouns *he*, *his*, and *him*. My argument requires an exploration of the complexities of such concepts as generality and anonymity in ways that raise the question of whether there really can be an anonymous racist. Is white female racism identical with white male racism? Although the structure of racism as a claim of the superiority of one's race remains intact in the case of the female racist, an analysis from the standpoint of bad faith suggests that her relation to such a claim—given the hierarchical structure of racist societies—may differ from a white male's, white female's, black male's, black female's, or white homosexual's, white lesbian's, black homosexual's, black lesbian's, or white hermaphrodite's, black hermaphrodite's. The conservative choice of "generic" pronouns therefore permits me to explore these possibilities, as well as maintain the resonance of the antiblack, and as we shall see, misogynous world in which the subject of this study takes place. The context should reveal whether my *he* means abstract person or male person.
4. Anonymous indigenous Australian (Australian aborigine) author, quoted from the *Jerusalem Post* and the *Euro-News*, quoted in *The Drum: The SNMA-Yale Newsletter* (October 1991): 4. For a history of the Australian situation, see Robert Hughes, *The Fatal Shore: The Epic of Australia's Founding* (New York: Vintage Books, 1986).
5. For a discussion of at least Hitler's conception of race, see C. W. Cassinelli, *Total Revolution: A Comparative Study of Germany Under Hitler, the Soviet Union Under Stalin, and China Under Mao* (Santa Barbara, Calif.: Clio Books, 1976), 21–27.
6. For discussion of this dimension of anti-Jewish racism, see Paul Hayes's *Fascism* (New York: Free Press, 1973), an excerpt from which can be found under the title "The Myth of Race" in *Political Ideologies and Political Philosophies*, ed. H. B. McCullough (Toronto: Wall & Thompson, 1989), 187–92.

7. Quoted in Cassinelli, *Total Revolution*, 21.
8. Translated by George J. Becker (New York: Schocken Books, 1948). Will be cited as Sartre 1948.
9. Sartre, *Notebooks for an Ethics*, trans. David Pellauer (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992). Hereafter cited as Sartre 1992. In French, *Cahiers pour une morale* (Paris: Gallimard, 1983). (Sartre 1983.)
10. In "No Exit" and Three Other Plays (New York: Vintage, 1955). Will be cited as Sartre 1955.
11. Sartre, "Black Orpheus," trans. John MacCombie, in "What Is Literature?" and Other Essays, ed. with an introduction by Steven Ungar (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1988). Hereafter cited as Sartre 1988a.
12. Jean-Paul Sartre, "Black Presence," in *The Writings of Jean-Paul Sartre*, vol. 2, *Selected Prose*, ed. Michel Contat and Michel Rybalka and trans. Richard McCleary (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1974). Hereafter cited as Sartre 1974a.
13. For a firsthand account of the Scottsboro Nine case, see William Patterson, *The Man Who Cried Genocide: An Autobiography* (New York: International Publishers, 1971), chap. 9.
14. Translated, with an Introduction, by Hazel E. Barnes (New York: Vintage Books, 1968). Originally published as "Question de Méthode," Prefatory essay in *Critique de la Raison Dialectique*, vol. 1 (Paris: Gallimard, 1960). Search for a Method will be cited as Sartre 1968.
15. Vol. 1, *Theory of Practical Ensembles*, trans. Alan Sheridan-Smith (London: Verso, 1991). Will be cited as Sartre 1991.
16. Available for study at Paris' Bibliothèque Nationale. Discussion with excerpts from the work can be found in Elizabeth A. Bowman and Robert V. Stone's "Dialectical Ethics: A First Look at Sartre's Unpublished 1964 Rome Lecture Notes," *Social Text* 13-14 (Winter/Spring 1986): 195-215; "'Making the Human' in Sartre's Unpublished Dialectical Ethics," in *Writing the Politics of Difference*, ed. Hugh Silverman (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1991), 111-12; and "'Socialist Morality' in Sartre's Unpublished 1964 Rome Lecture: A Summary and Commentary," *Bulletin de la Société Américaine de Philosophie de Langue Française* 4, nos. 2-3 (1992): 166-200.
17. For discussion of this work, see Elizabeth A. Bowman and Robert V. Stone, "Sartre's Morality and History: A First Look at the Notes for the Unpublished 1965 Cornell Lectures," in *Sartre Alive!* ed. Ronald Aronson and Adrian van den Hoven (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 1991), 53-82. An excerpt from that work, "Kennedy and West Virginia," is translated by Bowman and Stone and included in the same volume, pp. 37-52.
18. For a statement on the existential phenomenological approach to the study of human phenomena, see Maurice Merleau-Ponty's classic lecture, "Phenomenology and the Sciences of Man," in *Phenomenology and the Social Sciences*, vol. 1, ed. Maurice Natanson (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1973), 47-108.
19. Among those who share this view are Ronald Aronson, in his introduction to his and Adrian van den Hoven's (eds.) *Sartre, Alive!*, and Thomas R. Flynn, "L'imagination au Pouvoir: The Evolution of Sartre's Political and Social Thought," in *Critical Essays on Jean-Paul Sartre*, ed. Robert Wilcocks (Boston: K. G. Paul, 1988), 50.

PART I: BAD FAITH

1. *Being and Nothingness: A Phenomenological Essay on Ontology*, trans. with an introduction by Hazel Barnes (New York: Washington Square Press, 1956), 87. In French, *L'être et le néant: essai d'ontologie phénoménologique* (Paris: Gallimard, 1943). The English translation will be cited as Sartre 1956, and the French will be Sartre 1943.
2. I take this articulation of the self as project from Sartre's discussion of the writer and the reader in *What Is Literature?*, trans. Bernard Frechtman, in *"What Is Literature?" and Other Essays*. Hereafter cited as Sartre 1988.
3. See our discussions of the body in bad faith and social bad faith in chapter 7, below.
4. This distinction between ordinary and ideal belief in Sartre's conception of bad faith also receives attention in Joseph S. Catalano's "Successfully Lying on Oneself: A Sartrean Perspective," *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* 50, no. 4 (June 1990): 673–93. See also Descartes's *Discourse on Method*, part 4, for a conception of knowledge as perfect belief, in *The Philosophical Writings of Descartes*, ed. and trans. Norman Kemp Smith (London: Macmillan, 1952), esp. 142, and Alfred Jules Ayer, *The Problem of Knowledge* (New York: Penguin Books, 1956), chap. 1.
5. *Transcendence of the Ego: An Existentialist Theory of Consciousness*, trans. and annotated with an introduction by Forrest Williams and Robert Kirkpatrick (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1988), 61. Hereafter, Sartre 1988b.
6. *Inscriptions Between Phenomenology and Structuralism* (New York: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1987), 175. See also 176–79. Cited as Silverman 1987.
7. In support of Silverman's position, however, Sartre does actually say that the I has the "meaning" of an empty concept (see Sartre 1988b, 89). And for discussion in support of my reticence here, see Chapter 10 of this part, below.
8. For a detailed discussion of the relation of desire to choice, see Judith P. Butler, *Subjects of Desire: Hegelian Reflections in Twentieth-Century France* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1987). Will be cited as Butler 1987. For this three-fold characterization of anonymous, fundamental, and specific expressions of desire and choice, see her discussion on p. 154.
9. *Nausea*, translated by Lloyd Alexander with an introduction by Hayden Carruth (New York: New Directions Publishing, 1964), 68. (Sartre 1964.)
10. On Hitler's "logic," see Cassinelli, *Total Revolution*, chap. 2.
11. R. McL. Wilson, "Mani and Manichaeism" in *The Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, vol. 5, gen. ed. Paul Edwards (New York: Macmillan and Free Press, 1967), 150.
12. See John Rawls, "Two Conceptions of Rules," *Philosophical Review* 64 (1955): 3–13.
13. On "essence," see Edmund Husserl's *Ideas: General Introduction to Pure Phenomenology*, trans. W. R. Boyce Gibson (New York: Macmillan, 1931), secs. 129 and 130. See also Maurice Natanson, *Edmund Husserl: Philosopher of Infinite Tasks* (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1973), esp. 13–14, 85, and 88.
14. John Stuart Mill, *Utilitarianism*, chap. 4, in *John Stuart Mill: A Selection of His Works*, ed. with an introduction by John R. Robson (Indianapolis: Odyssey Press, 1980), 192–93.
15. *John Stuart Mill: A Selection of His Works*, xxi–xxii.
16. For a developed discussion of the aesthetic dimension of this view, see George Santayana, *The Sense of Beauty: Being the Outlines of Aesthetic Theory*, with a foreword by Philip Blair Rice (New York: Modern Library, 1955), passim.

17. Sartre's "Intentionality: A Fundamental Idea of Husserl's Phenomenology," *Journal of the British Society for Phenomenology* 1, no. 2 (May 1970): 4–5, and Sartre 1956, 767. For another perspective on the relation of value/interest to meaning, see also William James's *Principles of Psychology*, with an introduction by George Miller (1981; reprint, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1983) and "Pragmatism" and "The Meaning of Truth," with an introduction by A. J. Ayer (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1978); will be cited as James 1978. See also Arthur Danto's discussion of the similarity between Sartre's conception of language and J. L. Austin's conception of language, manifested in Austin's notion of The Descriptive Fallacy, in *Sartre*, 2d ed. (London: Fontana Press, 1991), 30–31.
18. "Sartre's Existentialism," in Marcuse's *From Luther to Popper* (London: Verso, 1972); originally published in *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research* 8, no. 3 (March 1948).
19. *Philosophy of History*, trans. with an introduction by J. Sibley with a preface by Charles Hegel and a new introduction by C. J. Friedrich (New York: Dover Publications, 1956), 78. Cited as Hegel 1956.
20. Translated by A. V. Miller with an analysis of the text and foreword by J. N. Findlay (New York: Oxford University Press, 1977), para. 37, pp. 21–22. Cited as Hegel 1977.
21. For discussions of Sartre and Hegel on the in-itself-for-itself, see Klaus Hartmann, *Sartre's Ontology: A Study of "Being and Nothingness" in Light of Hegel's Logic* (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1966), 142–44, and Pierre Verstraeten, "Hegel and Sartre," in *The Cambridge Companion to Sartre*, ed. Christina Howells (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1992), 360–62. The former will be cited as Hartmann 1966 and the latter, Verstraeten 1992.
22. We use Yahweh here instead of the generic term God since God will be explored from at least six perspectives—Judaism, Christianity, Islam; Hegel's Kierkegaard's, and Sartre's. Each of these perspectives has unique conceptions of "God." Thus to avoid cumbersome explanations, we will use the following: *Yahweh*, the Hebrew God; *Christ* or *Jesus*, the Christian God; *Allah*, the Muslim God; *Geist* or *Absolute Spirit*, Hegel's God; the *Absolute*, Kierkegaard's God (to represent his philosophical standpoint in spite of his Christian standpoint); the *in-itself-for-itself*, Sartre's impossible God; and *God*, for the generic referent. "God" is presumed to be what all of these standpoints are ultimately referring to.
23. Epigraph from *The Visible and the Invisible: Followed by Working Notes*, ed. Claude Lefort and trans. Alphonso Lingis (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1968), 267. (Merleau-Ponty 1968.)
24. For similar analysis, see Debra Bergoffen's "Casting Shadows: The Body in Descartes, Sartre, de Beauvoir, and Lacan," *Bulletin de la Société Américaine de Philosophie de Langue Française* 4, nos. 2–3 (1992): 232–43. Bergoffen and I both raise the question of how the body is lived as an effort to evade freedom. But we differ in the substance of our arguments. Bergoffen examines the body as the source of alienation from the self (235), whereas I argue that there is simply alienated consciousness in the flesh. There are other differences in our analyses, which will be noted below.
25. See Descartes's classic formulations of the mind–body problem in his *Meditations on First Philosophy*, Meditations II and VI, and his letters on the subject, all of which are in Descartes 1952.

26. See our discussion of pre-reflective and reflective consciousness in this part, Chapter 10, below.
27. Calvin Schrag, *Experience and Being* (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1969), 129–33. (Schrag 1969.)
28. Again, see Chapter 10 of this part, below. See also our remarks in Part V, about the reductionism in the subject–object discussion in *Being and Nothingness* and how it can be overcome.
29. Thomas Nagel, *The View from Nowhere* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1986), 60–66.
30. *Phenomenology of Perception*, trans. Colin Smith (Atlantic Highlands, N.J.: Humanities Press, 1962), 67. Hereafter cited as Merleau-Ponty 1962.
31. “Sartre’s Changed Conception of Consciousness: From Lucidity to Opacity,” in *The Library of Living Philosophers*, volume 16, *The Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*, ed. Paul Arthur Schilpp (La Salle, Ill.: Open Court, 1981), 235.
32. An added problem with the purely factual view of the body is that it fails to appreciate the existential implications of the body as lived—to articulate, that is, the dimensions of how the body will fare as manifestations of choices, for example, to exercise, to smoke, or to drink alcohol. For a defense of the Sartrean view of the relationship between consciousness and the seen body, see Judith Butler (1987) for a reply on the basis of the pre-reflective cogito, as well as our discussion of pre-reflective consciousness in the flesh in our Part I, Chapter 10, and Part V, below.
33. See Fred E. Inbau, James Thompson, and Andrea Moenssens, *Cases and Comments on Criminal Law*, 3d ed. (Mineola, New York: Foundation Press, 1983), 266–72.
34. The theme of the attitude of bad faith toward sexuality often taking the form of an aversion to light surfaces in a great deal of Sartre’s writings. Some notable examples are *The Respectful Prostitute*, where Fred insists on having sex with Lizzy in the dark so as not to see his “sin”; *No Exit*, where the bourgeois woman is offended by the constant light in Hell; and *The Words*, where Sartre’s grandmother’s aversion to sexuality is connected to her penchant for keeping the shutters shut during the day. A version of this—fear of the white Other by the white subject—is discussed in our treatment of exoticism below.
35. On forcing situations, see our discussion of the antiblack racist and the emotions in Part II, below. On playing along with a person’s bad faith, see our concluding remarks in Part V.
36. For discussion, see, for example, Merleau-Ponty 1962: 428–31, and 1968: 257–75.
37. Translated by Bernard Frechtman (New York: Pantheon Books, 1963). Cited as Sartre 1963.
38. See Robert V. Stone, “Sartre on Bad Faith and Authenticity,” in Schilpp, *Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*.
39. Elias Canetti, *Crowds and Power*, trans. Carol Stewart (New York: Farrar Straus Giroux, 1984), 15–16.
40. The similarity of this section to Wittgenstein’s notion of a limit of the world about which we cannot speak, where language is shown to be by nature public, receives some discussion in Kathleen Wider’s “A Nothing About Which Something Can Be Said: Sartre and Wittgenstein on the Self,” in Aronson and van den Hoven, *Sartre, Alive!*, 324–39.
41. Paul Robeson, *Here I Stand* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1958), 78.
42. With the exception of my discussion of contradiction as an ontological feature

- of human reality and my discussion of imagination, most of my discussion in this section is based on Joseph Catalano's article "Successfully Lying to Oneself: A Sartrean Perspective," cited above, and his books *A Commentary on Jean-Paul Sartre's Being and Nothingness* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980) and *A Commentary on Jean-Paul Sartre's "Critique of Dialectical Reason,"* vol. 1, *"Theory of Practical Ensembles"* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1986). They will be cited as, respectively, Catalano 1990, Catalano 1980, and Catalano 1986.
43. For discussion, see Ivan Soll, "Sartre's Rejection of the Freudian Unconscious," in Schilpp, *Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*, 582–604.
 44. For a discussion of this view of the existential significance of *immédiation* and Sartre's discussion of the pre-reflective *Cogito*, see Gilbert Varet, *L'Ontologie de Sartre* (Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1948), 87–88.
 45. Jean-Paul Sartre, *Imagination: A Psychological Critique*, trans. Forrest Williams (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1962).
 46. Jean-Paul Sartre, *The Psychology of Imagination*, trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: Citadel Press, Carol Publishing Group, 1991). A notoriously bad translation, it has become customary to mention that emendations have been made, which isn't necessary in this case since no quotations are used. The original version was published in Paris in 1940 by Gallimard as *L'Imaginaire: psychologie phénoménologique de l'imagination*.
 47. On this point, see Edward S. Casey's criticisms of Sartre's view of images, "Sartre on Imagination," in Schilpp, *Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*.
 48. *The Ethics of Ambiguity*, trans. Bernard Frechtman (Secaucus, N.J.: Citadel Press, 1948), 23; *Pour une morale de l'ambiguïté* (Paris: Gallimard, 1947), 33. The former cited as Beauvoir 1948; the latter, 1947.
 49. "Ontological Relativity" and *Other Essays* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1969), 11.
 50. Edmund Husserl, *Cartesian Meditations: An Introduction to Pure Phenomenology*, trans. Dorion Cairns (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff Publishers, 1960), 15. Hereafter Husserl 1960.
 51. See paragraph 169, pp. 106–7. For Bergson's observations on and theory of time, see his *Time and Free Will: An Essay in the Immediate Data of Consciousness*, trans. F. L. Pogson (London: George Allen & Unwin, 1910), chap. 2, esp. 90–91, and *Creative Evolution*, trans. Arthur Mitchell (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1913), 337–44.
 52. *The Phenomenology of the Social World*, trans. George Walsh (Evanston, Ill.: Northwestern University Press, 1967), 103. (Schutz 1967.)
 53. Epigraph from "Introduction," in *Philosophy of the Social Sciences: A Reader*, ed. Maurice Natanson (New York: Random House, 1963), 18. Hereafter cited as Natanson 1963.
 54. See the quote from *Being and Nothingness* (87) that opens this part.
 55. For Sartre's discussion of the problem of constitution, see 1988b, *passim*, and for Husserl's formulations late in his career, see his 1960, especially the Third and Fourth Meditations.
 56. Charles Taylor, *Multiculturalism and "The Politics of Recognition": An Essay by Charles Taylor*, with commentary by Amy Gutmann, ed., Steven Rockefeller, Michael Walzer, and Susan Wolf (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1992), 33. (Taylor 1992.) For a similar view, see Beauvoir 1948, 11–14; 1947, 15–19.

PART II: LOGIC OF RACISM, RACIST LOGIC

The epigraph at the beginning of Chapter 12 is from Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love: Some Christian Reflections in the Form of Discourses*, trans. Howard Hong and Edna Hong (New York: Harper & Row, 1962), 23. (Kierkegaard 1962.) The epigraph at the beginning of chapter 13 is from *Shadow and Act* (New York: Vintage Books, 1972), 28.

1. Anthony Appiah, "Racisms," in *Anatomy of Racism*, ed. David Theo Goldberg (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1990), 3. Hereafter cited as Appiah 1990. This chapter was written before the publication of Appiah's *In My Father's House: Africa in the Philosophy of Culture* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1992); hereafter Appiah 1992. Since his position remains the same in the lengthier work, but his discussion of racism and racialism is more terse there, I have left the quotations from 1990, but I have added parallel sections from 1992. A general discussion of racism and racialism can be found in pp. 13–15 of 1992.
2. See *Foundations of the Metaphysics of Morals*, trans., with an introduction, by Lewis White Beck (Indianapolis: Bobbs-Merrill Educational Publishers, 1959), preface and the second section.
3. For discussion, see also Robert V. Stone, "Freedom as a Universal Notion in Sartre's Ethical Theory," *Revue Internationale de Philosophie* 39, nos. 152–153 (1985): esp. 139.
4. See our discussion of the body in bad faith, Part I.
5. For Kant scholars, these considerations should raise a serious question in regards to the internal completeness of at least Kant's "system" of ethics. The famous demands of acting from respect for Duty, willing that one's maxims can be universalized, and treating members of the Kingdom of Ends as ends in-themselves instead of as means may be rendered independent in virtue of the possibility of a misanthrope's being consistent with the first but not the third, unless, of course, even human beings are "cleansed" from the third.
6. *Prospero and Caliban: The Psychology of Colonialization* (New York: Praeger, 1964).
7. See Cornel West's discussion of Kant in *Prophesy, Deliverance!: An Afro-American Revolutionary Christianity* (Philadelphia: Westminster Press, 1982), 62–63.
8. I owe this observation to Professor Emeritus John Ladd of Brown University, who is currently doing work on Kant's views on race and gender. It should be noted that the conclusions drawn in this section are not Ladd's.
9. See Paulin Hountondji, *African Philosophy: Myth and Reality*, trans. Henri Evans with the collaboration of Jonathan Rée, and an introduction by Abiola Irele (London: Hutchinson University Library of Africa, 1983), chap. 5: "An African Philosopher in Germany in the Eighteenth Century: Anton-Wilhelm Amo," pp. 111–30).
10. See our discussion of evidence and emotions in this part.
11. *Frege: Philosophy of Language*, 2d ed. (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1973), xii. (Dummett 1973.)
12. See John Pittman, ed., "African-American Perspectives and Philosophical Traditions," *Philosophical Forum: A Quarterly*, 24, nos. 1–3 (Fall–Spring 1992–93): 3–296.
13. *Toward the African Revolution: Political Essays*, trans. Haakon Chevalier (New York: Grove Press, 1967), 40–41. Hereafter cited as Fanon 1967a.
14. This reference is from Betsy Bowman and Robert V. Stone's *Sartre's Morality of*

Praxis: An Introduction to the Ethical Writings of the Mid-1960's (forthcoming), chap. 6: "Need and Humanity: The Algerian Revolution." The Rome Lecture will be cited as Sartre 1964b.

15. See Ernst Cassirer, *Kant's Life and Thought*, trans. James Haden with an introduction by Stephan Körner (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1981), particularly chaps. 3–5. See also Charles Taylor, *Hegel and Modern Society* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1979), 3–7, for a discussion of Kantian Man; hereafter Taylor 1979. See also Richard Rorty, *Consequences of Pragmatism (Essays 1972–1980)* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1982), passim; hereafter Rorty 1982.
16. See our Part I, especially our discussion of the foundations of bad faith in Chapter 10.
17. In "Fear and Trembling" and "Repetition," ed. and trans. with introduction and notes by Howard Hong and Edna Hong (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1983), 20–23. (Kierkegaard 1983.)
18. For a discussion of black and Jewish rationalism in the face of racism, see Fanon 1967, 118–19. For recent discussion of black-Jewish dynamics, see Cornel West, *Race Matters* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1993), chap. 6.
19. Although it suggests a form of authentic good faith. See our Chapter 10. For the classic statement on rationality and loyalty, see Josiah Royce, *The Philosophy of Loyalty* (New York: Macmillan, 1908).
20. We have been using the classic study on this subject throughout: *Black Skin, White Masks*. See especially chapters 4 and 6. See also Fanon's observations, in *Toward the African Revolution*, on his efforts to practice psychiatry under racist conditions in the former French colony of Algiers.
21. Both quoted in Studs Terkel, "Under Our Skin," *Mother Jones* 17, no. 3 (May/June 1992): 38.
22. "Statistical Stigmata," in *Deconstruction and the Possibility of Justice*, ed. Drucilla Cornell, Michel Rosenfeld, and David Gray Carlson (New York: Routledge, 1992), 334 (Gates's brackets except for "[sic]"). Will be cited as Gates 1992.
23. "Is Patriotism Like Racism?" in *APA Newsletters on Philosophy and the Black Experience* 91, no. 2 (Fall 1992): 9–12.
24. See his *modus tollens* argument (1990, 16) and our criticisms of it below.
25. See our discussion on effeminacy and antiblackness in Chapter 17.
26. Abridged version in Descartes 1952, 285–305.
27. See Sartre 1956, 311, 591; and Sartre's introduction in his *Emotions: Outline of A Theory*, trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: Philosophical Library, 1948). Latter cited as Sartre 1948a.
28. *Sartre and the Problem of Morality*, trans. Robert Stone (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1980), 24. Cited as Jeanson 1980.
29. A detailed discussion of the distinction between the significance and reductionist approaches in psychology and the social sciences isn't necessary here. For a general overview with references to more detailed study, see David Baybrooke, ed., *Philosophical Problems of the Social Sciences* (New York: Macmillan, 1965), particularly Baybrooke's introduction, where the distinction between action and behavior serves as an important point of departure.
30. In *Translations from the Philosophical Writings of Gottlob Frege*, 2d ed., trans. and ed. Peter Geach and Max Black (London: Basil Blackwell, 1960). See also Dummett, chap. 5.
31. For discussion, see John E. Smith, *America's Philosophical Vision* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1992), 11–12.

32. On this matter of the logic of contradiction and contraries in Sartre's ontology, see Robert Richmond Ellis's article, "Sartrean Logic and the God-Project," *Bulletin de la Société Américaine de Philosophie de langue Française* 4, nos. 2–3 (1992): 201–8.
33. For a discussion of the phenomenological sense of signification, see Alfred Schutz 1967, 100, 118–26.
34. A summary of these examples, which are all from Sartre 1948a, can also be found in Jeanson 1980, 27–28.
35. In the French, *Problème de moral et la pensée de Sartre*, lettre-préface de Jean-Paul Sartre (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1965), 48. Cited as Jeanson 1965.
36. *The Souls of Black Folk*, with introductions by Dr. Nathan Hare and Alvin F. Poussaint, M.D. (New York: Signet Classics, 1969), chap. 1.
37. "An Answer to the Question: 'What is Enlightenment?'" in *Kant's Political Writings*, ed. with an introduction and notes by Hans Reiss, trans. H. B. Nisbet (London: Cambridge University Press, 1970), 54.
38. For some discussion, see our Part V.
39. For discussion of such parallels, see Henry Parker, "Serpents & Doves: A 'Dis-Arming' Approach to Racial Understanding," *APA Newsletter on Philosophy and the Black Experience* (1992): 19.
40. Hannah Arendt, *On Violence* (New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1969), 18–19.
41. For a discussion of Arendt's encounters with race issues prior to 1969, see Elisabeth Young-Bruehl, *Hannah Arendt: For Love of the World* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1982), esp. 308–18, where Bruehl discusses the heat Arendt received for her controversial "Reflections on Little Rock." And for discussion of legitimate and illegitimate ways of regarding others through their artifacts—objects they have left behind—see Alfred Schutz 1967, esp. 109.
42. *A Theory of Justice* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1971). See also our Part I, Chapter 8 and Part III and Part V, *passim*.
43. Sartre, "Preface," in *The Wretched of the Earth*, by Frantz Fanon, trans. Constance Farrington (New York: Grove Press, 1963). References to Fanon will be cited as Fanon 1963. Sartre's Preface will be cited as Sartre 1963a.
44. Appiah ultimately shares this conclusion (1992, chap. 3). See also Jan Pieterse, *White on Black: Images of Blacks in Western Popular Culture* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1992), chap. 1, and Sartre 1992, app. B.
45. For Sartre's brand of "logic," see Ellis.
46. Richard Rorty, *Contingency, Irony, Solidarity*, (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1989), 134 (Rorty 1989.)
47. For a discussion of definition, essence, and existence in Sartre's anthropology and traditional anthropology, see Danto 1975, chap. 1.
48. See, for example, Alain Locke, "The Concept of Race as Applied to Social Culture," in *The Philosophy of Alain Locke: Harlem Renaissance and Beyond*, ed. with an introduction and an interpretation by Leonard Harris (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1989), 188–99.

PART III: ANTIBLACK RACISM

1. For some contemporary "scientific" discussion of the limitations of "race" as a scientifically cogent concept, see Appiah 1992, 35–37.
2. *Childhood and Society*, 2d ed. (New York: W. W. Norton, 1963), 242–43.

3. *The Conquest of the Americas: The Question of the Other*, trans. Richard Howard (New York: Harper Perennial, 1984), particularly chap. 3: "Love."
4. *The Dark Center: A Process Theology of Blackness* (New York: Paulist Press, 1973), chap. 2.
5. For a discussion of the racial dynamics of the Hindu caste system, see Ratna Revankar, *The Indian Constitution: A Case Study of Backward Classes* (Teaneck, N.J.: Fairleigh Dickinson University Press, 1971), chap. 1.
6. See Stevie Wonder's descriptions from his childhood, in James Haskin's "Growing Up in a World of Darkness," in *Listen Children: An Anthology of Black Literature*, ed. Dorothy S. Strickland (New York: Bantam Books, 1982), 111.
7. "The Sentiment of Rationality," in *William James: The Essential Writings*, ed. Bruce Wilshire, with a preface by James Edie (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1984). (James 1984.)
8. Ralph Ellison, *The Invisible Man* (New York: Vintage International Edition, 1990), "Prologue," p. 3. For an interpretation of Ellison's *Invisible Man* that bears similarity to mine, see Howard McGary, "Alienation and the African-American Experience," *Philosophical Forum: A Quarterly* 24, nos. 1–3 (Fall–Spring 1992–93): 285. (McGary 1992–93.)
9. For elaboration on Fanon's autobiographical presentations, see Irene L. Gendzier, *Frantz Fanon: A Critical Study* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1973). David Caute's *Frantz Fanon* also has a number of insights—particularly on Fanon's experience of being addressed by white strangers and professional "subordinates" with the disrespectful French *tu* instead of *vous*.
10. "Man has, as it were, become a kind of prosthetic God," Sigmund Freud, *Civilization and Its Discontents*, trans. and ed. James Strachey (New York: W. W. Norton, 1961), 43. Speculative and symbolic as Freud's reflection may seem, antiblack racism concretizes his claim. The impact of antiblack racism on psychoanalysis is explored by Fanon (1967), where he argues that black people "are" the neurotic's negative categories in antiblack societies. He discusses this thesis throughout, but special focus is made in chapters 4 and 6.
11. The relationship between these two values is discussed in our section on effeminacy and blackness, below. See also (Fanon 1967, 46–47 n. 5).
12. Calvin Hernton, *Sex and Racism in America* (New York: Grove Press, 1965), 32.
13. Sartre makes a similar observation of the Jew's predicament in Nazi Germany: "The Jew had to be put to death wherever he came from not because he had been caught preparing to fight, or because he was taking part in resistance movements, but simply because he was Jewish," "Vietnam: Imperialism and Genocide," in *Between Existentialism and Marxism: Sartre on Philosophy, Politics, Psychology, and the Arts*, trans. John Mathews (New York: Pantheon Books, 1974), 67. The Jew is, in other words, guilty of being Jewish.
14. See James Comer and Alvin Poussaint's discussions with this facet of growing up black in the United States in their classic *Black Childcare: How to Bring up A Healthy Black Child in America* (New York: Pocketbooks, 1975), 256–68.
15. Sartre observed this feature of antiblack racism in the United States as early as 1945. See his "Retour des Etats-Unis: ce que j'ai appris du problème noir," *Le Figaro*, 16 June 1945.
16. "The orthodox opinion is that the quantity of reality must at all costs be conserved, and the waxing and waning of our phenomenal experiences must be treated as surface appearances which leave the deeps untouched," William James, from his *Some Problems of Philosophy*, excerpt reprinted in James 1984, 8. This is

also the basis of Sartre's view of freedom's being a form of nothingness. There is no more being-in-itself than that which already "is." Consciousness therefore "adds" to the world negatively.

17. Clarence Major, *Dictionary of Afro-American Slang* (New York: International Publishers, 1970), 85.
18. "A New Way of Talkin': Language, Social Change and Political Theory," in *Exploitation and Exclusion: Race and Class in Contemporary U.S. Society*, ed. Abebe Zegey, Leonard Harris, and Julia Maxted (London: Hans Zell Publishers, 1991), 71.
19. See our discussions of the transcendancy of blackness in our introduction and the beginning of this part.
20. See our example of composing a story in our discussion of the foundations of bad faith in Part I.
21. *The Crisis of the Negro Intellectual: A Historical Analysis of the Failure of Black Leadership* (New York: Quill, 1984), 420–48.
22. Perceptive though Cruse's observations may be, they are marred by the serious absence of West Indian and African intellectuals like Fanon, C. L. R. James, and Amílcar Cabral. These theorists did not engage in the form of petty internal squabbles that Cruse discusses, which suggests that Cruse's choice of "theorists" is an excellent example of the straw-man fallacy.
23. This letter is purported to have been sent to a black inmate in a Chicago jail. Copies of it were sent to his church and, through the network of black churches in the United States, found its way to New Haven, Connecticut.
24. Gerald Jaynes and Robin Williams, eds., *A Common Destiny: Blacks and American Society* (Washington, D.C.: National Academy Press, 1989), 464–72, provide homicide demographics and statistical data of economic damage.
25. The Mau Mau rebellion is claimed to have resulted in the death of an estimated 13,500 Africans as compared to 95 Europeans. See David Lamb, *The Africans* (New York: Vintage Books, 1987), 61. For a look at the less-violent aspects of Mau Mau, see Jack Woddis, *New Theories of Revolution: A Commentary on the Views of Frantz Fanon, Régis Debray and Herbert Marcuse* (New York: International Publishers, 1972), 128–32.
26. See Lamb, 332–36.
27. The specific Western perspective is the egalitarianism of Christianity; see Hegel 1956, 107, and part 3; *Philosophy of Right*, trans. T. M. Knox (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1967), esp. 51. For a discussion and defense of this interpretation, see Steven B. Smith, "Hegel on Slavery and Domination," *Review of Metaphysics* 46 no. 1 (September 1992): 97–124, and *Hegel's Critique of Liberalism: Rights in Context* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989), 98–131. See also Taylor 1979, 100–101.
28. Jean Baudrillard, *Seduction*, trans. Brian Singer (New York: St. Martin's Press, 1990), 69.
29. This is, of course, a reformulation of the Marxist problem of forging working-class values. How can this be done if *values* are bourgeois? For discussion of Sartre's reflections on this problem, see Bowman and Stone 1992, *passim*.
30. See our comments on the difference between Sartre and Hegel in our discussion of theodicy in an antiblack world, Part IV.
31. See our discussion of God in Part IV.
32. Connecticut WPKN, 7 January 1993.
33. These are actual examples I have gained through conversation with a former gang member.

34. Epigraph from Jean-Paul Sartre, *The Words: The Autobiography of Jean-Paul Sartre*, trans. Bernard Frechtman (New York: George Braziller, 1964), 30. (Sartre 1964a).
35. James Baldwin, *Notes of A Native Son* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1955), 119. (Baldwin 1955.)
36. The Zulu example is attributed to Saul Bellow. See Charles Taylor 1992, 70–72, for discussion of Bellow's alleged remark.
37. See 1956, 554 and 576–77. See also our criticisms of deconstruction in Part V.
38. René Maran, *Un homme pareil aux autres* (Paris: Editions Arc-en-Ciel, 1947), 152, Charles Lam Markmann's translation from *Black Skin, White Masks*, 68.
39. "The Multicultural Wars," in *Black Popular Culture: A Project by Michele Wallace*, ed. Gina Dent (Seattle: Bay Press, 1992), 191.
40. Note, the allusion to a relationship between femipinity and castration isn't unusual in Western thought. Consider the myth of Ouranus and Gaia in Hesiod's *Theogony* (147–208), where Ouranus/Sky, while engaging in sexual intercourse with Gaia/Earth, is castrated by Kronos, one of the sons who have been trapped in Mother Earth by her husband.
41. For a work that simply discusses Sartre's sexism in this regard, see Margery Collins and Christine Pierce, "Holes and Slime: Sexism in Sartre's Psychoanalysis," in *Women and Philosophy: Toward a Theory of Liberation*, ed. Carol C. Gould and Marx W. Wartofsky (New York: Perigee, 1976), 112–27. I consider the analysis of Sartre in this work problematic from the standpoint of the theory that will be outlined here.
42. "The Philosophy of the Limit: Systems Theory and Feminist Legal Reform," in *Deconstruction and the Possibility of Justice*, ed. Cornell, Rosenfeld, and Carlson 78. (Cited as Cornell 1992a.)
43. An outline of some of the problems of formulating the subject of feminist inquiry is offered by Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990). (Butler 1990.)
44. See Jan Pieterse (141), for a discussion of similar views.
45. Drucilla Cornell (1992a) addresses these dimensions from a Lacanian psychoanalytical standpoint of woman as lack, but the question is raised whether the advancement of women's issues came about in the interest of white women and the retrenchment of these concerns have come about primarily through the construction of the colored woman as the locus of these issues. It would seem that women's gains in the first place were not by way of Lacanian notions of lack but by way of a form of self-deception: white women's simultaneous awareness and denial of the masculine dimension of their white identity in an antiblack world. When *de facto* lack—colored women—was raised as a political possibility, a political reality of absence or invisibility emerged: a reformulation of interests in terms of a white male figure who regards himself as a "victim" of colored progress and "political correctness."
46. This paradigm of betrayal under conditions of oppression in the work of Sartre is developed in Flynn (47); in the context of white women's "betrayal" of blacks, particularly in the forms of black women's servitude to white mistresses/managers/capitalists and white feminists' role in encouraging the myth of the black rapist—white feminist antiblack literature—see bell hooks, *Ain't I A Woman?: Black Women and Feminism* (Boston: South End Press, 1981); Jacqueline Grant, *White Women's Christ and Black Women's Jesus* (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1989), chap. 7; Angela Davis, *Women, Race, and*

- Class*, chaps. 4, 11, and 12; and Joy James, "Anita Hill: Martyr Heroism & Gender Abstractions," *Black Scholar* 22, nos. 1–2 (Winter–Spring 1991–92): 17–20.
47. This was certainly Freud's view (see esp. 1961, 58–60 n. 3).
 48. Placide Tempels, *Bantu Philosophy*, translated by Colin King, with a foreword by Margaret Read (Paris: Présence Africaine, 1959). The revised French version, translated by A. Rubbens, of which Fanon is probably referring when he considers Diop's introduction, was published by Présence Africaine in 1949 and was based on a version, by the same translator, that first appeared in 1945 in Elizabethville, Belgian Congo (now Lubumbashi), published by Editions Lovania, 1945. This edition is no longer in print. See "Note by the English Translator" in the 1959 version.
 49. Similar questions are raised by Maurice Natanson in his "Problem of Others in *Being and Nothingness*," in Schilpp, *The Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*, 332. Natanson raises these questions in the context of the relation between Sartre's description of others and mundane experience, p. 333. Since we have argued in our Part II that racism has to be understood in its mundane dimensions as well, it was inevitable that we find ourselves facing variations of Natanson's questions, since the realm of the mundane, the everyday, the natural attitude, is the social world of others. See also Natanson's *Journeying Self: A Study in Philosophy and Social Role* (Reading, Mass.: Addison-Wesley, 1970) for the various challenges to Sartrean philosophy posed by the perspective of sociality, especially in terms of Alfred Schutz's arguments in *The Phenomenology of the Social World*.
 50. Arthur Schopenhauer, *The World as Will and Idea*, vol. 1, trans. R. B. Haldane and J. Kemp (London: Kegan Paul, Trench, Trubner, 1883), 354.
 51. See her *Sartre's Concept of a Person: An Analytic Approach* (Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 1976).
 52. See also Taylor 1992, 71, for a similar conclusion.
 53. See particularly our discussion of the image and indistinct consciousness in Chapter 10, above.
 54. *The Black Jacobins: Toussaint L'Ouverture and the San Domingo Revolution*, 2d ed., rev. (New York: Vintage Books, 1989), 11–12.
 55. For a more developed, critical discussion of Tempel's work, see Hountondji (34–46). Note also John Mbiti's *African Religions and Philosophy* (Garden City, New York: Anchor Books, 1970), esp. 13–14.

PART IV: "GOD" IN AN ANTIBLACK WORLD

Epigraphs: Genesis 1:1–5. This is the King James Version. Another version, the Anchor Bible, reads thus: "When God set about to create heaven and earth—the world being then a formless waste, with darkness over the seas and only an awesome wind sweeping over the water—God said, 'Let there be light.' And there was light. God was pleased with the light that he saw, and he separated the light from the darkness. God called the light Day, and he called the darkness Night. Thus evening came, and morning—first day."

Most versions translate John 1:5 as either "The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness has never put it out" (Anchor Version) or "And the light is shining in the darkness, but the darkness has not overpowered it" (New World Version). Darkness apparently waits for lightness to blink.

Payne cited in Thomas F. Gossett, *Race: The History of an Idea in America, 1900–1930* (Baton Rouge: Louisiana State University Press, 1965), 96.

James Baldwin, *The Fire Next Time* (New York: Dell Publishing, 1962), 56–67. Hereafter Baldwin 1962.

1. I suggest Cain Hope Felder, ed., *Stony the Road We Trod: African-American Biblical Interpretation* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1991), esp. part 3, pp. 127–84, as well as Baltazar (1973), James Cone, “Black Theology as Liberation Theology,” in *African-American Religious Studies*, ed. Gyraud S. Wilmore (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 1989), and William Jones, *Is God a White Racist?: A Preamble to Black Theology* (New York: Anchor Press/Doubleday, 1973), for surveys.
2. The question is from W. E. B. Du Bois, “Litany at Atlanta,” in his *Darkwater: Voices from Within the Veil* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Howe, 1920), 25.
3. For a brief discussion of the difference between Hegel’s Geist and existential conceptions of God, see Taylor 1979, 29.
4. See our discussion of the pre-reflective *Cogito* in Part I, Chapter 10 above.
5. See Robert Champigny, “Sartre on Sartre,” in Schilpp, *Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*, 102f.
6. We have touched upon this problem in our discussion of “Black Orpheus” in our introduction.
7. See also Fanon 1967, 113, 116, 121–22, 131–33.
8. See our critique of at least Kantian universality in our discussion of Appiah and the implications of black women’s worship in this chapter. For detailed discussion of the problem of the subject, particularly in the context of gender, see Butler 1990, esp. 16–25.
9. This argument isn’t contemporary. A version of it is found in Aristotle’s *Politics* (1261a10–21), where he argues that Plato’s value of unity in the *polis* carries the danger of unison—that is, a self-contradictory society of one human being.
10. See our discussion of the emotions in Part II and our concluding remarks in Part V.
11. See especially Sartre’s reflections throughout *The Words*.
12. See also C. L. R. James’s discussion of this phenomenon (1989, esp. 11–12).
13. One of the best statements on this view is Martin Buber’s: “In the relation with God, are unconditioned exclusiveness and unconditioned inclusiveness one and the same?” *I and Thou*, trans. Ronald Gregor Smith (New York: Charles Scribner’s Sons, 1958), 91. In leaping over the chasm of exclusivity, we not only “meet” the Mysterious, meet God, but also the disclosure of His relation to all: “God hovers over His creation not as over a chaos; He embraces it. He is the infinite *I* that makes every *It* into his *Thou*,” “The Question to the Single One,” in *Between Man and Man*, trans. Ronald Gregor Smith (New York: Collier Books, 1965), 56; and: “A God reached by excluding all His creatures would not be the God of all lives in whom all life is fulfilled,” p. 52. See also Jean Wahl, “Buber and the Philosophies of Existence,” trans. Forrest Williams, in *Library of Living Philosophers*, vol. 22, *The Philosophy of Martin Buber*, ed. Paul Arthur Schilpp (La Salle: Open Court, 1967), 482–85.
14. Sylvain Boni has argued that since God is the ultimate Other, to reject Him leads to a slippery slope toward rejecting others, *The Self and the Other in the Ontologies of Sartre and Buber* (Washington, D.C.: University Press of America, 1982), 169–80. Thus Buber’s embrace of God leads to Thou, whereas Sartre’s

rejection of God leads to the *problem* of contacting the Other. Racism, in effect, challenges one's ability to contact the Other of another race and hence starts the slide down the slippery slope to all others. Thus God is, from this perspective, a useful trope against racism. But the essential question is what kind of God is it whom we leap toward? There is something self-contradictory in the notion of a racist God—such a God is, by implication, unable to make contact with us; we are posed to him as a mysterious “it.” Thus the accessibility of such a God in an antiblack world is a function of the distorted ontology of such a world, the distortion, that is, of placing White Man on the level of God.

PART V: CRITICAL ENCOUNTERS

1. This question differs from Buber's question of the uniqueness of each person, although it ultimately appeals to the Buberian sense of uniqueness. For Buber would regard this question as an appeal to Others as forms of *It*; what else is an identity—whether of ethnicity, race, gender, or class—but a form of collective? See Martin Buber, *Das Problem des Menschen* (Heidelberg: Verlag Lambert Schneider, 1948), 162. Our concern here is with the degree to which calling a situation what it is represents not only an authentic relationship to the situation, but also consequently an authentic relationship to oneself in the situation: that is, an overcoming of bad faith.
2. For a similar view, see Alfred Schutz 1967, chap. 3, “Foundations of a Theory of Intersubjective Understanding,” esp. secs. 19 and 21.
3. See our discussion of the foundations of bad faith and authenticity in sections Part I, Chapters 10 and 11, above. See also Schutz's *Collected Papers*, vol. 1, *The Problem of Social Reality*, ed. with an introduction by Maurice Natanson and a preface by H. L. Van Breda (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff Publishers, 1962), where Schutz criticizes the practical limitations of bad faith relations with others, as modeled under the subject-object dichotomy in *Being and Nothingness*: “[Two people engaged in everyday conversation] seize one another as a co-performing subjectivity. Sartre's theory, in spite of his many admirable subtle analyses, has nothing to contribute to the elucidation of this mechanism. His attempt to overcome epistemological solipsism leads to an unrealistic construction which involves, so to speak, a practical, solipsism” (203). Our point is that such a practical solipsism cuts off the possibility of good faith relations with others, which would render bad faith relations impossible.
4. For a similar response, see Catalano 1986, 133.
5. See, for example, Merleau-Ponty 1962, 438–39.
6. The critics in this camp are many in number. Among them are Charles Taylor, *Philosophical Papers*, vol. 1 (New York: Cambridge University Press), and, though not in explicit reference to Sartre, Taylor 1979; and Risieri Frondizi, “Sartre's Early Ethics,” in Schilpp, *Philosophy of Jean-Paul Sartre*.
7. For a critical, Sartrean response that is more detailed than mine, see Jeanson 1980, 184–94; 1965, 245–54), and David Jopling, “Sartre's Moral Psychology,” in *The Cambridge Companion to Sartre*, ed. Christina Howells. See also Rorty's remark (1982, 98).
8. See our discussion “‘Strong’ and ‘Weak’ Bad Faith” in Part I above.
9. The volumes on these criticisms and their rebuttals are many. See François Lapointe and Claire Lapointe, *Jean-Paul Sartre and His Critics: An International*

- Bibliography* (1938–1975) (Bowling Green, Ohio: Philosophy Documentation Center, Bowling Green State University, 1975). Although *Being and Nothingness* has ethical implications, Sartre himself conceded that a more developed study was needed for a moral and political philosophy, which later on turned out to be his *Notebooks for an Ethics* and *Critique of Dialectical Reason*. On this matter, see Catalano 1986, 112–15. For a treatment of the ethical implications of Sartre's work, see Jeanson (1965 and 1980) and de Beauvoir (1947). Although de Beauvoir's ideas differ from Sartre's in some respects, her project of defending an ethics based on what it means to exist *authentiquement*—that is, to exist without losing oneself in transcendence nor facticity—demanded her replying to most of these objections. It is unfortunate that most of Sartre's critics don't give this work the attention it deserves. This oversight, at least among scholars who don't read French, could be due to the limitations of the English translation. The French title suggests a *defense* of a philosophical/moral position, whereas the English title suggests a more passive project. See Margaret Simons, "Beauvoir and Sartre: The Philosophical Relationship," *Yale French Studies* 72 (1986): 165–79.
10. Epigraph from "Force of Law: The 'Mystical Foundation of Authority,'" in Cornell, Rosenfeld, and Carlson, *Deconstruction and the Possibility of Justice*, 3–4.
 11. For discussion, see Silverman 1987, chap. 4.
 12. For example, Michel Foucault's *The Order of Things: An Archaeology of the Human Sciences* (New York: Vintage Books, 1973).
 13. For a similar concern and criticism, see Richard Rorty 1989, 9–10.
 14. Calvin O. Schrag, *Radical Reflection and the Human Sciences* (West Lafayette, Ind.: Purdue University Press, 1980), 61–62.
 15. For another, recent statement on the relevance of Kierkegaard's question, most notably in postmodern encounters with critical theory, see Martin J. Matušík, *Postnational Identity: Critical Theory and Existential Philosophy in Habermas, Kierkegaard, and Havel* (New York: Guilford Press, 1993), chap. 9.
 16. See Derrida's famous essay that bears that name, in his *Margins of Philosophy*, trans., with additional notes, by Alan Bass (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1982), 1–27.
 17. See also Smitherman (72), for a discussion of who stands to gain in a world of denied subjects/agents.
 18. *Phenomenology and Deconstruction*, vol. 1, *The Dream is Over* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1991), 72.
 19. Derrida, *Margins of Philosophy*, 39.
 20. See our discussion of the spirit of seriousness in Part I.
 21. See, for example, Henry Louis Gates, Jr. (1990) and, although he regards himself as a Christian-Marxist-Pragmatist, Cornel West (1982, *passim*). Drucilla Cornell is a noteworthy example of a feminist deconstructionist who argues for a philosophy of engagement (1992a, esp. 82–83 and 87–89). For discussion of the convergence of deconstruction with feminism with concerns along the lines I've voiced here, see Patricia Huntington, "Autonomy, Community, and Solidarity: The Implications of Heidegger's Thought for the Feminist Alliance with Poststructuralism" (Ph.D. diss., Fordham University Philosophy Department dissertation, December 1993).
 22. The interpretation of deconstruction on which this criticism is based can be found in Richard Rorty's 1982 and 1989, John D. Caputo, *Radical Hermeneutics: Repetition, Deconstruction and the Hermeneutical Project* (Bloomington: Indiana

- University Press, 1987), and Robert Denoon Cumming 1990. See also Christina Howells, "Conclusion: Sartre and the Deconstruction of the Subject," in *The Cambridge Companion to Sartre*, 318–52. I have already referred to Derrida's *Margins of Philosophy*. The Derrida and Heidegger bibliographies are, however, too vast for citation here, but two noteworthy anthologies are *A Derrida Reader: Between the Blinds*, ed. with an introduction and notes by Peggy Kamuf (New York: Columbia University Press, 1991) and *Martin Heidegger: The Basic Writings from "Being and Time" (1927) to "The Task of Thinking" (1964)*, ed., with general introduction and introductions to each selection, by David Farrell Krell (New York: Harper San Francisco, 1977).
23. See Annie Cohen-Solal, *Sartre: A Life*, trans. Anna Cancogni and ed. Norman MacCafee (New York: Pantheon Books, 1987), chaps. 2 and 4, and Ronald Hayman, *Sartre: A Biography* (New York: Carroll and Graf Publishers, 1987), chap. 22: "Kill Sartre." For a brief, updated discussion, see also William McBride, "The Case of Sartre," *Social Research* 56, no. 4 (Winter 1989): 849–75.
 24. This theme is not only in *Being and Nothingness*, but also in *What Is Literature?*
 25. The "it" of which I speak here is, of course, human being. For a recent discussion of this "it," see Maurice Natanson, "The Illiac Passion," *Yale Journal of Biology and Medicine* 65 (1992): 165–71.
 26. I'll focus on the *Critique* instead of the unpublished works since they are not readily available for consultation by most readers. Bowman and Stone's *Sartre's Morality of Praxis* have copious references to various sections of this work, and their previously cited studies of the work will be of assistance as well.
 27. Fanon avoided discussing these factors of division in *Toward the African Revolution* and *A Dying Colonialism* because of their sensitivity during the early stages of the Algerian war.
 28. For recent discussions of the deficiencies of liberal-capitalist and Marxist treatments of the black, specifically African-American, situation, see Howard McGary 1992–93: 282–96; and his "Race and Class Exploitation," in Zegeye, Harris, and Maxted, *Exploitation and Exclusion*, 14–27. See also David Theo Goldberg's "Racist Discourse and the Language of Class," in *Exploitation and Exclusion*, 84–99, for discussion of the independence of race and class.
 29. See Bowman and Stone, *Sartre's Morality of Praxis*.
 30. The form of transcendental considerations I have in mind here are those in the Fifth Meditation of Husserl's *Cartesian Meditations*. In this regard, Sartre's existential concerns can be regarded as an advance of the *constituting* dimension of Husserl's investigations. For further discussion of this dimension, see Merleau-Ponty 1962.
 31. See our Part II.

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BAD FAITH AND ANTIBLACK RACISM

Lewis Gordon here presents the first detailed existential phenomenological investigation of antiblack racism as a form of Sartrean bad faith. Bad faith, the attitude in which human beings attempt to evade freedom and responsibility, is treated as a constant possibility of human existence. Antiblack racism, the attitude and practice that involve the construction of black people as fundamentally inferior and subhuman, is examined as an effort to evade the responsibilities of a human and humane world. Gordon argues that the concept of bad faith militates against any human science that is built upon a theory of human nature and as such offers an analysis of antiblack racism that stands as a challenge to our ordinary assumptions of what it means to be human.

The themes explored include problems emerging through the convergence of race and gender, race and class, race and rationality, race and language, race and identity, race and philosophy, race and theology, race and psychology, race and ethics, and race and violence. This investigation will be of interest to students of philosophy, African American studies, gender and cultural studies, social and political theory, and systematic theology.

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ISBN 0-391-03872-9

Humanities Press
New Jersey

Designed by Judith Mumford-Forsyth